

ISLAND OF PEACE



Krystian Gotuch

*“Peace belongs to those who dare to protect it.
The weak may wish for it, the naïve may pray for it —
but only the strong can keep it.”*

— First Headmaster of the University of the Abyss

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Someone amazing

“Mankind never knew peace. Ceaseless wars over resources, land, and power have consumed our race since the dawn of time. This fact did not change when, in the year 1226, the veil of our world cracked and magic filled our planet to its very core. As if there weren’t enough ways to kill each other, humans took this miraculous new resource and shaped it into a tool of war. Despite its limitless potential to improve our lives, nations used it to slaughter each other for the same old reasons.

That is why the Faculty of the University of the Abyss decided to abandon the World Below. Tools that we researched to better livelihoods and develop the new world were used to kill innocent people. Our two systems of values clashed, which resulted in developing the most complex magic known at the time of writing this book. It let us lift the entire island hundreds of meters above ground while maintaining the supply of water. The gravity magic that was used needs to be constantly powered in order—”

Kristoffer stopped reading aloud as a flurry of fluffy dandelion puffs blew straight into his face, some lodging in his mouth. He coughed, shooting a weary look at his mischievous master.

"Lady Sofia, we need to finish this chapter before your exam. Could you please put the flowers down and focus for just a little longer?"

“But it’s sooo boring,” Sofia whined, blowing another puffball at him with theatrical innocence. “Even Moonfick’s boring history books would sound better if they stuck flowers on your serious face.”

She grinned cheekily, sunlight catching in the golden waves of her hair.

Kristoffer plucked the stray puffball off his face with all the patience of a man slowly being eroded by the tide.

“Lady Sofia, you asked for a refresher before the exam. I’m delivering it.”

“Yes, but I asked for the fun parts.” She kicked a pillow onto the floor with a huff. “Like the duel where Lady Renna scorched a noble’s hair off and he tried to pretend it was ‘the latest court fashion.’ Or the wizard who tried to propose mid-spell and exploded.”

Kristoffer turned the page with the same reverent precision a surgeon might use on a beating heart.

“Unfortunately, I doubt they will ask you to list the most humiliating failures of the Academy or the Tower. That’s why we should proceed with a structured historical overview of magical societal evolution.”

Sofia slumped, picking at a loose thread on her sleeve. “Suddenly, magic doesn’t sound so exciting anymore.” She pouted dramatically. “Honestly, you make it sound like all mages

ever did was hold councils and invent new ways to kill each other slightly more efficiently.”

“They also wrote thorough documentation while doing so,” Kristoffer added, raising an eyebrow — as if that was the true mark of greatness.

“Lady Sofia, would you like me to continue, or shall I prepare your eulogy for tomorrow’s exam?”

Sofia sighed as if the weight of the world had settled on her slim shoulders.

“Fine. Read me the part about the Binding Faculty again. That one’s creepy enough to stay mildly entertaining.”

Kristoffer allowed himself a rare, almost imperceptible smirk. “Page 182. Pay attention this time.”

She curled her legs beneath her, pretending to listen — but her gaze drifted immediately toward the tall library windows. Mana-reinforced glass caught the drifting light, throwing shimmering patterns onto the floor. Outside, the floating gardens swayed lazily past, their vines pulsing faintly with ambient energy, alive with the slow heartbeat of the Upper World.

He had barely resumed reading when she interrupted again.

“Do you ever get tired of being the walking instruction manual?” Sofia asked, tilting her head in mock innocence.

Kristoffer let out a slow, patient sigh — one he seemed to reserve solely for her.

He knew her well enough to recognize a lost battle when he saw one.

The remaining puffballs caught a sudden playful gust from the window and scattered, much like Sofia's attention. With a resigned shake of his head, Kristoffer closed the book carefully and set it on the polished desk they shared.

"And I've told you, don't call me 'Lady' when we're alone," Sofia grumbled, already distracted, now weaving flower stems into some odd, abstract shape.

"It's important to practice proper etiquette," Kristoffer said, smoothing down his sleeves. "When you're at the university, even a small slip could harm your reputation... and cost me my life."

He stood up and stepped away with a respectful bow. "I'll check if dinner is ready."



When closing the door, Kristoffer caught sight of Sofia sticking her tongue out at him. Fourteen years of dealing with her antics had left him thoroughly unfazed.

To outsiders, Sofia might seem like an immature, spoiled noble, but Kristoffer knew better. She was fearless, immensely talented, and a remarkably quick learner — though her mind wandered in unpredictable directions and required equally unconventional teaching methods.

For Kristoffer, ensuring her success wasn't just duty. It was purpose.

His thoughts wandered as he walked toward the kitchen.

The Elernes family had gone to great lengths to allow his Lower Worlder mother to give birth to him here — and to keep him.

Normally, nobles weren't permitted to retain additional servants once they reached their legal limit. But Sofia's father, Eduard Elernes, was nothing if not a master of loopholes.

One particular clause in Upper World law stated that nobles could only contract employees *younger* than themselves.

Servants brought up from the Lower World typically arrived no earlier than the age of fifteen.

But children *born* in the Upper World... could be contracted before reaching adulthood.

Thus, Sofia — who was three months older than Kristoffer — officially hired him as her personal servant while they were still infants.

A technicality. A lifeline.

Kristoffer glanced at the black rune mark on his forearm — the visible symbol of his bond.

Traditionally, the mark was placed on the back of the left hand. But because he was so small during the ceremony, it had ended up further down his arm. The irregular placement often caused trouble with guards and strangers alike.

Kristoffer didn't mind.

Each time he saw it, it reminded him of the mischievous smile of the girl who had unknowingly saved his life.

"What happened? Lady Sofia got hungry again?"

Nora's teasing voice pulled him from his thoughts as he reached the kitchen door. She greeted him with a wooden spoon in hand, waving it like a wand.

"Here, try this. Enough salt?"

Kristoffer didn't even have time to answer before Nora shoved the spoon into his mouth.

He chewed, ready to protest—until his taste buds betrayed him.

"It's delicious as always, Mom," he said with a grin, swallowing.

"Does that mean it's ready? She's getting distracted again. History lessons are a losing battle these days. Maybe your food can wake her brain up a little."

Nora smiled fondly. "Second course will be ready soon. Go ahead and start with the soup."

She reached up, fussing over his disheveled blond hair.

“Kristoffer, fix this mess a little better, will you? You’re representing the Elernes family now, you know.”

He gave her a familiar, bittersweet smile and helped set the dining room.

Once everything was prepared, he went to inform Ernest, just in case Sofia’s parents decided to attend for once.

But when Sofia arrived, the room was empty, as it had been for weeks.

She smiled brightly — praising Nora’s food with genuine warmth — but Kristoffer noticed the quick glance she gave the empty chairs.

Not even Sofia’s breeziness could fully hide the loneliness she carried.

“I’ve been eating alone a lot lately,” she remarked lightly as the second course was served. “Are you *sure* you can’t join me?”

“We Lower Worlders could never dine with someone as great as you, Lady Sofia,” Nora said, bowing respectfully as she set the plate down. “But if you wish, I could ask Master Ernest to join you.”

“But Kristoffer’s my servant,” Sofia teased, flashing a mischievous grin. “What if I *ordered* him to?” Kristoffer felt the sharp looks from the other servants like needles at his back.

Sofia loved teasing him, but lately, it had grown more frequent — and harder for him to brush off.

“I’m joking,” Sofia laughed, waving her hand airily. “I wouldn’t force anyone to eat with me.”

The tension in the room eased, and the rest of the meal passed peacefully.

“Thank you again, Nora,” Sofia said warmly as she rose to leave. “I love how you prepare salmon. Kristoffer, come to my room in half an hour, alright?”

As the other servants cleared away the dishes, the air turned awkward again. Finally, when only Nora and her son remained, she pulled him into a hug.

“I know it’s hard,” she whispered, pressing a kiss to his hair. “But they’re just jealous, you know. Lady Sofia clearly favors you. And nobody likes feeling like a second choice.”

Kristoffer was about to brush it off — to insist it didn’t bother him — but something about his mother’s quiet, enduring warmth stopped him. Instead, he hugged her back, drawing strength from her presence.

He kissed her cheek gently. “Thank you. I should get going. We need to finish reviewing before the exam.”

Kristoffer didn’t show it outwardly, but his mother knew him too well.

The way the other Lower Worlders treated him — cold, distant — wasn't lost on either of them.

He was born here, unlike the others, who had clawed their way up from the dirt.

His servant mark was irregular, another reminder that he didn't quite belong anywhere.

And, most unforgivable of all: Lady Sofia treated him with a warmth no noble was supposed to show a Lower Worlder.

Kristoffer could have asked her to tone it down in public. Could have begged her to stop making things harder for him.

But he never had the heart.

He knew — better than anyone — that Sofia's teasing, her laughter, even her jabs, were shields against the loneliness that gnawed at her when no one else could see.

In this sprawling, echoing mansion, she was often more prisoner than princess.

And if enduring a little coldness from the others meant giving her even a shred of normalcy, Kristoffer would carry that burden gladly.

He knocked lightly on Sofia's door.

"Come in!" she called brightly. "Let me guess—you're here to finish boring me to death?"

Kristoffer stepped inside, catching the way her golden hair glowed in the afternoon light streaming through the windows.

The easy smile she flashed him didn't quite reach her eyes. It was becoming a familiar, painful sight.

He hesitated, then crossed the room and sat beside her.

"Maybe we should put history on pause," he suggested.

Noticing the green bracelet she had woven from dandelion stems, Kristoffer added, almost absentmindedly, "After your exam, we should return the *Magic Principles* book and request *Mana Frequencies* by Professor Borgman."

Another groan escaped Sofia.

"Another book? We barely survived *Elemental Principles*."

"Yes," Kristoffer said seriously, "but I feel like the foundation it gives is lacking. Since you asked for my help, it's my responsibility to make sure you don't learn the wrong things." He tapped his finger thoughtfully against the desk. "Most of the current models — splitting magic into four basic elements plus the Irregular — are based on unconfirmed assumptions.

According to *Magic – Types and Categories*, Professor Borgman proposed a theory that what we call an 'element' is actually just a frequency of mana.

Which means, in theory, there could be an infinite number of elements — not just four.

If you imagine the traditional four elements forming the corners of a square, then everything inside it would be—"

He stopped mid-sentence as Sofia started giggling at his enthusiasm.

Kristoffer cleared his throat, embarrassed. "Anyway. You don't need to know the details just yet. I'll go through the book properly and prepare a summary that's easier to digest."

Sofia smiled teasingly.

"Aren't you getting a bit *too* intense about my studying lately?"

She leaned back in her chair, arms folded. "Ever since I taught you to read, you've been ridiculously helpful at translating Teacher Rosalia's nonsense into something I can actually understand. But lately? It's like you're trying to prepare me for war instead of an exam."

Kristoffer gave her a patient look.

"In the near future, you'll have to attend the National Academy, Lady Sofia. It was you — ten years ago — who ordered me to help you with studying. It's my responsibility now, as your servant, to ensure you are prepared. With your family's status... expectations will be high. Very high."

"I know, I know, okay," Sofia cut him off, waving her hand.

"I'll ask for the stupid book. Everything always has to be logical and calculated with you."

She puffed out her cheeks briefly, then grinned.

“We have about an hour until the exam. Let’s just get started.”

Kristoffer smiled, seeing her rally herself.

"Alright then. Let’s begin with a summary of mana basics—"

The idea of teaching spoiled noble children had disgusted Rosalia from the very beginning. She had once been a respected professor at the National Academy, well-regarded for her research and teaching. But after her husband’s research center fell victim to political sabotage and failed to receive funding, they were both unceremoniously removed from their positions. The Tower’s political landscape was as cold as it was unforgiving. The loss of their status left Rosalia without a job, a source of income, or the means to support the lavish lifestyle she had grown accustomed to.

To maintain her dignity and the veneer of nobility, she reinvented herself as a private tutor—one of the most expensive on the market. The irony wasn’t lost on her. What started as a fall from grace transformed into a lucrative career. Now, she found herself taking on high-paying noble clients, teaching their children. In a way, it was the perfect compromise between survival and her pride.

Over the years, she encountered a wide array of students. Some, utterly useless—no interest, no drive, and no hope for

improvement. Their parents, with their immense wealth, used the tutoring fees to alleviate their guilt over neglecting their children's upbringing. Others were eager learners, working at their own pace, some of them so naturally gifted they reignited Rosalia's dormant passion for teaching. With her experience and knowledge, she quickly saw the potential in some students, helping to refine them into skilled magicians. But none of these students stood out like Sofia Elernes.

Rosalia first met Sofia seven years ago, and to say she had misjudged the girl would be an understatement. Sofia, the daughter of one of the most prominent families in the Upper World, was everything Rosalia expected of a spoiled noble: distracted, self-absorbed, and uninterested in actual learning. Birds chirped outside the window, and Sofia's attention would immediately drift, lost in the rhythm of the world outside the classroom. The girl could barely sit still long enough to finish a sentence without her mind wandering off to something more "interesting."

For months, it seemed like a losing battle. Rosalia tried every method, every strategy, but Sofia's mind danced away from every lesson, as if learning itself was a punishment. Yet despite the frustration, something gnawed at Rosalia. Something in the back of her mind told her that she had missed something important. But it wasn't until Sofia made an unexpected request that Rosalia's perception began to shift.

One day, after months of feeling like nothing had stuck, Sofia asked for a book on the basics of magic. She wanted to study independently.

Rosalia was taken aback. The child who had seemed completely uninterested in the past had now taken the initiative to dive into studying on her own. And to Rosalia's surprise, Sofia followed through—eagerly, even. Week after week, she came to lessons armed with thoughtful questions about concepts in the book. They were questions that no child her age should be asking. They were advanced, challenging questions that sparked something deep inside Rosalia—a feeling she hadn't experienced in years.

As time went on, Rosalia's approach shifted. She began recommending more advanced texts, borrowing them from the National Library. She even began delegating more of Sofia's learning to self-study, thinking to herself that the less effort she had to put in, the better. After all, she was being paid generously, and there was no need for her to work harder than necessary.

It was the perfect arrangement. Sofia was growing, learning, becoming more talented than Rosalia ever anticipated, and Rosalia didn't have to exert the same effort she once had. But then came the day Sofia spoke a strange, unfamiliar rune while tending to a dying plant on the windowsill. It was a rune Rosalia didn't recognize, even after years of study.

"Absorb light." Sofia had murmured the words, as if they were second nature.

Rosalia blinked, caught off guard.

The wilting sprout on the windowsill shifted — its color brightening, its leaves lifting as if it had suddenly remembered how to live.

Ab-sorb?

The rune hung strangely in Rosalia's mind. It wasn't one she recognized — and that simple fact stirred something cold and unwelcome in her chest.

Still, she masked her confusion with the polished ease of long habit, settling into her chair with an air of mild authority.

"Long time no see, Sofia," she said lightly, brushing past the moment. "Four months without lessons. The longest break we've had so far. I trust you kept yourself busy?"

She watched the girl carefully.

Sofia beamed at her — that same careless, sun-bright smile that Rosalia had once dismissed as nothing but fluff.

"Today," Rosalia continued, tapping a finger against her notes, "we'll start working on creating a barrier around your source. It's a critical step to prolong your life — and to sharpen your control. Building it usually takes years, so don't get discouraged too quickly."

She leaned in slightly, voice dropping into something more serious.

"Your source is your life, Sofia. If we put a strong enough barrier around it, you'll lose half as much mana just by existing. Twice the lifespan. Not a bad deal, wouldn't you say?"

Sofia's eyes lit up immediately.

"Oh, you mean like a waterfall strainer?" she asked, almost bouncing in her seat.

Rosalia froze.

"...A waterfall what?"

"A waterfall strainer," Sofia repeated, patient as ever, as if explaining something terribly obvious. "You know — magic's like a river, right? If you put a strainer on it, less leaks out. You get to keep more inside."

Rosalia stared at her for a long moment.

Then, carefully, she said, "That's... one way to describe it."

Inside, she could feel a headache brewing.

The girl had always thought in metaphors — crooked, tangled metaphors that somehow hit closer to the truth than any textbook ever managed.

"Building the barrier is only half the work," she continued, smoothing over the crack in her composure. "Keeping it up while asleep, under stress — that's the real challenge. We'll start by training your willpower. Any questions before we begin?"

Sofia tilted her head thoughtfully for a second.

Then, brightly, she said:

"Professor Rosalia, I already have the waterfall strainer."

Rosalia blinked once. Then again.

"You... what?"

"I set it up already," Sofia said, as if informing her the tea was ready. "I read about it in that book on mana pathways and precision. Oh, and by the way, did you bring the book on medicine and magic I asked for? I think it could really help with a plant growth project I've been working on—"

Sofia's voice rolled over her like a tide, faster and faster. Rosalia barely caught the words — medicine, growth acceleration, cross-application of magical frequencies — and felt something inside her brain quietly short-circuiting.

She set up the barrier? Alone? That's supposed to be intermediate academy-level work at best—

"And next time," Sofia added casually, "could you also look for books on ancient and modern runes? I'm trying to figure out why the old spells still seem stronger even though everyone says we improved them—"

"Wait," Rosalia said sharply, cutting across the babble.

Sofia blinked at her, surprised.

"May I check your source?" Rosalia asked, already rising to her feet.

Sofia hesitated.

"I read it's dangerous to let people do that..." she began — but one look at Rosalia's expression ended any protest. "...but of course since you're my teacher Professor Rosalia, I've no problem with that."

Rosalia placed her hand on the back of Sofia's neck and focused her will, delving into the girl's essence. Immediately, she encountered a formidable barrier of resistance, but it melted away as Sofia willingly lowered it. What Rosalia found left her speechless: a robust, meticulously constructed mana barrier containing Sofia's source - one of the strongest she'd ever encountered.

She opened her eyes, pulling her hand back like she'd touched fire.

"It's..." Rosalia cleared her throat. "...good."

Very good. Alarmingly good.

For a moment, she simply stood there, staring at the girl who was now flipping through her sketchbook without a care in the world.

"I think we should... take a short break," Rosalia said stiffly, already moving toward the door.

She stepped into the corridor and closed the door behind her with exaggerated gentleness, as if afraid she might shatter something if she slammed it.

Out in the cooler air, she braced herself against the wall. Four months ago, she'd labeled Sofia as a lost cause: a spoiled, distracted child with too much privilege and not enough grit.

Now, standing there with her heart hammering oddly fast, Rosalia realized something far worse had happened:

She had been wrong.

Painfully, humiliatingly wrong.

"This girl is a disaster," she muttered to herself, eyes wide with something halfway between horror and admiration. "A beautiful, brilliant disaster."

And somehow — gods help her — it was no longer just about money anymore.

Rosalia pressed her palms together, breathing in deep. No more laziness. No more just coasting on titles and paychecks.

Sofia Elernes had stormed into her life like a wild, blinding force — and Rosalia, proud fool that she was, had no choice now but to follow her into whatever chaos came next.

Rosalia straightened her spine, smoothing down her skirts as footsteps echoed from the main hall.

The examiner had arrived.

She wiped the emotion from her face and stepped forward to meet him, ready to stake everything on the chaotic prodigy waiting inside.



"Good afternoon, Professor Richard. A pleasure to see you again," Rosalia said, her tone smooth as glass as she greeted the stern man at the entrance to the Elernes mansion.

"Good afternoon, Rosalia," Richard replied curtly, his bearded face settling into a hard, familiar glare. "Let's hope we don't waste much time here."

Rosalia maintained her pleasant smile, though inwardly she sighed. She had expected as much.

A fourteen-year-old claiming third-circle proficiency? The Tower had sent their most merciless examiner for a reason: to shut the door politely but firmly.

"I'm sure my student will manage to entertain you," she said lightly. "She's waiting for us in the training hall. Allow me to show the way."

"I'd be grateful," Richard said, tipping his fedora with stiff politeness.

They moved through the stone corridors in silence, the weight of old traditions pressing around them.

When they entered the training hall, Sofia was animatedly chatting with a young servant — her face bright with mischief, hands gesturing wildly in some unfinished story. At the sight of her visitors, she straightened immediately, slipping into a graceful, almost theatrical curtsy.

"Good afternoon, Professor Rosalia, Professor Richard," Sofia said with a graceful curtsy. "My name is Sofia Elernes."

"Good afternoon," Richard returned briskly. His eyes, sharp as knives, swept the room. "I don't have much time, so if you're ready, we'll begin."

"I'm ready," Sofia said, meeting his gaze with steady calm.

"Good."

His gaze flickered toward the servant still standing respectfully at the side — and hardened.

"Remove the Lower World filth," Richard said coldly, gesturing dismissively. "Then we'll proceed with the theoretical part."

He turned away, already pulling a stack of papers from his leather case.

Rosalia stiffened, but kept her face neutral. Sofia, however, froze — just for a heartbeat.

"Is there no way my servant could remain as an observer?" Sofia's eyes, a clear and striking blue, narrowed slightly, their warmth replaced by an icy sharpness.

"Are you joking?" His voice thundered across the hall. "A Lower Worlder attending a magic examination? Unthinkable. The very idea is an insult to the Tower!"

Before Sofia could respond, Rosalia stepped in smoothly, her tone placating but firm.

"My apologies, Professor Richard," she said. "Sofia is unfamiliar with some customs, as she hasn't yet attended the Academy. I'm sure she meant no offense."

Sofia's eyes flicked toward Kristoffer — the briefest flash of something between apology and command.

"I'll see you later in my room," she said softly.

With a quiet nod, the servant left, his steps silent against the marble floor.

Richard, still bristling, adjusted the papers in front of him with sharp, precise movements.

"Well then," he said after a pause, his voice clipped, "let's begin."

He turned his full, unimpressed attention to Sofia — a silent weight behind his stare, as if daring her to prove she was worth the time.

"We'll skip the written test," he announced. "I'll ask questions directly."

Without waiting, he fired off the first salvo.

"Explain why even mages of the tenth circle sometimes use chants, despite being capable of silent casting."



Rosalia's breath caught. Her eyes widened — just slightly — before she masked her reaction.

That bastard, she thought, almost admiring the audacity. It was a loaded question. Way beyond third-circle curriculum. He was setting Sofia up to stumble right from the start.

But as Rosalia stole a glance at her student, the corner of her mouth quirked upward. Richard had underestimated the disaster he was dealing with.

Sofia's face lit up with that familiar, chaotic energy.

"Oh! You mean the Magic Megaphone!" she chirped brightly, as if they'd asked her about her favorite dessert.

Richard blinked.

Rosalia smothered a cough into her sleeve.

"If someone isn't paying attention," Sofia continued, her hands already sketching invisible diagrams in the air, "they won't respond unless you grab their focus. It's the same with magic! When your will is sharp enough, silent casting works — but if you're distracted, or the environment's unstable, the magic might not respond properly. So you grab a *huge megaphone*" — she mimed holding a giant cone to her mouth — "and that's the chant!

The runes and the verbal spells basically shove your intent right into magic's face so it listens even if you're all wobbly upstairs."

She finished with a bright, expectant smile.

Silence stretched across the hall.

Rosalia bit the inside of her cheek, fighting the laughter bubbling under her ribs.

Richard opened his mouth, closed it, then opened it again — as if trying to recalibrate reality itself.

"...Technically correct," he muttered at last, shuffling the papers with more force than necessary. "In... unusually vivid terms."

Rosalia folded her arms, allowing herself a small, satisfied smirk.

Let the battle begin.

What was with this girl?

Richard felt his composure slipping, a slow crack running beneath the surface of his professional mask. He had come prepared. He had pulled some of the most grueling theoretical questions from the Tower's archives—problems borrowed from fourth- and fifth-circle exams, wrapped in enough complexity to tie a fourteen-year-old in knots.

And yet... Sofia answered them. Every time.

The answers were strange, littered with wild metaphors and odd leaps of logic, but when you sifted through the chaos, the foundations were solid. More than solid.

She understands, Richard thought grimly, watching her animated explanations. *She understands better than half the candidates twice her age.*

It was unnatural. Unheard of.

Despite her remarkable performance, Richard knew he could not simply allow her to succeed. A fourteen-year-old noble—one tied to Lower World influences—passing a third-circle exam would spark outrage. Donations would plummet. Families already uneasy about the Tower's neutrality would turn suspicious. More than that, her success could destabilize the careful balance of power that generations had built.

"I see your theoretical knowledge is... not terrible," Richard said finally, forcing dismissiveness into his tone. "But magic isn't about spending hours in a library. Knowledge is just the beginning. It's intent, willpower, the ability to control mana, and the creativity to connect runes into something that actually works."

He opened a wooden box from his briefcase and set it carefully on the table. Inside, the glint of specialized tools caught the light.

"As a third-circle user, you must be able to cast spells without failure. Losing concentration during an experiment could mean death. If your success rate is low, you endanger not only yourself, but also every mage around you," he continued, lifting a plain glass from beside the box. "Let's test your practical skills. Using the materials provided, design a magic circle that keeps this glass of water warm, powered solely by mana. You have fifteen minutes."

This was no ordinary test. Casting a heating spell was simple. Designing a static circle capable of maintaining that warmth without direct willpower was an entirely different challenge. When drawing circles, the magician's intent couldn't guide the spell in real-time. It had to be precise from the start, every rune aligned perfectly to produce the desired effect. Even Rosalia, with all her experience, would struggle to design such a circle cleanly under a fifteen-minute limit.

Richard watched, waiting for hesitation. For panic.

But Sofia didn't even blink. She opened the box, examined the tools with quick, decisive movements, and selected a small quill pen. Turning the glass upside down, she set to work, the tip of the pen scratching rapid patterns across the base. For five minutes, she scribbled intently, occasionally pausing to tilt the glass and inspect her progress with a narrow-eyed focus that made something uneasy stir in Richard's gut.

When she finished, she gave the ink a careful breath to dry it, flipped the glass upright again, and filled it from a nearby jug.

A moment later, visible steam curled up from the water's surface.

"Looks like I got it right on the first try," Sofia said proudly, her face bright. "Of course, if the temperature isn't to your liking, Professor Richard, I can adjust it."

Richard picked up the glass automatically, turning it carefully in his hands. His brow furrowed deeper with each slow rotation. The

magic circle etched onto the bottom was compact—elegant, even—almost half the size of what he himself would have designed. From the edge of his vision, he caught Rosalia's gaze, sharp and astonished.

Bringing the glass closer, he traced the runes with his eyes, studying the old-style architecture woven into the design.

"Did you use... an ancient joint between the runes?" Richard asked, his voice betraying a rare flicker of uncertainty. He recognized the pattern but couldn't immediately place the details.

"I wouldn't call it ancient," Sofia said, tapping the base lightly. "It's only about a hundred years old. Modern rune structures are beautiful, you know—like dandelions. Simple, practical. But the old ways—" her voice brightened with a kind of effortless enthusiasm, "—they're like roses. More complex. More elegant. A bit harder to grow, sure, but so much more precise. That's why the glass stays cool even when the water heats up."

Only then did Richard notice—the glass in his hand was completely cool to the touch. He frowned and dipped a cautious finger into the water. Warm. Steady. Perfect.

He set the glass down more carefully than necessary, his mind racing to catch up with what he was witnessing. Across the table, Sofia's clear, honest eyes were watching him expectantly,

unaware—or perhaps entirely aware—of the quiet storm she had unleashed inside him.

"Yes... good job," he mumbled, the words tasting strange on his tongue.

Sofia smiled, and the atmosphere in the room seemed to lift with her. Richard found himself standing awkwardly, unsure how to proceed. Because of their high difficulty, even the basics of ancient runic joint techniques were not taught until the second year of the Academy. Most mages treated them like an academic curiosity—more suited for hobbyists and craftsmen than for serious fieldwork. Their complexity often made magical devices error-prone, unreliable in real-world situations. Yet this girl, without formal instruction, had not only used them confidently but created something that could easily fetch a high price on the open market.

There was no doubt now: the theoretical part hadn't been luck. This girl was extraordinary. Leagues beyond any third-circle candidate he had ever encountered.

But that did not mean he could let her pass.

It was no longer about politics. Someone as talented as her would be seen as a threat almost immediately. Other noble houses, sensing danger to the established order, would come after her with ruthless precision. And because she was the

daughter of Lower World supporters, she would be an easy target.

Richard set his jaw. He was an educator first—and educators protected their students. The spark of genius inside this odd, vibrant girl needed to survive, not be snuffed out by court intrigue and Tower manipulation. Her talent wasn't something that belonged to the Upper World or the Lower World. It belonged to the future.

"Alright," he said, clearing his throat. "Let's move on to the third part of the exam."

Sofia straightened instinctively, attentive.

"A true magician must be able to adapt to new situations with their available skills and creativity. That will be your last test. I will place this candle behind the pillar. You stay on the other side, where you cannot see it. Your task is to light it without moving from your current position. You have three minutes."

He positioned the candlestick carefully behind the stone pillar, ensuring it was completely hidden from both Sofia and Rosalia. As he stepped back, an uncomfortable weight pressed down in his chest. This test wasn't difficult—it was impossible.

But Richard consoled himself grimly that it was for her own good. If she failed, she would stay below the Tower's radar a little longer, giving her the chance to grow in peace. There would be no need to throw her into the lion's den before she was ready.

For the first time since the exam had begun, Sofia's face turned serious. The playful, sunny aura she carried so naturally faded, replaced by a look of pure concentration. Richard noticed Rosalia's disgusted glance from the side but took it silently. This decision wasn't about fairness—it was about survival. He was prepared to carry the guilt if it meant keeping her safe.

"Can I use what's left from the previous test for a magic circle that I will draw on the floor from my current position?" Sofia asked, her face brightening slightly again as the gears in her mind whirled to life.

Richard blinked, momentarily thrown off by the question.

"As long as you don't leave your spot," he replied, wary but intrigued.

How could a magic circle help her? She couldn't even see the candle.

A flicker of unease crept into him. Could she know some ancient technique he wasn't aware of? It gnawed at him — not his pride, but genuine scientific frustration. Ancient runes weren't even his specialty, yet the thought that a fourteen-year-old knew more than him clawed at his mind. Still, Richard forced himself to set it aside. Disbelief was unworthy of a real educator. As always, evidence had to speak louder than pride.

And despite his worry, he also felt a dangerous excitement stirring in his chest.

What would she come up with this time?

For a fleeting moment, he forgot about the Tower. About politics. About all the reasons he had come here today.

All that filled him now was genuine scientific curiosity.

Sofia knelt, dipping her quill into the leftover ink, and began sketching a small circle on the floor. Her movements were precise, yet there was a kind of passionate artistry to them—like a painter working feverishly on the masterpiece of his life. When she finished, she straightened — and, to everyone's surprise, slipped off her shoes.

Richard and Rosalia exchanged a confused glance — which turned to shock as they felt the sudden shift in the room's mana.

Before Sofia had even spoken, her will filled the air. Mana rushed toward her naturally, swirling around her petite figure. The very atmosphere seemed to hum, the hem of Richard's coat lifting ever so slightly.

"Wind," Sofia whispered, her voice affectionate, as if calling an old friend.

The response was immediate. Mana snapped into motion, forming a coiling serpent of air around her. It twisted and shimmered with hypnotic grace. Sofia, calm and focused, placed the tip of her toe into the center of her drawn circle, channeling mana directly through it. A small flame bloomed above her bare foot, glowing intensely.

The serpent of wind dipped low, absorbing the flame. In an instant, it became a fiery snake, twisting in vibrant, living heat. The serpent slithered forward, graceful and precise, coiling around the pillar — and a moment later, the column blew up in a bright combustion.

Richard's jaw nearly hit the floor.

He shot a glance at Rosalia and found her mirroring his expression, stunned into silence.

What the hell was that?

No wand. No catalyst.

Sofia had shaped and layered a double spell before even casting it — and she had done it with such fluid grace that it defied standard technique. She was one step away from mastering silent casting, something most full-fledged mages spent decades struggling with.

And that spellwork — was it even legal to fail someone after witnessing something like that?

Rosalia would have every right to appeal to the Tower if he tried. She could throw this entire exam into scandal — and drag both Sofia's and his own career down with it.

"Does it count?" Sofia asked hesitantly, her earnest, open expression returning. "I was a bit nervous and lost control of the mana. If you'd like, I can try again—"

"No, no, that won't be necessary," Richard said quickly, gathering his shattered composure and schooling his face into the stoic neutrality expected of a Tower examiner.

"That will be all, Miss Sofia. You will be informed of the results after I discuss it with your teacher."

Sofia's shoulders relaxed, though a trace of disappointment flickered across her face. She gave a small nod and turned toward the exit — but paused halfway, walking back toward Rosalia.

"Professor Rosalia, I put *Magic Principles* in this drawer here," she said, pointing at the desk. "I'm returning it. Thank you for finding it. Do you think you could get me *Mana Frequencies* by Professor Borgman?"

"Of course, Sofia," Rosalia replied warmly, unable to hide her pride. "You've already finished *Magic Principles*? I'll need to prepare a test for you the next time we meet."

"Don't let Professor Borgman's wild theories corrupt your young mind," Richard muttered, unable to stop himself. "The Academy considers him a madman. Why would you even want to read his ramblings?"

"His theory about mana having specific frequencies gives a possibility of infinite elements instead of four," Sofia recited matter-of-factly, as if quoting a shopping list. Without waiting for

a reaction, she waved cheerfully and headed for the door. "Thank you, Professor Rosalia!"

The door closed softly behind her, leaving an echoing silence.

Richard stared at the empty doorway, dumbfounded. *Infinite elements?*

Now that he thought about it... if mana really had frequency bands — and if it could be tuned — it would revolutionize elemental magic. Entire new fields could be born overnight. Infrastructure, technology, warfare — everything could change.

And this girl had mentioned it casually, as if she were commenting on the dessert she had eaten that morning.

He turned sharply toward Rosalia, suspicion burning through his confusion.

"What was that?" he hissed, struggling to keep his voice low. "Rosi, I've known you for decades. I know exactly what you're capable of. Modern runes, teaching theory, sure. But that mana control? Ancient runes? Mana frequency theory? Where did she learn all of this?"

Rosalia smiled sweetly, folding her arms across her chest.

"Being a mentor isn't just about passing down knowledge. It's about giving your student a push in the right direction," she said, pride shimmering under her words. "You underestimate me, Richard."

"I heard you've been haunting the library lately, but this—" he shook his head, exasperated, "—this is another level. Why don't you just apply for the sixth circle yourself? The Tower's been underestimating you for years, if—"

"No, thank you," Rosalia cut him off smoothly. "I'm happy where I am. If the Tower wants me back at the Academy, they can hire me without worrying about my official ranking. It was never a problem before."

Richard pressed his lips into a thin line.

"Rosalia, you know it doesn't work like that," he said sourly. "And the same goes for your pupil. I'll admit it—she's highly skilled. I've never seen a student like her. But if we rank her as a third-circle mage now, she'll have a target painted on her back. You know better than anyone how ruthless the Tower is when it comes to protecting social hierarchies."

"I'm not part of the council or faculty anymore," Rosalia snapped, her voice rising before she caught herself. Her cheeks flushed with restrained anger. "All I care about is my student being treated fairly. She deserves recognition for our work. If she can't get that, then the system is broken. *Island of Science*, that's what Lucius Greywar called it. Knowledge and skill above politics—that's the foundation we're supposed to stand on. Wasn't that the reason we built this society in the first place?"

Richard's expression softened slightly. "But here and now isn't about a revolution," he said quietly. "It's about this young girl's life. Her safety."

He paused, choosing his next words carefully.

"I agree—the system isn't what it should be. And as a fellow professor, I don't want her to suffer for its failures. But you know the reality, Rosi. The moment her name rises too high, the political machine will grind her down."

Rosalia's fists clenched at her sides.

"Then what?" she demanded. "Tell her she's not good enough? Lie to protect her? Do you have any idea how easy it is to kill a child's ambition? To suffocate a spirit like hers with quiet, careful betrayal? You think you'll be saving her, but you could just as easily condemn her to a life of low self-esteem and wasted potential."

Richard sighed, closing his eyes briefly.

"I admit," he said, voice low, "I was considering it. I thought failure might keep her safe. But after seeing that last spell..."

He opened his eyes again, steady and thoughtful.

"I changed my mind. I think there's another way to keep her safe for longer—without crushing her spirit...chat"

"Welcome back, Lady Sofia. How did it go?" Kristoffer asked as he spotted his master coming down the hall.

"Let's talk inside," she replied, opening the door to her room. Once Kristoffer closed it behind them, she turned back to him, her voice softer.

"Kristoffer... please don't call me 'Lady' today. At least not today. I've been working really hard on the exam. Could you just call me 'Sofie' for a bit?"

"If that will make you happy," he said hesitantly, a small smile touching his lips. "Sofie."

She beamed, her mood visibly improving as she collapsed into her favorite armchair, limbs sprawling carelessly.

"I think the theory part went well, but I'm not sure. The examiner just sat there like a stone, not giving anything away. No feedback, no reactions." She pouted slightly. "I got lucky with the magic circle assignment, though. I recreated the one you used on the teapot you gave me for my twelfth birthday. The last part was tricky—it seemed impossible with just one spell, so I solved it using a magic circle."

"Sounds like you did great, Sofie. I'm sure you'll pass," Kristoffer reassured her, calmly pouring tea into her cup as if nothing in the world could shake his confidence in her.

"If I manage to become a third-circle mage... what does that make you?" Sofia grumbled, taking the cup from him. "I'm not

even sure I know half the runes you do. It's stupid that you can't study magic properly. Society's insane."

"Sofie, I'm not a mage," Kristoffer said, the corners of his lips lifting slightly at her angry puppy expression. "And I'm nothing special. I'm just a bookworm servant who's good at logic and mathematics. Magic isn't only about knowing runes. You have something far rarer—real talent. The way you use your willpower... it's beautiful, natural. I'm just copying equations. It would be disrespectful to real mages to even pretend we're the same."

"Every time you talk like that, it reminds me how stupid you can be sometimes," she said, huffing as she leaned back and took a sip of her tea. "I want a prize for all the studying I had to go through."

"A prize?" Kristoffer asked, raising an eyebrow, already wary.

"Yes. I have been thinking —"

The moment the words left her mouth, Kristoffer carefully set the teapot down and gave her his undivided, alert attention.

"Why are you suddenly so serious?" she asked, squinting suspiciously at him.

"Well, La—Sofie," he corrected quickly, "when you say you've been thinking, things tend to... escalate. I have to prepare myself."

"You're an idiot," she informed him primly, taking another sip. "I'm not a child anymore. I don't get in trouble."

"Sofie," Kristoffer said in a perfectly neutral tone, "last month you brought home a 'pet' that turned out to be a magical beast. It trashed the garden for two days before I managed to capture it. I still remember you saying, 'I've been thinking our mansion could use a pet to liven things up,' right before buying it from a suspicious vendor because it was 'cute.' Five months ago, you said, 'I've been thinking the walls here are very bleak,' and then you—"

"OKAY, OKAY, I GOT IT," Sofia interrupted, scowling at him. "This time it's nothing troublesome! There are flowers that grow only in the wildlife sanctuary. They're beautiful, but they wilt unnaturally fast after being cut, so you can't even buy them. I want to see them while they're still blooming. Let's go on a trip."

Kristoffer sighed, the sound soft but long-suffering.

"A trip to a wildlife sanctuary. And you think there won't be any trouble? Sofie, I think we have very different definitions of the word 'troublesome.'"

"Don't be stupid. We'll stay in the safe zone. Nothing to worry about," she said, waving a hand dismissively. "If I'm such a burden to you, we can even hire some protection..."

"And a guide, to make sure you don't get lost," he added dryly.

"Why are you like this?" she sighed dramatically. "Fine, we'll have a guard and a guide in one. Let's not overdo it. One qualified person will be enough. Does that mean you'll go with me?"

"I'm your servant, Sofie," Kristoffer said simply. "I'll go anywhere you want me to."

At that, Sofia set her tea down, her movements slower.

She stared out of the window, her expression thoughtful, the lightness draining from her for a brief, raw moment.

The silence stretched, heavier than before, until a knock sounded at the door.

"Lady Sofia, your examiners are here to see you," a servant announced politely from the hallway.

Kristoffer immediately moved to the door. After confirming Sofia was ready, he opened it carefully, returning to his natural, silent vigilance.

"Ekhem... Lady Sofia," Richard began, his voice noticeably more respectful than earlier. "I apologize for the delay. We needed a moment to finalize some details. Unfortunately, there are a few legal complications."

Sofia blinked, caught off guard by the shift in his demeanor.

From the corner of her eye, she saw Professor Rosalia nodding with an oddly apologetic expression.

"You see," Richard continued, clearing his throat, "so far, we have only accepted third-circle mages who had at least formally enrolled in the Academy. I am truly ashamed to ask this, but... would you be willing to wait until your enrollment is official before receiving your formal certification?"

"So..." Sofia tilted her head, thinking it through, "I passed the exam, but I'll get the diploma in four years? Sure. I don't really need the title now. It was someone else who pushed me into taking the exams in the first place..."

As she spoke, her eyes flicked toward Kristoffer with a quick, accusing glance — so brief it could have passed for her simply scanning the room.

Then she shrugged lightly toward the professors, her posture casual, as if the outcome didn't concern her in the slightest.

"Thank you for your understanding, Lady Sofia," Richard said, visibly relieved. "I will personally ensure that the day you step into the Academy, your status as a third-circle mage will be immediately formalized. Also..." he added, pulling a small card from his pocket, "if you ever need my support in the future, please don't hesitate to contact me."

He handed her the card with a respectful nod and an almost fatherly smile.

"Richard," Rosalia said dryly, her face an impeccable mask of politeness, "please don't try to steal my student right in front of me."

Richard chuckled under his breath but wisely said nothing more. After a few more congratulations and formal apologies, the examiners took their leave, leaving the room in a quiet, sunlit calm.

"Congratulations, Sofie," Kristoffer said once they were alone again.

"Thank you," she replied, collapsing back into her chair with a satisfied sigh.

She picked up her tea, holding it between both hands, and glanced at him sideways.

"Now go deal with organizing our trip," she said airily. "You can personally choose the guard who'll come with us. Maybe then you'll actually enjoy yourself for once instead of spending the whole time worrying about me."

Kristoffer gave a small, patient smile — the kind only Sofie ever managed to pull from him — and bowed his head slightly.

"As you wish, Sofie."

Time off

Kristoffer's relationship with the other servants had only deteriorated over time.

Unlike the others, who revered Upper Worlders as gods, Kristoffer had been raised within the Elernes estate—and to him, nobles were simply people.

Well, except for Sofia.

Witnessing her brilliance from an early age he was confident that she had to be one of the most talented humans to ever exist. If someone called her a goddess, he could almost understand it. But other Upper Worlders, like the butler Ernest, had nothing divine about them. They just had normal day-to-day jobs serving people like Sofia. Why would anybody see him as a 'greater being'? Kristoffer could not comprehend other servants' mindset.

The situation had worsened even further once word spread that he would be accompanying Lady Sofia on a personal trip.

Jealousy festered.

The attention Sofia gave him, the casual way he spoke to her—it infuriated the other servants, who saw it as dangerous disrespect.

That was why, when the day of the trip finally arrived, Kristoffer allowed himself a rare moment of true relaxation.

Two enormous horse-like magical beasts pulled their sturdy carriage through the countryside. Kristoffer sat beside Greg, the ex-hunter and soldier who would guide them safely into the forest.

In front of them, Sofia was attempting to paint, stubbornly focused despite the jolts and bumps of the road.

The preparations were complete. Every worst-case scenario had been accounted for.

Without even realizing it, Kristoffer's usual vigilance slipped away. His eyes closed. Sleep took him.

Sofia noticed his blissful sleeping face and stifled a laugh behind her hand, her eyes gleaming with mischief.

Most of the time, Kristoffer was so serious, so focused on duties and studies, that she forgot he could even relax.

Despite years of teasing, coaxing, and plotting, she had never quite managed to teach him how to enjoy life for himself. His servitude wasn't just something forced on him; it was a part of him. She didn't like it.

She didn't like that he couldn't see her as an equal, not really.

Still, compared to the worshipful, fearful looks other Lower Worlders gave her, Kristoffer's stubborn honesty was a dramatic improvement.

"Makes me want to sleep too," Greg said, noticing Sofia's expression. He nodded toward the sleeping Kristoffer with a half-smile. "But he's not a very good servant if he sleeps on the job."

"He's been working hard lately," Sofia replied easily, still smiling. "A little break will be good for him. And I don't mind if you take a nap either. With those magic beasts pulling the carriage, we don't exactly need a lookout."

Greg chuckled.

"We'll be at the sanctuary wall in about three hours," he said. "Sticking to the royal roads, it should be a smooth trip."

Sofia returned to her painting, though the bumpy road made precision impossible.

The result was more abstract than she had planned—wavy strokes of grass and trees bending in invisible winds. After a moment of contemplation, she decided she liked it even better this way.

The spirit of the journey, captured not by strict lines, but by the chaos of movement.

It had been too long since she left the estate for anything other than business or shopping trips. The thought of exploring a place

where magic shaped plants and landscapes filled her with excited anticipation.

Maybe, with the right magic circles, she could even grow some of those rare plants in her family's gardens.

"I've heard paintings from the Elnes family fetch high prices among nobles," Greg commented, glancing at her work. "Didn't expect the painter to be so young."

"Art is very autotherapeutic," Sofia replied without looking up. "Painting helps me sort my thoughts. It's a way of putting pieces together without talking. If it's not too personal, I don't mind selling my emotions on a canvas."

Greg chuckled, shifting slightly in his seat.

"Kristoffer's right—you're different from other nobles."

"Do you know Kristoffer well?" Sofia asked, surprised. "Are you a noble too?"

"Oh no," Greg said, laughing. "Not even close. My ancestors came here as farmers. I met Kristoffer about three years ago. I was surprised when he asked for me to guide you personally."

"Strange. He never mentioned you..." Sofia mused, tilting her head. "How did you two meet?"

"I arrested him," Greg said, rubbing the back of his neck awkwardly. "He was wandering the noble district without a servant mark on his hand. Looked suspicious as hell."

Sofia blinked, stunned. She spent most of her time with Kristoffer—how could she have missed something like that?

"Do you remember when it was exactly?"

"Summer, I think," Greg said. "Turned out he was just waiting for his master—who'd gotten lost chasing stray cats."

As Greg explained, realization dawned on him at the same time Sofia's ears turned bright red.

"I was younger back then," she muttered, flustered. "I don't act like that anymore."

Greg chuckled and leaned back against the bench, grinning.

"I didn't realize nobles took on servants so young. Is that even legal if they're under fifteen?"

"He's a survivor child," Sofia explained quietly. "We took him in before the Tower could execute him or ship him to the Lower World."

Greg's smile faded slightly, replaced by a thoughtful frown.

"Twisted law," he muttered. "I'll never understand it. Why's it a crime for Lower World folks to have children here?"

He shook his head, then glanced sideways at her.

"So... he's been your servant since he was born? Isn't it weird? Growing up together like that? Seems like a pretty good way to catch feelings at that age."

Sofia blinked, caught completely off guard.

"It's not like that," she stammered. "I don't even think Kristoffer's capable of seeing me as anything but his master. To him, everything's a math problem that needs solving."

Greg laughed quietly, remembering.

"Yeah, he is a bit strange sometimes. Once, he dragged a peeping tom all the way to our station. The guy was twice his size."

"When was that?!" Sofia demanded, feeling like there was an entire secret life of Kristoffer's she knew nothing about.

"Not too long ago," Greg said, grinning. "Beginning of this spring."

He watched her frustrated expression with amusement, then softened.

"But he cares for you. In his own way. You should've seen how he planned this trip—like he was organizing it for the headmaster himself. He picked the safest day of the week, when the investigation teams left for a cleanup expedition this morning. Most of the bigger animals will be hiding deeper inside the forest now. And he hired me," Greg added with a wink. "Normally, I work yellow-zone jobs. He definitely overpaid for a simple green-zone stroll like this."

"It does sound like something he would do," Sofia sighed, gazing out the window.

Greg leaned back, closing his eyes.

"I might follow the kid's example and nap for a bit. If anything turns up, wake me."

Left alone with her thoughts, Sofia glanced again at Kristoffer's sleeping face and smiled softly. Without a word, she silently apologized for the stray cat incident.

Then she leaned back and closed her own eyes, letting the warm breeze and endless blue sky wash over her. It promised to be a beautiful day.

They slept through most of the journey. The soft murmur of soldiers' voices woke them as the carriage finally came to a halt. Greg stepped out first, heading toward a group of knights stationed by the towering gate.



Sofia and Kristoffer peeked out through the window.

Before them stood the last line of defense between civilization and the wild: sturdy stone buildings clustered near an enormous ten-meter wall, its surface laced with runes that shimmered faintly in the midday light.

The wall wasn't just imposing; it radiated a quiet power, the protective aura woven into its very foundation.

It was the first time either of them had seen the barrier that divided the island's controlled territories from the raw magic of the Sanctuary beyond.

Both of them stared in silent amazement.

Greg returned moments later, dusting off his sleeves.

"We'll need to go through a quick safety course," he informed them. "Security's tighter lately. Even with a guide, there's no skipping it. Luckily, my friend Berian's the commander here. He'll give us the short version. Sofia, since you're an Upper Worlder, you can get a certificate afterward—means you'll skip it next time."

"Aren't you being a little too casual with Lady Sofia?" Kristoffer asked, his tone cooling slightly. "Maybe I should explain again what the Elernes name means."

"No, no, please don't," Sofia interrupted quickly, raising her hands. "I prefer it this way. Honestly."

Greg grinned, sensing an opportunity.

"Pot calling the kettle back, isn't it? Who slept through half the trip in front of his master? Wasn't that 'a bit too casual' too?" he teased. "And besides, where's the consistency? I'm an Upper Worlder too, you know. I don't remember you ever treating me with even half the respect you give her."

Kristoffer raised an eyebrow, unimpressed.

"Maybe if you spent more time arresting real criminals instead of peaceful bystanders, I'd find that respect you're looking for."

"I'll have you know," Greg shot back, "I have one of the highest success rates in the district."

Kristoffer's mouth twitched upward.

"Speaks volumes about our district, if you ask me. Especially if you think chasing peeping toms outside clothing shops counts as—"

"GREG!"

A booming voice cut through their banter.

A middle-aged man stood atop a watchtower, waving a hand. He was dressed in black leather armor — polished, elegant, yet practical. His serious face bore a faint resemblance to Greg's, but unlike Greg's rougher edge, the man radiated calm warmth and authority.

Greg and Kristoffer exchanged smirks like old conspirators before heading toward the tower.

Sofia followed, her steps slowing slightly.

She felt... out of place.

Growing up, Kristoffer had never mingled at noble gatherings. The Elernes family, wary of how it would look to parade a child servant, kept him out of sight during official functions.

Sometimes, he was sent into the city alone — posing as an Upper Worlder thanks to his lack of a servant mark.

But never during public events.

This was the first time Sofia truly saw him interact with Upper Worlders without the heavy veil of "servitude" between them.

And it hurt, more than she expected.

He was different with them.

Casual.

Natural.

The careful distance, the formal politeness — he reserved it for her alone.

Until now, Sofia had told herself it was just the way Lower Worlders were taught to act toward nobles.

But maybe... maybe it was just how he chose to act around her.

Was it because she was his employer?

Was that all she was to him?

Would he even see her as a human being if the contract between them disappeared?

A quiet voice interrupted her thoughts.

"Lady Sofia, are you alright?"

Kristoffer had stopped a few steps ahead, turning back to her with that same calm, steady expression he always wore.

Waiting.

Watching.

She forced a small smile, lifting her skirts slightly as she hurried to catch up.

"Yes," she replied quickly, masking her turmoil. "I was just thinking about my next painting." She stepped closer, her voice brightening. "Let's go in."

Greg led them into a modest office where the man who had called them earlier was now seated behind a sturdy wooden desk.

As they entered, he rose to his feet, bowing respectfully.



"I had no idea a daughter of Lady Isabelle was arriving today," he said warmly. "Otherwise, I would have prepared a more proper

welcome. It's an honor to meet you, Lady Sofia. My name is Berian, and I command this unit."

"It's a pleasure to meet you too, Commander Berian," Sofia said, offering a radiant smile that seemed to brighten the entire room.

"And please, just call me Sofia. I'm still a year away from being considered an adult. Do you know my mother well?"

Berian's face softened into a fond smile.

"Lady Isabelle often comes by to gather rare plants for her research. She is also kind enough to treat any wounded when she is here," he explained, turning to the accompanying hunter with a grin. "Greg, good to see you. You look well fed."

Greg laughed and stepped forward to shake his hand.

"The food's definitely better with the army than whatever scraps you survive on out here," he teased.

Berian laughed heartily. "Still, if you ever get tired of city life and patrolling the borders, you're always welcome back. We could use someone like you."

"Isn't everyone here part of the army anyway?" Sofia asked, genuinely curious.

"Well technically yes, but in practice, no," Berian smiled awkwardly. "We cooperate with the army, but our focus is on protecting this precious nature sanctuary. The army is responsible for keeping public safety and fighting off whatever

tries to come to our island. Our mission is to maintain the balance of the sanctuary's ecosystem. Sometimes we cull dangerous species when their numbers get too high; other times, we work to preserve endangered ones."

"Also, in the army they pay well, but here you get whatever scraps are left," Greg added with a grin.

"The pay might be lower, but you get to spend time in nature. The capital can become suffocating," the commander gestured for them to sit as he poured tea into simple, sturdy cups.

"I apologize if this is rude to ask," Berian said, glancing at Kristoffer, "but is your servant allowed to join us at the table?"

"I'd be offended if he wasn't," Sofia replied lightly, settling into her chair.

Berian's smile deepened, a hint of relief in his posture.

"That's what I expected from Lady Isabelle's daughter. But you'd be surprised how often things are... different around here."

He turned to Kristoffer and offered his hand.

"Nice to meet you too, Kristoffer. I'm Berian."

Kristoffer stood straight and accepted the handshake without hesitation.

"My name is Kristoffer, and I serve Lady Sofia. It's nice to meet you, Commander Berian."

Berian gave a small nod of approval before settling back into his chair.

"Well then," he said, rubbing his hands together, "now that introductions are done, I'm sorry to rush you, but my schedule today is a bit packed."

He shot an exaggeratedly accusing look at Greg. "Someone neglected to tell me we were getting VIPs."

Greg shrugged with a crooked, remorseless grin. Berian shook his head with a chuckle.

"But I'll help however I can. What brings you here today?"

"I'd like to see some Ondines," Sofia said brightly.

"Ondines?" Berian repeated, visibly surprised.

"Flowers that grow only here, inside the sanctuary," she explained. "They feed on mana instead of sunlight, and they die quickly after being cut."

"Like mother, like daughter," Berian laughed heartily. "Well, that shouldn't be a problem. I know those flowers. They grow in the safe zones, so I don't expect any trouble. But I'll have to bore you with some details for your certificate."

"I can explain on the way," Greg suggested. "You said you were busy today."

"It's fine. I want to finish my tea break," Berian waved a hand casually. "You should know the sanctuary is divided into three

zones. The center and everything in a ten-kilometer radius around it is classified as a red zone. That's where one of the old mana rifts appeared—mana there is extremely dense. Over time, animals evolved, some becoming... considerably dangerous. We send hunting groups regularly to keep the population manageable. One of the teams went out this morning, actually."

He paused to sip his tea, his gaze catching on Kristoffer, who had unconsciously leaned forward in his seat, eyes sparkling with fascination.

Berian smiled kindly. "Do you like magical beasts?"

Sofia almost choked on her tea, startled by the unexpected softness in Berian's tone. For a moment, it almost seemed like he was talking to a wide-eyed child enchanted by fairy tales. Although she suspected the commander misunderstood Kristoffer's nature, it was still heartwarming to see his thoughtfulness.

Kristoffer, however, didn't miss a beat. He launched into a rapid-fire string of questions. "The evolution of magical beasts sounds fascinating, but I'm more curious about the rift itself. How large was it? Has the terrain been altered? Are there secondary mana pools formed—?"

Sofia noticed Berian's eyebrows lifting in confusion—and a faint hint of suspicion. It wasn't legal for Lower Worlders to study magic, let alone speak about it so openly. Unfortunately,

Kristoffer's fascination with magical theory tended to override his usual caution.

"I'm sorry," Sofia interrupted quickly, stepping lightly on Kristoffer's foot under the table. "My servant gets overexcited. You know how boys are with anything dangerous."

She flashed her most innocent smile. Across the table, Greg was visibly struggling not to laugh, biting the inside of his cheek.

Berian gave her a knowing look but let it pass.

"As I was saying," he continued smoothly, "the red zone is extremely dangerous. I've only been to the center a few times myself, and never for long. The mana concentration there is so high that even high-circle mages don't stay more than an hour. Exposure tends to have... unpleasant effects on the mind. But for your trip, none of that should matter. The flowers you want are deep inside the green zone—the safe zone."

He leaned back slightly, his voice growing a little lighter.

"The green zone is relatively harmless. Most creatures there are harmless herbivores or mana-saturated plants. Still, stay close to Greg at all times. Nature has a way of surprising even seasoned guides. He can deploy a magic shield if anything unexpected happens."

"It's okay," Sofia added brightly. "I can cast shield spells too. We won't go in deep, but I'd love to do some sketching while we're there."

"You can already cast shield magic at fourteen?" Greg asked, eyebrows lifting in honest surprise.

"As expected of Lady Isabelle's daughter," Berian said, chuckling warmly. "Well, that's about everything you need to know."

He drained the last of his tea and stood, smoothing the creases from his jacket.

"Unfortunately, I have to meet with a certain baron who keeps insisting on hunting in my sanctuary." His tone soured slightly. "Greg will take good care of you. If anything comes up, just leave a message at the gate—I'll make sure the guards are informed to treat you with respect."

He bowed politely to Sofia, nodded to Kristoffer, and walked out with steady, confident steps.

As the door closed, Greg clapped Kristoffer lightly on the shoulder.

"Congratulations," he said with a broad grin. "You didn't even last fifteen minutes before making Berian think you're a weirdo."

"I'm impressed as well," lifting her teacup with an exaggeratedly serious face.

Kristoffer slumped slightly, staring down at his feet as if they were the most fascinating thing in the world.

The towering trees stretched high into the sky, their thick branches heavy with leaves in colors Sofia had never seen before—vivid purples, deep oranges, and glistening silvers that shimmered under the filtered sunlight.

Even the small critters and birds darting among the branches were extraordinary, bearing strange traits: tiny horns, shimmering scales, glowing red eyes, razor-sharp claws. Everything here felt like a dream woven from wild, ancient magic.

But what truly captivated her were the flowers. Their intoxicating aromas and dazzling hues made her heart race with wonder. She leaned down toward a particularly brilliant bloom, losing herself in the vivid world around her—until a voice called her back.

"Try not to wander off the path," Greg reminded firmly. "It's hard to protect you if I can't even see you."



Reluctantly, Sofia let go of the flower and moved closer to Kristoffer and their guide.

"How is this a safe zone if I can't even stop to smell the flowers?" she grumbled under her breath.

"Sorry," Greg said with a sheepish smile. "I'm paid to keep you safe, not to let you get eaten by something hiding in the bushes."

Sofia shot an accusing look at Kristoffer, but her servant remained stoically focused on the path ahead, as if her frustrations floated right past him.

With a heavy sigh, she fell into step behind them.

"Greg," she said after a moment, trying to lighten the mood, "I heard that soldiers are taught some of the forbidden spells."

"We learn a few basics," Greg admitted carefully. "Things necessary for defending the country. But we take a strict oath not to misuse that knowledge. I'm sure you know—violence is harshly punished in the Upper World. Usually by death."

"You can use that kind of magic for more than just violence," Sofia muttered, disappointment clear in her voice.

Greg glanced back at her but didn't comment. Sofia shifted gears, curiosity pulling her attention.

"How long were you a hunter here?"

"About ten years," Greg said, chuckling awkwardly. "But it didn't pay enough for a house. The army's safer—and better fed."

He shook his head. "Out here, it always feels like something's trying to kill you."

"Have you ever been near the center of the sanctuary?" Sofia asked, her voice brightening. "Any unique plants that don't exist outside of there?"

"Honestly, I never paid much attention to flowers," Greg laughed. "I was too focused on staying alive. I was a yellow zone hunter. We left the red zone to professionals like Berian."

Sofia tilted her head thoughtfully.

"Is he really that strong? He seems so... kind. I can't imagine him in a fight."

"Not just strong," Greg said. "Smart, too. Back at the academy, he topped the second-best class in our year. Of course, that was forty years ago—when blood purity wasn't everything. Berian's from—"

He broke off suddenly, his body stiffening. His hand drifted instinctively toward the wand at his belt.

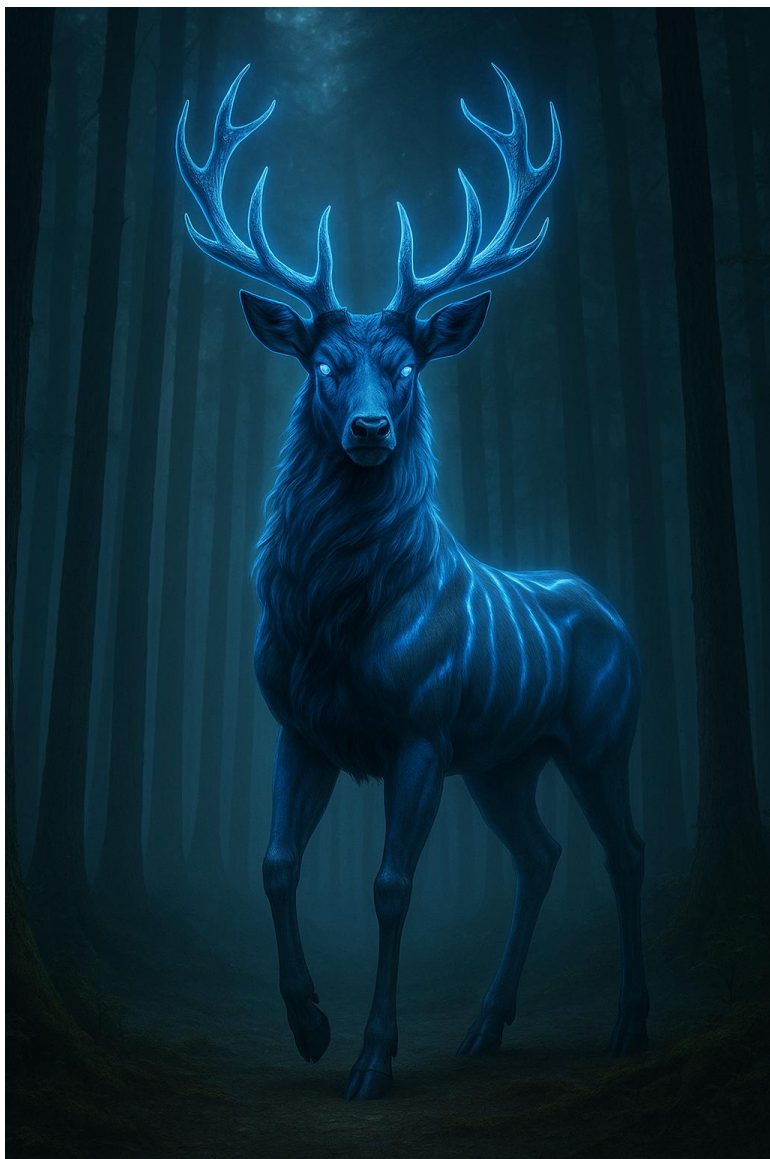
"Quiet," Greg said sharply. "Something's coming."

Before Sofia could react, Kristoffer had already stepped protectively in front of her.

Following Greg's narrowed gaze, Sofia peered into the trees, her heartbeat quickening.

A massive creature resembling a deer was watching them from the shadows. Its enormous three-meter frame shimmered under the dappled light, striped with faintly glowing blue lines that

pulsed along its body. Twin antlers, radiating an eerie blue glow, crowned its head like a pair of ghostly flames.



"It's an emnlat," Greg whispered. "It shouldn't be here. And it's a big one. Start walking back—slowly. No sudden moves."

Sofia obeyed immediately, stepping backward with cautious, measured movements. But the emnlat mirrored her, its luminous antlers bobbing as it crept closer.

"Run!" Greg barked, breaking the tense silence. "Hide behind the trees!"

Sofia spun to flee—

—but before she could even take a full step, Kristoffer scooped her up effortlessly, sprinting back along the path they had come from with shocking speed.

Greg seized the moment, drawing a fast sequence of runes in the air.

"Magic missile!" A blue-glowing projectile blasted from the red crystal embedded in his wand, hurling straight toward the emnlat's head.

The projectile shot forward, striking the emnlat directly in the head. The enormous beast halted its charge, shaking its head in fury. Between the horns, a shimmering blue mana needle began to materialize.

"Shield!" Greg shouted, throwing up a barrier just as the needle launched forward.

The emnlat's attack struck the invisible shield with a sharp, ringing crack, shattering into glittering fragments that rained harmlessly down.

The beast snorted, pawed at the ground—and then, with a frustrated bellow, turned to flee into the deeper forest.

"Oh no, you don't!" Greg growled and launched into a chase. His wand moved quickly constructing another spell.

"Piercing missile!"

This time, the magic formed a narrow, dense lance of pure energy—thinner, deadlier, and far harsher than the wild beauty of the emnlat's shimmering spellwork.

Just as the creature's massive body slipped between the trees, Greg released his spell.

The projectile whistled through the air and struck cleanly into the emnlat's side. The beast let out a terrible, guttural scream, its legs buckling beneath it as it thrashed violently. It convulsed for several long seconds before finally collapsing into the brush, motionless at last.

"Damn, that was close." Greg exhaled sharply, his shoulders sagging as the adrenaline drained from his body. He turned to look over his shoulder—and blinked in surprise.

Sofia and Kristoffer had retreated a good fifty meters during the chaos, using the trees as cover.

"You two alright?" he called out, sheathing his wand.

"We're fine!" Sofia replied, hurrying back toward him, worry etched across her face. "Are you hurt?"

"I'm fine," Greg said, wiping sweat from his brow. "But that was a tough one. I was lucky none of my spells fizzled out. Honestly, I mess up that last spell more often than not." For the first time, they saw him laughing so heartily that it made him look strikingly like Berian.

"That thing was huge! Can we take a closer look?" Sofia asked, her eyes sparkling with excitement.

"I wouldn't recommend it," Greg said, reaching into his jacket and pulling out a small flask. He took a long sip before continuing. "It was a strong mana beast. The mana around its body might still act violently for an hour or so."

Sofia's face fell in disappointment. "That's a shame. Maybe we can check it out on our way back? We must be close to the flowers by now."

"Lady Sofia, we were just attacked by a dangerous mana beast. We should return immediately. This area isn't safe," Kristoffer argued, his tone firm.

"The kid's right," Greg agreed, nodding. He gave Kristoffer an approving pat on the shoulder. "Emnlats usually stay deep in the yellow zone. They were originally from the red zone. It normally takes a team of three to take one down."

"But is it really that dangerous? Do you think there might be more? It looked like a stray," Sofia questioned him, not ready to give up on the Ondines.

"They usually travel in groups," Greg admitted, rubbing the back of his neck. "This one probably got separated when its herd was being hunted... but I'd still advise heading back. There could be more strays."

"If it got separated, wouldn't the others be far away by now?" Sofia countered quickly. "We're so close! Let's just finish what we came to do and head back."

"Lady Sofia, we can come back with a bigger group some other day," Kristoffer insisted.

"But we're already here!" she protested, then turned to Greg with wide, pleading eyes. "Would you keep going if it were just you?"

Greg scratched his head awkwardly. "Hmm... probably."

"See?" Sofia grinned. "If something happens, we can just run away again—and you can do your thing."

Greg sighed, defeated. "Alright, alright—you're the boss."

Kristoffer sighed loudly in return. Sofia turned to him with a radiant, mischievous smile.

The group continued carefully down the path, their senses heightened. Despite their vigilance, no further threats emerged.

Before long, the trees parted to reveal a small clearing, darker and thicker than the rest of the forest.

Sofia's eyes lit up instantly. Nestled in the shadow of an ancient tree—easily towering over fifty meters—was a cluster of glowing blue flowers, their light casting soft ripples across the clearing.



"Lady Sofia, please don't run off," Kristoffer warned as she dashed toward the flowers.

"Isn't it beautiful?" she laughed, waving him off without slowing.

"Yes. Lady Sofia. It's very pretty," Kristoffer replied, his gaze sweeping the trees around them with growing wariness.

"You know," Sofia said, crouching by the flowers, "Ondines only started appearing about twenty years ago. They feed on mana, so they prefer dark places where sunlight can't reach them. Nothing can grow near them—they drain mana from everything, even each other."

She leaned in, brushing a gentle finger along a petal.

"People think they're the most beautiful flowers alive," she continued softly. "But I feel a little sorry for them. Admired from a distance... but they live lonely lives. Far from others. Always isolated." She inhaled the faint, sweet scent and glanced up with a mischievous smile. "Tell me, Kristoffer. Would you rather be admired but alone—or ordinary, surrounded by your kind?"

Kristoffer thought about it for a moment, completely serious. "I'd rather be a poisonous plant," he said. "That way, I could live with others—and keep predators away. Preferably black, to absorb more sunlight."

Sofia groaned theatrically. "Of course. So logical."

"There's a flower called the Hellebore—or Hatu," she added, settling more comfortably in the grass. "It blooms only in winter. Beautiful white petals, tough as nails. It survives anything—frozen soil, harsh winds, lack of light. Completely focused on

survival. Honestly, Kristoffer, you and the Hatu are a perfect match."

Before Kristoffer could retort, Greg reappeared, his boots crunching lightly over the leaves.

"Area looks clear," he said, scanning the clearing one more time.

"But we shouldn't go any deeper."

"We don't need to," Sofia answered brightly. "Just give me a moment. I want to make a quick sketch... and try something."

She rummaged through her bag, pulling out parchment and tools. It took only a few minutes to produce a clean, detailed drawing. Then, carefully, she cut one of the Ondines.

The blue petals darkened almost instantly, the vibrant color bleeding away until the flower hung limp and dead in her hand.

Sofia frowned but didn't give up. She moved to a second bloom, cut it just as carefully, and this time channeled a slow, steady trickle of mana through her fingers. The flower's color remained vivid, the petals glowing gently against her palm.

A bright, triumphant smile spread across her face. "Just as I thought. If we support them with mana, they might survive outside the sanctuary. Maybe even in the gardens!"

She gathered a few more flowers, cradling them like fragile treasures. Yet as she worked, a subtle unease began to creep along her skin—a magnetic pull rising from the deeper woods

beyond, tugging at her senses with a rhythm almost too faint to name.

The forest around her sharpened. Every sound—the distant chirp of a bird, the faint rustle of a mouse in the undergrowth—resonated like a heartbeat in her chest. The scents of damp earth and living greenery grew intoxicating, and the ambient mana of the sanctuary seemed to flow into her bones, weaving itself into her pulse.

With every breath, every step, the pull deepened—ancient, alive, insistent. Something was calling her from the heart of the forest.

Sofia hesitated, standing there with the flowers in her arms. The temptation to follow the call gnawed at her, whispering promises of understanding, of connection.

She closed her eyes briefly. "No," she whispered, steadying herself with sheer willpower.

When she opened them again, her face was calm. She looked down at the flowers she held and smiled faintly, masking the turmoil inside.

"Okay," she said, her voice light. "Let's head back to the emnlat. I want to see its antlers."

Greg and Kristoffer both exhaled quietly in relief and moved to follow her. They retraced their steps with cautious speed, sticking close together. But just as they neared the clearing, Greg suddenly halted, throwing out an arm to block their path.

"Wait," he whispered sharply.

In the dense canopy above, a massive spider crouched among the branches, nearly invisible against the thick foliage. Only the glint of its many red eyes gave it away, flashing ominously in the dim light. Its black, furry body blended so perfectly with the trees that it might have been missed entirely—if it hadn't been watching them.

"I've never seen anything like it," Greg murmured, his voice tight. "It's definitely watching us. And it's sitting right above the path."

He hesitated, his instincts prickling. "I don't know if it was there earlier... but I don't like this. We should cut through the forest. Avoid it."

"I trust you," Sofia replied softly, her voice barely audible.

They began backing away carefully, step by step, but the spider moved with them, shifting its bulk in an unnervingly fluid motion. It leapt to a closer branch, shortening the distance.

"Stop," Greg ordered, holding out a hand.

"It won't let us leave," he said grimly. "We need to act first. I'll strike, then we run. If it dies, good. If not, I'll buy us time."

Greg focused with all his might. His willpower was already a bit strained after the previous battle, but he had to successfully cast his most deadly spell, or they would be in grave danger. He channeled mana into the magical crystal in his wand to maximize the power.

“Get ready,” he warned them as he shaped the mana into the runes “Piercing missile.”

The spell materialized, larger and more potent than before. The blue projectile swirled with energy, spinning furiously as it shot toward the spider with incredible speed.

Yet just before impact, it dispersed—breaking apart into shimmering blue particles that floated harmlessly in the air

“Huh?” Greg’s voice faltered in shock.

The spider wasted no time. It lunged, moving with terrifying speed from branch to branch before landing in the clearing with a heavy thud.



“Shie-” Greg tried to cast a defensive spell, the moment the spider spat a bright green liquid toward him.

He was too late. The fluid splashed across his face and neck, and his screams of agony echoed through the forest.

Sofia watched in horror, frozen, as his skin began to melt away, the acid eating through flesh and muscle. Desperately, Greg tried to wipe it off, but the acid only spread, devouring his hands and arms as well. His cries grew weaker, until finally, mercifully, he collapsed lifelessly to the ground.

Sofia's breath caught.

Before she could react, another ball of green acid hurtled toward her, hissing as it cut through the air. She tried to jump back, heart hammering wildly—but it was too late.

The acid was only a meter away when Kristoffer moved, faster than thought. He threw himself between her and the attack, his left forearm raised as a shield.

“Shield!” he shouted.

Mana flared into existence, forming a thin, trembling barrier. The acid struck with a wet, ugly impact—and began eating through the shield almost instantly. Several drops broke through, splattering across Kristoffer’s forearm and chest.

Sofia hit the ground hard, dazed, the crushed flowers spilling from her trembling hands. She stared, wide-eyed, as Kristoffer hissed in pain, his face tight with focus.

He shot her a quick glance, confirming she was unharmed, before turning his full attention back to the spider. Sofia recognized that look—the cold, clinical calculation. Kristoffer’s mind was already racing ahead, mapping out every possible move and outcome.

“WATER BARRIER!” he shouted, raising both hands.

Mana surged from him. A swirling vortex of water burst into existence, wrapping them in a protective globe. The ground around them dried instantly, the water barrier roaring

as it spun furiously, intercepting the next volley of acidic spit. The deadly fluid was absorbed into the spiraling shield, neutralized by the flowing water.

"Lady Sofia, I apologize for my incompetence, but I need your help now," Kristoffer spoke up quietly, his face showing his intense focus and pain. Blood was flowing down his left arm as he held the spell "I'll need you to set up the same barrier. I will deal with the spider, but you must protect us if we want to survive."

"The same barrier?" Sofia echoed, her mind struggling to catch up.

Another ball of acid slammed against the roaring vortex, sending a tremor through the shield.

"Yes, Lady Sofia. I know you can do it. There are four aspects of it and the joints between the runes are quite complex, but it is nothing you cannot do. You need the rune of water, rotation, shield and barrier-"

"I have seen it during your cast" she interrupted him, digging her nails deep into her palms to regain some clarity of mind. "I will do it. If you say I can do it... then I will."

Kristoffer managed a strained laugh.

"It is just like you, Lady Sofia, to grasp an entire spell structure in a moment." He shifted, steadying himself. "The instant your barrier is up, I'll drop mine."

Another blast of acid struck, but the shield held firm—barely.

"I told you not to call me 'Lady' when we're alone," Sofia said with a quick, shaky smile, before closing her eyes.

"Water Barrier."

Mana swirled from her, rising in graceful arcs. The ground beneath them dried again as her water gathered strength. Kristoffer's existing vortex wavered, beginning to collapse—but before the falling water could even touch the soil, it was absorbed seamlessly into Sofia's newly-formed stream.

This time, the shield wasn't wild and violent. It flowed in controlled spirals, a beautiful, stable current that seemed almost in harmony with the living forest around them. When the spider launched another attack, the new barrier devoured it effortlessly, scattering the acid into harmless mist.

Kristoffer wasted no time.

"Clean" he muttered, casting a healing spell on his injured arm.

The pain hit immediately.

He gritted his teeth through the agony, the acidic burns hissing and crackling as the magic fought to purge the corruption.

Sofia flinched visibly, worry etched across her face.

Without hesitation, Kristoffer repeated the spell over his scorched chest, his hands trembling slightly with the effort.

When the worst of the damage was contained, he forced himself upright, reaching for Greg's bow.

Kristoffer knew the basics of archery, but he definitely didn't consider himself a proper hunter. However, seeing how the spider canceled Greg's spell before, Kristoffer concluded it was still their best shot. What happened there did not look like a mana shield, but more like deconstruction of the spell. It should not be possible, but Kristoffer saw the proof with his own eyes. If the spider could destroy magic, physical attacks would be their best bet.

"Lady Sofia, please maintain the barrier. I'll be walking in and out, so don't get surprised. Keep your focus," Kristoffer instructed, rising to his feet.

He nocked an arrow and locked eyes on the spider. It had ceased its attack, the red eyes cautiously observing them from the distance. Kristoffer carefully moved out of the defensive water barrier, opening a small entrance by shaping the mana in front of him. The spider reacted instantly, launching another volley of its deadly spit. Kristoffer retreated swiftly into the barrier, the swirling water deflecting the acid harmlessly. With practiced resolve, he stepped back out and loosed the arrow.

The arrow flew true, but when it was halfway there the spider jumped from the ground to a nearby tree. Dodging the attack, did not stop the furry insect from spitting another ball of the deadly fluid towards the boy. Kristoffer barely managed to dive back into

the barrier, the water once again absorbing the lethal attack. He clicked his tongue in frustration.

“Kristoffer, I can’t hold this much longer!” Sofia cried out, her voice cracking with strain. Maintaining a spell of such complexity wasn’t just draining her mana—it was tearing at her will. It felt like painting four different canvases at once, each demanding absolute precision.

Kristoffer’s eyes darted around the battlefield. They were out of options—until his gaze landed on Greg’s body. The half-melted corpse lay slumped on the ground, armor still hissing where acid clung to it.

Even in death, Greg could save them.

“I’m sorry,” Kristoffer whispered. He crouched quickly and dipped the tip of his arrow into the pool of still-burning fluid. It sizzled on contact.

He stood, nocked the arrow, and took a breath.

Blood trickled from his arm, his grip tight with effort. Mana surged around him like a tightly wound coil. His face was pale, his body trembling, but he stepped outside the barrier once more.

“Tracking shot” he murmured.

The spell snapped to life.

The arrow surged forward, cloaked in spiraling mana. A silver streak tearing through the air.

The spider moved—fast. It leapt from its branch just in time to avoid the direct strike. But Kristoffer didn't flinch.

Sofia felt the mana shift.

Her breath caught.

Even at that distance, he hadn't lost control. The spell held steady—anchored not to the beast, but to the venom it had left behind. The acid on the arrow's tip pulled it like a scent on the wind.

The arrow veered midair.

Like a hungry beast, it followed its mark.

Just as the spider's legs hit the ground, the arrow curved and pierced its abdomen from behind with a sickening crunch. A shriek followed—high and unnatural. Viscous green fluid poured from the wound, hissing as it hit the ground.

The spider reared, flailing in agony. It launched one last, wild glob of venom—missing them completely—before it turned and bounded away into the trees, bleeding heavily, its screeches growing fainter as it disappeared into the forest.

Silence fell like a curtain.

Sofia's concentration shattered. The barrier dropped with a crash of water, soaking her from head to toe.

Kristoffer staggered.

"I think... it's gone," he muttered, barely upright.

Then, somehow, he smiled. “You’re incredible as always, Lady Sofia... I spent days constructing that barrier spell. You held it together on your first try.”

Sofia rushed to him. “You idiot!”

She caught him just before he collapsed. Her hands hovered over his arm and chest, her face pale.

The acid had eaten deep—through fabric, through skin.

“Why would you jump in like that?” she demanded, panic rising. “I don’t know what this stuff is—I can’t treat it. We have to get you to a doctor. Fast.”

“I am your servant, Lady Sofia,” Kristoffer murmured, his expression dazed but content. “I’m just glad I was able to protect you. You should follow the path and return to commander Berian. It’s too dangerous here.”

“Why can’t you think about yourself for once?” she snapped, tears burning at the corners of her eyes. “I want to protect you too. I hate seeing you hurt, Kristoffer. I hate it!”

“But you did protect me, Sofie,” he whispered, and from the undamaged fold of his jacket, he pulled out a handkerchief with trembling fingers. “Without you... we’d both be dead. Your barrier saved us.”

Sofia bit her lip as he gently reached out and dried her face, the motion painfully slow. His hand dropped a moment later, the last bit of strength gone from him.

She looked to Greg's melted corpse, then back at Kristoffer's trembling form. Panic surged. Could she carry him? Should she run for help? Could she leave him here alone?

Greg's ruined face swam in her vision. Her legs still shook. But the sight of Kristoffer—his bloodied chest rising and falling—gave her clarity. She stood, braced herself, and tried to lift him.

He was heavier than she remembered. Solid muscle beneath the ruined uniform. Her arms strained with effort.

He groaned in protest. "Don't... it's fine... just go..."

But he had no strength left to stop her.

Sofia stumbled forward, dragging him with stubborn resolve. Every step was agony. They'd never make it—not without help.

And then... something stirred in the forest.

The sound of footsteps. Rustling leaves. Low, urgent voices.

She froze.

Was it the spider, returning? Another beast?

She clenched her fists, preparing to summon a spell—but before the incantation even reached her lips, four figures broke through the trees.

"Help!" Sofia cried, voice raw and panicked. "Please!"

“Rey—movement ahead!” a tall man shouted, his voice sharp with alarm. All four rushed forward, weapons drawn, eyes scanning the shadows.

Then they saw her. Saw Kristoffer.

“Children?” their leader said, confused—until his gaze dropped to the blood soaking Kristoffer’s uniform. “Shit. Krein, treat him now. We need to stop that bleeding before he crashes. Rey, cover me.”

One of the men immediately knelt beside Kristoffer, unrolling a leather case of vials and tools. A healer.

The leader turned to Sofia, his tone brisk but not unkind. “What about you? Are you injured anywhere?”

“I... I’m fine,” she managed. Her body trembled. “But please... please, we need to get him to a doctor—”

“Don’t worry. We’ll carry him,” Rey said, already slinging Kristoffer’s arm over his shoulder. “He’s lucky we were tracking the spider. Thing shot past us like the gods themselves were chasing it. We followed the trail of acid here.”

He paused, eyeing her closely.

“You look like you’ve been through hell. Are you sure you weren’t bitten? Any cuts? That stuff can linger.”

“I’m fine, it was—”

But the sentence never finished.

The world lurched sideways, and Sofia collapsed without a sound, eyes fluttering shut as everything went black.

Eduard Elernes had been a very busy man lately. The Noble faction already took over the Tower and National Academy. The most powerful institutes have been contaminated with some absurd ideologies about purity of blood. As a direct descendant of one of the First Counselors, Eduard felt a deep responsibility to uphold the old values, where merit, skill, and knowledge were the true measures of worth—not the superficiality of skin or hair color.

This commitment to fairness had brought him to his current meeting. He sat across from Bayan Cosar, a company owner accused of paying lower wages to employees without direct lineage to the First Faculty. The practice blatantly defied the Forefathers' Law, which emphasized equality and fairness.

“Mr. Eduard, I must reiterate, it’s not a lower wage,” Cosar defended himself. “All employees receive the same base pay. Bonuses are awarded purely on performance.”

Eduard's stern expression betrayed no belief in the man’s words. He knew, after thorough investigations, that Cosar was merely a puppet for Baron Valron, who orchestrated these injustices from behind the scenes. Before Eduard could press further, a knock on the door interrupted the tense meeting.

“Who is it? I’m in a meeting,” Eduard asked coldly.

“Lord Eduard, it’s about your daughter, Sofia,” his secretary replied from behind the door.

“I believe we’re done here,” Cosar seized the opportunity to stand, brushing off the tension. “You have my statement already, Mr. Eduard. I am a busy man, in the future contact my lawyers directly.” With that, the company owner left the room.

The secretary entered, bowing apologetically. “Forgive me for interrupting, Lord Eduard, but you told me to come to you no matter what, when it came to your daughter. She had an accident during her trip and was transported back to your home, with doctors caring for her in the carriage on the way back.”

Eduard’s eyes narrowed in alarm. “Cancel all my meetings. I’m leaving at once.”

Although justice and fairness were important to him, his daughter was even more so. With a heavy stomach the lawyer decided to get back home as quickly as possible. Instead of taking the carriage, he asked servants in his office to put a saddle on his personal mana beast steed. The powerful, horned creature awaited him outside, and he mounted it carefully. Eduard cantered through the busy streets and moved into gallop as soon as he left the center.

Within ten minutes, Eduard arrived at his estate. Servants briefed him quickly before he made his way to the guest room where

Sofia was resting. Preparing for the worst, Eduard opened the door cautiously and peeked inside. Sofia's servant was sleeping in the bed covered in bandages, and his daughter was snoozing on Isabelle's lap next to him. His wife was petting Sofia's head and smiling. Noticing her husband, Isabelle rose quietly, gently putting their daughter's head next to Kristoffer. She gestured for silence before guiding Eduard out of the room.

"What happened? Is she okay?" Eduard asked nervously, the moment they were alone.

"She's fine. Just dizzy from overexertion—and shock," Isabelle said, loosening the tie on her hair with a weary sigh. The golden strands fell down her back, slightly tangled from hours of stress. "She burned through more mana than she's ever used in her life. Once she's rested, she'll recover."

She paused. Her next words came quieter.

"The boy, though... that's another story."

Eduard's expression darkened. "Kristoffer?"

Isabelle nodded. "He saved her, Eduard. That poison—whatever was in the spider's spit—I've never seen anything like it. It mixed with his blood, burned through skin, tendons... part of the bone. I honestly don't know how he's still alive." Her voice grew heavier. "The damage is already set in. Most of the wounds were properly disinfected by the time he got here, but healing magic has its

limits. If I accelerate his regeneration too fast, I'll overload his already weak body. He's barely holding on as it is."

Eduard ran both hands through his hair. "Will he make it?"

Isabelle didn't answer immediately.

"I don't know," she admitted finally. "Even if he does, his left arm might never work the same again. The nerve damage is severe. And the scars—they'll be permanent."

Eduard paced a few steps, thoughts turning over too quickly. "But what happened? How did it come to this?"

"They went to that sanctuary field trip Sofia told us about," Isabelle said, rubbing her temples. "I reached out to one of the stationed commanders. Apparently, a 'mage-killer spider' appeared in the forest. A rare one. Violently territorial. It attacked one of the scouting units too. A lot of hunters died."

She leaned against the edge of the table.

"But here's the thing," she added. "That spider... ran."

Eduard blinked. "What?"

"It ran from them, Eduard. The survivors who followed the trail said the spider was injured—bleeding—and fleeing in a panic. They tracked it through the forest and found Kristoffer barely conscious, and Sofia still standing. Soaked, surrounded by acid, blood, and death." Isabelle crossed her arms. "These are seasoned hunters. They've seen horrors. They don't exaggerate."

She gave him a pointed look. “They’re already whispering. About her. That she made the spider run. That it fled from her magic. Maybe they think it was luck. Or a fluke. But more than one of them called it a miracle.”

Eduard exhaled, his pulse quickening. “An Upper World girl and a Lower World servant face down one of the most dangerous beasts known to us—and it runs.” He shook his head. “Of course people will talk.”

Isabelle’s voice lowered. “And there’s more. Sofia told me... Kristoffer used magic.”

Eduard froze.

He had always known how close the two of them were, but not this close. Not enough for her to risk that. How had they missed so much? What else had unfolded under their roof, right beneath their noses? It wasn’t just oversight—it was distance. Years of chasing reform and ideals while letting their daughter grow up largely alone.

He ran a hand through his hair. “Even if he can use magic,” he said slowly, “how could two children survive something that wiped out trained hunters?”

Isabelle hesitated, then spoke with quiet conviction. “From what she described... he’s gifted. Exceptionally so. Maybe even more than her.”

Eduard blinked. “More than Sofia?”

“That’s what she said,” Isabelle confirmed. “And I believe her. She wasn’t jealous. She was proud of him. But it’s dangerous, Eduard. If this gets out—his ability, what they did today—our family could be dragged into it. We’re already walking a political tightrope.”

Eduard gave her a cautious look. “Are you saying we should... get rid of him?”

“What? No!” she snapped. “It’s too late for that—and even if it weren’t, I’d never let you. Not after everything. Not after he saved her life.”

She rubbed her eyes, then met his gaze again. “I just want us to be smart. If he survives... what’s our plan?”

Eduard nodded, slowly. “Then we say nothing. If they’ve kept this secret this long, they know the risks better than we do. We’ll speak with Sofia when she’s ready, but for now... silence is safer. And later, maybe—if he really is that skilled—we could use it. A Lower Worlder mage, strong as any noble-born? That would shake a few pillars.”

Isabelle sighed. “The boy’s half-dead, and you’re already imagining how to weaponize him.”

She softened and leaned in to kiss his cheek. “Let’s think about dinner instead. They both need rest, and Nora cried herself to sleep. I had to kick her out just to finish treating his wounds.”

Eduard let out a long breath, tension easing from his shoulders. “Alright. But I’m going to need a drink. And I want every detail. Don’t leave anything out.”

It was still dark outside when Kristoffer opened his eyes. The only light in the room was coming from a faint, bluish glow of a magical lamp. Pain radiated through his entire body, and the world spun slightly, but fragments of memory began to piece themselves together. The last thing he remembered was being carried by some hunters they met on the way. He turned his head slightly and noticed Sofia’s cute, sleeping face right next to his right hand. The sight took a huge weight off his chest. Seeing her safe with such a blissful expression made the pain more bearable but he was still restless.

This immense whirlwind of emotions swirling inside his chest was something new to him. He remembered the gruesome scene. The moment the spider attacked his master, Kristoffer froze up. Then his servant mark started burning and before he knew it, he was covering Sofia with his own body. Was it his decision or was it something that was forced on him by the oath? Was anything he felt or thought real, or was it all product of the contract magic that surrounded his source?

Kristoffer winced as his left hand throbbed with fiery pain. He glanced at the bandages but resisted the urge to touch them. Sofia twitched in the chair, and her facial expression tensed up.

Kristoffer reached out and brushed a stray strand of hair from her face, tucking it gently behind her ear. At his touch, her expression softened, and her breathing steadied. He felt guilty about making her worried enough to fall asleep in this uncomfortable position.

Since he was responsible for preparing this trip, he felt as if all of it was his fault. If he hired more people, Greg wouldn't have to lose his life, and Sofia wouldn't have to go through this horror. Tears appeared in corners of his eyes as he thought about the cranky guard. He did not deserve a death like that. Now that Kristoffer thought about it, he should have realized mana shield would not work the moment Greg's spell didn't reach the spider. This creature had some magic canceling properties. If only he thought about this sooner, he could have saved Greg using the water barrier spell earlier...

"Kristoffer?" Sofia's sleepy voice broke through his spiraling thoughts. She rubbed her eyes, her expression brightening with realization. "Kristoffer! How do you feel?"

"I'm alright, don't worry Lady Sofia," he replied, trying to wipe his tears before his master could notice.

"You idiot!" she snapped, grabbing his hand mid-motion. Her own tears began to spill over as she looked at him with a raw mix of anger, fear, and anguish "Why are you like this? You almost died, and I couldn't do anything! Can you at least not lie to me?! Just—just be vulnerable for one *fucking* minute!"

Her voice cracked, her emotions overflowing. She reached out, threading her fingers through his messy hair, and pulled him close, pressing his head to her chest. Kristoffer stiffened at first, but as her warmth surrounded him, he broke. His shoulders slumped, and tears flowed freely down his cheeks.

“Greg had a wife and a daughter,” he whispered, pressing his face tighter into her warm body. “I killed him, Sofie. He didn’t want to go, but I pressured him into this job.”

“Don’t say that,” Sofia murmured, her hand gently stroking his disheveled hair. “I was the one who wanted to go deeper into the forest. It’s my fault he’s gone, and it’s my fault you’re hurt.”

“No, Sofie. I was responsible for organizing this trip. And it is my responsibility as your servant to protect you. I promise you I will get stronger, so nothing like that ever happens again. I am sorry you had to see Greg dying like this. I will ask Ernest to sign me up for sword lessons and-”

“Shut up for a moment, you idiot” Sofia interrupted him “I will make sure his wife and daughter will be taken care of. You saved my life, Kristoffer. I will never forget it. You did your best. Sometimes life just gets ahead of us.”

Kristoffer knew there was no arguing with her when she got like that, so he didn’t answer and enjoyed her embrace for a bit longer. But deep down he had already made up his resolve. After all those years, he learned that Sofia was a magnet for trouble,

and he felt it was his responsibility to protect her from it. Kristoffer vowed to strengthen both his body and mind. He would become someone who could stand by her side—not just as her servant, but as someone capable of shielding her from any danger the world might throw her way.

Step into adulthood

Sofia's life changed significantly after the incident. With her servant recovering, she found herself with a lot of free time. In the past, she might have spent these hours connecting with nature or painting whenever inspiration struck. But this time was different. Seeing Kristoffer's heavily wounded, immobile arm had sparked a new sense of purpose within her. Not one fueled by expectations from her parents, teachers, or servants, but by her own desire. She was determined to do everything she could to restore his body to its condition from before the accident.

When Isabelle saw her daughter coming into her room, she was worried something bad had happened. She could not contain her surprise when Sofia asked her to study healing magic together. For the first time in almost a decade, they started spending more time with each other. Isabelle engrossed herself in research of the core fissure for the last eight years, so seeing her daughter's current knowledge and skill was quite a shock. It didn't take long before Isabelle decided to treat her more like a young researcher than a student. It also made her feel bad that she missed out on her own child growing up.

Kristoffer spent the next two weeks in bed. Although he wanted to come back earlier, everybody nagged him to stay put and recover. Especially his mother. Nora was very proud of him for

protecting Sofia, but at the same time she was angry with him for how reckless he is. She kept overflowing with those contradicting emotions as she took care of her son. Her overprotectiveness reached new heights. Not only did she cook and clean, but she also tried to feed him, and even help him bathe. Determined to escape her vigilant care, Kristoffer became more motivated to ease back into his old routines.

Although Kristoffer typically assisted with maintaining the manor and gardens, with only one functional arm he was unable to perform most of the tasks. Even helping his mother with something as simple as peeling potatoes was beyond him. Frustrated by his own sense of uselessness, he found an unexpected silver lining: other Lower Worlders, who usually frowned upon his close connection to Upper Worlders, were now eager to take over his chores. Hoping to improve their standing in the manor and to impress their masters, they jumped at the chance to handle his work. With his daily responsibilities handled by others, Kristoffer found himself with extra time to devote to his research.

At least, whenever he could. Sofia had been buried in research with her mother lately, requiring little of his help or presence. However, the family's dedicated butler, Ernest, had made it his personal mission to train Kristoffer into a reliable protector worthy of his master's daughter. Each day, Kristoffer spent at least two hours sparring with Ernest, striving to land even a single

blow against his swift and relentless teacher. Ernest was an excellent, if demanding, mentor. He believed in the power of repetition to achieve perfection. Kristoffer was highly motivated and found no problem in repeating sword swings and stances thousands of times. But the training became grueling when the same policy was applied to parries and dodges. Evading Ernest's quick strikes was difficult enough, but with only one functional arm, it became a true test of endurance and determination.

Adding to his struggles was the daily toll of fighting off the lingering effects of the spider's venom. The poison coursing through his bloodstream continued to wreak havoc on his body. Kristoffer noticed slight improvement over time, but he suspected it more due to his raising proficiency with the spell than to any real improvement of his health. Still, it was the best option he had. There was no antidote for this kind of poison. Healing his arm posed an even greater challenge.

Through his connection to Sofia and her tutor, Kristoffer gained access to various texts, hoping to find a way to heal the damaged nerves. But none of them had what he was looking for. The most interesting were *Chronicles of the Elder Lands* that described in detail body strengthening techniques used by the first people that were capable of using mana. Later they were deemed barbarians, so not much was available about details of the magic they used. Other books contained even less relevant information.

However, luck was on Kristoffer's side. His master was currently working with one of the most talented medics that have ever lived. Putting together the scrapped information from the library with the handwritten notes from Isabelle about potential in using magic to strengthen nerve signals, gave him the theoretical insight he needed.

The conclusion was clear. With the current medical knowledge, it was impossible to restore his arm to its former state. But that did not stop him. If he could not heal it, he had to find another way. His first idea was to strengthen the nerve signal itself, amplifying it to the point that it could overcome the damaged connection.

The long years Kristoffer had spent perfecting the mana barrier around his source were finally bearing fruit. Though his original hypothesis about thickening the construct had failed, the countless attempts had significantly enhanced his mana control. In the last year, he had begun experimenting with a multi-layered barrier, a concept which forced him to polish those abilities even further.

Yet despite all his experience, Kristoffer's mana compression technique was still insufficient for his current goal. Over the next three months, he had to train rigorously in an attempt to compress raw mana to the size of a nerve signal. At last, he tried channeling these concentrated clumps of mana through the

damaged nerves in his arm, willing it to move. But nothing happened.

Frustrated, he punched the ground with his healthy hand. Normally, directing magic through intention alone was enough to achieve a result—but that was only when spells were supported by runes, which acted as guides to constrain and shape the mana. What he was attempting bypassed runes entirely, relying solely on raw mana.

This can't all be for nothing, Kristoffer thought, clenching his fists. He hurried to his desk and began poring over his notes, flipping through page after page in a frantic search for some clues.

Maybe simply channeling mana wasn't enough. Just as fire and water each had distinct frequencies, perhaps the nerve signal had its own as well. But how could he even begin to grasp something so abstract? How can one sense magic of a nerve signal, when humans can't even feel their nervous system?

Kristoffer closed his eyes, taking slow, measured breaths to calm his racing thoughts. After a hundred deep inhales, an idea began to form. Meditating on his body's internal processes, he noticed that moving his arms felt different when his eyes were closed. What if he could eliminate the interference of all other senses? Taste, smell, hearing, and sight overwhelmed the brain with extraneous information. By deactivating four of his five senses, his mind could focus entirely on the sensation of touch, honing his awareness to an unparalleled degree.

Pursuing the idea took him two months, and it was possible only thanks to Sofia ‘borrowing’ her mother’s secret notes. Kristoffer spent an entire night copying the documents, so Sofia could discreetly return them by morning. These notes contained forbidden knowledge that Isabelle had fiercely guarded, never intended to see the light of day beyond her own research. The ability to turn off another person’s senses was a power that could be horrifically abused, which was why Isabelle kept this knowledge strictly to herself. Yet, the pages also offered Kristoffer something invaluable: meticulously detailed illustrations of every tendon, bone, and muscle in a human body.

The magic Kristoffer planned to use on his arm required no runes or guiding symbols, making the spell delicate and unpredictable. He knew he’d have to attempt it in a controlled, isolated space in case anything went wrong. The crowded servant quarters, where half a dozen people slept in one room, were out of the question.

The training grounds would be better. But to maximize the effectiveness of his experiment, he’d need to be completely free of clothing, as even fabric against his skin would interfere by sending distracting signals once his sense of touch was heightened. The best option would be to do it at night, under the cover of darkness...

“Kristoffer, dinner!” his mom interrupted the pondering. “Come quickly, before Grant eats your cake!”

He immediately jumped off the bed and rushed downstairs.

“Uncle Grant, you could at least show some decency toward a cripple,” Kristoffer teased the bulky man.

Grant smirked, though he made no effort to deny the accusation. “I always give you at least one minute before I take the first bite,” he grumbled. Turning back to the other Lower Worlders, he continued his story. “As I was saying, my savior Lord Edmund praised me today for the work we did in the east garden. Despite his busy schedule he still has time to appreciate even our simple work. This man is a true divine.”

“It’s only natural, given that the Great Lady Isabelle is his wife,” added the woman beside him, her tone bright with admiration. “She’s the most beautiful and wise of all the Great Beings, so I’m certain she chose a truly worthy man. Tomorrow morning, it’s finally my turn to help her get ready. I’ve been waiting over a week, and I’m so excited!”

Kristoffer was used to being excluded during those dinner conversations. The Lower Worlders weren’t openly hostile, but since he was not praising Upper Worlders as feverishly as they did, he was left out more often than not. He ate the soup his mother had served him, and after listening to the usual prayers and small talk about the gods and Great Beings, he went to bed with the rest of them.

Or at least, he tried. Kristoffer was too excited about his planned experiment to fall asleep. After an hour of tossing and turning, he gave up. Quietly, he checked that everyone around him was

sound asleep, then slipped out of the room and headed toward the training grounds. It has been almost half a year since the last time he could use both hands. He could not imagine living as a cripple for the rest of his life. His manly pride would never allow it. He wanted to feel useful again.

He glanced around the empty training yard once more, then, a bit embarrassed, stripped off his clothes. He sat on the cold stone floor. Despite the chill in the air, his anticipation kept him warm. Lady Isabelle's technique was well-documented in the notes Sofia had given him, but it required an astonishing level of mana control. Forming the runes and keeping smooth mana flow was extremely difficult. There were a lot of potential negative consequences to this spell, but the possible reward was worth the risk. The first sense he chose to disable was taste.

"Detach sensation."

The runes took shape in front of him, and a faint tingling spread through his body. He licked the salt that he pocketed during dinner. Nothing. The first spell was a huge success. He could already feel his other senses being heightened. But he did choose the sense of taste for a reason. It would be the easiest for him to live without it for the foreseeable future. Because the spell responsible for recovering the sense was constructed of far more complex runes.

"Recover sensation."

He shaped the runes, channeling mana to reconstruct the sensory connection. But midway through the spell, the spell fell apart and the mana dispersed into the cool air. Frustrated, Kristoffer gritted his teeth, bit down his tongue, and took ten slow breaths to refocus.

“Recover sensation” he said again. This time, the mana dissipated even sooner.

Instead of giving in to frustration, he sighed, gazing calmly at the faint remnants of his failed spell. It was hardly a disaster. Taste was a small sacrifice, and he could practice restoring it later. Tonight was still a success. It took him one step closer towards the goal.

A serene calm washed over him as he looked up at the night sky. The stars shone with a tranquil clarity, and the moon, bright and high, seemed to invite him forward, calling him to explore the mysteries hidden across the forests, caves, and seas of the world. He felt a pull deep in his soul, urging him toward the unknown.

“Recover sensation” Kristoffer whispered once more.

This time, the runes held, and a familiar tingling coursed through him. He licked his lips tasting the leftover salt.

“If I can succeed two more times,” he whispered, clenching his fists. “Then I’m going all in.”

Next, he attempted to disable his sense of smell, managing to suppress and restore it on the first try. He repeated this with his sense of sound, confirming his ability to both disable and restore it with ease. Confident now, he was ready to proceed.

“Detach sensation” he murmured, starting with taste again.

This time, he focused on how the absence of that one sense impacted his consciousness. Indeed, he did feel a bit... more. The trees appeared sharper, sounds became clearer, and the air carried a fresher intensity.

“Detach sensation” he repeated, cutting off his sense of smell.

Now he couldn’t detect the floral notes in the air, but the feeling of air flowing through his nose sharpened. He noticed for the first time the constant, delicate touch of the air on his skin—an obvious yet astonishing revelation.

“Detach sensation.”

Silence enveloped him entirely, and for a brief moment, panic surged. Without sound, his vision honed in on every movement, every color, scanning for potential threats. His body felt hyper-aware. Each muscle twitch felt painfully detailed. As he moved his fingers slowly, it was as if he was discovering his body anew.

The mana around him was stunning. He sensed a closeness to it like never before, feeling for the first time that he was merely a tiny moving part in a vast, endless universe. He felt one with it all. And he wanted to become even closer with it.

“Detach sensation.”

His world went completely dark, leaving only his sense of touch. As much as he loved seeing the world from new perspectives, this one was terrifying—utter darkness, black and empty, isolating him from everything. But the magic remained, the ambient mana ebbing and flowing like waves. Strangely, he realized that until now, he hadn’t been moving with its rhythm. Slowly, his consciousness began to attune itself to the mana’s pulse, syncing with its flow.

He moved his right hand, feeling every vein pulsing with blood, each tendon shifting with intent. Even the damaged nerve in his left arm pulsed faintly. For the first time, he truly saw his body as a beautifully intricate creation, like a finely crafted machine. Lost in awe, he forgot the experiment’s purpose, immersing himself in this inner landscape. Drifting into a near trance, he felt himself dissolving into the surrounding mana, losing his sense of self.

A thought stirred in the back of his mind. *What if I gave up the sense of touch?* The idea was intoxicating. If he abandoned the last tether holding him to his physical body, could he truly become one with magic? The endless void seemed to call to him, beckoning with a soothing, irresistible promise of unity. With every passing moment, the temptation grew stronger.

Suddenly, a force yanked him back. Pain exploded through his body like fire, each nerve lighting up with raw, unfiltered intensity. The flood of signals racing toward his brain was overwhelming.

He recoiled at the pain's sharpness, gathering the rest of his sense of self to silently shape the ambient mana into the only spell that could help him decrease the pain. Instantly, all his senses returned, pulling him back to the world in a flood of sensation. Ready for combat he opened his eyes.

"Mom?" Kristoffer asked, his voice hoarse with surprise.

"Who sleepwalks like that?" She scolded, relief evident in her voice "At first, I thought you were just masturbating like a normal boy for a change. Well, not completely normal because it is still outside where people walk around but better than your usual antics. But then you just sat there, motionless, for so long that I knew it couldn't be your foreplay. I got so worried! I was calling your name for at least a minute but you wouldn't wake up."

Kristoffer's face burned. "Why would you follow me if you thought that?" Kristoffer protested, hastily covering himself.

She grinned mischievously, letting him go.

"Well, you also *might* have been sneaking out to visit Lady Sofia! But it seems even you aren't that bold... Anyway, from now on, I'll just have to tie you to your bed at night!" Nora laughed out loud and patted his shoulder. "Get dressed and come back to the quarters before you catch a cold. I will stop by the restroom on the way."

Before Kristoffer could reply, Nora turned and strode off, her laughter echoing behind her.

Kristoffer remained frozen in place, his breath coming in heavy gasps. Only now did Kristoffer realize how deeply the experiment had shaken him. While the experience had deepened his connection to mana and his understanding of his own body, it also left a mark on his mind. He vividly remembered the pull of the void - a cozy, tranquil peace that tempted him with a fierce allure. The sensation left him shaken, and he began to doubt whether sharing this technique with Sofia was a good idea. Her carefree, free-spirited nature made her unpredictable, and he worried she might not return from the void. Truthfully, if his mother hadn't intervened, he wasn't sure he would have come back either. That thought sent a chill through him.

And yet, the experiment hadn't been without value. Somewhere in the depths of that near-disaster, he had found the answer he sought. He now understood the precise frequency of the nerve signal and the exact mana shaping required to restore it. Kristoffer was grateful he had succeeded on the first try, as he wasn't ready to face the void again.

The void's whisper lingered at the edges of his awareness, faint but persistent. Kristoffer clenched his fists, determined not to let it take hold of him again. As his thoughts settled, one realization stood out. In the midst of the chaos, he had performed silent casting to restore his senses—a feat of magic that few wizards ever achieved. How much training would it take to heighten his magic sensitivity to this level without relying on disabling his

senses? The answer eluded him, but Kristoffer knew one thing for certain: he would reach that mastery on his own terms, through effort and discipline, without shortcuts.

Before heading to bed, Kristoffer had to test what all this effort had been for. He carefully shaped the mana, recreating the signal he'd felt when his mother touched his arm. Once he had it, he sent it down through his hand and into the damaged nerve.

For the first time in what felt like forever, his left arm twitched. It was a tiny, crude, almost insignificant movement, but Kristoffer had to bite his lip to hold back tears. Months of relentless training and research had finally shown a glimmer of success. He knew he'd need to send countless signals to achieve any functional movement, but the mere possibility lifted an enormous weight from his chest. Fueled by a newfound motivation, he was ready to face the challenge head-on.

The next day he afforded himself a small celebratory gift. Before his usual training with Ernest, Kristoffer disabled the sense of taste once again. Immediately after the spell was cast the promise of a peaceful void became more entrancing. It took significant willpower to resist the urge to shut off his other senses and return to that alluring state. But he resolved to keep at it and maintain the spell long enough to give himself an edge against the old butler.

After a quick warm-up and a few practice swings, they dove into their usual sparring routine. Kristoffer felt his battle instincts

sharpened. The butler's movements were easier to track, and his own reactions felt quicker, more precise. His awareness of his own body had deepened after last night's experiment. The techniques Ernest had been drilling into him suddenly made perfect sense. Kristoffer could see how they were designed for maximum efficiency, and for the first time, he noticed subtle flaws in his execution.

As he worked to correct those inefficiencies, his thoughts briefly wandered back to the void. Its strange, magnetic allure crept into his mind.

"You're moving better, but you're distracted," Ernest said, tapping his shoulder with the sword's hilt. "Set other thoughts aside."

Kristoffer shifted his focus fully to the butler's blade and the path it traced through the air—a flowing, graceful arc. Instead of resisting the blade, he redirected it, attuning himself to its rhythm. Immersed in this new awareness, he set thoughts of the void aside, captivated instead by the beauty of the sword's dance.

The butler did his best to mask his surprise, not wanting to disrupt Kristoffer's focus. He was astounding today. Something had clearly shifted, allowing him to reach a new level overnight. Even with one arm, Kristoffer was shaping up to be the finest student Ernest had ever trained. Deciding to test him further, Ernest quickened the pace of his attacks, but Kristoffer kept up,

beads of sweat forming on his brow as he matched the increased speed.

Then, for the first time, Kristoffer landed a clean hit. A small but genuine smile crossed Ernest's face as he acknowledged the moment.

"Took you a long time, but you finally managed to land a blow. That leaves only 9,999 to go," Ernest said, straightening his mustache with a touch of humor.

Kristoffer's expression was both thrilled and slightly horrified at the challenge, but his satisfaction was clear. It was time to reap the fruit of his hard work.

After the long, exhausting session, Kristoffer cleaned himself up and went to check on Sofia. He found her in her room, surrounded by papers filled with rune sketches, each sheet connected with strings like a detective's wall of clues. He had to announce his presence for her to even realize that someone entered the room. Kristoffer told her about his progress, though he carefully downplayed the parts about the void.

"You detached your senses just for a *training session*?" Sofia exclaimed, clearly horrified. "Did you even read what was in those notes? Every time you detach or restore a sense, both your brain and mind pay a heavy toll. This isn't something you should do casually—you could lose your mind or permanently lose your

senses. Strengthening signals won't help much if you fry your brain in the process."

"It was only for the sake of experiment, Lady Sofia," he replied apologetically. "I know it's dangerous. I won't do it again unless it will be my last resort."

Sofia shook her head, disapproving, and launched into a stern lecture to ensure he understood the risks.

For the next several months, everybody was engrossed in their individual duties. With their busy schedules, the days at Elernes estate began to feel short. A year passed in the blink of an eye, and the smell of spring filled the air once again. Together with the new season came new responsibilities, which life grew even busier.

"Absolutely not," Eduard said firmly to his daughter. "If Kristoffer attends for your first servant-assigning ceremony, it will cause chaos. Everyone will wonder how you've acquired a servant before the ceremony even began. And let's not forget he lacks a visible mark right now. At best, this is a legal grey area."

"Fine," Sofia sighed. "Do I need anything? Or can we go?"

"I've gathered all the necessary documents here, Lady Sofia," Ernest interjected, holding up a brown briefcase. "The carriage is ready as well."

“Thank you, Ernest,” Eduard replied, taking the briefcase. “Let’s depart then. There’s still much to prepare before the party.”

Ernest opened the carriage door, allowing them to step inside before seating himself next to the coachman. The journey took over an hour, winding through the scenic countryside before the admission office came into view. It was a large, fortified building positioned strategically at the island’s border. The area was filled with soldiers and city guards, ensuring the barrier surrounding the Upper World remained secure and impenetrable to any potential threats or trespassers.

As the carriage came to a stop, Ernest helped Eduard and Sofia out, where they were greeted by two officials exiting the building. Both wore polite smiles, their manner professional but calculated.

“It’s a pleasure to see you again, Lord Eduard,” said the shorter man. “This is my assistant, Dolores. She was responsible for the last summoning ritual. And this must be your daughter. The resemblance to Lady Isabelle is remarkable.”

Both officials bowed respectfully.

“Good to see you too, Waron,” Eduard replied. “Yes, this is Sofia. As I mentioned in my letter, she’s turning fifteen today and is ready to form her first contract.”

“I’m sure Dolores will be able to help you with that. If you need any further assistance, I’ll be in my office. I apologize for not

accompanying you, but with the latest proposal on the new fertility law, we're overwhelmed with work..."

Eduard's expression darkened briefly, but he nodded in acknowledgment. Waron excused himself, leaving Dolores to guide them into the building. Sofia couldn't help being fascinated with the interior. Unlike the rest of the Upper World, this building was not designed to be elegant and magical. Instead, it gave an impression of a stone-cold bunker. People working here moved with serious purpose and seemed committed to their jobs. It was a completely different atmosphere compared to the one from the Tower, where most of the staff didn't have time to work, too busy with trying to appear more important than they actually were.

"The summoning took place a week ago, so the candidates are still fresh," Dolores explained as they walked. "What are we aiming for? Male or female? Intensive physical labor, housekeeping, or something else entirely?"

The questions made the young noble girl feel dirty. The casual way their guide spoke about it made it even worse. Sofia glanced at the woman, trying to gauge her age, but it was difficult. In the Upper World the aging process varied a lot depending on one's magic capability and access to beauty products made of magic beasts. Dolores could have been anywhere between 25 and 60 years old.

"Sofia needs a young girl that can help her with everyday tasks," Eduard explained. "A servant she can take to academy with her."

“You’re in luck then. I have two perfect candidates. Follow me.”

Dolores led them through a maze of hallways, each one sterile and imposing. Eventually, they stopped before a heavy metal door reinforced with external barricades. Dolores unlatched the lock and pushed the door open, revealing a sparse room inside.

The room held two beds placed on opposite walls, separated by a modest toilet. Two young girls sat on the cots, their postures tense. At the sight of the newcomers, they immediately stood and dropped to the floor, bowing low.

“Great Beings!” they murmured in unison, their voices filled with fervent reverence.

“This one is Ana,” Dolores said, gesturing toward the scrawny brown-haired girl. “And the one with black hair is Lisa. But we can change their names if you prefer something else. Personally, I recommend Lisa. She might appear reserved, but she’s well-organized. Ana is more energetic but tends to be clumsy, which could become an issue if she’s your university servant. So, which one do you prefer?”

Both girls glanced up from their bowed position, their eyes sparkling with excitement and anticipation. Sofia’s took a closer look at the girls, and only then did she notice the chains binding their legs to the wall.

“Can we take both?” Sofia asked her father. “This feels like we’re on some kind of fair buying farm animals. Can we not stoop that low?”

“We’ll take both,” Eduard stated quickly, hoping to stop his daughter from saying anything further. “That won’t be a problem, will it?”

“More people are scheduled to receive their Lower Worlders today...” Dolores mused aloud. “But I think we can manage that. Let’s discuss it with Professor Waron.”

Dolores closed the heavy door behind them as they left the room. Eduard felt incredibly awkward on the way to Waron’s office. He wanted to be on his daughter’s side and support the innocent, untainted righteousness she still had. But the reality of the Upper World was starkly different. Until now, Sofia had been shielded within the safe confines of their estate. But today marked her entry into adulthood, where she was about to face the world where her perspective and opinions were vastly different from the rest of society. Having an opposing mindset to the ones in power meant walking a thin line between a ‘friend’ and ‘enemy’. In order to live comfortably in a country that had a vastly contrasting system of values, it was necessary to pick the right battles.

He let out a sigh of relief as they finally arrived at Waron’s office.

“Of course, it will be possible,” Waron said with a smile after hearing their request. “We’ll make it work Lord Eduard. The assigning ceremony will be prepared shortly. In the meantime, please make yourselves comfortable in the waiting room.”

Sofia and Eduard settled into plush armchairs in a room furnished with a coffee table between them. Shortly after, two beautiful, very scantily dressed women, brought them coffee and biscuits. The women asked if they required anything else before leaving with practiced grace.

Eduard could feel the weight of Sofia’s piercing, judgmental gaze. It felt like her eyes were burning holes into his very soul.

“It’s a different culture,” Eduard said quietly, trying to mentor her. “We must respect their ways if we’re to live in this world together.”

“Oh, so kidnapping people from the Lower World, dressing them like whores and chaining them to the walls is part of their culture?” Sofia whispered icily. “And you, my dear Father, want to live quietly among people who think that’s acceptable?”

“Sofia, language!” Eduard hissed. “You saw those two girls. They see us as gods, Sofia. This is what they willingly do. What you see as abuse, others see as granting one’s wish.”

The noble girl looked at him disapprovingly, and an uncomfortable silence fell between them. They remained quiet until Waron returned to escort them back to his office.

“Lady Sofia,” Waron began, smiling warmly. “This feels nostalgic, you’ve grown so much since I last saw you as a baby. Now, please place your hand on this magic circle in order to start the contract ritual.”

He gestured toward a small, bluish tablet positioned in front of a chair.

“It’s only a fragment of the full magic circle,” Sofia noted, examining the intricate runes etched into the pedestal and extending along the wall. “What does it do?”

“I’m impressed you noticed that, Lady Sofia” Waron replied, laughing heartily. “You truly remind me of your mother. Yes, your servants are in another room on the other side of the circle. The circle incorporates forbidden runes, so we keep its specifics out of public knowledge.”

“I don’t even know what I am casting,” Sofia said, her voice tinged with unease. “Isn’t that dangerous? For all I know you could set them on fire using my mana.”

“Haha, I don’t think the Tower would allow that,” Waron reassured her with another hearty laugh. “But if you’re curious, Lady Sofia, I highly encourage you to study hard and research circles in our bureau in the future. I’m sure you’d be an invaluable asset.”

“Waron, she hasn’t even had her coming-of-age party yet, and you’re already offering her a job” Eduard sighed.

“Early bird gets the worm, Lord Eduard,” Waron replied with an apologetic smile. “I’m still sad that your wife left us. But let’s not delay any further—shall we begin, Lady Sofia?”

Sofia sat down, and hesitantly placed her hand on the pedestal. The magic circle activated immediately, draining her mana at an alarming rate. Sofia struggled to maintain the barrier protecting her core, but the spell was relentless, hungrily pushing against her defenses. Her mana wall began to thin, and for a fleeting moment, the magic breached it, touching her core directly. A chilling sensation rippled through her body, but just as quickly as it had begun, the spell ended.

Breathing heavily, Sofia steadied herself, and Waron broke into enthusiastic applause.

“Well done, Lady Sofia! Most people faint under the strain, you must have extraordinary control over mana” he exclaimed.

“That was an incredibly powerful spell,” Sofia said, her voice steadying as she regained composure.

The door opened, and Dolores entered, flanked by Lisa and Ana. Both girls stepped forward and bowed deeply. Black marks, the visible symbols of their contracts, adorned their hands.

“Lady Sofia,” they greeted in unison, their voices tinged with awe.

“Your butler has already finalized the paperwork,” Waron informed them. “It was a pleasure seeing you again, Lord Eduard.”

“Are you sure you don’t want to join us for the party? Isabelle would be delighted to see you” Eduard asked.

“I’m afraid it would be more than I can handle,” Waron replied with an awkward laugh. His tone shifted as he added, “I’ve heard Duke Ralezo will be attending. Lord Eduard, please be careful. Make sure that Lady Isabelle will not lose her composure.”

The head of Elernes house smiled weakly, seeing the official’s honest, worried face. He knew tonight would be exceptionally challenging. Eduard tried to prepare his wife and daughter for it, but he still could not help but worry. Until now, it was more than a full-time job to keep Isabelle from starting disputes and fights during every party. But now he would have to look after both of them, and Sofia seemed to be even more fierce than her mother.

“Everything is ready, my lord,” Ernest reported as Eduard settled into the carriage beside Sofia. The two new servants sat across from them, their gazes fixed on Sofia with unbridled admiration.

“Thank you, Ernest. Let’s head back,” the Earl said before addressing the girls. “Allow me to introduce myself properly. I am Eduard Elernes, Sofia’s father.”

The girls seemed momentarily pulled from their dreamy state. They straightened and introduced themselves.

“My name is Ana. I’m the daughter of Bishop Albert. I promise to serve the Great Beings with utmost devotion, Lord Eduard,” Ana said reverently.

“Please, don’t call us Great Beings,” Eduard chuckled awkwardly.

“My name is Lisa,” the other girl said, bowing respectfully. “I hope to be of service to you, Lady Sofia and Lord Eduard.”

“It’s nice to meet you, Ana and Lisa. I hope we can become friends,” Sofia said warmly.

“We could never be worthy of such a relationship, your highness,” Ana replied, her voice filled with adoration.

“Please don’t call me ‘your highness’. Or a Great Being. Just Lady Sofia is fine,” the noble girl said with a soft smile. Then, turning to her father, she added, “By the way, Father, I plan to take Kristoffer as my servant when I attend the Academy.”

Eduard froze, processing her words. Slowly, he turned to his daughter, his expression a mix of shock and concern.

“Sofia,” he began carefully, “Kristoffer is a boy. You’re only allowed one servant at the Academy, and even setting aside the fact that he’s a Lower Worlder, having a young noblewoman living alone with an adolescent boy would cause a scandal. The nobility would tear you apart. You’ll need friends and allies to survive in this world.”

“I became an adult today, didn’t I?” Sofia replied curtly. “This is my decision as an adult. I’m taking Kristoffer.”

Eduard sighed deeply. “Let’s revisit this discussion another day. But please, Sofia, just for today, try not to be too outspoken. It’s vital—”

“I know, I know,” Sofia interrupted. “I’ll behave. I don’t want you to suffer because of me.” Then she turned to Ana and Lisa, her tone brightening. “Now, girls, let me explain what we’ll be doing today and what your new lives will look like...”

“Kristoffer, can you knead the dough for me? I have to finish making the stuffing” Nora asked her son while moving in a hurry through the kitchen.

All the Lower Worlders in the estate believed Kristoffer’s arm was gradually recovering thanks to Lady Isabelle’s renowned medical expertise. While his progress was slow, he had regained some basic functionality. Though he still couldn’t move multiple fingers simultaneously, he could lift his arm and grasp objects—although much slower than a healthy person would. Kneading dough had become an excellent way to practice his magic and refine the precision of his movements.

“Sure, Mom,” Kristoffer replied, rolling up his sleeves and getting to work. “I think the goulash is ready, but I’d add a bit more pepper.”

“Not too much, though. Lord Welder’s family is coming, and they don’t like spicy food” Nora reminded him while stirring the pot. “It all starts in about two hours. Did you give Lady Sofia her birthday gift?”

"Not yet. I'm planning to give it to her after the party," Kristoffer admitted, a little embarrassed. "I think it'll look better at night."

"So, what did you get her? You know your mom loves a little gossip. Come on, tell me," she said, glancing at him with a playful smile while continuing to mix ingredients.



“I followed your advice and got her something money can’t buy,”
Kristoffer replied, the corners of his mouth lifting slightly.

“But what is it? Come on, you can tell your mom” Nora pressed with an indulgent smirk.

“Mom, no. It’s personal,” Kristoffer said firmly, trying to keep his mother’s curiosity in check.

Their conversation was interrupted by a shout from the hallway.

“Lord Eduard is back! Lord Eduard is back!”

"Sorry, Mom. I have to go to Lady Sofia. The dough's almost ready," Kristoffer said quickly, beginning to clean his hands.

“Of course. Go ahead. I’ll take care of the rest,” Nora said with a knowing nod, returning her focus to the cooking.

After climbing the stairs, Kristoffer stepped out of the mansion and immediately spotted Ernest opening the carriage door. Relief washed over him when he saw Sofia stepping out, healthy and unharmed. Whenever she left without him, he couldn’t help but worry. Trouble always seemed to find his master.

He hurried over to greet her. "Welcome back, Lady Sofia. How was the trip?"

"Nice to see you too," Sofia replied with a bright smile. "It went well. I brought two new tenants for our mansion. Meet Ana and Lisa. They’ll be working with you. Please show them the ropes. Explain how everything works and what they should do today. I’m going to go scream into a pillow for a bit. Come see me in an hour."

Without waiting for a response, Sofia headed inside. Kristoffer turned to the two girls with an awkward smile, then nodded politely at Lord Eduard, whose troubled expression caught his eye. Eduard returned the gesture with a faint smile before entering the mansion, his butler following close behind.

"Welcome to the House of Elernes," Kristoffer said to the new arrivals "Follow me, and I'll show you your quarters."

He led them to a building adjacent to the mansion, where the servants lived and worked.

"We Lower Worlders all live here," he explained. "We'll provide you with proper clothes and go over your tasks. Since it's Lady Sofia's birthday today, you'll be helping out at the celebration. Don't worry, it won't be anything too complicated. Just show up and serve as her attendants."

"Hmm? You're from the Lower World too, Kristoffer?" Ana asked curiously, leaning in to scrutinize his face. "I don't remember seeing you at school. Where are you from? When did you ascend?"

"I was born here," Kristoffer replied, gently nudging her back to reclaim his personal space. "But my mother is from the Lower World. As I mentioned, you'll need to work during the party tonight. Have you ever waited tables before? Serving desserts and salads might be a good start."

"Sure, we can be waitresses. But what about your father? Why is your hair blonde? Is he an Upper Worlder? Did your mom have a spicy fling with a god?" Ana asked with a mischievous grin.

Kristoffer sighed, clearly exasperated. "I'm starting to worry if you're fit to serve Lady Sofia," he muttered before turning to Lisa.

"Do you two know each other?"

"A bit," Lisa replied curtly.

"A bit?!" Ana exclaimed, her mouth falling open. "We've been in the same class for ten years!"

"Nine," Lisa corrected.

"Is she always this much of a handful?" Kristoffer asked Lisa, eyeing her serious demeanor.

"She is," Lisa confirmed, shaking the hand Kristoffer offered. "But she's also cute, so people usually let it slide."

"Hey! Don't bully me!" Ana pouted, her brows furrowing in mock indignation at the budding alliance.

"I'll show you the basics, but we can't possibly go through everything now," Kristoffer ignored her and continued. "Starting tomorrow, you'll have daily lessons. Many areas of the mansion are powered by magic circles and crystals that need to be charged and maintained. We have special tools for that, and I'll teach you how to use them. It would also help if you learned to read Lady Sofia's expressions. With enough practice, you'll be

able to predict how troublesome the near future will become just by looking at her brows and eyes..."

"We only have three years left to prepare you for the Academy," Rosalia declared proudly. "Have you thought about which specialization you'd like to pursue?"

"Not yet, Professor Rosalia" Sofia replied with a faint smile. "I still want to explore the world of magic for a bit longer, before deciding on anything."

"I'm sure you will excel in whatever you choose, Lady Sofia," Richard chimed in, adjusting his monocle "But if you'd like to have a lot of freedom, we have an excellent research department in the Tower. You would be able to choose your own topic of study, and there are plenty of benefits, such as—"

"Richard, this is neither the time nor place to offer a job," Rosalia interrupted coolly. "Sofia hasn't even started at the Academy yet."

"Thank you for your kind words," Sofia said with a polite bow. "I apologize, but I must excuse myself for a moment. I hope you both enjoy the party."

Although the head of Elernes house warned her about the scale of this event beforehand, Sofia was still surprised after seeing it with her own eyes. Since the average lifespan in Upper World went up so much, anyone under fifteen was regarded as a mere

child and was not even allowed to take part in major social events. This was Sofia's first experience attending one, and it was as dazzling as it was overwhelming.

A constant stream of well-dressed, important-looking people started tiring her out sooner than she expected. Dozens of nobles and servants filled the room, gossiping, drinking, dancing, and making their political moves. Sofia's role as the Earl's daughter demanded she engage with dozens of important figures, memorizing their names, faces, and affiliations. It was exhausting, but she bore it with grace, knowing her family's reputation depended on her composure.

Just as she was preparing to slip away from the dining room for a moment of quiet, an elderly, white-bearded Viscount approached her. "Ah, Lady Sofia, just the person I wanted to see!" he said warmly. "This is my son, Jens. He's taken quite an interest in magic lately—seems accounting wasn't exciting enough for him."

"Hello Lady Sofia. My name is Jens Varsmith, and I hope to be your classmate in three years" the young man said, bowing with a polite smile. His blonde hair, nearly white, framed a handsome face.

"It's a pleasure to meet you, Viscount Jens" she nodded and used a fan to cool her face. "I apologize, but I need to get some fresh air. I'll return shortly."

Sofia left the room in a hurry, before anyone else had a chance to stop her. Over the past hour she got several dozen job and marriage offers. Every time she got an invite to another party, she felt her lifespan shortening. Sofia was preparing for fifteen years to be able to survive adult life as a noble, but she did not feel ready to keep up this fake, political mask at all times.

“That bad?” a familiar voice asked. Isabelle Elernes stood by a tall flower bush, observing her daughter with mild amusement.

“I just need five minutes,” Sofia replied, taking a deep breath to steady herself.

“You should learn to drink,” Isabelle remarked, exhaling the last puff of her cigarette as she approached. “It helps take the edge off.” Her tone softened as she added, “I know I wasn’t the best mother, but remember, you can always come to me if you need help, Sofia. You’ll always be more important than my research or your father’s politics.”

“I know, Mom,” Sofia murmured, pulling her mother into a brief hug. “Don’t make me cry. I’ll ruin my makeup.”

“Now, I am afraid I have to admit that I came to look for you for another reason,” Isabelle admitted, stepping back. “Duke Vincent Ralezo is coming with his son Julian. They will be here in a moment. We should greet them. Your father is practically losing his mind—let’s do our best for his sake.”

“Alright.” Sofia straightened her posture, took another deep breath, and replaced her weary expression with a neutral smile. “I feel better already.”

They headed together to the front entrance, where Eduard Elernes stood anxiously waiting.

“You found her! I love you so much, Iz” he leaned in to kiss his wife. “Sofia, why did you disappear like that? It would have been disastrous if we hadn’t been here to greet them...”

Two carriages pulled up to the foot of the stairs. From each emerged a blonde-haired man, flanked by two scantily dressed women. The Duke and his son, Julian, looked like there wasn’t more than ten years of difference between them.



“Isabelle!” the older man boomed, raising his hand in greeting while his other hand lingered on the buttock of one of his servants “Eduard! It’s been far too long!”

“Duke Ralezo,” Eduard greeted warmly, though his smile was forced. “Thank you for accepting our invitation. We’ve prepared guest rooms for you and your son as requested. My butler, Ernest, can show you the way if you’d like to unpack first.”

“That’s awesome, thank you,” the Duke replied cheerfully as he ascended the stairs. “I just need a little *relief* after the trip. I’ll be back in fifteen minutes—unless the ladies are feeling particularly demanding.” He laughed heartily at his own crude joke and slapped one of the women on the rear, drawing a delighted, flirtatious giggle.

“Oh yes, that’s my son, Julian. Julian, introduce yourself!” the duke shouted back before disappearing behind the corner.

“It’s a pleasure to meet you, Lord Eduard, Lady Isabelle,” Julian said, stepping forward. His charm was as polished as his appearance. “And Lady Sofia, you look stunning in that white dress—your eyes shine like gems.” He bowed, flashing a dazzling smile. “I apologize for my father’s behavior. It seems he had a little too much bourbon during the journey.”

“It’s a pleasure to meet you too, Lord Julian. Would you like to unpack before joining us?” Eduard asked, shaking Julian’s hand with a courteous smile.

“That would be lovely,” Julian replied, his tone apologetic. “I’ll leave my servants to settle in so they won’t disturb your party. Thank you for your consideration.”

With that, Julian followed the family's servants toward the guest quarters, leaving the Elernes family standing at the entrance.

"Thank you both for not saying anything," Eduard said quietly, wiping his brow.

"Don't treat me like a child, Eduard" Isabelle sighed, crossing her arms.

"I'm tolerant, just like you wanted me to be, Father," Sofia said, her smile now razor-sharp with sarcasm. "I *completely* understand that our esteemed guests have brought along sex slaves to enjoy during my birthday party—it's a cultural difference, after all. And since we didn't specify a dress code, I'm sure a half-unbuttoned shirt is perfectly acceptable."

"Please, Sofia," Eduard pleaded, his voice filled with weariness. "Never say anything like that to anyone else. Just for a few hours, do your best not to cause any incidents."

"Robert Garnez has been far too quiet lately," Ludwig Varsmith murmured to Eduard over his glass of champagne. "Normally, he'd attend events like this to sway hesitant nobles into his faction. His absence tonight means he's plotting something. Meanwhile, our faction's efforts to assist the farmers outside the city have failed. We had hoped to divert funds toward research on compost magic," he added with a frustrated sigh, "but, as

always, the Tower prioritized transport instead. They're obsessed with faster ways to shuttle people to and from the bar. And while they play with convenience, the problem of evolving mana beasts grows more dire by the day. Those mage-killer spiders are an immediate threat that appeared right under our noses. Even other mana beasts stay away from it. Then what can we expect from the Lower World? No one is managing the animal populations or monitoring their growth over there. It's only a matter of time before the situation escalates beyond control."

"Just the man we need right now," Eduard said, extending his arm in greeting as a figure passed nearby. "Commander Berian, do you have a moment to join us?"

"Lord Eduard Elernes," Berian replied, shaking his hand firmly. "Your daughter might grow to be an even stronger woman than your wife. Of course, I have time. How could I be of help?"

"How are things in the sanctuary? Do we have the situation under control?" Eduard handed Berian a glass of champagne.

"We conduct regular scouting missions," Berian began. "The yellow and green zones are under our full control. However, any attempt to venture into the central zones ends in critical injuries or fatalities. The magical beasts are growing increasingly aggressive, and we have less and less resources to deal with them."

"Do you hear that, Eduard?" Ludwig said pointedly, gesturing at Berian. "The situation won't improve unless we act decisively."

Before Eduard could respond, a sharp crash interrupted the conversation. The clatter of a metal tray hitting the floor and the shattering of glass drew every eye in the room. Eduard's gaze quickly found the source: Ana, his daughter's new servant, stood frozen with wide, apologetic eyes.

"I- I'm so sorry," Ana stammered, her voice trembling as she faced Duke Ralezo.

"Well, aren't you clumsy?" he wiped the wet spot on his shirt with his finger and licked it. "It's just a bit of wine. I am glad a cute girl like you didn't hurt herself." His tone grew lewd as his eyes swept over her, and he reached out to help her to her feet.

"Are you alright?" Sofia asked, approaching her servant with calm authority.

"I apologize, Lady Sofia," Ana murmured, her head bowed as she began gathering shards of glass with her bare hands. "I didn't mean to cause trouble."

"I'm sure you would have kept your balance," Sofia said, her voice icy, "if someone hadn't touched your back." Her sharp eyes landed on Duke Ralezo with open accusation.

"Ah, caught red-handed!" Vincent laughed, rubbing his nose nonchalantly. "You've only had this servant for a few hours,

haven't you? Do you mind selling her to me? I like cute, clumsy girls like her. I'll pay you five hundred gold."

A hush fell over the room. Conversations ceased, and the band stopped playing. The guests turned their attention to the unfolding scene, some gasping audibly at the generous offer.

"My apologies, Lord Ralezo," Sofia replied coldly, "but she is my servant. She is not for sale."

"You hardly know her," Vincent countered with a disarming smile. "I promise to treat her well. Ask any of my girls—they'll vouch for me. She would live a good life. Besides, I feel there's been some distance between our families lately. This gesture of goodwill could warm our relations." He spread his arms wide in an exaggerated display of sincerity. "I'll double my offer to one thousand gold—ten times her market value—as a token of my friendship."

"Lord Vincent," Commander Berian interrupted, stepping forward with a genuine smile, "you're putting the birthday girl in a rather awkward position."

"And what's so awkward about it, Berian?" Vincent shot back, his tone feigning innocence. "We're two adults discussing a perfectly legal transaction. Last I checked, it was entirely lawful for one noble to purchase a Lower Worlder from another."

“I must apologize once again, but Ana is not for sale,” Sofia said firmly, stepping in front of her servant to shield her from further discussion. Her tone brooked no argument.

Kristoffer came in between the duke and the noble girl with a broom and dustpan to sweep up the broken glass. Vincent looked at him agitated but he chose to redirect his focus to the person who had interrupted him moments before.

“Are you going to explain it to me Berian? Do you think I’ve done something wrong?” the noble man’s kind attitude had vanished, replaced with a sharp edge. “I’m sure everyone here would love to hear your opinion.”

“It just seems to me, that Lady Sofia would prefer to discuss business at a more appropriate time” the commander answered calmly and stood on her side.

“And who are you,” Vincent spat, his voice rising, “to get between us nobles, and decide what is proper and what is not? I doubted your reason Berian, the day I heard you want to protect bunch of wild beasts that are killing our people,” Vincent narrowed down his eyes and Sofia instinctively took a step back sensing his hostility. “Let’s celebrate this joyous occasion with an old school duel. I’m sure it will be very educational for the birthday girl.”

The room fell silent. Every whisper ceased as eyes turned toward Berian. The commander assessed the duke’s expression, confirming that he was serious. With a heavy sigh, he nodded.

“Fine. Let’s do it.”

“That’s more like it.” A vicious smile spread across Vincent’s face.

“Eduard, surely you have a place where we can settle this properly?”

“There’s a training area about two minutes from here,” Eduard said hesitantly. His voice trembled as he gathered the courage to interject. “But, Lord Ralezo—”.

“Don’t worry, Eduard,” the duke interrupted smoothly. “I won’t ruin your party. Of course, if people want to watch, you are all invited. But it’s just a boring duel between two gentlemen. You can all keep on drinking and mingling. You,” Vincent pointed at Kristoffer, who was still sweeping what looked like a clean floor by now. “Show us the way to the arena.”

Kristoffer glanced at Sofia for approval. She gave him a subtle nod, and he passed the broom and dustpan to Ana. “Yes, My Lord,” he said, bowing.

As Kristoffer led them from the ballroom, Vincent waved casually at the onlookers. Once the three men exited, the room erupted in heated conversation.

“I should have been the one to step up,” Eduard muttered, his face a mask of guilt. “Not Berian.”

“And what would you have done?” Ludwig Varsmith replied sharply. “It would only worsen your family’s situation and weaken our faction. Berian knows what he’s doing—he’s taking one for

the team. Duke Ralezo has no sense of decency, but let's hope he shows some restraint during the duel."

More and more people started leaving the ballroom. Any kind of fighting was forbidden in the Upper World. Only nobles of high standing dared to exploit the loophole of relying on ancestral laws. Naturally, a rare event like this attracted a lot of attention.

Sofia moved to stand beside her father without saying a word.

"Please, say something," Eduard pleaded, pressing a hand to his forehead. "You can speak freely. Ludwig is a trusted friend."

"His son seemed more reasonable, but he left mid party to play with his whores upstairs. I recommend you pick him up," Sofia declared with an informative tone. "I want to make sure nothing will happen to Berian."

Ludwig burst into laughter despite the tension. "I thought it's good Isabelle went for a smoking break, but I see your daughter takes after her," he said, clapping Eduard on the shoulder. "It's not easy for you, is it?"

"You've no idea" Eduard replied, exhaling heavily. "Ludwig, could you let Isabelle know what's happened here? I'll ask the duke's son for help."

Sofia joined the stream of people heading toward the arena, while Eduard and Ludwig moved in the opposite direction.

After party

“Five spells each?” Duke Ralezo asked, taking off his jacket.

“I’d prefer three. Do you mind if I use a training sword?” Commander Berian replied, stretching his muscular arms in preparation.

“Let’s meet mid-way,” Vincent said with a chuckle, hanging his jacket on the weapon rack. “You get your sword, but we stick to five spells.”

Berian nodded in agreement, selecting a long, one-handed wooden training sword. He was aware of what was coming—after all he had known Vincent Ralezo for a long time. The duke wasn’t famous for his mercy. But despite his personality, he was a proud man who respected strength above all else. If there was any hope of salvaging this situation for both himself and the Elernes family, it lay in demonstrating that strength here and now.

As Berian readied himself, his eyes briefly flicked to the strange servant boy, who was standing at the edge of the arena and watching them intently. He recognized him, remembering Sofia disastrous sanctuary trip. The boy’s piercing gaze felt almost invasive, as though he was studying every movement and expression with clinical precision. Berian had caught him earlier

trying to get a closer look at the duke's jewelry. The commander felt a bit exposed under such a penetrating gaze.

Vincent's voice cut through the tension. "See, Berian, I don't like it when people take me for a dimwit." He rolled up his sleeves, pointing directly at the commander. "Don't play mind games with me—admit it. You think you're morally superior. For reasons I can't fathom, people like you look down on me, even though I follow the law and give my servants a good life. But that's what's so beautiful about the world my grandfather Lucius built." He gestured dramatically. "Magic is everything. It decides what's right and wrong. So, we'll settle this according to the rules of our forefathers—no pretense, no posturing. Come at me, Berian. And don't hold back, because I certainly won't."

Berian swallowed a curse and settled into a fighting stance. If Vincent wasn't going to hold back, surviving five spells would be a brutal challenge. His chance was to end the duel before the duke could fully unleash his magic. The rules were simple: one clean hit would decide the match. The commander's sharp ears caught snippets of excited chatter from the crowd that had gathered, eager to witness this rare spectacle. He inhaled deeply, forcing himself to focus.

"Boost" Berian muttered, activating the spell as he launched forward.

Sofia arrived just in time to see the stone floor crack beneath the commander's feet as he shot forward with astonishing speed,

closing five meters in the blink of an eye. The sight left her momentarily awestruck. But before Berian could strike, the handsome noble man waved his hand and a stream of scorching hot fire appeared between them.

Berian's eyes widened as he reacted instantly, shifting his trajectory with a quick sidestep. His momentum carried him past Vincent, and the acrid scent of singed hair filled the air.

"Silent casting," someone nearby whispered, their voice tinged with awe.

"Missile Barrage!" Berian cast the spell with booming voice, pivoting sharply and surging toward his opponent once more.

Sofia recognized the Magic Missile spell Greg used back in sanctuary but this was something far more advanced. Eight glowing mana projectiles launched from Berian's outstretched hand, each streaking toward Vincent with deadly precision. And following close behind them was Berian himself, his wooden blade poised to strike.

"Earth Shield" Duke Ralezo said stoically, stomping hard on the ground before him.

A thick, two-meter-wide wall of stone rose from the ground just as Commander Berian's spell struck it with full force. The first projectiles impacted solidly, but the final two sent chunks of rock flying, though none managed to penetrate. Yet Berian's agility allowed him to adjust once again, bringing him to the edge of the

wall and within striking distance of the duke. His wooden sword was already raised high, poised to strike down.

“Shatter” Vincent said calmly.

It was only then that Sofia noticed the duke’s hand resting on the wall all along. Suddenly, the stone barrier shattered as though detonated from within. The fragments exploded outward, the sharp debris hurtling toward Berian. With no time to cast a defensive spell, the commander instinctively leaped back, raising his arms to shield his face and chest.

“Does that count as a ‘clean hit’?” the duke asked with a sly smile
“You managed to cover your vital organs, and your mana-enhanced body is impressive, considering you're still standing.”

Blood dripped from Berian's arms and thighs. Although he enhanced his body with mana to the very limit, the massive amount of earth bullets cut deeply, perhaps even fracturing some bones. Worse, Vincent had used only three spells so far, which meant he had two left. The crowd murmured with worry, but Berian looked at his opponent and laughed heartily. It has been a long time since he fought another human being seriously.

“That barely counts as a hit, Lord Ralezo” he said, taking up a fighting stance again. His will was far from breaking, in fact the pain was invigorating. “I still have three spells.”

“Now *that's* the spirit,” Vincent replied, his smile turning mischievous.

“Electrocute” Berian intoned, and the air around him seemed to hum with energy. His dark hair stood on end, crackling with the charge.

The duke raised a hand, prepared for the next strike, but it never came. Instead, Berian focused, his voice rising once more.

“Tidal Wave.”

Sofia gasped as a towering mass of water materialized, surging forward like a liquid wall aimed directly at the duke. It wasn’t as fast as the earlier projectiles, but its sheer size and momentum made it impossible to avoid. The crowd erupted in chaos, people tripping over one another as they tried to move further from the escalating battle.

“Earth dome!” Vincent shouted, his voice raised for the first time since the duel began.

The ground around him erupted, forming a solid, globe-like barrier that sealed him inside. The wave slammed into the dome with tremendous force, sending sprays of water in all directions. Those who hadn’t retreated far enough—including Sofia and Kristoffer—were drenched. Sofia's eyes widened in awe. The spell’s scale was extraordinary, requiring immense reserves of mana and unshakable willpower. For Berian to conjure such power in his injured state, and without a magical catalyst, was nothing short of incredible.

“Harden” Berian murmured, his voice audibly weaker.

With a burst of effort, he lunged toward the dome, leaping high and plunging his sword into its surface. The blade pierced through, and the residual water from the tidal wave poured inside. Cracks spiderwebbed across the dome's surface before it collapsed. A cloud of white steam exploded outward, enveloping the arena. Kristoffer gently pushed Sofia away, to protect her from potential danger.

Moments later, a stream of curses emerged from within the mist. As the air cleared, the two combatants came into view. Both lay on the ground, battered and bloodied, though Vincent was visibly livelier—and far more agitated.

"What happened?" Sofia whispered to Kristoffer, her voice barely audible over the murmurs of the crowd.

"The duke won," Kristoffer replied quietly, glancing around to ensure no one could overhear them. "He created a fire cyclone inside his dome, and it hit commander Berian on contact. But there was not enough air in the small room, so the fire spell was not strong enough to deal with this amount of water. The tidal wave water flooded inside, and Berian's lingering electricity spell charged it. The duke had nowhere to run and got electrocuted."

"Isn't that a draw?" Sofia asked, frowning in surprise.

"The duke landed the first hit," Kristoffer said curtly, falling silent as other nobles approached the arena.

"Move aside!" Eduard Elernes shouted, pushing through the crowd with Isabella and Vincent's son, Julian, close behind.

"Father!" Julian yelled, rushing toward the battered men in the waterlogged arena. "What have you done this time?"

"Just a friendly exchange," Duke Ralezo said, slowly rising to his feet, though he winced and twitched from lingering shocks. "We're old friends from the army, no need to worry."

Julian's gaze fell on Berian, who lay unconscious in a pool of his own blood. Disappointment etched across his face as he shook his head.

"He's alive," Isabella declared after kneeling to inspect Berian's condition. "But he's lost a lot of blood and is suffering from mana exhaustion. Take him to my office," she ordered her husband sharply. "The party is over. Everyone can thank Duke Ralezo on their way out."

Eduard hesitated, glancing between his wife and the higher ranked noble man, before deciding he fears the first one more. The head of Elernes house lifted Berian and hurried out with Isabella, leaving the crowd stunned.

"Isabelle! Don't be so cold! I'm injured too!" Vincent called after her, flashing his trademark grin.

"I left you alone for half an hour," Julian snapped, glaring at his father. "Button up your shirt. We're leaving."

“Why are you all making such a big deal out of it, it was a normal duel between two friends...” the duke complained as Julian dragged him away. “Humans fight, then drink and fuck. People are so fragile these days.”

“Enough, Father. We’ll talk later.” Julian paused when he spotted Sofia. “Lady Sofia, I apologize for my father’s behavior. Ruining your coming-of-age celebration was never our intent. I owe you a favor.”

As Julian pulled his father from the arena, the remaining nobles exchanged confused murmurs.

“Is the party really over?”

“Are the Elernes and Ralezo families enemies now?”

“How utterly rude.”

Sofia surveyed the chaotic scene and closed her eyes, taking a deep breath before addressing the crowd.

"Everyone! Thank you for attending my party. Unfortunately, our family friend has been gravely injured, and we must end the celebration early. I hope you’ll forgive us. Please take your time leaving, and our servants will assist you to the best of their capability.”

She glanced apologetically at Kristoffer, who nodded in understanding and began directing the crowd back toward the ballroom.

"I caused trouble for Lady Sofia on the first day," Ana sobbed, burying her face in Lisa's chest. "She's going to hate me for ii-it."

"She won't hate you," Lisa reassured, her black hair framing a face softened with sympathy. "She already said it wasn't your fault." Still, her eyes turned pleadingly toward Kristoffer, silently asking for help.

The three of them sat tucked away in a small storage room, taking a break from the chaos outside. The nobles had left, and the staff had begun cleaning up after the party. Although their shifts were over, they still felt guilty for lazing around when others were working, so they hid themselves in a quiet spot.

"But still..." Ana whimpered again, tears rolling down her flushed cheeks.

"Kristoffer, could you please tell her it's okay?" Lisa asked wearily, patting Ana's back.

"It's okay," he replied flatly, barely glancing up as he focused on his notebook, scribbling something with sharp, deliberate movements.

Lisa was extremely curious about what he had there. She'd tried to sneak a peek earlier, only for him to move out of reach, guarding its contents like a treasure. He had been sketching since they'd arrived.



“You’re a real natural at comforting girls,” Lisa commented sarcastically.

“She’s been crying for over an hour about it, even though Lady Sofia explicitly told her it wasn’t her fault,” Kristoffer replied, his tone as dry as parchment. “I’m powerless against this kind of illogical behavior.”

“And now he hates me too!” Ana wailed, her sobs growing louder.

“Great job,” Lisa hissed at him, glaring.

“It’s not my job to deal with her insecurities,” Kristoffer said matter-of-factly as he closed his notebook and slid off the barrel he’d been perched on. “I’m going to check if Lady Sofia wants dinner or if she’s retiring for the night. If you’re tired of consoling her, I have something that might help her sleep better. She’ll feel fine tomorrow.”

“I’m not going to drug her!” Lisa snapped, cradling Ana protectively.

Kristoffer shrugged off his jacket and used it to cover their legs.

“At least don’t catch a cold. The stone floor is freezing.”

It was only then that Lisa noticed his arms. For the first time, she saw him without sleeves. His left arm was covered with what looked like deep burn scars. The patterns reminded her of what she’d seen back home when the fire consumed their village. She opened her mouth to ask about it, but before she could speak, Kristoffer turned on his heel and left, the door closing softly behind him.

Kristoffer headed towards his master room, his chest filled with a mix of anxiety and excitement. Sofia often scolded Kristoffer for hiding his scars. He did that because most of the people couldn't help but be disgusted with the red, hairless scar tissue. Which was understandable. Kristoffer felt it was unnecessary for his master to lose appetite over some ugly skin, if he could easily wear a jacket to fix the problem. But since she kept on insisting, sometimes he visited her like this. And today was a perfect occasion to follow Sofia's wishes.

Throughout his life Kristoffer was a pacifist. Violence always seemed like a crude option for people that were not intelligent enough to solve their problems through negotiations or logical arguments. But as he was on his way to the noble girl's room, his thoughts were still consumed by the duel he'd seen earlier. Every detail replayed in his mind—the intricate runes, the sharp precision of their movements, the sheer force of their attacks.

Commander Berian's enhancement spells fascinated him. They were more structured than the barbarian magic Kristoffer had read about while researching ways to heal his arm. Although it was not as powerful, the magic still demanded extreme physical conditioning, and Berian's control was nearly flawless. It must have taken years to train his body to handle such strain. And Duke Ralezo? The way he blocked and countered, calm and deliberate, as though he were testing Berian rather than truly fighting him—it was masterful.

His body and mind were itching for a good rivalry like that. Through the last year of sparring with Ernest, Kristoffer discovered that he enjoyed pushing himself over the limit. Failing over and over only to finally be able to land a blow was highly rewarding. It gave him a sense of fulfillment that he rarely found elsewhere. Taking part in a fight like the one he has seen today had to be thousands of times better than his sword spars with the butler.

When Sofia didn't answer his knock, Kristoffer announced himself loudly and peeked inside. He was worried that she fainted again given the mental strain from today's events. But to his surprise there was no sign of his master in the room. After running through the list of places Sofia possibly could go to in her current state, Kristoffer headed towards the garden.

Sure enough, Sofia sat on a bench near the barren patch where she'd tried to plant Ondines earlier. The faint glow of a magical lamp reflected off her blonde hair, giving the scene a mystical feeling. Her white dress was soaked in water and covered in dirt, but that did not spoil the image. Instead, it made her look like a mythical nymph, as if she was nature itself. Kristoffer hesitated to speak, caught by the strange serenity of the situation.

But Sofia sensed him and looked up. "Did you come here just to stare from a distance?" she asked, trying to cover her tired face expression with a weak smile.

“No,” he said, stepping closer. “I didn’t want to startle you. Are you alright, Lady Sofia?”

“I’ve been better,” she admitted with a sigh. “It was only my first day as a noble, and I’m already exhausted. I don’t even know what to think of today.”

“Writing things down helps sometimes,” Kristoffer suggested. “Your scattered thoughts might take shape this way.”

“I don’t need a piece of paper. I need advice Kristoffer,” she said, turning toward him fully. Her tired eyes were sharp, searching his face. “What do you think about all of this? Duke Ralezo, Commander Berian, my parents? Who is right and who is wrong? Am I wrong to feel this way about him using those Lower World girls like that??”

Kristoffer hesitated, then sat beside her.

“I don’t think I’m the right person to ask,” he admitted, his hands clasped tightly as he stared at the flickering moths circling the lamp. “But I’ll do my best to be honest. It’s true that through last months we heard about more and more people dying on the missions outside the safe zones. Lady Sofia, you know how much I love science, but I think duke Ralezo is right. Those mana beasts are too dangerous to keep for research. The only reason humans ended up on top of the food chain was because we were intelligent enough to create and use tools that other animals could not. But magic is much more powerful than any tool we

know, and those magic beasts seem to be very proficient with it. If we don't do anything about it, I'm not sure how long we can stay on the top."

"So, you agree with a seventy-year-old man who is using fifteen-year-old girls as his playthings," Sofia sighed, her fists clenched in her lap. "What happened to the world? I say this knowing that I am a kid as well, but he is brainwashing innocent kids."

"Duke Ralezo's moral compass is a separate thing from his logical approach to the magical beast issue," Kristoffer replied, his tone steady. "Lady Sofia, I'm not too good with things like morality and emotions, so I am not the right person to judge his actions. What I do know from all the people I live with, is that down there in the Lower World they lived hellish lives. Countries are in constant war, innocent people, including children, are being slaughtered on a daily basis. They are thankful for the life they can live here, seeing Upper Worlders as their gods and saviors. That is how those young girls see it, and that is why they were so happy about spending time with the duke. He might be abusing the poor situation he found them in, but their lives became significantly better. My emotional intelligence is not high enough to come up with any moral judgement, and even if I could, it wouldn't be my place."

For a moment, neither of them spoke. The sound of crickets filled the silence, the garden heavy with the weight of their unspoken thoughts.

Finally, Sofia broke the quiet. “And the duel? What did you think of that?”

“That was something,” Kristoffer said, his voice laced with admiration. “I think Duke Ralezo did a brilliant job tricking everybody into thinking that he is capable of silent casting. Those rings with engraved magic circles on them are a genius idea.” His enthusiasm bubbled over as he continued, “I learnt a lot from this, it was a good duel.”

Sofia chuckled softly. “I meant more of ‘do you think it was justified?’”

“Oh,” Kristoffer cheeks reddened in embarrassment. “Well, it might have been a harsh reaction, but it was all legal. And in the end, the duke seemed to gain some respect for Commander Berian. It might have been necessary to clean some air between them, this entire situation looked like the last straw of a long ongoing conflict.”

“It’s hard to believe that as a Lower Worlder you take his side,” Sofia said, exhaling sharply. “He’s attacking and brainwashing people, but no one even seems to care. Is this how the world works? Am I the one who is weird?”

“I wouldn’t call it weird,” Kristoffer gave her a faint smile. “You just want to save everyone, but sometimes...” He hesitated, searching for the right words. “Sometimes people don’t want to be saved. Fighting for freedom and rights for someone who

doesn't care about them will end badly for all parties involved. You can't make people change if they don't want to. Maybe you have to let them choose to be their worst selves sometimes."

Sofia stretched and let out a long sigh. "I can't just accept that twisted logic, no matter how much sense it makes. But enough about nobles and their schemes." Her expression softened as she leaned back on the bench. "I told you I wasn't coming to supper. Did something happen that made you come looking for me?"

Kristoffer shifted, suddenly self-conscious. "No, nothing happened," he said, standing awkwardly. "I just... I didn't get the chance to wish you a happy birthday earlier, Lady Sofia, and I thought—"

"Sofie," she corrected him firmly. "If you're going to wish me happy birthday, do it properly."

"S-Sofie," Kristoffer stammered, flustered. He took a deep breath and tried again. "I wanted to say that I'm sure you'll be able to handle all those nobles and whatever they throw at you. I just hope you can still find your own way to be happy, and I'll do whatever I can to support you in that."

He reached into his pocket and pulled out a neatly folded piece of paper. "I couldn't afford to buy a worthy gift for you Sofie. That's why I made something that can bring you happiness in your

everyday life. It turned out to be more complicated than I initially thought... but maybe I should just show you.”

Kristoffer handed her the paper and stepped back. His expression grew serious, his focus sharpening as he raised his hand. With a fluid motion, light pink flowers began to bloom in the air before them. Their delicate glow illuminated the dark garden, painting Sofia’s face in soft hues. She gasped, immediately recognizing the flower.

“Dahlia,” she murmured, her voice barely above a whisper. Sofia recognized the species immediately. It was Dahlia, flower that symbolizes elegance and inner strength, the very one Kristoffer compared her to after their trip to the sanctuary.



“You always complain about your paintings getting ruined in carriages,” he grinned, remembering her rants from the past. “Now you will be able to paint whenever you want, even during those bumpy rides to noble parties.”

He gestured to the paper. “I explained its structure on this piece of paper. Basically, by imbuing the mana particles with a specific frequency, you can change their colors however you want. All that limits you is how densely you can gather mana in one place and of course your creativity. You need to have a very detailed image of whatever you want to show. I practiced by drawing this image over and over. With your talent and knowledge, you should grasp it quickly. You don’t need even to cast it, since it is not really a spell. It is more like unfinished casting since you fill up the mana particles with —”

Before he could launch into more details, Sofia stood and hugged him. The suddenness of it froze Kristoffer in place, his words cut off mid-sentence.

“Thank you,” she whispered, her voice thick with emotion. He felt the warmth of her tears on his neck.

“Lady Sofia?!” he exclaimed, stepping back in alarm as he saw her wiping her face. “Are you alright? Should we go inside?”

“It’s called feelings, you idiot” she said, her tone light despite the tears. “I love it. You made a spell for me! Isn’t that amazing?”

The glowing Dahlia began to fade, its light dimming until only the cool blue glow of the magical lamp remained.

“As I said, it is not really a spell, more like a deliberately unfinished spell,” Kristoffer mumbled, still unsure if he did

something wrong to make his master cry. “Are you sure you are alri—”

“Enough,” Sofia interrupted, taking the handkerchief he offered. She sat back down on the bench and patted her lap.

“Come here,” she said, her voice weary but firm.

“What?”

“Lie down,” she instructed him, as if it was the most natural thing in the world. “Put your head here.”

Since his master had commanded it, Kristoffer obeyed without hesitation. He shifted into position, resting his head on Sofia’s lap. The thin fabric of her dress barely separated the warmth of her thigh from his cheek, a sensation that sent a ripple of unfamiliar emotion through him. Kristoffer, typically detached and composed, was startled by his own reaction. It was a complicated feeling, that felt both good and wrong at the same time. He instinctively sought to analyze it, dissecting the moment piece by piece as he often did with his thoughts. But no matter how he tried to break it down, he could not reach a sensible conclusion.

“I’m taking you with me to the Academy,” Sofia announced abruptly, her tone firm and decisive.

“Lady Sofia, it would be an honor,” Kristoffer began carefully, “but you should know that it could spark rumors and hurt both you and your family.”

“Sofie,” she corrected him sharply, “and it isn’t up for discussion. Would I even be able to follow the classes without your help? I couldn’t follow Rosalia. And you saved my life Kristoffer. Could I find a better bodyguard than that? Besides, how is me bringing a male servant any different from all those noblemen bringing their female ones?”

“Sofie, servants are also there to help you get dressed and other things...” he said sheepishly.

“I’m supposed to be an adult, Kristoffer,” she replied unconcerned. “I can dress and bathe myself. Another thing—since I’ll be getting more servants, I’ll need a head of staff. I know it’s three months earlier than planned, but as part of your birthday gift, I’ve prepared this.” She reached into her pocket and pulled out a small armband adorned with her family crest. “Kristoffer, will you become my butler?”

“It would be my honor—” Kristoffer began, moving to stand and bow formally.

“Stay,” she said, cutting him off with a gentle but commanding tone. “And as my first task for you as my butler, I want you to lay here and stop thinking for once. Stop calculating. Don’t worry about the future, about protecting me, about doing your job. Just stay in this moment with me. Experience it.”

Her demand caught him off guard, but he tried to oblige. Letting go of his constant stream of thoughts was far harder than he

expected. For as long as he could remember, Kristoffer had seen the world as an endless web of variables—every decision, every word, every step carefully analyzed and adjusted to produce the best possible outcome. Although he had to constantly keep revising his plans and stay on his toes, all this effort usually rewarded him with satisfactory results. It wasn't easy to stop a process that had been ongoing in his head for nearly fifteen years, silencing it now felt almost unnatural.

He shifted his focus to the moths fluttering around the nearby lamp, their pale wings illuminated in the soft glow. For a fleeting moment, he thought he might succeed. But his restless mind soon latched onto another puzzle.

Was the warmth in his chest genuine? Even now, his body obeyed his master's peculiar request to rest his head on her lap—a situation that felt undeniably inappropriate. Was his reaction a result of their relationship, or was it influenced by the master-servant bond? Was he being brainwashed by magic or were these thoughts and feelings his own?

Before he could spiral further, Kristoffer felt Sofia's hand rest gently on the top of his head. Her long, slender fingers began threading through his disheveled hair, each stroke deliberate and calming. The sensation jolted him out of his mental spiral. He resisted the urge to look up, fearing her reaction to his questioning expression. Kristoffer realized that he got distracted from his wild train of thought, overwhelmed by the softness of

Sofia's fingers. Instead, he simply let himself feel the softness of her touch, realizing with some astonishment that it had silenced his chaotic thoughts.

The insects faded from his focus entirely. He closed his eyes, hoping to clear his mind further, but the soothing rhythm of her hand made him feel drowsy, almost sluggish. A rare, faint smile tugged at the corners of his lips as his body relaxed against his will.

As his mind finally gave in to the moment, Kristoffer felt his breathing grow deeper and slower. The last thing he remembered before drifting off was Sofia's flowery scent, wrapping around him like the warmth of her lap.

"We were polite. Does that make you happy with the results?" Isabelle asked coldly as she entered the study, her gaze sharp. After ensuring Berian's condition was stable, she had wasted no time seeking out her husband. "He has a broken collarbone and more cuts than I care to count."



Eduard looked up from his chair, his expression conflicted. “You know that’s not what I wanted, Iz...” he said meekly. “But this is

politics. Every move we make has to be calculated. We can't afford to act rashly."

Your 'politics' nearly killed my friend," Isabelle snapped, grabbing the half-finished bottle of wine from the table and taking a long sip. "Thank whoever is watching over us that Garnez couldn't make it. If this pervert Ralezo was willing to go this far, who knows what he'd have done? You *watched* this man bully our daughter, Eduard."

"He didn't bully her," Eduard protested, his tone defensive. "He proposed a legal deal—one she declined. It was just a conversation."

"You should be ashamed of yourself for even framing it that way." Isabelle's voice cut like a knife. She set the bottle down with a heavy clink. "I spoke with one of Barnos's wives earlier. It seems he'll be voting against increasing funding for farms managed by Lower Worlders."

"Just like Ludwig Varsmith predicted," Eduard murmured, more to himself than to her. "Should we leak the information about his child with a servant? If Barnos realizes he'll never be fully accepted by the purebloods, he might reconsider and support our faction."

"It may come to that," Isabelle replied, kicking off her shoes and sinking into the armchair. "But we'll need to discuss it with the

others first. How much can we trust Varsmith? He's been unusually friendly with you lately."

Eduard leaned back, considering. "Our goals are aligned for now. But if it comes to it, I've gathered documents that could damage his credibility."

"Good," Isabelle said with a nod, then softened her tone. "Would you massage my feet?" She looked at him with puppy eyes, making him sigh before dragging over a nearby stool to fulfill her request.

As he knelt down to knead her feet, Isabelle leaned back with a satisfied sigh. "By the way, Sofia's examiner was paying her a lot of attention through the evening. We must be careful, the Tower might try to use her. It will be difficult to protect her once she's in the academy."

Eduard paused mid-motion, his shoulders heavy with the weight of yet another worry. "Speaking of the Academy," he said after a moment, "she told me today that she wants to take Kristoffer with her."

Isabelle laughed, reaching for the wine again. She took another sip before passing it to her husband, who accepted it gratefully. After a swig, he resumed his task.

"I told you it would come to this," she said, clearly amused. "How naïve can you be? They're teenagers, Eduard—teeming with hormones. Even with the master-servant contract, these things

happen all the time,” she said, in a visibly better mood. “How did you respond?”

“I tried to explain why it wasn’t a good idea,” Eduard muttered, his frustration clear. “But she can be so stubborn sometimes...”

Isabelle waved off his concern. “I don’t think it’s such a bad idea. Sofia has always been resilient to rumors, and frankly, I feel better as a parent knowing Kristoffer will be by her side. That boy was willing to die for her, Eduard. Would you prefer sending some hapless servant girl who’d only become prey for those noble brats?”

Eduard sighed, moving his hands from her feet to her calves. “Ernest has assured me time and time again how reliable Kristoffer is. Still, this could backfire spectacularly—I can already hear how other nobles call our family perverts. We might lose credibility as supporters of Lower Worlde rights.”

“They wouldn’t be completely wrong,” Isabelle murmured seductively. She leaned forward, cupping his chin and tilting his face toward hers. “You are a bit of a pervert.”

Eduard smirked, shifting onto the armchair to hover over her. His hand brushed her neck, firm but gentle, as he whispered, “You’ll need to keep quiet. We wouldn’t want to wake Berian, would we?”

Isabelle shivered under his touch, her earlier frustrations melting away as he kissed her deeply. Whatever battles remained to be fought, they could wait until tomorrow.

Start of the semester

Ernest approached the entrance to the servants' quarters, hesitating just before knocking on the wooden door. From inside, the lively sound of music and singing spilled out, vibrant and carefree. He doubted anyone would hear his knock over the revelry, and it wasn't often that he ventured here. The fervent, almost reverent way the servants treated Upper Worlders always left him feeling uneasy. After a moment's pause, he exhaled, steeling himself, and gently pushed the door open.

Inside, the Lower Worlders were in the midst of a lavish goodbye party. The room was warm with the glow of candles, laughter, and camaraderie. Ernest's eyes scanned the crowd until he spotted Nora and Lisa laughing over cups of wine. He started toward them, intending to ask after Kristoffer before anyone could notice the presence of an Upper Worlder.

But he didn't get far. Just a few steps into the room, he caught sight of Kristoffer himself, all smiles as he danced with Ana, who wore a crown of woven flowers. The boy looked carefree, his movements light and joyous in a way Ernest had rarely seen. The atmosphere scratched at a long-forgotten part of the old butler's heart, and for a fleeting moment, he found himself smiling.

"Lord Ernest!" someone called, shattering the moment.

At once, the room fell silent. All eyes turned toward him, and the music stopped. The Lower Worlders froze in awe, bowing with a deference that only added to Ernest's discomfort.

"Kristoffer, can you come with me?" Ernest said, cutting straight to the point.

Kristoffer's smile faded as confusion crossed his face. He stepped away from Ana, her flower crown slipping slightly, and made his way to Ernest. The older man couldn't help but notice the jealous stares following the boy as he left the crowd.

"Did something happen?" Kristoffer asked once they were outside, his voice low with concern.

"Nothing serious, don't worry," Ernest assured him. "Lord Eduard wants to speak with you for a moment." Then, eyeing Kristoffer closely, he added, "Wait... have you been drinking?"

"I am not drunk," Kristoffer replied, though his cheeks flushed slightly. "But I had a little wine."

Ernest sighed, a touch of envy in his voice. "Ah, to be young again." Without another word, he gestured for Kristoffer to follow.

As they walked through the crisp night air, Kristoffer inhaled deeply, trying to clear his head. The cool breeze helped, and by the time they reached the grand, ornamented wooden doors of the study, his thoughts felt sharper.

"Lord Eduard, I've brought him as requested," Ernest announced, knocking lightly on the door before stepping aside.

Kristoffer entered, the heavy door closing behind him with a decisive click as Ernest left them alone.

The familiar scent of high-quality paper, ink, and polished wood greeted him—a hallmark of Lord Eduard’s workspace. Kristoffer straightened instinctively, his mind snapping into professional focus. As he took a step forward, he glanced at the Earl, trying to decipher the man’s expression and discern what this sudden summons might mean.

“I’m sorry to interrupt your farewell party,” Eduard began with a nod of apology. “But I’ve just received important news. Circumstances have changed. We need to let things take their natural course. It could be dangerous, so stay close to her.”

“Yes, my lord,” Kristoffer replied, his tone steady and polite. “Lisa and our allies are prepared for any potential threats. I’ll make contact with the Lower Worlders from the Welder family as soon as we arrive at the University. Lady Sofia will be safer with such a powerful name at her side. My friend and I have made arrangements in advance, and Lady Katrina plans to stick to Lady Sofia’s side.”

Eduard stood, his expression growing more serious. “We need to keep a low profile for the next three months. Once we’ve gathered enough evidence, we’ll be able to deal a decisive blow to their faction. With half their voting members imprisoned, we’ll have the leverage to push through better laws. Until then, avoid the

spotlight if you can—and if Sofia gets too bold or reckless, do your best to talk her down.

“That said, if some madman dares to harm her, don’t hesitate to use magic to protect her. If word of your abilities leaks, I’ll arrange to relocate you to safety temporarily. In three months, we’ll reform the laws for Lower Worlders, and you’ll be able to step back. Ernest will fill in as Sofia’s guard until things stabilize.”

“Yes, my lord,” Kristoffer said with a deep bow, his expression grave.

Eduard stepped closer, placing a hand on Kristoffer’s shoulder. “Kristoffer, I’m not speaking to you as your employer or as an Upper Worlder. I’m asking you as a father—please protect my girl. I know I’m asking a lot of you. You’ve already done so much for us these past three years. I don’t know how we’ll ever repay you.” His voice softened. “I know this work has strained your relationships with other Lower Worlders. But without your help, Sofia would have far more enemies and far fewer friends. I hate to think how much we’ve asked of you, using your youth for our cause.”

“It’s an honor to serve you, my lord,” Kristoffer replied, bowing again. “I’ll protect her with my life.”

Eduard’s eyes sharpened. “Don’t overdo it. Your life is just as valuable as hers.” His tone shifted to one of paternal concern. “Write to me whenever you can. Now go—maybe they’ll be too drunk to hold it against you for slipping away. And remember,” he

added with a sly smile, “don’t drink too much tonight. It’s a bumpy road to the University.”

Kristoffer’s ears flushed red, and he muttered his farewells before hastily leaving the room. Eduard watched him go, a rare smile playing on his lips. For a moment, he saw not the ever-serious young man but a normal boy—a fleeting glimpse of the person Kristoffer might have been in a different life.

The Earl returned to his desk, where the letter from the Tower still lay. Its contents had the potential to resolve matters peacefully, though Eduard knew better than to rely solely on such a hope. The evidence they already had was enough to bring down Welder, but it wouldn’t be enough to implicate Garnez, who could distance himself and escape accountability.

One more move was needed.

The next shipment of magic stones from the Lower World would provide the final proof. When that evidence was in hand, they could destroy the rival noble faction entirely and seize a commanding majority of votes in the Tower. Eduard steepled his fingers, his expression hardening as he considered the pieces falling into place. Soon, it would all come to fruition.

“Send me a letter every month,” Nora said, pulling her son into a tight embrace one last time. “And promise me—don’t cause any trouble for Lady Sofia.”

“Don’t worry, Mom. Everything will be fine,” Kristoffer assured her, returning the hug. “I’ll be back next summer.”

As he stepped away, he noticed Sofia wrapping up her own goodbyes. He moved quickly to open the carriage door for her. Once inside, the carriage began to roll away, leaving behind the waving Elnes family and staff.

“It feels surreal, leaving home for an entire year,” Sofia remarked as she settled comfortably on the bench. “But I’m glad the rules changed so I could bring all of you along.”

“We’re very happy too, Lady Sofia,” Ana replied, her face lighting up with a bright smile.

“Just remember,” Kristoffer cut in, seated across from them with arms folded and an ever-watchful gaze, “we won’t all be together the whole time. Only one of us will attend to Lady Sofia directly, while the rest of us join the Lower Worlders’ classes. That could be dangerous—those classes were created to deal with the mana beast problem. You’ll need to work hard and prove the worth of the Elnes family with your—”

“Kristoffer,” Sofia sighed, rolling her eyes with a smile, “don’t scare them before we even see the gates. Listen, girls,” she continued, voice gentler, “I want you to enjoy yourselves. Make friends, explore. This is your first taste of freedom in the Upper World.”

“But...” she leaned in slightly, her smile sharpening just a touch, “if you happen to hear something interesting—rumors, gossip about other families or their agendas—it would help our cause. Just don’t go looking for trouble.”

“We’ll be careful,” Lisa said, meeting Sofia’s gaze with a calm, resolute nod.

Sofia nodded, pleased. “Good. In the beginning, we lay low. The last thing we want is the Tower paying too much attention to me.”

Ana tilted her head. “Is the University part of the Tower?”

“Technically, no,” Kristoffer answered with a tired breath. “But practically? Almost everyone there is tied to the Tower in some way—or wants to be. I’ve explained this, Ana.”

Ana shrank a little. “Sorry.”

Kristoffer’s tone softened—slightly. “Just ask if you don’t understand, alright? Think of the Tower as our ruling force. The University of the Abyss is where the next generation of elites are molded. The Tower ensures its influence by planting its own there—mentors, instructors, even students. Talented outliers who don’t fall in line are seen as threats. And threats... get removed.”

He shot a meaningful look at Sofia.

“I’ll make sure that we can be of help to you, Lady Sofia,” Lisa replied confidently.

“Good.” Kristoffer nodded before adding, “This is the first time in history that they’ve opened a school for Lower Worlders. We need to stick together and be ready for anything. Don’t let any information slip to other families. As we’ve learned over the past three years, most of them are openly hostile to the Elernes name. That means no babbling about Lady Sofia’s affairs or how amazing she is. Understood, Ana?”

“You didn’t have to single me out!” Ana protested with a pout. “I would never betray Lady Sofia!”

Kristoffer smirked. “The first week, I’ll be staying with Lady Sofia to help her settle in at the academy. During that time, I probably won’t be able to interact with other servants, so you’ll have to represent the Elernes family on your own. First impressions are critical; they’ll shape our entire social network. Lisa, I am counting on you to be in charge when I am gone. Weaponize Ana’s cuteness to get on good terms with a lot of people.”

“You can count on me,” Lisa answered, as they both nodded in agreement.

Sofia chuckled at the exchange while Ana pouted, giving Kristoffer a light punch on the arm.

“It’s not far,” Sofia said once they’d all settled in. “But it’ll still take about two hours to get there. Feel free to nap if you’d like.”

She reached for the gift her parents had given her for her 18th birthday—a stunning 15-centimeter wand crafted from dark,

spiral-shaped wood. At the tip, an impressive green mana stone glimmered with energy. The wand exuded an aura of both elegance and danger, its wood harvested from trees that only grew near mana rifts in perilous environments. This material made it exceptionally efficient at conducting mana.

Sofia studied the wand with excitement. Because of Kristoffer's hands-on teaching style, she hadn't had much practice casting magic with a catalyst, and she was eager to see what this one could do.

As she focused her energy, the green gemstone began to glow brighter. A breathtaking illusion of a lively mountain stream materialized above it. The colors were so vivid that, if not for the absence of sound, one might have mistaken it for the real thing.

"That's very impressive, Lady Sofia," Kristoffer complimented. "Changing the mana frequency so smoothly takes a lot of skill. The movement looks incredibly natural, and the level of detail is remarkable."

"I spent hours practicing with it," Sofia replied with a smile as the projection faded away. "But keeping the motion going puts a lot of strain on the caster. I can't maintain it for more than a few seconds."

"You seem to know a lot about magic, Kristoffer," Lisa observed, tilting her head curiously.

“I’ve just picked up a few terms during Lady Sofia’s lessons,” he replied with calm modesty.

Sofia’s lips curved into a faint smile as she leaned against the carriage wall. “I might try to nap for a bit. I didn’t get much sleep last night with all the preparations. Wake me up before we reach the Academy grounds.”

Kristoffer nodded, watching as she quickly drifted off. It never failed to fascinate him how Sofia could fall asleep so effortlessly, even after all they’d been through together. The past three years had been a whirlwind of activity—meetings, parties, and navigating the treacherous world of Upper World nobility. He already had a good sense of who might be in her class at the Academy, and some of those names concerned him deeply. Her uncompromising righteousness clashed with the typical values of Upper World society, and he suspected life would only grow more challenging from here. Still, he was glad she could enjoy a moment of peace before they arrived.

Across from him, Ana stretched out and rested her head in Lisa’s lap. Kristoffer’s heart softened as he watched Lisa gently stroke Ana’s brown hair. He worried for these two as well. According to what Ernest had told him, the Lower Worlder school might be less of an academic institution and more akin to a military training camp.

The rise in mana beast attacks had brought terror to the farmlands outside the city, leaving Lower Worlders defenseless

and facing heavy casualties. The Tower was finally taking the issue seriously, fearing a potential food shortage. But this meant the school's agenda would likely be intense and dangerous. On top of that, Eduard Elernes had recently spoken to Kristoffer at length about their most dangerous political opponents. With the Academy's strict rules prohibiting outside communication, Sofia's safety would fall squarely on their shoulders.

Kristoffer stared out the window, lost in thought. His mind raced with contingency plans, carefully crafting responses to every scenario he could imagine. For now, he would remain vigilant and ensure they were ready for whatever challenges lay ahead.

"Welcome to the University of the Abyss, or as we now call it—the National Academy," announced an older man with short white hair, his voice resonating through the grand auditorium filled with young adults. "This institution, the largest repository of magical knowledge in the world, is now open to all of you."

He paused, scanning the crowd with piercing eyes before continuing, "I am Alden Sophron, the headmaster of this academy. As you know, graduating from here will open the door to any career you desire. But nothing in life comes without effort. Classes here will be rigorous, and at times, dangerous. Overcoming these challenges will shape you into individuals worthy of this esteemed institution."

"If you feel unprepared to face such demands, this is your final chance to withdraw without consequence. Simply raise your hand, and we will arrange for you to return home."

A wave of silence swept the room as students exchanged glances, searching for anyone bold enough to quit. When no hands were raised after a tense minute, the headmaster gave a nod of approval.

"Excellent. I hope this determination remains with you for the next six years," he said, his tone firm. "This year marks a significant departure from tradition. For the first time, all nobles have been permitted to bring up to three individuals from the Lower World. These attendants will rotate weekly, allowing them to participate in their own educational program designed to benefit our nation."

"We have arranged special living quarters for them. After this introduction, all Lower Worlders are to follow the professors wearing a green star on their chest." Alden gestured briefly, giving the students a moment to locate the designated staff members.

"But that is not the only unique aspect of this year," he added. "Tomorrow morning, all Upper Worlders will depart for a sanctuary near the border. There, you will undergo intense training to strengthen the barriers around your mana source. Based on your performance, you will be assigned to classes suited to your abilities."

"I wish you all the best of luck. Professor Rena Karlton will now provide information about accommodations and how to communicate with your families."

With that, the headmaster descended from the podium, replaced by a tall, elegant woman with an air of authority. Her silver hair, meticulously tied in a bun, accentuated her strict demeanor.



"Welcome," she began, her sharp gaze sweeping across the room. "I will now read the names of purebloods and their

assigned buildings. Remember, each of you may bring only one servant, who will remain with you for the week."

She opened a scroll and began to read. "Erik Garnez..."

For several minutes, the auditorium was filled with tension as she continued listing names. It was clear to everyone what this public roll call symbolized: the establishment of the school's social hierarchy, even before classes began.

Out of the roughly three hundred students present, fewer than half were named. Those who weren't mentioned endured quiet ridicule from the front rows, where the purebloods sat confidently.

When Professor Karlton finished, the named purebloods and their chosen attendants exited the room, leaving the remaining students to be addressed by other staff members of lower rank.

"Ana, Lisa, take care of yourselves," Sofia said with a warm smile, resisting the urge to embrace them after catching Kristoffer's warning glance. "We'll be back in a week. I trust you two can manage."

"I'll miss you, Lady Sofia," Ana murmured, her voice trembling as she fought back tears.

"Don't worry, Lady Sofia. We'll be more than fine," Lisa assured her, elbowing Ana firmly to snap her out of her emotional state. "Please take care of yourself, too."

As the two girls followed a nearby instructor, Sofia waved them off with a radiant smile, doing her best to appear confident and composed.

"How touching," came a smooth voice from behind them. A handsome young noble with platinum blonde hair combed a hand through his locks as he approached. "Sofia, I see you've grown even closer to your servants since the last time we met. Such a philanthropist you are. Don't you want to meet mine? My previous one broke, unfortunately, so I had to replace her. This is Nina."

He yanked the wrist of a timid girl standing behind him and shoved her forward.

"Duke Garnez," Sofia greeted him with a polite, neutral smile. "It has been some time. It is a pleasure to meet you, Nina. My name is Sofia." She turned her attention back to the duke. "I apologize, Duke Garnez, but I must settle into my room and rest before tomorrow's assignment."

"But of course," he replied, his lips curling into an unpleasant smile. "I wouldn't dream of keeping you. Nina needs to get to work soon anyway. Sofia, if you manage to do well enough to make it into Class A, we'll have plenty of opportunities to talk in the future. I'll look forward to it."

Sofia maintained her composure, offering a brief nod before she and Kristoffer turned and left the auditorium. They made their

way toward the massive building that loomed nearby, its grand structure resembling an opulent mansion rather than a dormitory. The heavily ornamented walls and intricate sculptures lining the roof reflected a level of luxury reserved for the elite.

As they approached the massive, decorative metal gate, Sofia's eyes wandered to the elaborate carvings, recognizing some of the ancient runes etched into the stonework. Just before entering, she noticed another familiar face approaching from the other direction.



“Sofia, you look even lovelier in your school uniform than I imagined,” Julian Ralezo greeted her with a polite bow. His smile

was charming as always. “Seeing you like this has made my day worth living through.”

“Duke Ralezo,” Sofia responded with a graceful curtsy. “I was under the impression that first-year students were discouraged from interacting with upperclassmen until after class assignments.”

“That’s a rule for commoners,” he said with a dismissive wave and a laugh before pausing, his expression softening. “Ah, forgive me. I didn’t mean to offend. I forgot you’re... sensitive about these matters. That was unbecoming of me. I merely came to fulfill a promise. I still owe you a favor. If you ever find yourself in trouble here, do not hesitate to call on me for help.”

“Thank you for your generous offer,” Sofia replied, slipping on her practiced, official smile. “Now, if you’ll excuse me, I must rest after the long trip.”

Without waiting for a response, Sofia turned and quickened her pace, determined to avoid further interaction. She registered at the dormitory reception in record time, then hurried toward the room she had been assigned. As she climbed the stairs with Kristoffer in tow, a cheerful voice called out from behind.

“Sofie!”

Sofia turned to see a short girl with a radiant smile waving at her enthusiastically.

“Katrina,” Sofia greeted, her exhaustion seeping into her voice.

“Where’s your room? Mine’s 201. You can stop by anytime!”

“I’m in 306,” Sofia replied with a faint smile. “I’ll visit after I’ve had some time to rest. See you later, Katie.”

When they finally reached her door, Kristoffer opened it, and Sofia rushed in, collapsing face-first onto the bed. She let out a muffled scream into her pillow, muffling her frustrations.

“It’s not all bad, Lady Sofia,” Kristoffer said with an attempt at optimism. “You enjoy Lady Katrina’s company. I’m sure she brought some of that tea you love so much.”

Sofia lifted her face just enough to give him a pointed look.

“I’m thrilled that a few seconds of polite chit-chat with Katrina managed to compensate for the rest of today’s disasters,” she replied with biting sarcasm.

“The son of Duke Ralezo offering his help from the start is also a promising development,” Kristoffer added, undeterred.

“We don’t know how sincere that offer is,” Sofia sighed, rolling over on the bed and kicking her legs idly. “For all I know, it’s just an elaborate pretense to lure me into his bedroom. And now we’ve left Ana and Lisa alone for a week in a place where everyone will look down on them. They even look down on Upper Worlders who aren’t tied to the First Faculty! This whole place feels like a nightmare. I hate it already.”

“There’s no need to worry, Lady Sofia,” Kristoffer said with a calm smile. “I’m confident Lisa will handle things. And I believe it will

get better once everyone settles into their classes. The beginning is always the hardest part.”

“You sound like my father,” Sofia complained, burying her face in her hands. “I’m not a child, you know. You really trust Lisa, don’t you? It’s rare for you to put that kind of faith in people.”

“Let’s just say she’s my kind of person,” Kristoffer replied with a subtle shrug as he looked around the room. “They call this a ‘room,’ but you have your own bathroom and a guest room for a servant as well. It’s not a bad setup. Please try to enjoy your time here, Lady Sofia.”

“Fine, fine,” Sofia muttered, pressing a pillow over her face. “Just let me wallow for a bit, and I’ll pull myself together.”

“Are we going to be okay?”

“Yes,” Kristoffer replied, though his tone carried a note of caution. “I don’t think there’s a high chance they’ll act openly. I’ll try to stay close whenever I can, but just in case...” He paused and handed her a fountain pen. “You can always say it’s for taking notes or as a backup for Lady Sofia. But if your or Ana’s life is ever in danger, don’t hesitate to use it. I know you swore you’d never do this again, but this is a last resort for when I’m not around. Aim for the eyeball or the throat. And be careful—don’t cut yourself. It will paralyze you.”

The weight of his words hung in Lisa's mind as she recalled the exchange, her grip tightening on the pen hidden in her pocket. She snapped back to the present, surveying the chaos before her.

The woman with a green star pinned to her chest had led them to a barn-like structure, vast and loud with activity. Inside, it was divided into restroom facilities and a large hall filled with rows of bunk beds. Dozens of people were talking in hushed whispers, arguing in heated tones, or simply observing their surroundings. The air was thick with tension and noise—a cacophony of restless energy.

“This is where you'll be staying,” the Upper Worlder announced to the group. “Pick your place and gather in front of the building at dawn. We'll start with a light breakfast and physical exercise.” With that, she turned and exited, leaving them to fend for themselves.

The group she had led consisted of about fifteen people, with more trickling in. Lisa stood on her toes, scanning the crowd for familiar faces.

“Are we really going to sleep in the same room as the boys?” Ana whispered, clutching Lisa's sleeve nervously.

“What? Are you worried?” a well-built boy with long hair smirked as he stepped closer, clearly eavesdropping. “You do look pretty cute.”

“Touch my friend, and you’ll lose an eye,” Lisa said coldly, stepping in front of Ana. Her voice was steady and sharp as steel. “And that’s before my master arrives to finish whatever’s left of you.”



“Big, scary sister, huh?” the boy replied, his grin widening as if amused. “Relax, I was just teasing. Why would I hurt something

so precious? My name's Luka, and I serve Baron Valron. Nice to meet you."

"I'm Lisa," she replied curtly. "We serve Lady Sofia, daughter of the Earl Elernes. Disrespect us again, and it will be the last time." Her sharp gaze flicked past him as she noticed a familiar group of servants from the Welder household. "Now, excuse us. Our friends are waiting."

Grabbing Ana's hand, Lisa pulled her away, leaving the stunned boy behind. As they approached a small cluster of people, a tall young man greeted them with a warm smile.

"Lisa, Ana! I'm so glad you made it. We saved spots for you here," he said.

"Thank you, Keith. It's good to see you too," Lisa replied, her voice softening slightly. "Could you tell me what you've learned so far? I see the servants from Duke Garnez are attracting a lot of attention."

"We just left Carla and Lady Katrina not long ago," Keith explained, gesturing to the bustling room. "It looks like Garnez's servants have been here well ahead of us, which might explain why they've drawn a crowd. Let's sit and exchange information..."

"I can't believe they're sending us to the woods right from the start," Katrina Welder complained as she meticulously filed her nails. "Carla, can you even cook in the wilderness?"

“Yes, Lady Katrina,” her servant replied calmly. “Back in my village, we lived off the forest’s bounty.”

Carla was a striking young woman with short black hair and small marks scattered across her face. Her steady demeanor exuded strength and patience, a sharp contrast to her refined and often dramatic mistress. Because Katrina prized elegance, Carla wore a simple black dress instead of the typical linen shirt and pants most servants donned.



“Sofie, are you really going to present yourself like *that*?” Katrina asked, scrutinizing her friend’s leather pants and cotton shirt. “Your outfit looks a bit...boyish. It won’t leave the best

impression on the other nobles. And those rings don't really match, either."

"My rings were a gift, and I'm not leaving them behind," Sofia said firmly. "I don't care if people like my outfit or not. This is a class, not a ball. Besides, think how stunning *you'll* look standing next to me." She grinned teasingly.

Katrina rolled her eyes but smiled. "We should stick together if we're forced to camp out there. Carla's a great cook, and she seems to get along well with your servant. A bigger group with good relationships might make a week of bugs and mud less miserable."

"Let's wait and see what the school has planned," Sofia replied, glancing out the window as familiar buildings passed by. "They might assign us into groups regardless."

"It was bold of you to bring a boy with you from the start. Aren't you worried about the gossip?" Katrina pressed, raising her eyebrow.

"I don't care about gossip," Sofia said with a shrug. "Kristoffer is very capable and that is what matters, not some tittle-tattle from bored nobles. And Katie, didn't *you* bring Keith?"

"Well, yes," Katrina admitted, her blonde curls bouncing as she tilted her head. "But he's more of a support for the girls. I'm not planning to use him as my personal assistant." Her eyes shifted ahead. "Oh, look! There's a wall up ahead. We must be close."

Soon, the carriage came to a halt, and both Sofia and Kristoffer recognized the intricate runes etched into the towering wall. Around them, other new arrivals stared in awe, seeing the massive construction for the first time. Dozens of carriages were already parked nearby, with more arriving every minute. At the end of the long column there were uncomfortable looking carts filled with students that weren't part of nobility.

"Newcomers, enter the garrison here!" a chubby man with glasses barked from the doorway.

Carla and Kristoffer unloaded their masters' luggage as the group followed the professor's voice. Inside, the building was lined with long benches flanking multiple dining tables. Students were scattered about, enjoying refreshments after their journeys.

As Sofia and Katrina surveyed the room, familiarizing themselves with their surroundings, a handsome boy with light hair entered behind them. His face lit up in recognition.

"Lady Sofia?" he asked, his surprise evident. "What a pleasure to see you again! I couldn't find you during the opening ceremony."

"It's lovely to see you too, Viscount Varsmith," Sofia said, offering him a polite smile. "I was exhausted after the journey and retired to my room early. Allow me to introduce my friend, Katrina, daughter of Earl Welder. Katrina, this is Jens, son of Viscount Varsmith."

“I’ve heard so much about you, Lady Katrina,” Jens said warmly, bowing slightly. “Please, no need for titles—just call me Jens.”

“The pleasure is mine,” Katrina said, her cheeks flushing as she stole a glance at his broad shoulders.

“Should we sit together while we wait for the announcements?” Sofia suggested, seizing the opportunity to share the responsibility of entertaining her talkative friend.

“I’d be honored,” Jens replied, his tone gracious. The group moved to the nearest empty table, settling in to wait for the next stage of their journey.

Just as Sofia had predicted, Katrina and Jens quickly hit it off. They began exchanging harmless gossip about other nobles and reminiscing about past parties, giving Sofia a much-needed reprieve after enduring Katrina’s nearly three-hour-long tirade.

New students continued streaming into the hall until one of the professors closed the entrance gate. The short, chubby man who had greeted them earlier stepped up to the podium. As the chatter subsided, he addressed the crowd.

“My name is Professor Borgman, and I am tasked with ensuring you all understand what lies ahead.”

As he spoke, Sofia and Kristoffer exchanged surprised glances. Borgman was the professor they had planned to seek out as soon as they settled into the university—it seemed fate was on their side.

Borgman continued, his voice monotonous and his expression weary. “Over the next week, you will focus on building and strengthening the barrier around your core. This location is ideal for such training due to the nearby magical anomaly, which naturally drains mana from the surroundings. While this will make your task more challenging, it will also yield superior results.”

“In one week, your cores will be inspected, and based on your progress, you will be assigned to a class. Class A will be reserved for the top twenty students. For now, you will enter the safe zone, where you may choose to train independently or in a group under a teacher’s guidance. Be advised, though the area is protected, minor mana beasts can still appear. Now, please proceed through the gate behind me. I wish you all the best of luck.”

Borgman’s disinterested tone and fatigued demeanor suggested he would rather be anywhere else. Students glanced around uncertainly, unsure if that was truly the extent of his announcement. Other professors began ushering them out of the hall, clarifying details for the more confused participants. Sofia and Kristoffer moved with the group, catching glimpses of the sanctuary’s wild, ancient trees as they emerged into the safe zone.

Excited murmurs rippled through the crowd as students pointed out the small mana beasts wandering the area. Sofia and

Kristoffer were about to approach Professor Borgman when a sharp voice cut through the commotion.

“Please focus!”

The group fell silent as the authoritative Professor Rena stepped forward. She was the same professor who had delivered the opening ceremony speech, and her stern presence demanded immediate attention.

“We will now divide into two groups,” she announced. “As students of the University of the Abyss, it is your responsibility to choose how best to explore the world of magic. Those who wish to train under supervision will remain with me. Those who prefer self-study may follow Mr. Rey and Mr. Krein, skilled hunters responsible for maintaining the safety of the green zone.

“Regardless of your choice, all students must spend a minimum of three nights in the safe zone near the magical anomaly. This experience will teach you to sustain your barrier even in your sleep—a skill that is crucial for every graduate of this institution. The harsher environment will forge a stronger foundation for your future development. You have fifteen minutes to decide.”

As the crowd erupted into murmurs and hurried discussions, Sofia seized the opportunity to approach Professor Borgman. He was the author of several books that had been instrumental in her magical education, and she had long admired his expertise.

“Professor Borgman,” she called out, her excitement barely contained. “I’m Sofia of House Elernes. May I have a moment of your time?”

Borgman turned to her, his expression briefly clouded with suspicion. He was clearly unaccustomed to noble students approaching him without ulterior motives, and the wariness in his gaze was evident. Still, his tone was not unfriendly.

“Make it quick,” he said, adjusting his glasses. “This isn’t the best time for a chat.”

“I apologize,” Sofia said, nodding respectfully. “I wanted to ask if you might teach me the theory of silent casting if we stayed at the camp.”

Borgman’s brow furrowed, and though his initial skepticism lingered, his tone softened. “Silent casting, hmm? An ambitious topic.” He studied her face for a moment, as though gauging her sincerity. “I’m afraid it won’t be possible—not here. The program is designed to equalize the magic proficiency of all students. While you’re welcome to stay, you’ll be working on the basics, just like everyone else.”

Sofia’s shoulders slumped in disappointment, her carefully maintained composure slipping just enough to reveal how much she had hoped for a different answer. Borgman hesitated, a flicker of regret crossing his face, but before he could say more, Jens approached the group with a curious smile.

“What’s your plan, Lady Sofia? Lady Katrina?” Jens asked, his tone light but genuinely curious.

“I don’t like the idea of sleeping here one bit,” Sofia admitted with a grimace. “The so-called ‘safe zone’ isn’t safe at all.”

“Sounds like something a supporter of the Lower Worlders would say.” A sharp voice cut in, mocking and cold. “Do red-eyed squirrels terrify everyone in the Elernes household?”



The group turned. A tall young man approached, all sharp features and a practiced smirk. Baron Valron. Arrogant as ever.

“I agree with Sofia, Baron Valron,” Katrina said coolly, lifting her chin. “It would be reckless to treat this place lightly. You might remember—a mage killer spider appeared here three years ago. Even seasoned hunters suffered casualties.”

“The difference, Lady Katrina,” Valron said, voice dripping with disdain, “is that we are nobility, not peasants swinging spears. A dumb beast like that is no match for a trained group of mages.”

“I fought that spider,” Sofia said quietly.

Valron blinked. “You?”

“I was in the sanctuary,” she continued, her tone flat. “It killed our guide. Nearly killed my servant. And it only ran after we landed a spell that almost split it in half.”

Silence fell.

Katrina stared. “Wait... you’re *her*? The girl from the sanctuary?”

“I heard the story,” Jens added, brows lifted. “That a young noble made it flee. I just didn’t know that noble was you, Lady Sofia.”

“If that story’s true,” Valron said with a snort, waving his hand like swatting a fly, “then clearly the beast wasn’t worth the hype. If a girl like you scared it off, killing it should be easy enough.”

He turned on his heel, striding off toward the self-study group near Duke Garnez—his condescension trailing behind him like perfume.

“Don’t pay attention to him, Sofie.” Katrina said soothingly. “He’s always been a dick” She caught herself, blushing slightly as she realized Jens was still present. “I mean, um, he’s always been rude. Sorry, I got carried away.”

“No reason to be on guard with me around,” Jens said with a grin. “I happen to agree with your assessment, Lady Katrina.”

He turned to Sofia, more serious now. “Is it true what they say? That the spider could cancel magic?”

“It’s true,” Sofia replied evenly.

“Not entirely,” Borgman chimed in, stepping back into the conversation. The warmth in his tone hinted that he had been impressed by Sofia’s earlier composure and courage. “The spider doesn’t cancel magic—it disrupts *runic magic*. That’s an important difference.”

A few students nearby turned their heads, sensing that something worth hearing was coming.

“Runic casting,” he continued, “relies on structure. Symbols, chants, diagrams—they’re all scaffolding. You build a frame, and you pour mana into it like concrete. But if something strikes that scaffolding at the wrong angle? The whole thing crumbles. That’s what the mage killer spider does—it destabilizes those external patterns, and the magic collapses.”

He raised a hand and curled it slightly, as if cradling something unseen.

“But there’s a different kind of magic. Rare. Difficult. *Dangerous*, if attempted too soon. It’s called silent casting. No runes. No chants. Just raw intent, compressed mana, and absolute control.”

He paused, watching their expressions.

“Imagine building a tower from sand molds—easy to form, but easy to ruin. Now imagine forging that same tower from molten metal. It takes a furnace, a forge, years of effort—and it burns like hell to get it right. But once it’s shaped, nothing shakes it.”

He gave a wry smile, voice lowering slightly.

“Not even a mage-killer spider.”

The students were silent.

Borgman folded his arms. “But don’t mistake this as something anyone here can do—not even me. I’ve studied magic my whole life, and I’ve only *tasted* the edge of silent casting. It takes more than understanding. It takes *attunement*—to mana, to nature, to yourself. You have to feel the weight of the world and move with it, not against it.”

He tapped a finger to his temple, then to his chest.

“You need intellect, yes—but also maturity. Emotional control. Willpower. Technique. Adjusting the frequency of your mana. Compressing it like you’re squeezing fog into a blade. It’s as much meditation as it is mathematics.”

The students listened intently, though the complexity of his explanation left some looking confused.

“Borgman Vandick,” Professor Rena’s cold voice cut through the air. She stood nearby, her sharp gaze fixed on him. “Could you kindly focus on your task of organizing students instead of filling their heads with theories they’re not yet equipped to grasp? And you three,” she added, directing her stern look at Sofia, Katrina, and Jens, “shouldn’t you be deciding what to do instead of pestering professors?”

Borgman sighed, rolling his eyes slightly as he turned to follow her instructions.

“What do you plan to do from now on?” Jens asked, his expression betraying that he was still processing the events unfolding around them. “My tutor says I have a solid foundation in mana barrier techniques, but I think reviewing the fundamentals with the academy teachers could really help.”

“I’m not the best with magic, but—” Katrina began, but her words cut off abruptly. A chilling stillness fell over the crowd, silencing every voice.

The students’ gazes snapped upward, drawn to the massive creature hovering in the air a few hundred meters away. The beast, easily twenty meters long, floated motionless, its predatory aura palpable. Brown scales shimmered in the daylight, while massive wings flapped rhythmically, keeping it

aloft. Twisted horns jutted from its head, but the most unnerving feature was its eyes. Those slit pupils radiated an almost unsettling intelligence, their sharp gaze tracking even the smallest movements below.

“D-dragon!” someone screamed, breaking the silence. Panic erupted like a dam bursting, and many students bolted toward the gate they had just entered.

Sofia felt an all-too-familiar sensation gripping her—an icy weight of dread that froze her limbs. It was the same feeling she’d experienced years ago when she first faced the spider. Her mind sharpened in response, ready for action, but her body stubbornly refused to move.

Then she saw Kristoffer step forward, shielding her as he had done three years ago when her hesitation had nearly cost him his life. His expression was the same as it had been then: resolute and unyielding. The sight jolted Sofia back into control. With a steadying breath, she placed a hand on his shoulder, signaling her readiness.

Nearby, Katrina collapsed to her knees, her face the picture of despair. Carla crouched beside her, trying unsuccessfully to help her stand. Jens, meanwhile, stood frozen, staring blankly at the scene as if his very soul had left his body.

“Please refrain from panicking!” a voice boomed, cutting through the chaos. Rey, one of the hunters, stepped forward, his

commanding presence helping to calm the crowd. “There’s no danger. This dragon occasionally visits the barrier. Unlike other flying mana beasts, it never attempts to attack. And even if it did, our soldiers are always prepared.”

Professor Rena seized the opportunity to reinforce the lesson. “As students of the University of the Abyss, you should see this as a rare learning opportunity. Dragons are not something you encounter every day. Remember: panic is the enemy of magic. A clear mind is essential to cast effectively. Compose yourselves and behave as befits students of this institution. You have five minutes left to decide which group you’ll join.”

Katrina whispered shakily, “I’m staying with the teachers.”

“They must be joking,” Jens said nervously, his forced laugh betraying his unease. “They expect us to train with that thing watching us?” He turned to Sofia. “Lady Sofia, what are you going to do?”

“I’ve never been great at learning from teachers,” Sofia said, helping Carla lift Katrina to her feet. “I’m going with the self-study group.”

“Sofia? Is that you?” Rey, still working to calm the students, approached their small group.

“Hello, Rey,” Sofia greeted him warmly. “It’s nice to see you again.”

“Damn, you’ve grown up,” Rey said, his grin breaking the tension further. Then his gaze shifted to Kristoffer, and his eyes widened in recognition. “Wait a second—is this the guy we carried out back then? Krein didn’t think he’d make it. Glad to see he was wrong!” Rey laughed heartily, clapping Kristoffer on the shoulder.

Kristoffer bowed deeply. “Thank you for saving my life once again. I owe you a debt I hope to repay someday.”

“Don’t mention it. I was just doing my job.” Rey’s easy confidence was contagious, and the oppressive atmosphere began to ease. “You’ve both come a long way. Are you coming with us, Sofia?” His grin turned playful. “Guess I should call you *Lady* Sofia now. Sorry—I’ve never been good at the formal stuff.”

Sofia smiled. “There’s no need for honorifics. You saved us back then. Me and Kristoffer are coming along, but my friends are staying here.” She turned to Katrina and Jens. “I’ll see you later.”

“Be careful, Sofie,” Katrina said, hugging her tightly. “I’ll miss you. Come visit whenever you can.”

“I’ll do my best to end up in Class A with you, Lady Sofia,” Jens added, his tone filled with resolve.

With that, the group split up. Sofia followed Rey to the self-study group, her steps lighter as the tension finally began to subside. But the relaxed atmosphere didn’t last long.

“Does the Elernes family dress like Lower Worlders now?” Erik Garnez taunted, his voice dripping with disdain.

Sofia turned to him with an expression of icy composure. “The Elernes family prioritizes skill and efficiency over pride and vanity. I don’t see how a dress would be of any use in the forest.” Her tone was dry, but cutting. Without waiting for a response, she moved past him, following her old acquaintance, Rey.



“I see we’re down to just seven people from the original fifteen,” Rey said with a chuckle. “The dragon sure has great timing for thinning out the herd.” He turned to his companion. “Krein, look

who I found—it's our young spider-slayer and her 'pretty much dead' servant from back then."

The students in the self-study group stared at Sofia and Kristoffer with wide eyes. Krein, the other hunter, stepped forward, bowing politely to Sofia before shaking Kristoffer's hand.

"I'm glad to see you both alive and well," Krein said sincerely. "The last time we met, the situation was... grim. Forgive Rey's bluntness—he's never been one for etiquette."

"Well, damn the etiquette," Rey interjected with a grin. "Right now, I'm your temporary teacher, folks. You're responsible for your own safety out here, but first, we need to get you certified if you plan on roaming the forest." His gaze swept across the group. "Except you, Sofia. You're already cleared to go. Anyone else certified?"

Baron Valron's son and Duke Garnez both raised their hands.

"Great," Rey said, his tone slightly skeptical. "You can head out too. But let me warn you—if you're lying about your certification, they'll kick you out of the university when they find out." He looked at them pointedly. "Before you go, here's a quick tip: if you decide to switch back to the other study group later, just return to the gate and ask for directions. Also, keep in mind, you're allowed four stays in the garrison. You'll need to register each time so the university can verify you've spent three nights out

here. Me and Krein will be patrolling near the yellow zone to keep things safe. Have fun!”

Turning to the rest of the group, Rey’s tone shifted. “The rest of you will need to take a one-hour class on the sanctuary and its rules before heading out. Stay sharp.”

Max Valron shot Sofia a sharp look as he and his hulking servant—who looked more bear than man—strode into the forest. Sofia sighed, shaking her head. Without a word, she ensured Kristoffer was following her, and they headed off in another direction.

Once they were deeper into the woods, Sofia broke the silence. “What do you think? Should we spend the first three nights out here and then return, or should we check in at the garrison every other day?”

“It’s your decision, Lady Sofia,” Kristoffer replied, his eyes scanning their surroundings with practiced precision. “I know a reliable magic circle for camping—it’ll keep the ground warm and repel insects. We should be reasonably comfortable.”

Sofia smiled slyly. “Considering how demanding you were as my tutor, we could pass this survival test without lifting a finger. Maybe we should stay out here and use the time to gather some healing herbs. I bet you’d love to investigate that magic anomaly too.” Her grin widened mischievously. “Besides, why sleep on the ground? Can’t we just build a small house with earth magic?

Neither of us specializes in it, but I'm sure we can put something together."

"But building a house would defeat the whole point of camping, Lady Sofia," Kristoffer replied, his voice laced with a touch of disappointment.

"You never told me you were such a camping enthusiast," Sofia teased, laughing cheerfully as they continued deeper into the woods.

Return to the Sanctuary

The first two days passed uneventfully—or so it seemed. Beneath the surface, Sofia wrestled with an unsettling sensation she hadn't felt in years. The last time she was here, with Greg, a silent call had tugged at her, pulling her toward the forest's center. That faint attraction had now returned, stronger than ever.

What once had been a gentle whisper was now a persistent, insistent pull. Sofia could even feel her core being subtly tugged at. She wasn't sure whether her improved magical sensitivity made her more attuned to the phenomenon or if the pull itself had genuinely grown stronger.

Regardless, she had no intention of heading toward the source of that call. The memory of what had happened last time was too raw. While she could accept putting herself at risk, endangering Kristoffer on a whim was out of the question. The guilt of Greg's fate lingered, and Sofia decided not to mention her unease to Kristoffer. She knew he would launch into a long lecture, overthink her condition, and worry excessively. She valued her bond with him and wanted their relationship to feel equal, not like he was a parental figure looking after her.

As they didn't have to do anything for Sofia to pass the exam, they spent their time wandering the forest, collecting herbs she needed for her research. Her busy life as a noble rarely allowed

for such excursions, and their bad experiences in the Sanctuary had kept them from returning since the incident with Greg. Tension hung heavy between them as they walked through the same trees where their guide had been brutally killed. Neither spoke of it, unwilling to reopen old wounds.

Kristoffer, for his part, had hoped for another glimpse of the dragon, but the beast did not reappear. During their wanderings, they encountered Rey and Krein, who mentioned that the chances of another sighting were slim. The hunters seemed preoccupied, shepherding clueless students through the forest, so their conversation was brief—limited to five minutes of gossiping and exchanging valuable information about the local flora and fauna.

As the sun dipped lower on the horizon, Sofia and Kristoffer began their daily meditation. The anomaly in the forest still pulled strongly at the surrounding mana, but their barriers held firm. Meditation had become a daily ritual for them, a tradition spanning nearly fifteen years. This quiet time together, surrounded by magic, was sacred. Some days, they sat in companionable silence; other times, they shared theories, discoveries, and ideas about magic.

Their approaches to magic couldn't have been more different. Sofia saw magic as an intrinsic part of nature, something she was innately connected to and could harness through intuition. Kristoffer, in contrast, viewed it as a precise science—an

intricate, endless set of equations that could yield perfection when solved correctly. This fundamental difference made their partnership so effective.

Sofia's intuitive grasp of magic allowed her to refine her techniques, while Kristoffer's analytical mindset uncovered the technical foundation of her instincts. Together, their contrasting approaches pushed both to new heights. Sofia deepened her connection to magic by understanding the mechanics behind what came naturally to her, while Kristoffer ventured into uncharted territory inspired by Sofia's unconventional relationship with mana.

Many of Sofia's methods—what she described as simply “trying things randomly”—challenged some of magic's fundamental theories. For Kristoffer, this created opportunities to explore concepts that conventional scholars hadn't dared to touch.

Sofia was an exceptionally unique type of caster. Kristoffer had spent years studying how she manipulated air. Unlike most mages, she bypassed traditional spell formulas and condensed her casting into a single rune—Wind. She dismissed learning complete sequences as “too tedious.” While her unorthodox style initially seemed reckless to Kristoffer, it ultimately led him to breakthroughs he hadn't been able to achieve on his own.

Kristoffer's initial goal had been to use Sofia's methods to gain insights into silent casting, but instead, her techniques helped him overcome a theoretical barrier he'd been stuck on for years.

The dense mana of the Sanctuary provided the perfect environment for testing his newfound ideas. Although the anomaly drew much of the mana toward its center, the forest still held an abundance of ambient energy—far more than the plains outside. By the third day, Kristoffer was determined to share his discovery with Sofia, though her frustration was growing after repeated failures to replicate his success.

“All I’m saying is that the theory was never disproven, Lady Sofia,” Kristoffer began, his voice calm but insistent. If one mana barrier can double your lifespan, a second layer could double it again. Yes, it’s exponentially harder to condense a second barrier on top of the first, but it’s not impossible. I’ve managed to maintain a thin ring for several minutes. Even if you don’t complete it, an unfinished barrier could still act as an extra mana battery for your spells.”

Sofia groaned, her patience wearing thin after yet another unsuccessful attempt. “It’s like trying to shape glass with metal gloves! How am I supposed to stack it on top? It feels impossible!” She waved her hand in exasperation, stirring a sudden gust of wind that sent leaves swirling around them.

“You just need to be patient, Lady Sofia. I’m sure you can do it,” Kristoffer replied encouragingly. “Think of it as fitting a smaller balloon inside a larger one without them touching. Or, for a simpler start, imagine putting a ring around a balloon without making contact. Remember how impossible it seemed when you

first worked on your barrier? You also said it was impossible, but repetition and patience—”

“FINE, ENOUGH,” Sofia interrupted, her tone sharp. “Go gather those sweet berries or something. I need to be alone for a bit. Let me connect with nature in peace.”

“As you wish, Lady Sofia,” Kristoffer replied with a slight bow before retreating deeper into the forest.

Once he was gone, Sofia knelt down and tried to focus. She took several deep breathes, once again extending her will to feel everything around her. Chirping birds, rustling leaves, the faint sound of the wood mouse running through dry branches. Together, they formed a symphony of wilderness.

Sofia let herself melt into the cacophony of nature. Soon, the surrounding mana stopped flowing around her body, and tried to pass through it instead. With deliberate effort, she extended her will, trying to harmonize with the nature surrounding her. She began processing the external mana, gently shaping it into a small ring around her core.

It was like trying to hold sand in an open hand, the grains constantly slipping between her fingers. Time lost meaning as she repeated the process over and over, each attempt slightly more refined. But just as she began to feel a flicker of progress, the balance shattered. Something had disturbed the natural rhythm around her.

“I almost had it, if you wouldn’t interrupt-” she complained while opening her eyes and paused immediately.

The tall figure that was approaching from between the trees was definitely not Kristoffer. Baron Valron and his friend were coming closer accompanied by their servants. She recognized the other boy as the son of Bayan Cosar, the company owner that had been in conflict with her father for the last few years. But she couldn’t recall the boy’s name.

“I apologize for interrupting your studies, Lady Sofia, but I have an important matter to discuss,” Baron Valron said, his sharp features twisting into a malicious smile.

Sofia rose quickly to her feet, her instincts on high alert. Something felt wrong—terribly wrong—and she had learned to trust her gut.

“I’m afraid I’m rather busy at the moment, Baron Valron. The upcoming exam demands my full attention. However, I’d be happy to speak with you after dinner or arrange a meeting at the garrison,” she replied smoothly, maintaining her composure. As she spoke, she brushed imaginary dirt from her clothes, ensuring her wand was still securely tucked inside her jacket.

“This won’t take long. Tell me, where is your servant? Did you abandon your little boy toy in the forest?” Valron sneered, his tone mocking. As he spoke, his companions began to spread out,

trying to appear nonchalant but clearly maneuvering to encircle her.

“He went to speak with Rey, the hunter. They should be back any minute. We were seeking advice about edible plants,” Sofia replied, fabricating a plausible story while inching toward a wide tree to put her back against it.

“It’s unbecoming of a noble to lie so blatantly,” Valron retorted, his smile growing nastier. “Rey and Krein are back at the camp tending to some poor soul who got impaled by cursed ivy. You’re quite alone, Lady Sofia.”

He gestured to his companion, who immediately pulled a small box from his backpack. Sofia’s senses prickled as the mana in the air shifted. She shot Valron an accusing glare.

“What is the meaning of this, Baron Valron?” she demanded, pulling out her wand.

“It’s a remarkable little item,” Valron replied with a wicked grin. “As long as the mana stone inside remains charged, no one outside this barrier will hear what happens here.” His expression darkened. “You can thank your father for this. We warned him repeatedly to keep out of our business, but he insisted on meddling. It’s not his place to decide how we run our company, or what we do with our product.”

“So, this is about revenge? How petty,” Sofia said through gritted teeth, her eyes darting to the four men now surrounding her. “I

thought using magic items in combat was beneath nobles, but it seems there's no depth you won't sink to. What do you think my father will do when he learns about this? You're only making things worse for yourself."

Valron smirked, brushing a hand through his hair. "He'll do nothing. All anyone will know is that a magic beast attacked a helpless noble girl. I have my orders, but I'm not a monster, Sofia." His tone turned almost mockingly gentle. "Answer my questions, and I'll treat you well. Who is your father working with? Who's his rat in the Tower and in our company?"

Sofia's heart raced as she realized there was no reasoning with him. Escape wasn't an option; they had her boxed in. The only path left was to fight, but her hand faltered. Attacking a magic beast in self-defense was one thing, but turning her spells on another human being? The thought made her stomach churn. For the past four years, she had dedicated herself to saving lives—not taking them.

"My father won't believe your story, Max," Sofia said, keeping her voice as calm and steady as she could. "This will only escalate the conflict further. Let's talk it through and try to solve it like adults. We need to stop this unending circle of hatred."

Valron chuckled darkly. "He doesn't need to believe it. Worst case, he'll lose his mind after losing his precious daughter. That'll give us a perfect excuse to have him locked up for the sake of public safety. Best case? He'll strike a deal with us to save you."

His smile widened, smug and assured. “Don’t worry, I won’t kill you. You carry the blood of the First Faculty; it would be such a waste. You’ll make a fine breeder for valuable heirs. Art,” he added, addressing his companion, “make sure she doesn’t try to run. We’ll deal with her servant later.”

“Stone bullet” The young man cast his spell without hesitation. Particles of earth coalesced, forming a sturdy projectile that shot toward Sofia’s leg with impressive speed.

To everyone’s surprise, she merely waved her hand. The rock struck a shimmering mana shield that materialized before her, dissipating harmlessly.

“Wind!” Sofia raised her wand, pointing it at her attacker.

Blades of air shot toward him, sharp and precise, but the servant accompanying him leapt in front of his master. Sofia gasped in horror as her spell slashed deep into the boy’s chest and arms, which he had raised to shield his vitals. Blood splattered onto the forest floor.

Before she could react, Valron’s massive servant took advantage of the moment, sneaking up behind her and swinging a thick branch into the side of her head. The impact was brutal. Sofia’s wand slipped from her grasp as she crumpled to the ground, the world spinning. Her ears rang, drowning out the chaos around her.

Through her blurred vision, she saw Max preparing another attack. A sharp stone spike hurtled toward her, cutting through the air with deadly intent. Acting on instinct, Sofia channeled mana into the ring on her finger, activating the shield engraved upon it. The barrier flared to life just in time, deflecting the spike.

But the onslaught didn't stop. Max cast another spell—a larger, heavier stone projectile. His servant stepped out of the line of fire, unwilling to get caught in the crossfire. With both mages attacking her from opposite sides, Sofia was forced onto the defensive. Spells rained down on her in rapid succession, leaving no opening for a counterattack.

Occasionally, their spells misfired—an evident sign of their growing exhaustion—but the window of opportunity was too narrow for Sofia to exploit. Blood trickled down her temple from the earlier blow, warm and sticky against her skin. She gritted her teeth, trying to calculate her next move.

She couldn't think of a spell powerful and fast enough to break through the relentless barrage. The two attackers coordinated seamlessly, clearly practiced at working together.

The ringing in her ears began to subside, sharpening her focus. Sofia realized she had to act before her mana reserves were completely drained. A risky plan formed in her mind.

If I take a hit instead of blocking it, I might have just enough time to use the other ring Kristoffer made for me.

The thought was terrifying. Using the spell on humans was a last resort, something she had sworn to avoid. But if she aimed carefully, it might incapacitate without killing. If she moved quickly enough, the enemy's attack might graze her side instead of causing serious harm. And if luck was on her side, a misfire might spare her entirely.

Sofia steeled herself for the gamble.

Max Valron prided himself on his abilities. Since the age of twelve, he had accompanied his father on hunts, honing his skills. When tasked with interrogating and capturing Sofia Elernes, he hadn't expected much of a challenge.

She was, after all, a peace-loving artist from a noble house. Max had dismissed her claims of fighting a spider mana beast as exaggerations or outright lies. Still, his father had drilled into him the importance of never underestimating an opponent, especially during a hunt.

That's why he hadn't come alone.

Arthur, the son of Bayan Cosar, was Max's chosen companion for the task. Arthur had proven himself capable on previous hunts and his father was a perfect decoy for their schemes. Additionally, they assembled a group of trusted men to intercept Sofia and carry her drugged, unconscious body back to camp after she was subdued. Anticipating some resistance due to her noble

heritage, Max had orchestrated a distraction to keep the hunters occupied, ensuring no interference.

Everything was planned meticulously. Yet, when they confronted her, things went awry.

Despite being surrounded, Sofia didn't cower or plead. Instead, she stood her ground, using silent casting to fend them off. Max had never seen anything like it. The youngest silent caster he had heard of was 35 years old. And yet, here was Sofia—barely half that age—wielding the art with stunning precision.

The fight dragged on, longer and more intense than Max had anticipated. He had already burned through more than half his mana reserves, and Arthur was faring even worse. Their exhaustion showed in their increasingly sloppy spells, which misfired as often as they hit their mark. But Sofia's determination didn't waver. The fierce resolve in her eyes made it clear: she would not go down easily.

Max realized brute force wouldn't work. He would have to change his approach. Deciding on a new strategy, he prepared a slower, more powerful spell—one that would end the fight decisively. It came at a cost. He'd have to sacrifice Arthur as a distraction, but to Max, it was a necessary trade. Victory was all that mattered.

Before he could enact his plan, something erupted from the shadows at an astonishing speed.

A blur of movement collided with Max's hulking servant. The massive man—a figure of brute strength and intimidation—was sent crashing to the ground. A sickening crack echoed through the clearing, halting all spells mid-cast.

Everyone froze, eyes fixed on the unmoving bulk of the servant's body.

Max stared in horror. His servant's head was crushed against the ground, the bloody remnants of bone and brain scattered grotesquely. Atop the lifeless form crouched a blood-drenched figure.

It was Sofia's servant.

Max's heart raced as their eyes met. The Lower Worlder's face was smeared with gore, fragments of bone and crimson streaking his skin. His dark blonde hair bristled, as if charged with static energy. But it wasn't the blood or the mess that sent chills down Max's spine—it was the look in the man's eyes.

Pure, unrelenting rage.

In all his years of hunting mana beasts, Max had never encountered a creature—or person—that radiated such palpable danger. The air grew unnaturally hot, heavy, and suffocating. The oppressive aura tightened around him, making it difficult to breathe.

Arthur, sensing the looming threat, broke into a desperate sprint.

“Piercing Missile.”

The Lower Worlde's voice was cold, sharp as the spell he cast. With a casual wave of his hand—without wand or catalyst—a spinning needle of mana materialized in the air. It hurtled forward, piercing Arthur's chest with lethal precision.

Arthur staggered. A gaping hole replaced his sternum, blood gushing as his body crumpled lifelessly to the ground. The missile didn't stop; it continued, tearing through a tree in its path before dissipating.

"Giant Stalagmite!"

Max seized the opening, unleashing the spell he had been constructing. The ground rumbled and cracked, shifting violently as a massive, jagged pillar of stone erupted in a straight line toward the Lower Worlde.

But the man moved with inhuman speed. In a blur, he scooped Sofia into his arms and leaped away just as the stone spike shot up where he had stood moments before.

Gently setting Sofia on the ground, he nudged the bleeding figure with his foot, checking for signs of life. Satisfied that the injured Lower Worlde was no longer a threat, his attention shifted entirely to Max Valron.

"Kristoffer..." Sofia murmured, her voice breaking.

"Please wait here, Lady Sofia," he said, his tone cold and steady, his eyes never leaving Max. "I will keep you safe."

Max sneered, though there was a flicker of unease in his expression. “You taught your dog magic, Elernes? You’ll hang for this. Seems like it was a waste of effort—”

His words were cut off as Kristoffer closed the distance between them in a blink. A single blow to the gut left Max gasping for air. He crumpled to the ground, helpless, his hands scrabbling at the dirt as the wand slipped from his grasp. Kristoffer loomed over him, picking up the fallen wand with unnerving calm.

“Who sent you?” Kristoffer asked curtly.

Max spat blood and glared, his words slurred from a bitten tongue. “As if I’d answer a Lower World dog like you.”

Kristoffer’s expression didn’t change. “Harden,” he said, channeling mana into the wand before driving it into Max’s thigh.

Max screamed, his voice raw with agony. The enchanted wood pierced his leg cleanly, slicing through bone like softened butter. Tears streamed down his face as he writhed in the dirt, staring in horror at the blood pooling beneath him.

“Who sent you?” Kristoffer repeated, his tone as icy as ever.

“N-no one!” Max stammered, desperation tainting his voice. “It— it was my idea—”

Kristoffer wasn’t convinced. Grabbing Max’s other leg, he hoisted it off the ground. His foot slammed down on Max’s knee with bone-crunching force.

“Kristoffer, stop!” Sofia screamed, rushing toward them. “Not like this. He’s not worth it!”

Max gasped, his pale face twisted in pain, but a glimmer of defiance remained. “You’ll regret this,” he hissed. “My father will take revenge. Do you want to put your precious master in danger? If you stop now, I might even—”

Another scream tore through the clearing as Kristoffer silenced him with a brutal twist of his leg, the knee shattering audibly.

“Kristoffer, I ORDER you to stop!” Sofia cried, grabbing his shoulder and pulling him back. “We are not like them! Don’t dirty your hands anymore.”

Kristoffer tried to shake her off, his body trembling with suppressed fury. Every fiber of his being screamed to end the man who had dared threaten his master’s life. But Sofia’s order resonated through his own source making him feel like a prisoner in his own body. The scar tissue on his arm—the mark of his servant’s bond—burned with searing heat. It was the first time Sofia’s authority had ever restrained him so completely, and the feeling of being powerless enraged him further.

“We cannot let him live, Lady Sofia,” he hissed through gritted teeth, straining against the invisible force that held him. “He’s the kind who will seek revenge. The moment you show mercy, he’ll sell you out. You’ll pay with your life. I promised your father I would protect you—I must honor that promise.”

Kristoffer poured magic into the scarred arm, forcing mana to override his body's unwillingness. Signals jolted through his nerves, and his muscles twitched under the strain. His fingers curled slightly, and his forearm jerked forward.

"No!" Sofia's voice rang out, and Kristoffer's body froze once more.

Her words cut through his resistance like a blade.

"You are my butler, not my father's," Sofia said firmly, though her voice trembled. "We will arrest him and make him confess everything. That's what the court is for. We are not animals."

Kristoffer looked down at the mutilated body of the crying Max Valron. He took a deep breath and faced his master's agitated expression. She was too good for this world—too principled, too trusting. That is why sometimes she was naïve. Her father knew it as well. That's why the day before they left for the academy, he humbly asked him to make sure she was safe. Not as an Upper Worlder, but as a father.

"Yes! Listen to her! Control your dog, and we can break this circle of hatred together!" Max gasped, his voice raw with desperation. He turned his bloodshot eyes toward Sofia, grasping at the sliver of hope her mercy offered. "I'm sure we can talk this out. If your father apologizes to mine, we could—"

Kristoffer remembered Lord Eduard's resolved eyes and reached to the very bottom of his source. That was the only place in his

body where he was not restricted by his master's orders. His senses were otherwise muted, restrained by Sofia's command, but the core of his being—the purest form of his mana—remained his own. He began condensing it, forcing it to build pressure, his entire body trembling under the strain. Sweat dripped from his brow as he focused every ounce of willpower on the task, letting the condensed energy explode violently and spread through his muscles and nerves.

The pain was excruciating, like molten steel coursing through his veins. Kristoffer managed a single step forward before his magic gave out entirely. His scarred arm fell limp, useless at his side. But he didn't falter. Reaching with his uninjured hand, he grasped the wand embedded in Max's leg and, with a swift motion, drove it straight into the nobleman's heart.

Max's words died in a strangled gasp. His eyes widened, frozen in disbelief as blood bubbled at his lips.

"Why?!" Sofia's anguished cry tore through the silence as she collapsed to her knees. Her voice cracked with despair, her hands trembling as tears streamed down her face. "Why would you do this? We're not like them."

Kristoffer pulled the wand free with a sickening squelch, meeting her tear-filled eyes with a calm, unwavering gaze. "You are not like them," he said quietly. His voice was steady, almost detached, as he stepped toward the fallen servant Sofia had injured earlier. "I am whatever I need to be to protect you, Lady

Sofia. This man would have ruined your life. I made a promise to your father to do whatever was necessary to keep you safe. That promise is my duty.”

Kristoffer crouched beside the fallen servant, pressing two fingers against the boy’s throat. No pulse. No breath. He was already gone.

His gaze flickered back to Sofia’s horror-stricken face. Resolving to play the villain until the very end, Kristoffer acted without hesitation. The last thing he wanted was for Sofia to carry the guilt of having taken a life. With a final, deliberate motion, he drove the wand into the boy’s lifeless heart.

“NO!”

Sofia’s scream cut through the stillness as she struck the ground, her sobs shaking her slender frame. But when she lifted her head again, grief had already twisted into something sharper.

“You’re supposed to listen to me,” she hissed, her voice shaking with fury.

Slowly, she pushed herself to her feet. Her hands clenched at her sides, shoulders rigid with outrage.

“I refuse to live by your or my father’s standards. The world I want to build can’t be forged with murder.” Her breath wavered, but she forced herself to keep going. “I will not tolerate a servant who defies my orders.”

Kristoffer held her gaze, reading the fury in her expression—the kind of rage that only came from betrayal. His body swayed slightly as the weight of his actions crashed down on him. The violence, the instinctual brutality—it had come too easily. He had acted without thinking, without hesitation. And now, he was facing the consequences.

The sight of her, standing before him with barely contained fury and something far worse—hurt—made his insides twist. The haze of combat, the cold certainty that had guided his hand, shattered in an instant. For the first time, he felt the depth of what he had done.

His knees hit the ground.

“I apologize, Lady Sofia,” he said, voice steady despite the turmoil inside. He bowed his head. “It will never happen again.”

Sofia’s emotions churned like a storm inside her. His words rang with sincerity, but that only made the situation harder to bear. She wanted to scream at him, to strike him, to collapse into his chest and cry all at once. What he’d done was unforgivable. It disgusted her. Yet, deep down, she knew there had been no other way.

Max Valron had seen too much. His knowledge of Kristoffer’s magic, his violent way of solving problems, and the fact that he wanted to make her his own breeding cow made him a threat. Letting him live would have jeopardized everything. And that

thought alone made her hate herself. It was not right. Murder could never be the right choice.

“You are not forgiven,” Sofia said finally, her voice thick with restrained emotion. “But we’ll postpone this discussion. Right now, we need to deal with this mess. We can’t blame magical beasts for this. Those wounds are obvious evidence of torture.”

Kristoffer rose to his feet, his demeanor composed as he surveyed the carnage. “Burning the bodies would be most effective,” he began, his voice clinical, “but the smoke and smell could draw attention. A combination of earth magic and acid would—”

“No,” Sofia cut him off sharply, her glare silencing him. “We’re not desecrating their corpses. We’ll bury them deep, seal the graves with earth magic to contain the smell. That’s how we’ll handle this.”

“As you wish, Lady Sofia,” Kristoffer replied. His voice was steady, devoid of argument, as he moved to prepare the area. He avoided her eyes, his expression unreadable.

As they began their grim work, a suffocating silence enveloped them. It was a silence thick with unspoken guilt, lingering anger, and the oppressive weight of their actions—a silence neither of them dared to break.

First exam

It took them half a day of gruesome work to clean up the scene. Words between them were sparse, and the heavy atmosphere could be cut with a knife. The more Sofia thought about what had happened, the deeper her unease grew. What Kristoffer had done wasn't something that could be easily forgiven—or forgotten.

Even after years, the nightmares still plagued her: haunting visions of Greg's agonized screams and his bloodied, melted face. That memory, the guilt she carried, and Kristoffer's permanently scarred arm had become the driving forces behind her meticulous study of medicine. Helping her mother had only solidified her resolve. Every living creature felt precious now, and the thought of lives being snuffed out unnecessarily weighed heavily on her. Sofia thought that she got used to Kristoffer's cold, pragmatic way of thinking, but she would never have believed him capable of taking things this far..

"Let's set up camp here," she finally said, interrupting the awkward silence that accompanied their evening walk. "We can head back to the camp tomorrow."

Kristoffer nodded silently, offering no objections.

Sofia used magic to construct a simple, earthy shelter. The compacted walls were sturdy enough to withstand the night,

though crude and unrefined. Without his magic, Kristoffer was unable to assist. When the shelter was finished, he quietly fashioned a makeshift bed for Sofia before stepping outside.

“I’ll keep watch,” he said, settling himself on the ground near the entrance.

From inside, Sofia didn’t respond. Instead, he heard her chanting softly, casting spells to warm and soften the floor. The quiet stretched endlessly into the night. Hours had passed since the incident. Kristoffer stared at his hands. They were clean. But they still felt stained.

Murder was not like him. Why had he done it? There had been other options—he could have used his speed to grab Sofia and flee. But in that moment, watching her under attack, an overwhelming and primal urge had seized him. To kill. To eliminate the threat. Was it his nature? His blood? Or did the master-servant contract force him to do it?

Faint, muffled sobs broke the stillness, drifting from within the shelter. Sofia was trying to conceal her cries, and Kristoffer, out of respect, pretended not to notice.

He thought of his mother—what would she say if she saw her son now? If she knew what he’d done—taking lives in cold blood?

His connection to mana flickered, like an ember struggling against the dark. Ever since defying Sofia’s command, the magic had been slipping from his grasp, unraveling from his core. He

looked at his lifeless arm and let out a bitter chuckle. Years of struggle, all for the chance to protect her... and when he finally did, when he dirtied his hands so she could live, all he saw in her eyes was disappointment.

That look—like he had become something vile, unworthy. It cut deeper than any wound.

Sadness and anger twisted violently inside him, a storm without anchor. Before he knew it, he had slammed his fist into the ground. Gravel tore into his knuckles, pain blooming sharp and hot—and only then did he realize he had done it with his ruined arm.

For a single breath, mana flared within him. A flicker of strength, wild and unshaped, before it slipped away and the arm fell limp again. The cold emptiness rushed back in.

What was that?

He didn't know what shocked him more—the brief return of magic, or the force of the emotions that had dragged it out of him. Rage. Grief. Desperation. He had never felt so raw, so exposed. As if the weight of his soul had been stripped bare under winter wind.

Leaning against the wall of the shelter, he let the chill of the ground seep into him, grounding him in the present.

Morning came quietly. Sofia greeted him with a soft, distant voice, her eyes shadowed and apathetic. Without a word, she used water and cleansing magic to help him refresh before they resumed their journey.

The forest enveloped them in its serene yet indifferent embrace. They wandered in silence, gathering herbs along the way. Sofia cast regeneration spells on the bruise on her temple at intervals throughout the day, and by sunset, it had nearly faded. Only a faint discoloration remained, easily concealed beneath her long hair.

By evening, they began heading toward the garrison, moving deliberately while daylight lingered. Neither of them spoke, their silence a fragile barrier against the weight of unspoken guilt and simmering tension.



“Sofie!” Katrina broke away from the group of chanting students as soon as she spotted Sofia. She sprinted toward her, arms wide, and wrapped her in a tight hug. “I was so worried! Erik

Garnez and the others told us how the mana beasts kept attacking them in the forest. You didn't come back for four days. I was so scared! You look awful—did something happen?"

Kristoffer noticed the subtle transformation in Sofia. Her sour, anguished expression was quickly replaced by the practiced facade of a noblewoman. She donned a tired but cheerful smile, masking her emotions behind a carefully crafted exterior.

"Nothing happened, Katie," Sofia replied softly, returning the hug with a weak smile. "I'm just a little tired. Living in the forest takes a toll, but we weren't attacked or anything." She pulled back and gave Katrina a faintly amused look. "How about you? Were you sleeping outside?"

"For two nights!" Katrina exclaimed, her face showing her displeasure at the thought alone. "It was cold and scary. There were all these weird noises coming from the forest, and I barely slept. Are you staying here tonight? We should eat together! I have so much to tell you about the people I'm studying with. Oh, and when you were gone commander Berian joined our garrison. You have to see how he talks with Rena. She treats him like he's a little boy!" Katrina giggled.

"That sounds great, Katie. What about Jens? Is he still with you?"

"He stuck around for the first two days, but then he joined the self-study group. He said the basics were too easy for him, so he was bored. But don't worry—he promised to come back for

dinner tonight, so he should show up soon. Come on, let's go get ready! You have to tell me what you've been up to!"

With their servants trailing behind, the two girls made their way to the garrison gate. Sofia couldn't help but notice the curious glances from the students training under Rena and Borgman's supervision. However, she was far too drained to give them much thought.

At the entrance, a guard stepped forward, clipboard in hand, and halted them.

"Please provide your names for registration," he said crisply.

The guard scanned his list before looking up. "Miss Elernes, you're cleared to stay until the end of the week. Miss Welder, you still need to spend one more night outside if you want to take the exam in three days. You may proceed."

Kristoffer moved to follow Sofia, but the guard raised a hand to stop him.

"Servants sleep in the tents outside," he explained firmly. "We don't have enough space in the garrison to accommodate everyone."

Sofia turned to Kristoffer, her face a mixture of contradicting emotions, but he gave her a reassuring nod.

"Carla, can you show me where we sleep?" he asked Katrina's servant, his tone steady.

“Sure thing,” Carla replied, scratching at the black spot under her eye with an awkward expression. “I forgot that you haven’t been here before, so you don’t know how it works.”

As Kristoffer followed Carla, he cast a quick glance back at Sofia. He was slightly uneasy about leaving her, but he knew this was for the best. Spending time with her peers would give her a chance to take her mind off the events of the previous day. She needed the distraction, and nothing worked better than catching up with a good friend.

“It’s crazy that you guys spent four days in the forest,” Carla said with a laugh. “You didn’t even come back to pick up your tent! Ours was squeezed between other nobles, and Lady Katrina was so scared, I had to hold her hand the whole night.”

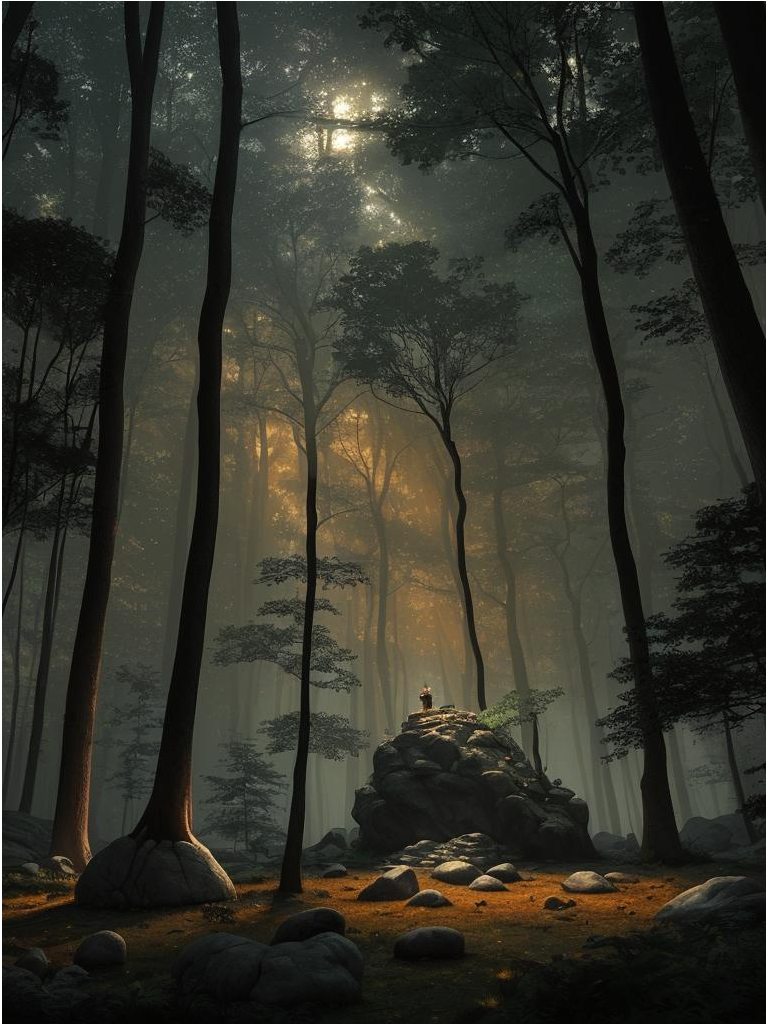
“Lady Sofia has limited patience. I think she just wanted to get out of here as quickly as possible,” Kristoffer replied with a faint smile. “Did the dragon stay for long?”

“Not really. I think it got bored after about five minutes,” Carla said with a shudder. “Still, those slit pupils... I get chills just thinking about them. Anyway, let’s eat first. I’ve got some bread and leftover pork from yesterday if you’re interested.”

“That sounds great. Thanks,” Kristoffer said, rubbing his tired eyes. “I think I’m hungrier than I am tired.”

Boost and Electrocute spells had taken their toll on his body, and with a sleepless night on top of it, Kristoffer was nearing his limit.

Carla led him to a tent not far from the others, grabbed her bag, and guided them to a small clearing surrounded by trees. At its center was a large rock, bathed in the warm orange glow of the setting sun. The serene atmosphere was almost magical. Carla noticed his limp arm and felt a flicker of curiosity about his injury but chose not to pry just yet.



“I like eating here,” she said as she passed him a wrapped sandwich before sitting comfortably on the rock. “It’s peaceful, and it reminds me of Razan. Though Razan had way more magical beasts.”

“Thank you,” Kristoffer said, accepting the sandwich and taking a bite. “This is delicious. Wasn’t Razan your second village?”

“Yeah, but I have more memories from there,” Carla replied, sentimentally looking up the sky. “I was really young when our first home burned down. If the Inquisition hadn’t kidnapped me, I probably would’ve spent my whole life in Razan.”

She paused, then asked hesitantly, “I’ve heard the rumors, but I never asked you directly. You don’t have to answer if you don’t want to. Were you really born here?”

Kristoffer sighed, taking another bite of the sandwich. “Ana is such a blabbermouth. I can’t believe I was worrying about her earlier. Well, not like the truth is worse than the rumors. Yes, I was born here.”

“You didn’t have to put it like that,” Carla said with a slight frown. “I’m not going to tell anyone. I thought we knew each other well enough by now for you to trust me a little.”

“It’s not that I don’t trust you,” Kristoffer said, his tone softening. “I’m just worried about how rumors might affect Lady Sofia’s image. It’s not like Elernes family wants to lie about it, but some topics are better left untouched. If anything, I trust you almost as much as Lisa. I feel at ease when Lady Sofia is visiting Lady Katrina because I know you’re there. You’ve got a good head on your shoulders.”

“Doesn’t everybody?” Carla joked dryly before grinning. “Still, I’m a little jealous. You don’t have a place or family to miss while you’re living up here. Wait—does that mean you weren’t sterilized like the rest of us?”

Kristoffer shrugged, finishing the sandwich and licking his fingers. “Honestly, I have no idea. I was just a baby when the contract was made, and no one’s ever told me anything about it. Do you know where can I get a tent? I’d like to set it up while there is still some daylight left.”

“Well, if you want, you can sleep in my tent,” Carla offered with a playful smile. “It’s already late and you are tired. I don’t bite. Well, unless you want me to.”

Kristoffer met her alluring smirk with a raised eyebrow. He was never sure if she was joking or not. Over the last three years, he’d seen Carla on numerous occasions and had grown to like the girl a lot. She was smart, funny and reliable. Their bond felt refreshingly natural, untainted by magical contracts or noble obligations. It was honest and simple—just two people who enjoyed each other’s company. It was not complicated. It should never be.

“I was looking for you,” a male voice called out suddenly, breaking the moment. A figure stepped out from between the trees. “Duke Garnez wants to see you.”

Kristoffer squinted, recognizing the Lower Worlder as a servant of one of the usual lackeys who hovered around the duke's son. He couldn't pinpoint exactly who it was, but he could smell the trouble.

"I'm honored by the Duke's interest," Kristoffer replied calmly, "but I am a servant of Lady Sofia of House Elernes. If the Duke wishes to speak with me, he should consult it with my master first."

The man's expression soured, his tone turning sharp. "You might not know this, since the Elernes family has always been poor at providing proper education, but Duke Garnez's status is far above your master's. His orders are of higher importance."

Kristoffer's voice remained steady. "Then we find ourselves at an impasse. Because to me, Lady Sofia's word is even more important than the headmaster's."

"You'll regret this," the servant snapped before spinning on his heel and disappearing back into the trees.

Kristoffer sighed, too weary from the events of the past few days to muster any anger. He shook his head, but Carla's reaction drew his attention. She was glaring after the retreating figure, narrowing her eyes in displeasure. Without a word, she reached for Kristoffer's hand.

"Let's go before this escalates," she said.

They started back toward her tent, but as they emerged into the open field, Kristoffer's unease turned into grim certainty. A group of figures was waiting for them.

"How preposterous," Erik Garnez spoke sharply, stepping forward with an air of theatrical irritation. "A Lower Worlder made me come to him. Look how much you angered Daniel's servant. He's fuming."

Kristoffer's unwelcome visitor from earlier was among them, his face twisted with hostility. The man stepped forward, his eyes showing the violent intentions.

"Carla, run," Kristoffer whispered, nudging her gently.

She hesitated, her eyes darting between Kristoffer and the group. But when she saw his determination, she nodded and bolted toward the gates. Kristoffer observed the group's reaction, but thankfully, no one moved to follow Carla.

The first punch came without warning, landing squarely on Kristoffer's face. He fell to the ground, bracing himself mentally for the next blow. A kick to the stomach followed shortly after, taking the air out of him. Kristoffer clenched his teeth, summoning every ounce of restraint to suppress the instinct to retaliate. The last thing he wanted was to give Erik Garnez or his cronies any excuse to twist this into an offense against House Elernes.

“Ben, that’s enough,” Erik said lazily, a smug grin tugging at his lips. “I just wanted to have a civilized conversation. You’ve been gone for a while, and since I’ll be spending the night in the woods, I won’t have a chance to speak with Sofia until tomorrow. I’m just worried about her and wanted to hear how she did during those long days in the forest.”

Kristoffer wiped the blood from his lip, his voice calm despite the pain. “I’m sure Lady Sofia will be more than willing to satisfy your curiosity tomorrow, Lord Garnez. As Ben kindly pointed out before, I am uneducated and unfit to speak on her behalf.”

The words had barely left his mouth when another kick landed against his ribs, knocking the breath from his lungs again. Kristoffer’s only functional arm instinctively moved to shield his torso. Ben was taller and heavier than him, so his blows were nothing to laugh at. Erik Garnez watched with a faint smirk, his aristocratic indifference making it clear that this was all just sport to him.

“If you want to be a loyal dog,” Erik started, stepping closer and staring down at Kristoffer, “then answer properly. Otherwise, you risk damaging the relationship between the Elnes and Garnez families. You wouldn’t want to make life harder for your master, would you? All I’m asking is how she did. Was it a productive study session?”

Kristoffer struggled to speak, his voice barely a whisper as he fought for breath. “I wouldn’t know, Lord Garnez. Lady Sofia

doesn't discuss her studies with me, since my small brain can't understand what she is talking about anyway."

Before Kristoffer could recover, Ben's boot connected with the side of his head, sending him rolling. Kristoffer's vision blurred, and the world tilted as pain overwhelmed him.

"Stop this immediately!"

A sharp voice cut through the air. One of the professors, accompanied by a breathless Carla, was sprinting toward them. The man's expression was a mix of outrage and disdain.

"Dirty Lower Worlders!" the professor snapped, his voice sharp with scorn. "How dare you bring your ape-like behavior here? The last thing we need is for our students to be infected by your violent tendencies. Both of you—follow me to the holding cells now, or I'll eliminate you where you stand."

Ben raised his hands, showing that he had no bad intentions. The bloodied Kristoffer was lying on the ground and struggling to get up.

"The professor's glare didn't waver. "What did you do to him?"

"He provoked me," Ben recited with feigned remorse. "I lost my temper, but I regret my actions. I'm ready to do whatever is necessary to make amends."

"Pick him up and carry him," the professor ordered coldly. "All of you—go to the garrison to provide a full report on this incident."

Carla hovered nearby, her face pale with worry as she followed the group. Ben, still playing the part of a remorseful aggressor, hauled Kristoffer's limp body onto his shoulder.

Once the group had left, Erik Garnez stood alone with his entourage, his face settling into an ugly sneer. "Sofia has herself a loyal dog," he muttered disdainfully. "Your servant did well, Daniel. As promised, you can have Nina for the entire night. Just make sure she can walk and speak tomorrow—I'll need her to testify."

Daniel straightened, his tone servile as he replied, "I'm honored to be of service, my lord. Thank you for your generosity." He bowed deeply, excited for sharing a woman with the son of Duke Garnez.

Erik exhaled sharply, irritation flickering in his expression. "I'm annoyed now. Let's get some drinks to take the edge off while Daniel entertains himself with my slave."

The group responded with a chorus of cheers, their laughter echoing through the darkening forest as they departed.

When Sofia opened her eyes, it took her a moment to understand why Katrina's sleeping face was the first thing she saw. As her mind slowly caught up, the memories of the previous evening came flooding back. Lavish food, multiple glasses of wine, Jens joining them with his usual cheerful demeanor, and even more

alcohol. Sofia had managed to forget some of the struggles of the previous days, but when she returned to her room, the feelings of loneliness and fear crept back in. Emboldened by the wine coursing through her veins, she'd knocked on Katrina's door. They ended up talking late into the night before falling asleep cuddled together.

Sofia rose carefully, trying her best not to wake her friend. She slipped out of the room, suppressing a groan as her head throbbed from the hangover. After a refreshing shower, the headache dulled to a manageable level. Hoping breakfast would help her recover further, she made her way to the dining area.

Sitting at the table, Sofia nibbled absentmindedly at her food, her thoughts wandering far from the present. Last night's time with her friends had felt like a much-needed reset. Surrounded by people she trusted, she had found the mental clarity to reassess the events of the past few days.

She thought about Kristoffer. She had known him her whole life, but she couldn't reconcile his actions yesterday with the man she knew. Never before had she seen him act in such an uncalculated way. Sofia frowned, letting her thoughts spiral deeper. Why had he killed all those people? What was going through his mind?

Kristoffer was nothing if not methodical, and Sofia knew that understanding his actions meant dissecting them logically, like a problem to be solved. His highest priority had always been her

safety—this much she knew without a doubt. Whenever she was in even the slightest danger, his first instinct was to ensure her well-being.

So why had he fought that group of people instead of simply escaping with her? It didn't align with his usual behavior. Was it because he thought they intended to harm her? From his perspective, it might have seemed like they wanted to kill her. Could he have acted on emotion?

Sofia shook her head at the thought. Kristoffer, acting on emotion? Impossible. This was the same person who once claimed hunger was an emotion. He was too cool-headed to lose control like that. Then was it her father's order? No, that didn't make sense either. Kristoffer would never prioritize her father's command over her safety. Even if, by some miracle, his loyalty shifted, the master-servant contract would have prevented it.

Wait—the contract. Sofia's eyes widened slightly as her mind honed in on this possibility. She didn't know much about the magic behind master-servant contracts. It was forbidden knowledge, accessible only to those with high-ranking titles. But she knew the basics. The contract was designed to prevent betrayal and suppress violent tendencies, especially since Lower Worlders were statistically more prone to aggression.

Still, there had to be more to it than what was common knowledge. Sofia leaned back in her chair, replaying the events in her mind. When she'd ordered Kristoffer to stop, he had frozen in

his tracks. Could her words really have such a powerful effect on him? What if the contract didn't just limit his actions but shaped his personality for her sake?

Her breath caught as another thought struck her. When she was a child, she had ordered Kristoffer to teach her magic. Could that be why he had become such an obsessive bookworm? Had she unwittingly stripped him of his free will? If that were true, what could she possibly do about it?

"Hi, Kristoffer," she imagined herself saying. "I might have completely altered your personality and destroyed your life. Sorry about that." The absurdity of the thought made her head spin.

Her spiraling thoughts were abruptly interrupted by a voice.

"Professor Rena wants to see you."

Sofia looked up to see a staff member standing by her table. She recognized him as the one from the gate yesterday.

"Once you've finished your breakfast, head to the official meeting room," he added brusquely. "It's at the end of the corridor."

Without waiting for a response, he turned and left, leaving Sofia alone with her spiraling thoughts.

She barely had time to process what had just happened. The summons sounded ominous, but she couldn't pinpoint the reason. The nobles had been drinking last night, and though things got a bit rowdy, it wasn't anything unusual. Was it

something else? Had they overlooked evidence of the battle with Valron? She and Kristoffer had painstakingly ensured everything was cleaned up, but the possibility of missing something nagged at her.

Stress churned in her stomach, and any hope of finishing breakfast disappeared. Giving up on the meal, Sofia stood and marched to the meeting room. She hesitated briefly before knocking lightly on the heavy wooden door.

“Come in,” a voice called from inside.

The space was familiar, almost identical to the one where she had first met Commander Berian. He sat behind a sturdy desk, but this time, he wasn’t alone. Professor Rena was seated beside him, her sharp gaze cutting through the air.

“Good morning. Sit down, Miss Elernes,” Rena said, gesturing toward the chair across the desk.

Sofia nodded at Berian’s quiet greeting and took her seat. The atmosphere was tense, and the weight of the situation settled heavily on her chest.

“Lady Sofia, I—” Berian began, but Rena cut him off with a raised hand.

“We called you here because of your servant, Miss Elernes,” Rena said coldly. “Last night, he committed the unforgivable act of engaging in a violent fight with another Lower Worlder in the presence of nobility. Both are currently imprisoned in the

isolation chambers, which means you will be without his assistance for the remainder of the exam.”

Sofia’s stomach tightened.

“Duke Garnez has made a sizable donation to the Tower to resolve this matter,” Rena continued, her tone unyielding. “He was understandably traumatized by the incident. In recognition of his goodwill, we have agreed to release the prisoners after they spend two days in isolation reflecting on their actions. Were it not for his benevolence, your servant could very well have faced execution. It would be wise to apologize to Lord Erik Garnez for the disgraceful behavior of your ill-trained attendant.”

Sofia’s mind raced, piecing together fragments of the puzzle. She couldn’t believe Kristoffer would instigate a fight without reason. But what if Erik Garnez had provoked him? She remembered Kristoffer’s terrifying expression when he had crushed the skull of the Lower Worlder who attacked her. He was more than capable of violence when it came to protecting her.

But what had happened this time?

They hadn’t spoken about the incident yet, and an awkward tension hung between them. She hadn’t even asked about his magic or his limp arm, and their relationship felt strained—frayed in a way it had never been before. Still, after all these years, Sofia couldn’t imagine her life without him. They needed to work through it together. She wasn’t ready to give up on him.

“May I speak with my servant?” Sofia asked, striving to keep her voice steady despite the tremor she felt. “I’d like to hear his account of the situation.”

“You may do so after his time in the isolation chamber,” Rena replied without a hint of empathy. “He must first reflect on his actions. We already have reports from reliable members of the nobility. I fail to see how his perspective would add any value.”

The professor’s words stung, but Sofia refused to let it show.

“You are dismissed, Miss Elernes,” Rena added curtly.

Sofia rose slowly, suppressing the storm of emotions threatening to break free. She nodded curtly and exited the room, her mind clouded with unanswered questions. She clenched her fists, trying to contain her anger. Sofia knew Rena Karlton was a strong supporter of the noble faction, but deep down, Sofia had hoped that as a professor of the University of the Abyss, the woman would uphold fairness for all students.

Berian’s sad eyes followed her as she left, and Sofia could feel his silent apology hanging in the air. But staying any longer would have been dangerous—her patience was nearing its breaking point. The tightness in her chest was almost unbearable as she stepped outside, hoping that the fresh air might clear her mind.

The sun hung high in the sky, its rays illuminating the bustling activity around the garrison. Students and soldiers moved purposefully, their chatter blending into the background. Sofia

took a deep breath and headed toward the woods, seeking the sanctuary of solitude. Since her arrival yesterday, she couldn't shake the feeling that many students were watching her, their gazes heavy with curiosity or judgment.

Before she could reach the treeline, a voice halted her in her tracks.

"Good to see you in good health, Sofia. I was starting to worry that the mana beasts had gotten the better of you," Erik Garnez said smoothly, his handsome face twisting into a mocking smile. It was fleeting, but long enough to make her blood boil. "Yesterday was most unfortunate. Who would have thought that the famous Lower World lovers were raising such violent servants?"

Sofia's jaw tightened. She knew he was trying to provoke her, but the knowledge wasn't always enough to stop emotions from running wild. Too many things had piled up. First, she was almost kidnapped. Then, she had to dispose of massacred bodies, which was much more disgusting than she could have imagined. The hangover and the huge information overflow were the top of the iceberg, and now this smug smile from Erik Garnez was the cherry on the top.

Before she realized it, she had stepped toward him, the mana around her swirling dangerously. Erik's eyes widened briefly in surprise, but he quickly regained his composure, his gaze steady and watchful.

Sofia glared at him, her fury blazing as she raised her hand. But just as she was about to act, a firm hand settled on her shoulder.

“Sorry to interrupt, Lady Sofia, but I need a moment of your time,” Commander Berian said, his calm voice cutting through her rage.

The fire inside her faded away as she turned to face him. His worried expression softened the storm in her chest, and her body slumped in exhaustion.

“Yes... let’s do that,” she whispered hoarsely, nodding.

Berian gestured for her to follow, and she did, ignoring Erik’s parting remark:

“I hope we can finish our conversation later, Sofia!”

With every step, Sofia felt herself growing heavier. Her mind was a blur, her limbs leaden, and she barely registered where they were going. She simply followed Berian’s broad back, her feet moving on autopilot.

Eventually, he stopped in front of a door, opened it, and ushered her inside. After stepping in behind her, he closed the door and locked it securely.

“We should be safe here,” Berian said gently. “That was close, Lady Sofia. You need to—”

His words faltered as Sofia leaned against his chest, her body trembling.

Then, the dam broke.

She began to sob, tears streaming freely as all the emotions she had bottled up came flooding out. The sense of safety Berian's presence offered shattered the last of her resolve.

Caught off guard, Berian hesitated for a moment before gently rubbing her back. He held her without a word, allowing her to release everything she had been holding inside.

"I don't know if I can do it, Berian," Sofia whispered, her voice fragile as she quieted down. "It's just too much. I feel trapped from every direction."

"I'm sorry I couldn't be of more help back there," Berian replied, his tone heavy with regret. "The Tower controls everything here. One wrong word and they would destroy lives of all the men working under me. I know it is a poor excuse, but with every action I take I must think not only of myself, but also of all the people I am responsible for."

I understand, Berian. You don't need to explain yourself," Sofia said softly, wiping her tear-streaked face with her sleeve. "My parents trust you, and so do I. I need you to pass a message to my father. I can't reach him until the end of the month, and this can't wait. Max Valron and Cosar's son tried to kidnap me. They wanted to interrogate me about my father's actions. Tell him I'm safe, but he needs to take steps to protect our family. My parents could become targets in retaliation. And make it clear—I'm not leaving the academy because of this."

“Kidnap you? Retaliation?” Berian stared at her in disbelief.
“What exactly happened?”

“They came with their servants and ambushed me,” Sofia explained, her voice trembling. “Max Valron admitted it was revenge for my father’s legal measures against their business. I tried to resolve it peacefully, but it was impossible. They wanted information, but when I refused, it ended in bloodshed. None of them survived... I had to hide the evidence to protect my family.”

Berian’s sharp gaze stayed fixed on her as she recounted the events. Sofia felt as if a heavy burden was taken off her chest, glad to be able to share it with somebody else she trusted. She told him about the sound-blocking magic item, Max Valron’s words, and the aftermath of the fight.

“But how did you survive that?” Berian asked, his tone edged with astonishment. “I’ve seen Baron Valron’s hunts. His son was a highly skilled fighter. With three others assisting him, even a seasoned mage would struggle.”

“What I’m about to tell you is a family secret,” Sofia said, taking a deep breath to steel herself. “I’m sharing this only because of how highly my mother speaks of you. I trust you’ll keep this to yourself.” She hesitated, then continued, “Kristoffer helped me. He is very skilled with magic and used the element of surprise to reduce their numbers. And after meeting Garnez, I’m certain he arranged Kristoffer’s imprisonment. Berian, I need you to check on him. I’m worried about what they might have done to him.

Garnez hunts Lower Worlders for sport. I wouldn't put it past him to do something... unspeakable."

Berian listened, his expression a mixture of disbelief and dawning realization. Sofia could see the gears turning in his mind as he connected the dots—Kristoffer's interest in mana rifts, the spider incident, the way he observed the duel with Duke Ralezo.

"I will check on him for you," he said at last. "But you need to stay calm and act rationally. Go to your room and compose yourself. Don't let anyone provoke you again. As for your father, I won't send a letter right now—it's too risky. I'll be leaving this garrison soon, and I'll deliver the message to him personally."

Berian's calm, measured tone reminded Sofia of Kristoffer and soothed her anxiety.

"Alright," she agreed, managing a weak smile. "Be prepared—Kristoffer can be extremely distrustful. By telling you all this, I've trusted you with my life and my family's future. I hope I'm as good at judging characters as I think I'm."

Berian knelt and bowed solemnly. "I'll take your secrets to the grave, Lady Sofia. Your mother saved my life more than once. This is the least I can do for you."

Sofia felt her energy returning. Though she'd been on the brink of breaking just moments before, Berian had provided her the safe space she needed to regain her stability. Clenching her fists, she

headed to her room with renewed determination, ready to meditate and to devise a new plan for her future at the academy.

Complete silence. That was the first thing Kristoffer noticed as he regained consciousness. The place he found himself in was pitch dark. The last thing he remembered was being carried by the servant who had beaten him. With every breath his chest filled with piercing pain.

Slowly, Kristoffer reached out with his uninjured arm, his fingers brushing against cold, unyielding walls. He began to crawl, moving tentatively as he mapped out the confines of his prison. It was a tiny, claustrophobic space—not even large enough for him to stretch out fully.

He knelt down, closing his eyes and sharpening his senses, hoping to learn anything about where he was. It was no use. The eerie silence and pitch-black darkness distorted his sense of time. Desperate for some measure, Kristoffer began counting seconds. But his efforts were short-lived. A splitting headache forced him to stop after barely a minute. Reaching up, he felt wetness in his hair and grimaced.

Kristoffer exhaled shakily, the realization settling over him: he had been here for quite some time already. The poison in his body—the same toxin that had lingered since the spider incident—was undoubtedly wreaking havoc on him. Though the

venom had weakened over the years, it remained potent enough to kill him if left untreated. Under normal circumstances, he would use healing magic before the internal damage became too severe. But now, without access to magic, the toxins were running wild in his bloodstream.

“Damn it,” he rasped, his voice dry and raw with thirst. Each word felt like sandpaper scraping against his throat. His body ached from injury and exhaustion. Swallowing hard, Kristoffer forced himself to focus, desperate to find even the faintest spark to magic.

Nothing.

He tried anger next, letting memories of what had happened ignite his veins. Still, there was no response. His mana remained silent.

The connection was gone.

A vital part of his being felt severed, leaving him hollow. Powerless. The rising tide of panic threatened to overwhelm him, and he clenched his fists tightly to keep it at bay. He forced himself to take slow, measured breaths. Think. Analyze. Survive.

Yet, since losing magic, something strange had begun to happen—he felt... different. The world appeared sharper, clearer, though its clarity carried no comfort. For the first time in years, he couldn’t hear the soft, sinister whisper of the void. That dark voice had been his constant companion—muted over the years,

yes, but never truly gone. Since arriving at the sanctuary, its presence had only grown stronger, suffocating him. Now it was silent, completely and utterly silent. It was a strange, sweet blessing. But that was the only bright side to his predicament.

The physical pain, dire as it was, paled in comparison to the emotional toll he now faced. Kristoffer felt suffocated, not by the tiny space around him but by the weight of his own existence.

To the Lower Worlders, the people he had grown up with, he was a traitor—a heretic—for his friendship with Sofia. They spoke of the Upper Worlders as gods, divine beings who deserved unquestioning reverence. Kristoffer had never subscribed to that belief, but he had also never been accepted by them. And to the Upper Worlders themselves, he was nothing more than an insect—a tool to be used, discarded, or ignored.

An outsider. Kristoffer belonged nowhere.

And then there was Sofia.

For years, he had cherished their bond, clinging to it as proof of something real—something built on trust, shared companionship, and mutual respect. Now he saw it for what it truly was. A curse. A contract. Forged when he was too young to understand its consequences. It bound him to her, twisting his will and making him vulnerable to her words, her commands, her desires.

The revelation was as cruel as it was shattering.

The love he thought he had for Sofia—his admiration, his devotion—was now uncertain. How much of it had been real? How much of it had been forced upon him by their master-servant contract? He couldn't tell.

And yet, the curse's influence fading had opened his eyes. Since losing his magic after the battle, Kristoffer noticed for the first time that Sofia had... flaws. It was as if he'd opened his eyes after 18 years of blindness. Her recklessness, indecision, and occasional frivolity had always been there, yet under the influence of the curse, he had accepted—even adored—those traits. Now, they filled him with frustration.

But his anger wasn't truly directed at Sofia.

It was the sheer unfairness of it all. She hadn't chosen to bind him with this curse, yet as long as he remained by her side, his autonomy would never be his own. They could never have anything more than a master-slave relationship. His will would always bend unconsciously to hers, making him a mindless pet.

And yet, despite it all, he loved her.

Kristoffer's love for Sofia was a raw, conflicted thing. How much of it was real, and how much was the curse? He didn't know. But the feeling burned in his chest, undeniable and persistent. He knew the logical choice was to walk away, to break free from her entirely. Yet he couldn't. Not when Sofia's life was in danger.

Someone was after her, and for as long as she needed him, Kristoffer would endure.

But that loyalty came at a price. Helping Sofia could strengthen the curse—could tighten the chains that bound him to her. He had already experienced the consequences. During the last attack, he had lost all control. The curse compelled him to kill those who threatened his master, even as Sofia's orders battled against it. It had ripped his will apart, and the magic he had used to resist her command had left him completely severed from his power.

Now, with his body battered, his left arm useless, and his connection to magic shattered, Kristoffer was more a burden than an ally.

But another, darker worry gnawed at him—his mother.

Though his father had been monstrously cruel to her, she spoke of him with love, excusing his actions as if they weren't truly his fault. Now, Kristoffer could see the truth: it had to be the curse's influence. The blind, unwavering devotion the Lower Worlders felt toward the Upper Worlders—he suspected it was rooted in the same dark magic that bound him to Sofia.

He wrestled with the idea of telling his mother about the curse, but the thought filled him with dread. What would happen if she realized the full extent of what she had endured? Would it break

her completely? Would it shatter the fragile reality she had built for herself?

The thought led him to a troubling theory: perhaps the curse had a stronger effect on others. He was almost certain that if he shared everything he'd learned about it with his mother, she would likely call him crazy, perhaps even react with hostility. Maybe his version of the curse was milder because he'd had it from birth. Or perhaps learning magic at an early age had granted him some resistance.

His spiraling thoughts were interrupted by a harsh, pressing need.

Kristoffer's bladder forced him to focus on his immediate situation. He hadn't considered the reality of such needs before. Desperately, he crawled around the cramped cell, feeling for anything that might serve as a bucket or even a hole in the floor. There was nothing.

Kristoffer surrendered and reluctantly picked a corner to do the deed. The smell of urine and blood filled the small compartment, making him feel sick.

Suddenly, the sharp click of the door unlocking jolted him.

He shielded his eyes as blinding light spilled into the room. A rush of fresh air followed, cutting through the suffocating stench.

"Waterball" a familiar voice said.

The door closed again, and the worst of the smell dissipated.

“Light Orb.”

Kristoffer squinted up at the orb of dim light now floating overhead. Above it, he recognized Commander Berian’s stern face. The man looked exhausted, but his eyes remained as sharp as ever.

“Lady Sofia sent me to check on you,” Berian said, his tone steady. “And I’m glad she did because, frankly, you look like shit. Let me see your injuries.”

Kristoffer tried to respond, but his cracked lips and parched throat made speech impossible. He nodded weakly instead.

Berian crouched beside him, his expression softening as he inspected Kristoffer’s wounds. Gently, he probed the side of Kristoffer’s head before examining his chest. The light orb brightened slightly, revealing the extent of the injuries.

“Looks worse than I expected,” Berian muttered, his brow furrowed. “I’m no expert in healing magic, and getting you a doctor here isn’t an option. Sofia told me you can use magic. Any chance you know how to patch yourself up?” His tone was worried but direct.

Kristoffer stared back, his expression unreadable as he weighed the risks of trusting Berian. The Elernes family clearly trusted the commander, but not enough to share this particular secret until now. What if Garnez have coerced him somehow? Kristoffer’s mind raced. Erik Garnez already suspected something had

happened in the woods. What if he had threatened Berian to ensure his cooperation?

“I don’t know what you’re talking about,” Kristoffer replied weakly, his numb tongue slurring the words.

Berian sighed, frustration flickering across his face. “Sofia also mentioned you might be difficult to work with. Fine, we’ll do it the hard way.”

Before Kristoffer could react, Berian placed a firm hand on his chest. In an instant, his connection to magic reignited, flooding his senses with the vibrant glow of mana. But just as Kristoffer began to appreciate the overwhelming beauty of it, Berian’s consciousness surged into his core, like a tidal wave drowning his defenses.

Panic set in as Kristoffer scrambled to force the commander out, hastily rebuilding the barrier around his core. The clash of wills didn’t last long. With his years of experience, Berian overwhelmed him almost instantly. For the first time, someone other than Sofia had breached Kristoffer’s source, and it terrified him. The commander’s presence gripped his very essence.

“Impressive,” Berian remarked, withdrawing his hand. “But your source is severely damaged. I’ve temporarily forced your magic to circulate by pressurizing and decompressing it a few times, but I don’t know how long this will hold. You should consult Lady Isabelle. When it comes to core fissures, there’s no one better.”

Kristoffer's mind reeled, but Berian continued calmly, "Now, rebuild your barriers. I'm going to test how stable the connection is."

Berian didn't hesitate for a moment. Though Kristoffer hadn't fully recovered from the first attack, his instinct kicked in. He raised the barrier around his core and used what little mana remained to twitch his injured hand. Before he could make another move, Berian's will struck again.

The first push didn't break through, but it left Kristoffer frozen. He reinforced his defenses, bracing for more. Berian attacked relentlessly, probing for weaknesses with surgical precision. The strikes came from multiple directions, overwhelming Kristoffer. His barrier began to crack, and before he could recover, the commander pressed against his core once more.

"Looks stable enough for now," Berian said, pulling back. "But you should consult it before it gets worse. Your barrier is impressive—better than most mages I've faced—but it's too polished for someone untrained. If anyone inspects you closely, your secret will come out. Even if you lower your defenses intentionally, your core's compression will raise questions. And there's something... strange about your source. Unfamiliar."

He paused, his sharp gaze landing on Kristoffer's injured arm. "And what's with your arm? Are you using magic to move it?"

Kristoffer stared at him in stunned silence, his mind racing. His defenses were built exactly as described in the book, but Berian broke through them in mere seconds. What was lacking? He followed the instructions point by point...

"You look confused," Berian said softly, his voice gentle but firm.

"I'm not your enemy. Ask me anything—I'll do my best to answer."

"How did you break through my barrier so easily?" Kristoffer mumbled, his voice tinged with disbelief.

Berian paused for a moment, then let out a hearty laugh.

"That's your first question?" Berian chuckled, shaking his head.

"You're an odd one. Just like the first time when you started interrogating me about the mana rifts. Still, I promised to answer, so I will. Though, we have bigger issues at the moment."

He took a deep breath before continuing. "You are still young and inexperienced. From what I can tell, you are trying to reject a part of yourself—and that creates weaknesses in your defenses. Magic is directly tied to your willpower. If you want to become stronger, you need to understand yourself fully and accept all parts—good and bad. Only then can you achieve real growth. Incidentally, it's common for a mage's personality to align with their mana type. What element do you specialize in?"

"My natural mana frequency favors fire," Kristoffer replied quietly.

"But I don't use it... for personal reasons."

“There’s your answer,” Berian said, nodding knowingly. “You reject your own element. Naturally your defenses will be weak. Now, about your arm—I could feel mana flowing through it. What’s going on?”

Kristoffer sighed and clenched his left fist a few times, letting Berian sense the mana flow through their connection. “A mage-killer spider damaged it severely. I’m using a blend of enhancement magic to control the tendons and muscles.”

“At all times?” Berian’s eyes widened as he leaned in to examine the arm more closely. “How is that even possible?”

“At first, I used mana to transmit signals between the severed nerve cells,” Kristoffer explained, his tone matter-of-fact. “Over time, the process became more subconscious, so I started focusing on increasing the muscle capacity and improving the tissue regeneration during training. It is not perfect, I still struggle with tasks that require fine dexterity. I avoid using this hand for delicate work, like transcribing runes.”

Berian stared at him in disbelief, as if waiting for the boy to admit it was all a joke. The precision and speed required to weave such intricate magic in real time seemed impossible. Yet here was Kristoffer, treating his own body like a marionette. Shaking his head, Berian pushed his astonishment aside, reminding himself of the task at hand.

“We’ll need to have a nice, long talk about this later,” Berian said.

“But for now, we don’t have much time. Let’s get back to why I came here. Can you heal yourself?”

“I should be able to deal with the worst parts.” Kristoffer admitted.

“Good. Do it. But leave some of the external injuries to avoid drawing suspicion when you leave. Also, make sure to hydrate; I doubt they’ll bring you any water. I’ll stand guard outside and make sure no one comes near. When you’re done, knock on the door. Although you can’t hear anything from the outside, it doesn’t work the other way. And don’t use any magic after this. Some people like to stroll by and listen to prisoners losing their minds. If skilled enough they could sense your magic.”

Berian stood, giving Kristoffer an encouraging smile. “One more day. That’s all you need to survive. Try doing some mental exercises to keep your mind sharp—I used to play chess in my head when I was stuck here. And remember to treat me like a stranger when we are in public.”

Without giving Kristoffer a chance to respond, Berian exited the room, leaving him once again enveloped in darkness. But this time, the void felt a little less oppressive.

Kristoffer exhaled slowly and began casting spells to inspect the degree of the damage to his body.

After losing control in front of Berian, Sofia felt deeply embarrassed. She spent the rest of the morning meditating in her room, focusing on constructing a partial second mana barrier. The exercise not only helped her organize her thoughts but also allowed her to regain her usual composure. Still, the memory of her childish outburst lingered, and she squirmed into her pillow one last time before forcing herself to move on and head outside.

It didn't take long for Katrina to find her. Stepping away briefly from her class, Katrina shared everything she'd learned from Carla. Sofia was relieved she had followed Berian's advice to calm down first; otherwise, she might have charged off to confront Erik Garnez without a second thought. Instead, she took a deep breath and focused on consoling Carla, who seemed deeply dispirited as she recounted the events of the previous evening. Their conversation, however, was cut short by a stern glare from the professor, prompting Katrina to hurry back to her lesson.

With her emotions in check, Sofia decided to climb up the garrison wall. She made an effort to chat with the guards stationed there, but their responses were stiff and formal—they were clearly intimidated by her noble status. Still, she lingered there, hoping to get a better view in case the dragon decided to appear again. Settling near a group of watchmen, Sofia sat cross-legged on a mat atop the watchtower and resumed her meditation.

The view was breathtaking. Unlike her own island, the Lower World below was dominated by vast forests and towering mountain ranges. Civilization was sparse, with only a few cities scattered across the landscape and small, barely discernible villages dotting the wild terrain.

The day passed uneventfully until evening, when Duke Garnez's son once again tried to provoke her. This time, Sofia simply gave him the cold shoulder, treating him as though he didn't exist. She had decided that Erik Garnez thrived on stirring up emotional reactions—like an emotional vampire feeding on distress—and that ignoring him was the best antidote to his antics. Her lack of reaction seemed to irritate him more than any confrontation could have.

The following day, Jens approached Sofia for help, and she gladly welcomed the distraction. She offered him advice, guiding him as he worked to stabilize his mana barrier. Though Jens wasn't a quick learner, his determination was admirable. Sofia found herself smiling as she watched him patiently struggle through each task she assigned. His calm persistence was a stark contrast to her own impatient tendencies, and she silently promised herself to learn some humility from his example. Jens was, without a doubt, a far more teachable student than she had ever been.

That evening, the atmosphere in the dining hall was thick with tension. The upcoming exam loomed large in everyone's minds,

and the students were acutely aware of the vast disparities in their skill levels. Some had only just begun learning magic, while others had spent years training under private tutors. The usual chatter was replaced by uneasy silence, and for the first time, nearly half the food went uneaten.

Despite the somber mood, Sofia remained in good spirits. In just a few hours, Kristoffer would finally be back at her side, and she was eager to clear the air between them. The thought of reconnecting with him brought her a measure of peace amid the lingering uncertainties.

“Release them both and hose them down thoroughly,” Renna Karlton ordered coldly. “Make sure they’re clean before anyone sees them.”

Jay nodded nervously and left the office, making his way toward the basement. Serving as a soldier at the border garrison was usually a peaceful job with decent pay and few surprises. But this past week had been anything but ordinary. No one had warned them that the University of the Abyss had chosen the garrison as a training ground for their students. The typically undisturbed routine had descended into chaos as nobles began throwing their weight around.

Fortunately, Commander Berian had joined them to help manage the upheaval, organizing shifts to keep the soldiers out of trouble

whenever possible. Even so, there were strange and unsettling figures roaming about. One of the nobles had an entire gang with him, and they were constantly using a Lower Worlder as their group plaything. Some of the others were getting high on mana beast fluids in the armories and hidden corners of the garrison. And then there was the peculiar girl who sat motionless for hours atop the guard tower, unnervingly close to the soldiers on duty. Jay had never felt so on edge during a shift.

Carrying a torch, he descended the stairs to the basement. It had been a long time since anyone had been kept in the isolation chambers for this long. With their senses cut off, people started losing their minds in a matter of hours. Starved for stimuli, the brain often produced the worst hallucinations possible. Jay once saw a prisoner who left the dark room after 12 hours and he would never forget it. It was a husk of a man, his eyes filled with desperation and madness. What would two days in that darkness do to these boys? The thought made Jay shudder, and he tightened his grip on his spear.

As he approached the hallway leading to the isolation chambers, the eerie silence struck him. Usually, the air was filled with desperate cries and pleas for help. But now, there was nothing. Jay approached the first cell cautiously, opening the door slowly. A rancid stench of urine and feces assaulted him, and he fought the instinct to cover his nose. Spear at the ready, he prepared himself in case the prisoner lashed out in a fit of madness.

But no attack came. Inside, Jay saw a tall, well-built young man laying motionlessly in his own urine and feces. The second thing he noticed was the blood staining the boy's fingertips. Upon closer inspection, it became clear that the Lower Worlder was using his fingernails to try to scratch his way out of the cell.

"Get up. You're free," Jay said, keeping his distance as a precaution. "Water and food are next to your cell."

The boy's eyes shifted, locking onto Jay's. What Jay saw wasn't anger or madness—it was emptiness. The young man's spirit seemed completely broken. Swallowing his pity, Jay bent the rules. He moved the tray of food closer to the prisoner's face and poured a little water over his head.

That small act finally elicited a response. The prisoner's eyes sharpened, and he began to stir. Slowly, he lifted himself off the floor, reaching immediately for the bottle of water. He drank greedily, draining it in seconds, and then grabbed the bread, stuffing it into his mouth with shaking hands. Tears streamed down his face as he ate, sobbing quietly between bites.

Jay watched, conflicted. He hated himself for breaking protocol but couldn't bring himself to feel regret. No one deserved to be reduced to this.

"I'm going to chain the door but leave it slightly open. I need to fetch the other guy," Jay informed the prisoner, backing out of the room cautiously.

As he stepped away, the Lower Worlde's sobbing grew louder. Without warning, the boy lunged toward the door. Startled, Jay leveled his spear in a defensive stance, but the prisoner seemed oblivious to the threat. Weakened by two days of dehydration and starvation, his movements were sluggish. Jay caught his arm easily and shoved him back into the cell before securing the chain on the door.

"Please don't leave me!" the prisoner cried, his voice raw with desperation. "I'll do anything you want—just don't lock me in here again!"

"I'm not locking you in, see?" Jay said from outside, leaving the door ajar. "I'll be back in a moment with the other guy. Eat and drink for now."

Taking a steadying breath, Jay turned and walked to the cell on the opposite side of the hallway. He wasn't eager to face another potential meltdown, but it was his damn luck that he pulled the shortest straw. Steeling himself, he opened the second door slowly.

The stench of urine and feces hit him again, but this time the prisoner's demeanor was entirely different. The young man sat calmly on his knees in the corner of the cell. Though blood had dried in his hair and stained his shirt, he appeared otherwise healthy. As the door creaked open, the prisoner adjusted his eyes to the dim light, blinking a few times before rising steadily to his feet.

“Can I get some water?” he asked, his voice hoarse but controlled.

“Y-yes,” Jay stammered, caught off guard. “It’s by the entrance.”

The prisoner stepped forward, prompting Jay to retreat reflexively, but there was no sign of aggression. The young man simply picked up the bottle of water, drank deeply, and then set it back down with deliberate care.

“Is the food for me as well?” His voice was clearer now, his tone even.

“Yes,” Jay replied, still trying to process the situation.

He stood watching the prisoner for a moment longer, half-expecting some delayed outburst. But the boy remained composed, eating the provided food with steady hands. Jay had heard tales of rare individuals with remarkable mental fortitude who could withstand the horrors of isolation unscathed. After twenty years at the garrison, he’d dismissed those stories as exaggerations—until now. Looking at this Lower Worlder, Jay couldn’t help but think that some of the rumors about Commander Berian might be true.

Satisfied that this prisoner wasn’t a threat, Jay crossed the hallway to retrieve the first one. He kept his guard up as he escorted the still-frantic boy out of the cell, maintaining a safe distance.

“I need to wash you both before I can take you upstairs,” he said, his voice firm but not unkind.

Jay couldn’t shake the guilt gnawing at him as he led the two prisoners to the washing room. Once inside, he had them strip and stand against the tiled wall. Using a magical apparatus installed in the chamber, he hosed them down thoroughly, ensuring every trace of dirt and odor was gone. Afterward, he handed each of them a set of fresh clothes.

“Which one of you is Ben?” Jay asked, his tone firm.

The bigger, terrified Lower Worlder flinched and stared at him in panic. Jay instantly regretted his harshness.

“It’s nothing bad,” Jay said, softening his voice. “Your master just said you should rest. He doesn’t need you right now.”

He turned to the other prisoner. “So, you must be Kristoffer. Your master said you can decide whether to rest or join her for the exam.”

“Has the exam already started?” Kristoffer asked.

“The ceremony began this morning. Servants are allowed to watch from the outer section,” Jay replied.

“If I can get some more water and food, I’d like to join Lady Sofia,” Kristoffer said without hesitation.

Jay stared at him, incredulous. Both prisoners were visibly weak, barely able to stand after two days without food or water. And yet,

Kristoffer wanted to march into an exam like nothing had happened. Maybe he had lost his mind after all.

“Fine,” Jay said reluctantly. “I’ll take you there. But for the rest of your time here, you’ll both be under strict supervision.”

He gestured for them to walk ahead, keeping a close watch as they made their way out.

“Class B,” Rena Karlton announced.

Polite but subdued applause rippled through the dining hall, filled to capacity with students seated at long wooden tables. One by one, each student awaited their turn for the mana barrier inspection, a test they had spent the past week preparing for.

Katrina descended the steps from the podium and returned to her seat beside Jens and Sofia.

“Congratulations, Lady Katrina. You’ve made incredible progress this week,” Jens whispered, careful not to disrupt the ongoing ceremony.

“But not enough to join you in Class A,” Katrina sighed, reaching for a plate of sweets to console herself.

“You can still advance if you do well in the end-of-semester exams,” Jens said, offering her an encouraging smile. “If you’d like, I can help you study.”

Their conversation was cut short when a professor's stern gaze swept their way. Another student descended the stairs after being assigned to Class F, their head hung low with disappointment.

The group returned their attention to the podium, where a boy with auburn hair was called up. His face glowed with excitement as he approached the ornamented chair and sat down. Rena Karlton placed her hand firmly against his chest, her expression impassive.

After a few tense seconds, she removed her hand. "Doesn't qualify," she declared.

The boy stood, his shoulders sagging under the weight of the verdict. He walked back to his seat, doing his best to maintain composure, but the sting of rejection was evident in his trembling steps.

Several other students failed to pass as well, and the tension in the room thickened with each announcement.

"Erik Garnez," a professor finally called out, reading from the long list of names.

The duke's son rose from his seat, met with a chorus of cheers from his peers. His confident smile didn't waver as he strode to the podium, exuding self-assurance. The crowd's reactions were mixed—some students watched him with awe, while others averted their eyes, clearly intimidated by his presence.

Rena felt a flicker of relief as they finally reached one of the self-study group students. Those who were taught traditionally for the past week, received additional points for the rate of their growth. She had an excellent memory, so Rena remembered everybody who made noteworthy progress and let them into a better class. But that also made her job predictable. She already had an idea where a person would be assigned to before the ceremony even started.

The self-study group always added a bit of spice to the monotonous ceremony. Each year, it was a mix of students that were either too arrogant or extremely talented. There was rarely an in-between. Rena placed her hand firmly on Erik Garnez's back, her consciousness diving into his mana source. She met immediate resistance. His barrier was solid, with no gaps or weaknesses, holding firm against her probing. Internally, Rena smiled. It was exactly what she expected from the duke's son. While his barrier still required some stabilization and refinement, his skills were years—possibly decades—ahead of his peers.

“Class A,” Rena announced.

The hall erupted into cheers as Erik made his way back to his seat, radiating pride. The professors allowed the noise to linger briefly before returning their attention to the list.

“Sofia Elernes.”

This time, there were no cheers as the young noblewoman approached the podium. Sofia offered the professors a polite nod before seating herself for the evaluation.

Rena couldn't help but feel a twinge of unease. She wasn't on good terms with either of Sofia's parents. Isabelle Elernes was one of her most troublesome students. She always swam against the current and had the strength and fortitude to continue to do so through the entire university. It took years after she graduated before the school could go back to being a peaceful place where manners and quality background mattered the most. Rena couldn't help feeling slightly hostile towards the daughter of a person that turned her beloved school into a place run by vulgar simpletons. Still, as an educator she tried her best to remain neutral.

Rena placed her hand on Sofia's back and entered her consciousness. But she was immediately stopped in her tracks. Sofia's barrier felt like an impenetrable wall of concrete and as if that was not enough, there was some kind of repellant around it. It looked as if she started building another barrier on top of the previous one.



But that would be impossible. She tried to poke around it but there were no signs of weakness or imperfection. It was difficult to believe, but this girl showed a level of skill and maturity that some mages could only dream of. Rena was tempted to attack the barrier at full force to see if she would be able to break it, but

this was no time or place to do that. The last thing she wanted was to make a spectacle here and draw attention to the girl.

“Class A,” Rena declared.

Scattered clapping filled the hall as Sofia gave another respectful nod and descended the podium. Rena continued to inspect the rest of the students through the ceremony, but she could not get out of her head the feeling of impenetrable fortress that Sofia gave off. She promised herself to keep a close eye on the girl from now on.

Peaceful student life

A group of youths clad in leather protectors stood in pairs, each holding a training spear with a blunt wooden tip. They faced their sparring partners, separated by five meters, their postures tense with anticipation.

“Take your stance!” the instructor barked. “Fight!”

Ana instinctively stepped back as her opponent lunged forward with practiced confidence. The attacker aimed for an unarmored section of Ana’s arm. Panicking, Ana twisted her body just enough to avoid the blow, but her opponent redirected the spear with fluid precision, striking Ana’s neck with the wooden shaft.

Ana tumbled into the muddy ground, gasping for breath, her eyes wide with panic.

“I’m getting tired of fighting a rag doll,” her opponent sneered, removing her protective mask. A strikingly beautiful face with sharp, refined features emerged, her expression filled with disdain. “Stop annoying me, or next time I’ll aim straight for your throat.”

Around them, no one paid attention, each pair too absorbed in their own struggles. The instructor glanced briefly in their direction but deemed the incident unworthy of his intervention.

Tears welled in Ana's eyes despite her best efforts to hold them back.

"Oh, are you going to cry again?" the girl mocked, her voice dripping with sarcasm. "Maybe if you wait long enough, your mommy will hear you and come to save you—just like—"

She stopped mid-taunt when someone stepped between her and Ana. A figure bent down to help Ana up from the mud. Although tears streamed down Ana's face, she stifled her sobs, refusing to give her tormentor the satisfaction.

The bully glanced to the side and noticed her colleague sprawled in the mud, clutching his side in pain. A faint smirk tugged at her lips.

"Looks like your mommy arrived," she sneered. "Let's see if she'll be there to save you every time." With a derisive chuckle, she strolled off to the refreshment area designated for sparring winners.

"You can't keep backing down, Ana. It's only going to get worse. You need to fight back," Lisa said softly as she wiped Ana's tear-streaked face. "Daria is a bitch. She won't stop until you show her that you can be a threat as well."

"I tried," Ana stammered, her voice trembling. "But when she attacked... my body just moved on its own."

“Alright, enough for today!” the instructor called out. “Thirty-minute break! Girls, wash up and get ready for ‘*How to Attend to Your Master*’. Boys, head to farming class.”

The tension dissipated as the students let out relieved sighs and began removing their protective gear.

Keith approached Ana and Lisa, his brow furrowed with concern as he loosened his protective belts.

“Again? Was it Toren, Daria, or Luka this time?” he asked tiredly.

“Daria,” Lisa replied curtly, already helping Ana unbuckle her armor.

Underneath the protective gear, Ana’s small frame was riddled with bruises. Purples, yellows, and reds mottled her skin, marking the spots where strikes had landed between the protective plates. The instructors provided a small amount of ointment for injuries, but Lisa had been using her share for days now to treat Ana’s wounds.

“I tried to report it again this morning,” Keith explained, frustration evident in his voice. “But they just told me that surviving in an unfriendly environment is part of the training. According to the staff, it’s common for Lower Worlders on farms outside the city to end up in situations like this, and they want us to be prepared for it.” He scoffed. “But that’s bullshit. I overheard the instructors saying, ‘*dogs should tend to their own garden.*’”

"It's fine. Lady Sofia should be back by evening," Lisa sighed. "We'll ask her if Ana can take this turn as her servant and spend the next week recovering properly at her side."

"I can't attend to her like this!" Ana sobbed. "Look at me! I look disgusting. You should go, Lisa—that's what we agreed on before. Lady Sofia needs to be represented properly."

"Leave your squabbles for later and get ready for the next lesson before they lock you out of the shower again," Keith interrupted, his tone sharp. "I have to go help Tiana."

"Someone's got a bad case of Carla withdrawal," Lisa murmured under her breath as Keith walked away.

The girls finished removing their armor and began heading toward their quarters. As they passed the schoolyard, they noticed Sofia's teacher, Rosalia, at the school gate yet again. For the past week, Rosalia had been coming every day to argue with the guard at the entrance. The girls had no idea what it was about.

Once they were out of earshot, Ana spoke quietly. "After this basic combat training is over, I think I'll take the courtesan specialization."

"If you think running from the battleground will resolve the bully problem, you are mistaken," Lisa replied, not slowing her pace. "It'll just take on a different shape. Think twice if you are ready for whatever disgusting things they prepared on this course, Ana. The one we are attending now is already bad enough, and these

are just the ‘basics’. You need to fight back. I’m doing what I can, but it’s hard to protect both you and myself. They need to see that you’re worthy of respect, or it won’t stop. Nobody else will help you, Duke Garnez’s servants have too much influence here.”

“They are stronger than me!” Ana suddenly exploded. “What do you expect me to do?! I’m not like you Lisa, okay? I can’t face three people threatening my life and be fine. Maybe you can do it, but I can’t. My mind goes blank, and I can’t do anything.”

“I’m sorry,” Lisa said softly, her voice tinged with regret. “I didn’t mean to attack you. I really want to help, Ana—I just don’t know how to.”

“No, I’m sorry,” Ana said, her voice trembling. “I know you just want to help. I’m not angry with you, I swear.”

They continued walking toward the showers in awkward silence, the weight of their conversation hanging heavily between them.

“Congratulations to all the students who managed to pass the qualification exam. The rest of you are welcome to try again next year,” Professor Borgman announced in a bored tone. “As you are all aware, the number of mana beast attacks has increased significantly over the past few months. Therefore, you will remain here for one additional week of basic combat training in your assigned classes. Nobles, please decide which servant you would like to have next. The current ones will be sent back so they

can catch up with their classes. Let's take a short break and reconvene at the same spot as on the first day in fifteen minutes."

A murmur of surprise rippled through the hall, accompanied by groans of discontent. Most of the students were clearly unhappy with this new development, many of them longing for the comfort of the city after enduring a week in the woods.

"No, no, no," Katrina moaned, throwing her hands up in frustration. "I cannot do this anymore! It was never like this in the past! And what am I supposed to do without Carla? If I take Keith, everyone will gossip, and Tiana is even more afraid of bugs than I am!"

"I'll support you, Lady Katrina," Jens said, attempting to lift her spirits. "We'll get through this together. And of course, you as well, Lady Sofia—though I doubt you'll need much of my help..."

Sofia gave them a polite, comforting smile, but her thoughts were elsewhere. She was too preoccupied with Kristoffer to pay attention to the conversation. After excusing herself, she made her way toward the sanctuary's exit, her heart racing.

The large double doors swung open, revealing the gathered servants waiting for their masters. Sofia's eyes immediately scanned the crowd. Near the back, on the left side, she spotted the familiar face she had been searching for. Kristoffer stood apart from the rest, accompanied by a soldier from the garrison. Before her thoughts could fully form, her legs carried her forward.

Kristoffer was leaning against the wall, looking thinner and smaller than usual. Seeing his black eye made Sofia's blood boil. Although his clothes and body looked clean, his eyes were a window to the truth. He was clearly exhausted. When he noticed her, however, he straightened up and flashed her his characteristic confident smile, as though nothing was wrong.

"Lady Sofia! How did the exam go?" he called out before she could reach him.

Sofia didn't slow down. She closed the distance between them and pulled him into a tight hug, relief washing over her like a tidal wave. Seeing him alive and standing felt like a weight lifting from her chest.

"Lady Sofia, everyone is watching," Kristoffer whispered, his voice soft as he gently tried to push her away.

It took her a moment to realize that her actions weren't exactly appropriate for the setting. She quickly stepped back, releasing him. Glancing around, she noticed the stunned expressions on the faces of those nearby. The soldier standing beside Kristoffer looked utterly shocked, his mouth hanging open. The rest of the servants and guards were equally wide-eyed, staring at her as if she had just done something unthinkable.

"Such passion, Sofia. I didn't think you had it in you," Erik Garnez sneered, stepping out from the crowd with his trademark arrogant smile. "But here you are, playing with your little boy toy

in public. Tell me, is sleeping with Lower Worlders a family tradition for the women of the Elernes? Or is this just you finding new ways to stoop even lower?”

Sofia’s eyes narrowed, her voice laced with venom as she shot back, “And how exactly would me sleeping with Kristoffer be any different from you bedding your servants, Erik? Oh, and while I know your hormone-addled brain might struggle with this concept, it *is* possible to hug someone without it being sexual. You should try asking your mother, Duke Garnez.”

Erik’s expression faltered, his arrogant smirk replaced by stunned silence. For a moment, his widened eyes betrayed just how unprepared he was for Sofia’s fiery retort. But before he could recover and fire back, the professors began shouting instructions, herding the students into formation for the next announcement. Erik was quickly caught up in the crowd, and their heated exchange was cut short.

Turning back to Kristoffer, Sofia’s expression softened with concern. “Are you hurt anywhere?” she asked, scanning him with worried eyes. “They’re planning to send you back today, but I can see you’re in no state for it. I’ll talk to the teachers—they might make an exception—”

“Lady Sofia, I’m fine,” Kristoffer interrupted gently, though his weak smile did little to convince her. “You should take a deep breath and calm down. Duke Garnez isn’t going to let this go. You should’ve denied his accusations more clearly.”

Sofia stared at him in disbelief. *This guy...* she thought. Kristoffer was never capable of putting himself first, always brushing aside his own well-being. Once again, she decided to bear the burden of protecting him. Out of the corner of her eye, she noticed the soldier who had been standing nearby trying to back away discreetly, as if to avoid getting caught in the tension.

Before she could respond, Borgman's voice boomed across the clearing. "Alright, fifteen minutes have passed!" he announced. "Please relay your decisions regarding chosen servants to the assistants near the carriages. Now, I didn't mention this earlier, but there's an alternative way to get excused from the remaining combat training."

The crowd fell silent, hanging on his every word.

"In this garrison, we have captured five darkclaws. Brave volunteers may challenge one in combat. If you defeat it, not only will you be excused from basic combat training, but you will also be allowed to choose any teacher you want to personally tutor you. That includes all the professors that are currently in the academy. However, a warning: darkclaws can slice through steel armor with ease, and we cannot guarantee your safety."

The students erupted into a mixture of excited murmurs and nervous whispers. The proposal sounded almost suicidal, but the reward was priceless. Many professors, particularly the academy's elite, wouldn't agree to tutor anyone even when paid

in mountains of gold. This was a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity to learn rare and coveted specializations.

“I’ll do it,” Erik Garnez declared, stepping forward with a confident grin. “Does the offer include the headmaster?”

“He’s still a professor, so it indeed does,” Borgman confirmed with a nod and gestured to an assistant nearby. “The cage will be brought here in a moment. Those who are afraid may head inside during the fight. Observers must maintain their distance—darkclaws are extremely fast. I recommend staying at least fifty meters away. Remember, you stay at your own risk.”

The crowd’s faces were a kaleidoscope of emotions—excitement, fear, and hesitation. They all knew the stories of darkclaws, those swift, deadly creatures prized for their valuable claws and fur. Only seasoned hunters dared face them alone. Despite the danger, about half of the students decided to stay, their curiosity outweighing their fear. Many sought what little comfort they could find, clustering behind their servants or inching closer to the stationed guards.

The hunters who had been scouting the sanctuary during the exams emerged from the watchtower, rolling out a large, reinforced cage. Inside, a massive creature—nearly two meters long—prowled restlessly. It resembled an oversized lynx, its sleek fur shimmering in the light. The darkclaw’s namesake claws glinted ominously, though its legs were shackled tightly with heavy metal restraints. Its muzzle was locked to prevent it

from biting, yet the low, guttural growls emanating from its throat sent shivers down the spines of the gathered students.

“We’ll release it twenty meters from your position to simulate a realistic forest encounter,” Rena explained, addressing Erik Garnez, the volunteer. She held up a rune stone etched with intricate patterns. “The shackles are bound to this rune. I’ll count to three before unlocking them. If you cast any spells before the countdown ends, you’ll be disqualified with no chance to attempt again. Do you have any questions?”

“None. Release the beast,” Erik declared, a smug, vicious smile playing on his lips.

Erik’s confidence was palpable. This wasn’t his first time facing a darkclaw. As the son of Duke Garnez, he’d hunted similar beasts before. The past week of battling forest creatures during the exam had only honed his skills further. The sanctuary might have grown perilous, but it was also the perfect training ground.

The area around Erik had been cleared. Students, professors, and guards watched from a safe distance, their collective gaze fixed on the darkclaw, which glared at Erik with pure malice. Inside the cage, the creature’s muscles rippled under its fur as it paced. Erik raised his elegant, dark wand and began visualizing the spell he would cast to start the fight.

Professor Borgman observed him with interest, standing amidst a cluster of students.

“Three,” Rena began her countdown, her voice cutting through the tension. “Two... one.”

With a loud, metallic *snap*, the shackles binding the darkclaw’s legs shattered. The beast didn’t hesitate—it hurled its body against the cage door with immense force. The lock and hinges gave way instantly, and the door crashed to the ground. The darkclaw tumbled out with a heavy thud but quickly sprang to its feet, snarling.

Erik didn’t waste a moment.



“Fireball!”

Runes flared to life in front of his wand, forming a glowing, head-sized orb of fire. The spell shot forward at high speed, colliding

with the darkclaw's neck in a fiery explosion. The creature roared in pain, its body thrown half a meter back. The fur where it had been hit was singed, revealing reddened, raw skin beneath. Yet there was no blood.

Rena nodded in approval, and the students murmured in awe. The precision, size, and power of Erik's spell were impressive, especially under the circumstances. He had reaffirmed his reputation as the son of a duke and the undisputed leader of Class A.

But unlike his classmates, Erik wasn't satisfied with the result. He clicked his tongue in frustration. This darkclaw was far tougher than the one he had fought alongside Max Valron in the past.

The beast rose, shaking off the blow, its hateful eyes locked on Erik. This time, it didn't charge recklessly. It began cutting the distance between them with calculated, diagonal leaps, each one bringing it closer.

"Fireball! Fireball!" Erik shouted, his voice sharp with focus as he unleashed a barrage of spells. The darkclaw, however, evaded each attack with astounding agility, its sleek form darting and weaving through the air like a shadow. When Erik attempted a fourth spell, the runes faltered mid-formation, forcing him to abandon the cast.

“Damn it,” he muttered under his breath, frustration flickering in his eyes.

The darkclaw, now only ten meters away, crouched low, muscles coiled in preparation for a final, lethal strike. Erik bit his tongue, forcing himself to remain calm. This wasn’t his first battle, and he refused to let fear overtake him.

“Ignite!” he roared, pouring a reckless surge of mana into his next spell.

As the darkclaw leaped toward him, jaws wide and claws poised to strike, Erik detonated the spell at point-blank range. A massive explosion erupted, with Erik at its center. The blast sent the darkclaw’s heavy body hurtling backward a full twenty meters.

The students gasped, shielding their eyes from the blinding walls of fire that enveloped the battlefield. Heat rippled through the air, ruffling their hair and clothing. Among them, Erik’s followers stared in awe, their admiration solidifying. He had once again proven himself as a leader worthy of loyalty. Even Professor Borgman nodded approvingly, silently acknowledging Erik’s power and control.

The darkclaw groaned, its body a burnt and bloody wreck. Its head was charred, with blood trickling from its eyes and ears. Yet it stubbornly fought to rise, legs trembling under the effort. The beast collapsed twice before finally managing to stand.

Erik, breathing heavily, was painfully aware of his limits. He had drained all the mana stored in his core barrier and even dipped into the reserves emanating from his source. He had enough energy left for one last fireball—half the size of his earlier spells. Any further expenditure would come at a dire cost, shortening his lifespan.

The darkclaw, blinded and maimed, crept forward with terrifying resolve. Its growls were low and guttural, a testament to its enduring hatred. Despite its injuries, it knew exactly where its enemy stood.

Erik steadied his breathing, willing himself to focus. He could not afford to fail now.

“Fireball” he said, his voice steady and confident.

Runes formed a final, flaming orb, which hurtled toward the darkclaw. The spell struck its head, and the beast collapsed with a heavy thud. Its body lay still, and a tense silence blanketed the clearing.

Moments later, the silence erupted into cheers. Erik’s followers surged forward, eager to celebrate his victory.

“Calm down!” Rena’s sharp voice cut through the excitement.

“Darkclaws are cunning. It might still be alive!”

The students froze, staring at the darkclaw’s motionless body in dread. Rena approached cautiously, inspecting the beast before nodding in confirmation. “It’s dead,” she announced.

The cheers resumed, louder than before, as students swarmed around Erik. Meanwhile, the hunters began clearing away the body and broken cage.

“Well done,” Professor Borgman said unexpectedly, his tone carrying a rare note of praise. “While your mana usage was excessive and inefficient, your ability to adapt under pressure is promising. Do I assume correctly that you’ll select the headmaster as your tutor?”

“Thank you, Professor Borgman. Yes, I plan to study under the headmaster,” Erik replied curtly, his tone dismissive as he barely acknowledged the compliment. Without sparing another glance at the gathering crowd, he shifted his focus elsewhere.

His attention landed on Sofia, who was deep in conversation with one of the hunters—a man who had introduced himself as Rey. A smug grin spread across Erik's face as he strode toward them, exuding an air of arrogant confidence.

“How did you enjoy the fight, Sofia?” he asked with a twisted smile. “If you’d like to learn proper magic, I’d be happy to invite you on our next hunt for the ownerless Lower Worlders. You might actually learn something useful.”

“It won’t be necessary,” Sofia replied icily, her gaze unwavering. “Mindless beasts may learn by murdering others, but I am a mage, not an animal.”

Erik's smile vanished, replaced by a venomous glare. "Do you think you're better than me?" he hissed. "Prove it. Show me how a 'mage' fights, if you're so confident."

"Gladly," Sofia said coolly, turning to Professor Borgman. "Professor, just to confirm—after the fight, we're allowed to choose any teacher to tutor us, and they must begin immediately upon our return to the academy?"

"That is correct," Borgman replied, clearly surprised.

"Then I volunteer," Sofia declared.

Erik Garnez stared at Sofia, dumbfounded—and he wasn't alone. The students, still abuzz from his hard-won battle, were now frozen in disbelief. The darkclaw was formidable, and Erik himself had barely emerged victorious. He hadn't expected anyone else to take up the challenge, much less Sofia. His taunt was meant to rile her up, not prompt her to step forward. As he processed her bold decision, Erik's gaze flicked to Rena, whose expression was an odd mix of unease and reluctant curiosity.

"As you wish," Professor Borgman said after a moment of hesitation, nodding to accept Sofia's decision. He began issuing instructions to the hunters to prepare the next cage.

"Lady Sofia, I don't think this is a good idea," Kristoffer whispered from behind her, his voice tight with concern. "Making a scene like this—"

“It’s a great idea,” she interrupted, her tone sharp and resolute. “I’ll finish this quickly, and then we’ll head back to the academy together.” Turning to the soldier who had been standing with Kristoffer, she added, “Jay, correct? Please escort him to the gate and ensure he’s safe.”

“Yes, Lady Sofia!” the soldier said, snapping a salute before gently but firmly guiding a reluctant Kristoffer away.

As the hunters rolled out the next cage, the other students returned to their spots, whispering among themselves in excited, nervous tones. Their eyes flitted between the cage and Sofia, who stood calmly in the center of the field. Erik Garnez, however, stayed silent, watching her intently.

The second darkclaw was nearly the same size as the first, though its right ear was jagged and torn, as if it had been bitten off in some previous battle. It paced restlessly in the cage, its glowing eyes locked on Sofia.

Rena Karlton couldn’t shake the unease curling in her chest. There was something about Sofia’s demeanor that set her on edge. That focused, unshakable look—it reminded Rena of someone she’d seen fifty years ago. Isabelle Elernes, who had defeated Duke Ralezo in the school’s tournament and solidified her family’s standing. But no matter what instincts screamed at her, it was too late to stop this now.

“Three, two, one,” Rena called out.

The darkclaw's shackles fell away with a metallic clink, and unlike the first beast, this one didn't blindly slam into the cage door. It pressed its massive front paws against the bars, forcing the weakened door to collapse under its weight. Without hesitation, the darkclaw lunged forward, closing the distance to Sofia in less than three seconds.

Gasps rippled through the crowd. Sofia hadn't even drawn a catalyst. She stood perfectly still, as though frozen in fear. The students murmured anxiously, and Professor Borgman gripped his wand tightly, preparing to intervene if necessary. The darkclaw's speed was staggering; there was little chance Sofia could react in time to defend herself.

But just as the darkclaw reached her, its deadly claws mere moments from striking, Sofia moved. In a single, fluid motion, she waved her left hand from above her head to her waist and stepped lightly to the side.

The beast's head flew cleanly from its body. Its lifeless form, carried by the momentum of its attack, collapsed to the ground where Sofia had stood only seconds before. Blood gushed from the severed neck, splattering Sofia's leather boots, but she did not seem to care.

A stunned silence fell over the field. Teachers, students, even the hunters—everyone was frozen in disbelief.

The silence was finally broken by Kristoffer's weary sigh from near the gate.

"I choose Professor Borgman," Sofia said evenly, her voice carrying over the stunned crowd. "I'd like to leave as soon as possible."

One hit? Erik Garnez couldn't comprehend what he'd just witnessed. His chest tightened with a tangle of emotions: hate, awe, fear. What was this feeling? His mind flashed back to their last confrontation, when Berian had stepped in to stop her. What might have happened if he hadn't? Erik stood motionless, his followers hovering nearby, their faces betraying their uncertainty. None dared to react until he did.

"Professor Borgman is the supervisor of outside activities," Rena Karlton finally spoke, breaking the tense silence. "It won't be possible for him to return to the university immediately."

"I was told otherwise before the fight, Professor Rena," Sofia replied, her tone calm but unyielding. "Professor Borgman said I could choose any teacher, and I intend to hold him to his word."

"That was the order I received from the headmaster," Professor Borgman said, still struggling to regain his composure after witnessing Sofia's display. He adjusted his posture and added, "It seems, in this case, you'll have to stay here, Rena, and take over the outside activities."

“Me? Stay here?” Rena’s sharp glare locked onto him, her irritation palpable. “I have far more pressing matters to attend to. I cannot remain here.”

“You’re free to find a replacement,” Borgman replied, barely concealing the small, amused smile tugging at the corner of his lips. “But I must follow the headmaster’s orders. Unless, of course, there are any other volunteers?” He glanced around, but none of the students dared to speak. “If not, I’ll return to the garrison to pack my things.”

Meanwhile, Sofia had already begun walking toward the gate, her posture calm yet purposeful. The other students remained silent, unsure of how to react, but two figures broke away from the group and ran toward her.

“Holy shit, Sofie, you were *awesome!*” Katrina exclaimed, throwing her arms around Sofia in an enthusiastic hug. “What was that? You went all *whoosh*, and then it went *bam!* You were incredible!”

“Lady Sofia, you’ve exceeded my every expectation,” Jens said, bowing deeply. His tone showed the newly gained respect towards her. “I humbly ask—please tutor me when we return to the university.”

“Don’t be so formal, Jens—jeez,” Sofia replied, her cheeks slightly flushed as she offered him an awkward smile.

“Why didn’t you tell me you were this good?” Katrina demanded, her voice high with excitement. “You could’ve been teaching *me* all this time! Silent casting without a wand? There can’t be more than thirty people on the entire island who can pull that off!”

“Katie, you’re embarrassing me,” Sofia said, her cheeks turning even redder. “I need to pack anyway. Kristoffer’s not in great shape, and I want him to rest as soon as possible. I’ll see you both next week. Good luck with the training!”

“I love you, Sofie! I’m going to miss you so much!” Katrina shouted as Sofia walked away, her voice brimming with affection.

The rest of the students awkwardly pretended not to notice this overly enthusiastic display, though the contrast between Sofia’s earlier display of power and this casual scene felt surreal, as though they’d stumbled into a fever dream. The hunters, meanwhile, had begun loading the headless body of the darkclaw onto a cart.

“The spider incident makes a lot more sense now,” Rey murmured under his breath, eyeing Sofia as she disappeared toward the gate.

“If I were you,” Krein said with a cheeky grin, “I’d be a lot more careful about how you speak to her from now on.”

Sofia had hoped to bid farewell to Berian, but he had disappeared before the exam even began. After completing a few formalities,

she retrieved Kristoffer from his guard and they headed toward the carriage. Around them, other Lower Worlders were being herded toward crude carts—many of them uncovered—meant to carry them back. Amidst the bustling crowd, a familiar face caught Sofia’s attention.

“Carla!” Sofia called out. “Do you want to ride with us?”

The girl turned at the sound of her name, her face brightening as she recognized Sofia. Grabbing a small sack from the ground, Carla hurried over. Kristoffer had a sense of déjà vu when she bumped into him before pulling him into a tight hug.

“I’m so sorry!” Carla whispered, her voice trembling. She clung to him even tighter, her grip causing him to groan softly. “I’m sorry I left that day, and I’m sorry I couldn’t do anything to help you.”

“You have nothing to apologize for, Carla,” Kristoffer reassured her, gently patting her head. “I was the one who told you to leave, remember? If you hadn’t brought the teacher, I wouldn’t have made it. I should be thanking you instead.”

“Let’s do this inside; people are staring,” Sofia interjected dryly, stepping into the carriage.

Carla loosened her hold, quickly wiping her red eyes with her sleeve. The three settled into the carriage, with Carla and Kristoffer taking the seat across from Sofia. As the carriage began to move, Carla turned to him.

“What did they do to you in jail? Did they hurt you?” she asked, her voice filled with concern.

“No, it wasn’t that bad,” Kristoffer replied with a grin. “They just left me alone. Honestly, you could call it a free holiday.”

“Holiday, my ass,” Sofia retorted with a sour face. “I’ve never seen you this exhausted.”

Changing the subject, Carla hesitated before asking, “Lady Sofia, you were incredible back there. But why did you choose Professor Borgman? Lady Katrina said the rest of the staff mocks him and that he always gets the worst assignments at the academy.”

“Professor Borgman has some intriguing theories I want to explore,” Sofia explained. “He’s also in charge of archiving necromancy research. Some of that knowledge might have applications in medical studies. The staff dislikes him because he doesn’t mindlessly agree with everything they say.”

“Who would’ve thought the academy would present an opportunity like this,” Kristoffer murmured, a faint trace of disappointment in his voice. “Professor Borgman seems to be a very interesting person.”

“I’ll summarize everything I learn later on,” Sofia said, her tone softening. “For now, you should focus on recovering. Go to sleep. Get some rest before we reach the academy.” She tried to make it sound like an order, but her worry crept through.

“You can lie down on me,” Carla offered, patting her lap. “You need to learn how to take care of yourself.”

Sofia watched in quiet surprise as Kristoffer leaned over without hesitation, resting his head on Carla’s lap. Though Sofia had seen the two talking often, she had never paid much attention to their interactions before. Now, however, a strange mix of emotions churned within her.

She liked Carla a great deal, but the sight of her so close to Kristoffer sparked a flicker of jealousy that quickly grew into a raging inferno. Sofia’s chest tightened as she watched Carla gently pet Kristoffer’s head, her fingers playing with his blond strands.

Kristoffer’s face softened in sleep, his expression so peaceful that it sent Sofia’s thoughts spiraling. She longed to be the one who made him feel so at ease, but she knew that desire was selfish. His well-being mattered most, she reminded herself. There were more important things to focus on—finding a way to remove their master-servant contract and resolving the tension between them.

Turning her gaze to the window, Sofia let the passing scenery distract her. Yet, despite her efforts, her emotions remained a tangled mess, and she struggled to quell the jealousy simmering in her heart.

“Assemble outside!” the instructor barked, stepping into the dorm.

The servants scrambled to their feet, hurrying outside to avoid any punishment for a delay or misstep.

“I’ll talk to Lady Sofia and see if you can go this week instead of me,” Lisa whispered to Ana as they joined the stream of servants filing out of the building. “Stick close to Keith while I’m gone.”

Ana nodded, her expression weary. Outside, the Lower Worlders formed three long rows, exactly as they had been taught during training last week. The cold evening breeze bit into their skin, sending shivers through the lines. Once everyone was in place, the instructor began speaking again.

“I will now read the list of servants assigned to attend their masters this week,” he announced. “When I call your name, proceed to the common hall. There, you will meet with the servant who attended last week to receive all necessary instructions for your duties.”

The instructor glanced down at his clipboard. “Tia for Erik Garnez, Lisa for Sofia Elernes...”

Lisa stepped out of the line and made her way to the designated building. Inside, she recognized a few familiar faces, but her attention was immediately drawn to Kristoffer. A massive black

eye marred his face, making her heart sink. Their eyes met, and she hurried over to him.

“Kristoffer!” she exclaimed.

Without hesitation, they embraced, both of them feeling a momentary relief from the weight of their respective burdens.

“What happened to your eye?” Lisa asked, pulling back to examine him.

“It’s a long story,” Kristoffer replied with a tired sigh. “The short version: stay far away from Duke Garnez and his lackeys. He holds a grudge towards Lady Sofia, and she just made a scene today to antagonized him even further.”

“Lady Sofia lost her temper?” Lisa asked, shocked. “But she’s been doing so well over the past year.”

Kristoffer let out another weary sigh. “He made some disgusting comment about her... and me. It spiraled from there. Honestly, I feel awful about all the rumors I’ve caused. Instead of ignoring them, she just keeps escalating things. It’s like she’s throwing fuel on an already raging fire.”

Lisa hesitated before replying. “I mean... she’s not the only one adding fuel, you know.”

“What’s that supposed to mean?” Kristoffer’s brows furrowed in confusion.

Lisa chose her words carefully, her tone gentle. “You two... act very close. Too close, at least for what people expect from a master and servant. Sometimes you say things to her in a way that... well, it feels special. From the outside, it looks like you’re more than that. Like you’re a married couple, almost. And... the way you look at her sometimes... don’t you think there is something more there Kristoffer?”

Kristoffer’s expression turned cold, his voice firm. “There could never be anything between me and Lady Sofia beyond a master-servant relationship. I would never do anything to hurt her reputation or status. I thought that much was obvious. Why would I risk turning the entire Upper World against her?”

Lisa frowned but didn’t push further. *But you didn’t answer the question*, she thought to herself.

Kristoffer changed the subject abruptly. “How are things on your side? Did you manage to gather any allies?”

Lisa’s shoulders slumped. “It’s bad. Really bad. We haven’t made any connections, and Ana is being bullied. I was hoping to switch places with her so she could attend Lady Sofia instead of me. But if this is how you were treated out there, I’m starting to think it’s not a good idea.”

“Ana’s being bullied?” Kristoffer’s voice sharpened. “What do you mean?”

"From the very first day, Daria, the servant of Duke Garnez, along with others serving under his house, took control of the camp," Lisa began. Her voice wavered with frustration and exhaustion. "The instructors just look the other way. Their attitude is basically, 'Let the Lower Worlders deal with their own problems.' They don't intervene, no matter what happens."

"It started with rough treatment during sparring sessions, but it escalated. There's this one guy—Luka, Baron Valron's servant. At first, he was just an annoyance for the first few days. Then something changed in him, Kristoffer. It's like... he became someone else. His entire personality shifted. He grew aggressive—violent. And one night, he almost... he almost raped Ana. If Keith hadn't stepped in when he did, I don't know what would've happened."

"Because of that incident, Lady Katrina's servants have also been targeted. There's backlash everywhere. I've tried my best to protect Ana, but I can't watch over her all the time." Lisa's voice broke off as she looked at Kristoffer's face. His expression had hardened, shifting from shock to disbelief, and finally to a chilling, controlled rage.

"He did *what*?" Kristoffer's voice came out cold and flat. But it wasn't the usual calmness she recognized—it was unnervingly devoid of emotion, and it made Lisa's skin crawl.

"Calm down, Kristoffer," Lisa urged, speaking quickly. "We stopped him before anything happened. But you can't go after

him. They control the camp. If you try to attack him, you'll end up fighting almost everyone there. We have to figure out a reasonable solution," she tried to use Kristoffer's favorite tools – logic and reason – to deescalate the situation.

Before Kristoffer could respond, one of the instructors stationed at the hall approached them.

"You! Enough talking. Move on to your tasks—it's already late," the man barked.

Kristoffer exhaled slowly, reigning in his emotions for now. "Lady Sofia will fill you in on the rest," he said quickly to Lisa. "She's with a private tutor this week, so there shouldn't be much trouble on her end." Then he turned to the instructor. "Where do I go?"

"The big building over there. Move quickly—it's getting crowded in here," the instructor replied curtly.

As Kristoffer began to walk away, Lisa called out after him, her voice tinged with worry. "Kristoffer! Please remember—Ana is sensitive and fragile. Treat her delicately!"

He waved in acknowledgment but didn't respond.

Kristoffer felt bone-deep exhaustion as he walked across the camp. The events of the past week had worn him down in every possible way, though he hadn't fully realized it until he woke up on Carla's lap. For a fleeting moment, as his eyes fluttered open, he'd felt safe—weightless. Free from the crushing burdens he

carried. But the worries surged back just as quickly, flooding his mind with everything he had endured.

A dragon encounter. An attack on Sofia. His first time killing someone with his own hands. Getting beaten senseless. Two days in solitary confinement without food or water. And the most unsettling realization of all: his master-servant contract was more than a bond—it was a curse, warping his thoughts and feelings in ways he was only beginning to comprehend.

His body hadn't fully recovered, but adrenaline surged as his gaze fell on the bruises marring Ana's frail frame. The girl that was like a little sister to him looked like a shadow of her former self. A protective fury ignited within him.

"Ana," Kristoffer called softly, stepping toward the cot where she sat. He knelt beside her, wrapping her in a firm but gentle embrace. "You're safe now," he murmured.

The scrawny, brown-haired girl tried to respond, but the words caught in her throat. As Kristoffer pressed her head to his shoulder, the dam broke. She trembled violently, her body shaking with sobs, and began mumbling incoherently—trying to convey a flood of emotions and details all at once.

Kristoffer met Keith's eyes over Ana's shaking form, offering the taller man a silent, grateful nod. Keith returned the gesture before moving to hug Carla, who had just arrived.

Though the other Lower Worlders in the room were busy reuniting with their own friends, they couldn't help but glance at Ana's breakdown. But anyone who lingered too long was met with Kristoffer's sharp, warning glare and quickly averted their eyes.

Gradually, Ana's sobs quieted. She clung to Kristoffer's shirt, finding solace in his steady presence.

Kristoffer let her cry until she could cry no more, all the while processing what he had learned. Lisa's account of Luka's behavior lingered in his mind. Could Luka's aggression have been triggered by the death of his master, Max Valron? The timeline aligned perfectly. If the master-servant contract had dissolved when the magic severed, it might have unleashed violent tendencies that had been suppressed for years.

The theory made sense, but Kristoffer couldn't act on it—not yet. Inspecting Luka's core could reveal his magic, and that was far too risky. Still, the thought gnawed at him, coupled with a bitter realization: since temporarily losing his magic, his emotions had become unbearably raw, sharp-edged in a way they had never been before. He struggled to remain calm, to think clearly. It was as if the shields he'd carefully crafted around his heart since childhood had cracked.

Was this the result of his damaged master-servant contract? Or maybe it was related to the core issues Berian mentioned?

Normally, Kristoffer could contain his rage, rely on logic to guide his actions. But now, every part of him burned with an overwhelming need to protect Ana. The desire to destroy anyone who had harmed her felt almost uncontrollable. It was unnatural how his emotions swelled, buzzing like they were amplified by something external—something he couldn't quite grasp.

A loud complaint cut through his thoughts.

"This is bullshit! Why wouldn't Lord Valron call anyone?!" someone shouted from a corner of the room, punctuating their outburst with a kick to a bedframe. The metallic clang made several people flinch and instinctively move away from the source of the outburst.

Kristoffer refocused, gripping Ana's shoulders gently. "Ana, look at me," he said softly. "I need you to trust me right now, okay? You're safe with me—I promise. But I need you to take me to Luka."

"Kristoffer, wait," Keith interjected, stepping forward. "We should talk this through first. Understand the situation better."

Kristoffer turned to him, his tone measured but firm. "Let me make sure I understand. It's every man for himself here, and the school staff doesn't care what Lower Worlders do to each other. Is that right?"

"Well... yes, but Luka is part of Duke Garnez's group—"

“It’s fine, Keith. I owe you for saving Ana, and I won’t forget it. You can always count on me,” Kristoffer said, cutting him off. Then, turning back to Ana, he softened his voice again. “Ana, can you do this for me? Can you take me to him?”

Ana hesitated, her eyes filling with worry. “Kristoffer, I don’t want you to get hurt. Look at your eye... what happened?” She sniffled, wiping her nose on his already damp shirt.

“It was an accident,” Kristoffer assured her with a faint smile. “I promise it won’t happen again. I need you to trust me, okay?” He gently wiped the remnants of her tears and snot from her face.

After a long pause, Ana nodded. “Okay,” she whispered, her voice shaky but resolute. She reached for his outstretched hand, gripping it tightly.

Together, they began walking toward the corner of the room where the earlier outburst had come from. Kristoffer’s piercing green eyes scanned the place like a predator before the hunt.



"I see you came to cheer me up. How nice of you, Ana. Great timing." The words came from a well-built boy with long hair

standing next to the servant Kristoffer recognized—the one who had mellowed down after his time in the isolation chamber.

"Are you Luka?" Kristoffer voice was sharp.

"And who are you?" Luka sneered, his lips curling into an ugly smirk. "Ana, did you trade in your mommy for a daddy? Think he'll protect you if you put out?"

Kristoffer's jaw tightened, but his voice remained calm. "I'm a pacifist, so I'll give you one last chance. Kneel and beg Ana for forgiveness."

Luka's laughter erupted, echoing through the room as if Kristoffer had told the best joke of the century. He wiped a fake tear and glanced at his companion.

"Ben, you know this clown?"

"He's from Elernes," Ben muttered uneasily. "The guy who went to prison with me."

"Ah, I see." Luka's grin turned savage as he cracked his knuckles.

"One black eye wasn't enough, huh? Let me help you with some symmetry."

"Ana, stay back," Kristoffer ordered, stepping forward with measured precision.

Luka lunged, his right fist swinging in a wide arc. Kristoffer shifted fluidly to the left, catching Luka's wrist in mid-air. In one seamless motion, he twisted the arm backward and swept Luka's

legs out from under him. The long-haired boy crashed face-first into the floor with a sickening thud. Kristoffer didn't hesitate—he wrenched Luka's arm, the audible *pop* of a dislocated joint making everyone in the room flinch.

Ben's expression twisted into shock before he charged forward. Kristoffer pivoted smoothly, meeting him with a precise punch to the throat. Ben crumpled instantly, clutching his neck and gasping for air.

The sound of shuffling feet signaled more attackers. Two boys rushed him at once, but Kristoffer was faster. He ducked under a wild swing, countering with a sharp strike to one's temple. The second attacker barely had time to react before an elbow to his jaw sent him sprawling. Both hit the ground, unmoving.

The tension in the room spiked as a nimble girl with hawk-like eyes leapt from the top bunk, a long knife gleaming in her hand. She landed with feline grace and pointed the blade at him.

"Drop to the ground or I'll use it," she snarled.

Kristoffer tilted his head, his expression chillingly cold. "Give it your best shot. Just so you know, I treat both genders equally."

Daria lunged, aiming for his chest with practiced precision. But Kristoffer was ready. His hand shot out, grabbing her slim wrist. He twisted it painfully, and snatched the knife from her. In the same breath, he headbutted her with brutal force, the crunch of

broken bone echoing as she stumbled back, blood pouring from her broken nose.

Kristoffer turned his attention back to Luka, who lay writhing on the floor, eyes wide with terror. He crouched beside him, grabbed a fistful of hair, and yanked Luka's head upward. With the knife in hand, Kristoffer sliced off a few strands of his long hair.

"I'm starting with your hair because, as I said, I'm a pacifist." Kristoffer reminded him, his voice eerily calm. "Now, do you have something to say to Ana?"

"I—I'm sorry! I'm sorry!" Luka stammered, his voice cracking with fear.

"But don't apologize to me," Kristoffer replied, pressing Luka's head down, forcing his forehead to hit the floor. "Say it to her. Properly."

Luka whimpered as he struggled to kneel, his dislocated arm hanging limp at his side. He looked up at Ana, his face streaked with sweat and tears.

"I'm sorry," he mumbled with a shaky voice.

"Tell her exactly what you're sorry for. In detail," Kristoffer ordered.

"I'm sorry for hitting you, I'm sorry for calling you names and mocking you, I'm sorry for ripping your clothes and attacking you, I'm sorry for—" Luka's litany was cut short by a swift kick to the head from Kristoffer.

Kristoffer straightened, his firm voice cutting through the tense silence. "I know everyone's watching, so listen closely. We can all be friends or enemies, and I'm fine with either. But if anyone ever touches Ana again, I will personally cut their dicks off." He turned and looked at Daria, still holding her bleeding nose. "And if you don't have one, I'll think of something else. Don't test me. And I'm keeping the knife. Try something when I'm attending to Lady Sofia, and when I come back, you're all dead."

Ignoring the terrified faces around him, Kristoffer grabbed Ana's hand.

"Come on, Ana. I'll show you how to use a knife properly, so you never end up like her."

"I don't want to go either, but if we decline this invitation, the rest of the nobility will see it as an open declaration of war," Eduard Elernes argued, his tone laced with frustration after nearly half an hour of trying to convince his wife.

"I can count on one hand how many times I've spoken to Valron," Isabelle retorted, pouring herself another glass of wine. "And I don't even know this Bayan fellow who oversees his business. It's highly suspicious that he'd invite us on such short notice."

Their discussion was interrupted by a knock at the door.

"My Lord, Commander Berian is requesting an audience," Ernest announced from the hallway.

Both Eduard and Isabelle raised their eyebrows in surprise. It was late in the evening, and Berian had never stopped by unannounced before.

“Let him in,” Eduard said, hastily buttoning up his shirt.

When Berian entered, the old soldier’s usual warm expression was replaced by one of visible exhaustion. He nodded politely, then closed the door carefully behind him.

“I apologize for intruding without notice, but this is a matter of great urgency,” Berian said, cutting straight to the point. “Can we speak safely in this room?”

Isabelle set her wine glass down and drew the curtains, her movements deliberate. It wasn’t often that she saw such a grave expression on her old friend’s face.

“The walls are enchanted,” Eduard assured him. “No one will overhear us. What’s happened, Berian?” He gestured toward an empty armchair.

“You should both sit as well. This will take some time to explain.” Berian lowered himself into the chair and began recounting everything he had learned from Sofia.

As Berian spoke, detailing the attack on their daughter, Isabelle got up and paced the room, trying to calm her rising anger. But she didn’t interrupt, even for a second. Eduard, on the other hand, sat stone-still, his brow furrowed as he absorbed every word, trying to not miss any details.

"I left the garrison as soon as my responsibilities allowed and headed here immediately," Berian concluded. "A trusted man of mine was instructed to release her servant, and Sofia should now be safe under Borgman and Rena's watch. The school launched a search party for Valron's son this morning." He finished his report and accepted a glass of water Eduard had poured for him.

"That's it," Isabelle declared, her voice trembling with rage as she came to a halt. "I'm going to dissect Valron slowly and savor every moment of it."

"Calm down, Iz," Eduard interjected, though his own voice was tight with anger. "It's not that simple. We have no proof, and Valron has the backing of Duke Garnez. Acting rashly will only escalate things further." He began pacing himself, his hands clenched into fists. "That bastard. I can understand coming after me, but how could he target our daughter? This changes everything. That invitation—it's obviously connected to what happened. He might be planning to eliminate us as revenge for his son."

"I can't believe I'm saying this," Isabelle muttered through clenched teeth, "but we may need to talk to Ralezo. With the backing of another duke, we could afford to be openly hostile."

"It may be our best option," Eduard admitted grimly. "But first, we need to get Sofia out of that academy immediately. We can't risk them coming after her again." He moved to his desk, opened a drawer, and began pulling out papers.

“Sorry to interrupt again, but your daughter strongly insisted that I inform you she is not going anywhere,” Berian murmured awkwardly. “That doesn’t mean I agree with her decision—I’m just the messenger.”

“Thank you for bringing this to us, Berian,” Isabelle said, giving him a quick hug before resuming her restless pacing around the room.

“I’ll go there tomorrow and bring her back by force if I have to,” Eduard declared angrily. “She’s being utterly irresponsible if she thinks staying among her enemies is a good idea under these circumstances.”

“Eduard, calm down,” Isabelle said, placing a firm hand on his cheek and looking into his eyes. “You were the one who warned against acting rashly. They won’t even let you into the academy without prior arrangements. If she refuses to leave, there’s nothing you can do about it. As long as she’s with the teachers and Kristoffer, she’ll be safe. Think about how well she’s handled everything so far. You have to trust her. She wants to contribute to our family too.”

Eduard sighed deeply, letting her words sink in as he dropped heavily into the chair behind his desk. He rubbed his temples, gathering his thoughts, and then glanced at Berian, who remained standing in an awkward silence.

“Berian, thank you for taking the time to come to us, even with your packed schedule,” Eduard said, bowing his head in gratitude. “You’ve saved our family once again. Would you consider spending the night here? No offense, but you look like you could really use a proper bed and a hot meal.”

“Thank you for the offer, but I must get back to work,” Berian replied, rising to his feet. “I’m on my way to another garrison and need to arrive tonight. Besides, it’s probably best if no one knows I stopped here.”

He paused by the door and added, “If you need my help with this situation, don’t hesitate to contact me. I’ll do whatever I can to support you.”

After Berian left, the room fell into a heavy silence. Isabelle and Eduard exchanged a long, meaningful look before Eduard finally spoke.

“Let’s figure out a plan,” he said, his voice measured and resolute. “We can’t disclose the full details of what happened to Ralezo, but under these circumstances, we also can’t afford to decline Valron’s invitation.”

And so began one of the most serious discussions they ever had.

New teacher

"This is very bad." Sofia rose from her seat the moment Lisa finished her story. "We need to go there immediately. Kristoffer is... unpredictable when something bad happens to people close to him."

"But, Lady Sofia, the gate to the dorm is already closed," Lisa said hesitantly. "I don't think they'll let us in. Can't it wait until morning?"

Sofia spun to face her, already fastening the buttons on her coat. Her tone was firm. "You haven't seen this side of him, Lisa. And trust me—you don't want to."

Without another word, Sofia led the way toward the Lower Worlders' quarters at a brisk pace, her heels clicking sharply against the stone paths. Just as Lisa had predicted, they were stopped at the gate by a stern-looking guard.

"The area is closed for the day," the guard informed them flatly, his arms crossed over his chest.

"But my servant forgot to deliver crucial information," Sofia said, her voice tinged with urgency. "It concerns the Earl, and we need it resolved tonight." Her expression softened dramatically, her wide eyes shimmering as if on the verge of tears.

The guard hesitated, frowning. He clearly wasn't convinced, but something about Sofia's earnest demeanor didn't let him ignore her. After a long pause, he relented with a sigh. "Fine. But you'll need to sign the guest book so there aren't any problems later. What's your name? And the servant's name?"

"Sofia Elernes," she answered sweetly. "And the servant is Kristoffer."

"Wait here. I'll bring him out." The guard disappeared through the gate, locking it behind him.

"Lady Sofia," Lisa whispered, leaning closer, "sometimes it scares me how easily you manipulate men."

Sofia chuckled softly, a sly smile tugging at her lips. "Not all of them. But most are simple creatures, really." She glanced at Lisa with a raised brow. "And you're one to talk—didn't you find your way to the Upper World using this exact approach?"

"Making sad faces wouldn't have gotten me this far," Lisa muttered defensively. "That's entirely different."

Before Sofia could reply, the guard returned with Kristoffer in tow. "Here he is," he said, unlocking the gate. "The instructors said you have three minutes."

"Thank you," Sofia replied politely, already grabbing Kristoffer by the arm. "That will be more than enough." She tugged him aside, gesturing for Lisa to follow. They moved out of earshot, huddling in a quiet corner.

"What happened, Lady Sofia?" Kristoffer whispered, his brow furrowed with concern. His eyes flicked between her and Lisa.

"Nothing happened—at least, not yet. But what about you?" Sofia's voice dropped, her eyes boring into his. "Lisa told me about Ana. Did you do something... reckless?"

Kristoffer sighed, his tone a mix of exasperation and mild hurt. "Lady Sofia, you seem to have a very low opinion of me lately."

"That's because you keep proving me right," Sofia retorted sharply. "So, what happened? Don't tell me it's nothing."

Kristoffer straightened his posture. "I talked to Ana. We figured things out."

"Figured things out?" Sofia's voice sharpened. "What exactly does that mean? Start with the things you consider 'not worth mentioning.'"

"We had a discussion with the people who were bothering her," Kristoffer explained, his tone steady. "They apologized and promised to correct their behavior."

Lisa folded her arms and raised a brow. "You *discussed* it? With Luka, Toren, and Daria?" she asked, her voice dripping with skepticism.

Sofia's eyes narrowed, her expression deadly serious. "Kristoffer," she asked pointedly, "did you kill him?"

His jaw tightened, but he met her intense gaze without flinching. "No, Lady Sofia, I didn't kill anyone," he replied firmly. "And frankly, it hurts that you'd even think I would."

"Hey! Your time's up!" the guard called out from the gate, his voice echoing across the courtyard.

Sofia raised her voice just enough for the guard to hear. "He's coming now!" She turned back to Kristoffer, her voice low and urgent. "Please, don't let your emotions get the better of you. Act with reason, Kristoffer. Do you understand?"

He nodded once, his face unreadable. "Yes, Lady Sofia."

Without another word, Kristoffer walked back toward the gate.

Lisa sighed, watching him disappear behind the heavy iron gate. "We should've called Ana. She'd tell us what really happened."

"You'll ask her tomorrow," Sofia replied, brushing a speck of dust from her coat. "It was just as important to remind him to keep his emotions in check." She pulled her coat tighter around her. "Let's get back—it's freezing out here. I have a meeting with Professor Borgman right after breakfast."

But as they made their way toward the dormitories, Sofia stopped abruptly. At the academy's main gate, dimly illuminated by a flickering lantern, a familiar silhouette caught her attention. Though the light was faint, she recognized the figure immediately. "Professor Rosalia?" Sofia called out, her voice tinged with surprise.

The figure at the gate stopped mid-argument with the guard and turned toward her.

"Sofia!" Rosalia exclaimed, her tone both relieved and irritated. "Can you help me get in? These morons refuse to let me through."

After a brief exchange to clarify the situation, Sofia signed the necessary papers, allowing Rosalia entry. Once inside, she led her former teacher to her place. Lisa, always quick on her feet, began preparing tea as the two women sank into the armchairs, grateful for the warmth of the room.

"I've been trying to get in here for a week now," Rosalia began, pulling off her gloves with exaggerated annoyance. "They told me you were away for training and wouldn't return for two more weeks. All I wanted was to notify the school that you're a certified third-circle mage so you could skip the entrance exams." She scoffed. "But those fools wouldn't listen to a word I said because I'm blacklisted from their precious academy."

"Did they blacklist you after firing you, Professor Rosalia?" Sofia asked, her tone both curious and amused.

"Something like that," Rosalia admitted with a grin, her eyes glinting mischievously. "Specifically, after I broke a window—one of the professors had it coming." She waved a hand dismissively, as though it were a trivial matter. "Anyway, you're back early. How was it? Are you done with the exam already?"

"Yes. I was assigned to Class A," Sofia replied. "They gave us the option of taking an additional exam for advanced placement, and both I and Duke Garnez's son passed. It allowed us to choose any professor for a week of private tutoring."

"That's fantastic news!" Rosalia beamed. "I'm sorry I couldn't deliver the papers in time. Still, your third-circle certification will come in handy—it grants you access to restricted areas of the library. So, who did you both choose as your tutors?"

"I chose Professor Borgman. I want to study mana frequencies in-depth and, if possible, delve into the forbidden aspects of rune writing and medical knowledge," Sofia explained. "As for Erik Garnez, he picked the headmaster. He's been boasting non-stop about learning from the most powerful mage in the Upper World. Apparently, his ambition is to become the strongest mage alive."

Rosalia snorted derisively. "That's a stupid choice then. Alden might be strong, but he's nowhere near Luna Oswell's level. The only reason he became headmaster is that he spent a decade running a political campaign to secure the position."

"Luna Oswell?" Sofia tilted her head, intrigued. "I don't recognize that name. Who is she?"

Rosalia hesitated, clearly searching for the right words. "She's a bit... peculiar. Luna locks herself up for days or just disappears somewhere for weeks without a word. Many people wanted her to become the headmaster or at least take a position in the

Tower, but she is like a stray cat. However, since she is so talented in multiple branches of magic, the school still lets her teach even though she sometimes fails to attend her own lesson. You might have the chance to choose her for extracurricular lessons in your second semester."

Sofia's brows lifted. "She sounds fascinating."

"She is," Rosalia admitted, leaning back in her chair. "But don't expect consistency. She'll either blow your mind with her knowledge or forget you exist for weeks."

"Interesting," Sofia mused. Then, glancing at the clock, she added, "Professor Rosalia, would you like to stay the night? We have a spare bed, and it's already late. I'll have to get up early for my meeting with Professor Borgman, so I can't keep you company for long tonight."

Rosalia waved a hand dismissively. "Oh, no need for that. I just wanted to drop off your badge and certification. I'll head back to my place—I prefer my own bed, anyway." Rising to her feet, she smiled warmly at Sofia. "It was good to see you again. I expect you to give those arrogant pricks here a taste of what real magic looks like."

"It was nice seeing you too, Professor Rosalia." Sofia stood and gave her teacher a quick hug before waving goodbye.

As the door closed behind her mentor, Sofia sighed deeply and collapsed onto the soft bed. Tomorrow, she thought, would be another long day.

“We’ve got newcomers today,” the instructor announced, his voice steady but commanding as he surveyed the group assembled in the training area. Everyone stood ready, clad in basic armor and gripping practice spears. “That’s why we’ll start by reviewing the fundamentals before the sparring sessions. After today, the class will be split into beginner and advanced groups. The division isn’t permanent, but it should solve the problem of more talented students being held back by the others.”

Arnold had been teaching for over thirty years, and he wasn’t blind to the tension simmering beneath the surface. He could feel it in the way some students exchanged furtive glances, others standing stiff and uneasy. Something had gone down yesterday. It wasn’t hard to guess—probably scuffles over hierarchy. Arnold had trained Lower Worlders outside the city many times and observed their natural tendency to establish a strict hierarchy within their groups. The academy anticipated similar behavior here but had decided in advance not to interfere unless the situation escalated beyond control.

He demonstrated the basics again: footwork, proper grip, basic thrusts, and the importance of feints and gauging distance. His

voice was sharp but encouraging as he emphasized how mastering these fundamentals laid the foundation for any good fighter. “The difference between a novice and an expert,” he explained, “is often just one step out of place. Remember that.”

When he asked the students to repeat the movements, Arnold’s keen eyes caught something off. Luka, one of the more promising trainees, was fumbling with his spear. The boy’s grip was awkward, and his movements lacked their usual precision. Arnold strode over, his expression firm but not unkind.

“What’s wrong with your arm?” he asked, his tone low enough to avoid drawing unnecessary attention.

Luka’s face blanched, fear flashing across his features like a lightning strike. Arnold recognized that look all too well—it was the look of someone cornered, someone who’d been threatened. The boy glanced quickly to the side, as though seeking an escape, or perhaps trying to avoid someone’s gaze. Arnold followed his line of sight but found nothing immediately suspicious.

“I... I must’ve hurt it during training yesterday,” Luka mumbled, his voice barely audible.

“Don’t lie to me,” Arnold said, his tone leaving no room for argument.

Arnold wasn’t one to interfere in student squabbles, but he disliked the idea of losing a talented fighter. Strong competitors

drove the whole group to improve, and a group without competition became stagnant. If someone was intimidating Luka—or worse, injuring others—Arnold had to find the culprit and deal with the situation before it worsened.

“It was him,” a sharp voice interjected.

Arnold turned to see one of the girls pointing across the training area. Her face was bruised, her nose clearly broken, ruining what was once strikingly pretty features. Arnold recognized her—she’d shown potential, but he’d noticed her tendency to pick on weaker students. It seemed her bullying had backfired.

The instructor followed the direction of her finger to a boy standing off to the side. He was plain-looking—average height, average build, messy hair that looked like it hadn’t seen a comb in days. There was nothing outwardly intimidating about him. Nothing, except for his eyes.

Those green eyes were sharp, intense, and calculating. Even now, Arnold felt the boy sizing him up, analyzing his movements, his posture, perhaps even his weaknesses.

“Is it true?” Arnold asked, his voice firm as he addressed the boy.

“Did you hurt Luka?”

The boy met his gaze, unflinching. “Luka got hurt because of his rape attempt,” he replied evenly, his voice cold and precise.

A stunned silence fell over the group. Arnold turned back to Luka, his eyebrows raised in silent inquiry. The boy refused to meet his

gaze, his head lowering in shame. That was all the confirmation Arnold needed.

“What’s your name?” the instructor asked, shifting his attention back to the boy.

“Kristoffer,” he replied.

“You’ll spar with me, Kristoffer,” Arnold announced, stepping into the center of the training area. “Come here. The rest of you, watch closely—I’ll demonstrate the basics in practice.”

The other students quickly cleared a wide circle, eager to witness what was about to unfold. Kristoffer stepped forward, his movements cautious but confident. Though he hesitated for the briefest of moments, there was no fear in his eyes—only calm resolve.

Arnold studied him carefully. Despite his unassuming appearance, there was something dangerous about this boy. It wasn’t just the way he carried himself—it was the way he looked at the world, as though every moment, every encounter, was a puzzle to solve.

“Do you have any experience with a spear?” Arnold asked, holding his own weapon loosely but with clear authority.

“More with a sword,” Kristoffer replied, adjusting his grip on the weapon, “but I’ve used a spear from time to time.” Then he hesitated for a moment before adding, “Professor, aren’t you going to wear any armor?”

Arnold let out a hearty laugh. “Do you think I’ll need it?” he teased, his confidence unwavering. “And don’t call me ‘Professor.’ I’m no academic. Attack whenever you’re ready.”

Kristoffer shifted into a ready stance, lowering his center of gravity with a textbook-perfect posture. The spacing between his feet, the grip on the spear, and even the subtle arch of his back exuded precision and discipline. Arnold’s lips curled into a smile; he loved moments like this—spotting raw talent that could be refined into something exceptional.

The boy sprang forward, his spear darting in a sharp, clean thrust. Arnold sidestepped and deflected the strike effortlessly, countering with a precise jab of his own. But Kristoffer wasn’t thrown off balance. Instead, he moved with fluid adaptability, dodging the attack by stepping to the side and leaning just enough to avoid the blow. Without wasting a moment, he pivoted and swept at Arnold’s legs in one smooth motion.

Arnold, quick as ever, leaped over the attempt and followed up with another thrust. The exchange was fast and dynamic, a back-and-forth that left the other students gaping. Kristoffer wasn’t just holding his own; he was pushing the instructor to exert effort.

Finally, Arnold exploited his superior reach, landing a controlled strike against the boy’s forearm protector. The sound of the blow echoed through the training area.

“Not bad!” Arnold praised, his grin wide. “Again! This time, aim higher. You’re too focused on the legs. Go for the chest—it’s a bigger and easier target.”

They squared off once more. This time, the bout lasted twice as long before Arnold managed to tap Kristoffer’s chest plate with a light hit. By now, Arnold’s curiosity had turned into certainty—these movements, the patterns of attack and defense—they were familiar.

“Ernest taught you, didn’t he?” Arnold asked suddenly, his tone more amused than accusatory.

Kristoffer froze for just a heartbeat, but the reaction was enough. Arnold’s laughter boomed across the training area.

“Fate is a fickle mistress,” the instructor said, shaking his head in disbelief. But then he glanced around at the gathered students, remembering that this was still a lesson. “Want to train with me for the rest of the session? You’ve got potential, but I can help you iron out those weak spots. The spear, after all, is called the ‘king of weapons’ for a reason.”

Kristoffer shook his head, glancing toward Ana, the girl who had spent the last week as the group’s scapegoat. “Thank you, sir, but for now, I’d like to practice with Ana.”

Arnold followed his gaze and saw the girl. She looked different today—no longer weighed down by fear or shame. Instead, her face was lit with a glimmer of hope, a stark contrast to how she’d

been before. Arnold allowed himself a small smile at the sight. These kids, with all their raw emotions and untamed loyalty, always managed to get under his skin.

“Fair enough,” Arnold said, nodding approvingly. “Back to class, everyone! Pair up! Newcomers will work with the lower ranks to get up to speed. Let’s get moving!”

It wasn’t easy for Borgman to explain the situation to the headmaster, especially since he himself didn’t fully understand it. He’d never interacted with Sofia Elernes before, and he had no idea why she had chosen him—of all the professors available—as her private tutor. With her exceptional ability to control mana, he couldn’t see what someone of his level could offer her. Borgman thought of himself as more of a researcher than a mage, and there were dozens of professors far better suited to mentor a young, gifted prodigy like her.

“Good morning, Miss Elernes,” he greeted her as she entered his small office.



“Good morning, Professor Borgman.” Her cheerful smile seemed to brighten the entire room. But Borgman couldn’t forget the cold,

detached expression she wore when she killed the darkclaw during the examination with a single wave of her hand.

“Since we’ve never had the chance to properly introduce ourselves,” he began, rising from his seat and placing a hand over his chest, “I believe we should start by doing so. My name is Borgman Vandick. I specialize in mana research, particularly in its nature and origins. As you may have heard, many of my theses are... controversial, especially the one about mana’s origin.”

“I’m Sofia, from House Elernes,” she replied with a polite humility that didn’t quite match her impressive reputation. “It’s a pleasure to meet you, Professor. I’ve read some of your work.”

“You have?” Borgman blinked in surprise. Few students ever bothered to read his publications, especially since his research was often mocked by the wider academic community. “We’ll discuss that later. First, if you don’t mind, I’d like to ask you a few questions about your recent time in the sanctuary. Please, have a seat. This might take a while.”

Sofia nodded and walked toward the chair, her gaze wandering around the room. The walls were lined floor to ceiling with books, scrolls, and papers—references for Borgman’s ongoing work. While he barely noticed the musty smell of old paper anymore, he could see that the young noblewoman was distracted by it.

“The first thing I’d like to discuss is the report you submitted regarding your time in the sanctuary,” Borgman began, sitting

back down. “You spent four nights deep in the forest, and yet you claim that not a single mana beast attacked you. Is that correct?”

“Yes, there were no incidents of that sort,” Sofia confirmed, absentmindedly tucking a strand of her golden, wavy hair behind her ear.

“That’s very peculiar, Miss Elernes. All the other students reported multiple attacks—exactly as we expected. We specifically instructed the hunters to let weaker mana beasts through to test everyone’s abilities.” Borgman leaned forward, studying her face closely for any sign of deceit.

“Maybe I just got lucky?” she said softly, almost as if questioning herself.

Her expression seemed sincere, and Borgman couldn’t decide whether she was an exceptionally skilled liar or genuinely telling the truth. If it was the latter, though, the question remained: why? With her potent mana signature, she should have been the first target for any mana beast. Choosing to set that mystery aside for now, he moved on to the second question that had been nagging at him since the examination.

“My next question concerns your encounter with the darkclaw,” Borgman said, folding his hands together on the desk. “While rumors about you being a silent caster have spread like wildfire among the students, I’ve done enough research on the topic to know that wasn’t the case.” His sharp eyes shifted to the rings

adorning her fingers. “Your mana control is truly exceptional, but I sensed something distinct about the spell’s origin in that brief moment. I won’t push you, but if you’re willing to show me the ring you channeled mana through at that time, it would be a gesture of trust—a foundation for a mutually beneficial relationship between us. I assure you, whatever you share with me today, along with any future matters, will never leave this office.”

For the first time since Sofia had arrived, Borgman noticed a shift in her expression. The subtle change reassured him—her earlier statements were most likely truthful. She seemed to be the kind of person whose emotions were written plainly across her face. For a brief moment, she appeared to be calculating, weighing the risks and benefits of her next move. After some hesitation, she slowly removed the ring from her middle finger.

“All right,” she said, her tone firm. “But that makes us accomplices, Professor Borgman. From now on, I trust that every conversation we have will stay between us.” Her sharp gaze lingered on him as she handed over the silver ring.

“I give you my word as a researcher,” Borgman replied solemnly, carefully taking the small accessory from her.

The moment he held it, his eyes widened in awe. The inside of the ring was engraved with an intricate array of minuscule, complex runes. Borgman immediately recognized many ancient symbols he had studied long ago. This artifact was worth more than

everything he owned combined. It was a masterpiece—a skilled craftsman must have spent months, perhaps even years, creating something of this caliber. The fact that such delicate inscriptions functioned at all was nothing short of astounding.

“Could you tell me who designed this? And who crafted it?” Borgman asked, his voice barely above a whisper, as if speaking louder might cause the artifact to vanish.

“Unfortunately, that’s not possible,” Sofia replied, her tone calm but firm. “It’s a family secret.” She reached out to retrieve the ring.

Borgman reluctantly forced himself to return the artifact, though every fiber of his being begged to spend hours, if not days, analyzing it.

“Many nobles might consider it cheating to rely on magic items,” Borgman admitted, “but using a delicate magic circle like that requires an incredibly high level of mana control. And you used it without a catalyst to focus your mana. Even knowing your secret, I’m still impressed.” He paused, then added gravely, “Keeping it a secret is wise. I know people who would kill to get their hands on something like this.”

“I’ll remember your advice,” Sofia said with a polite nod as she slipped the ring back onto her finger.

“I have one last question, Miss Elernes,” Borgman said, leaning back in his chair. “Why did you choose me as your tutor? I’m well aware there are far better mages here.”

“Because there are some things only you can teach me, Professor Borgman,” Sofia replied with a bright smile. “For example, your research on mana frequencies. I’d love to work with you on that.”

Her smile, innocent and sincere, made Borgman feel a decade younger. There was something disarmingly contagious about her enthusiasm.

“I’m afraid there isn’t much to work on,” he sighed. “My research in that area has hit a dead end. The theory can’t be proven or disproven at this point.”

“All I’m looking for is some guidance,” Sofia said with a light tone. “Maybe you could help me with a small project I’ve been working on.” She reached into her bag and pulled out a wand made of dark wood. At its tip was a green gem, which began to glow faintly.

Suddenly, a vivid blue bird materialized in the air. It flapped its wings and began to circle the room. Borgman blinked, stunned, as the creature moved with lifelike fluidity before dissolving into shimmering mana particles.

“As it stands now,” Sofia explained, “I can only manipulate the mana frequencies for a brief moment. I was thinking—”

“WHAT WAS THAT SPELL?!” Borgman exclaimed, slamming his palms on the desk as he shot to his feet.

“It’s not really a spell,” Sofia said, startled by his outburst. “It’s more of a failed spell that I’ve learned to misfire in a controlled way.”

“Can you teach it to me?!” Borgman’s eyes gleamed with excitement, an expression more suited to a child than an aging scholar. “This could be a huge breakthrough in my research!”

“That depends,” Sofia said with a sly grin. “Would you teach me about the forbidden magic circles and the medical techniques labeled as necromancy—the ones that were locked away?”

Borgman’s expression turned serious. He scrutinized his new student, searching her face for any hint of mockery or deception.

Borgman’s expression hardened as he studied Sofia carefully, ensuring she wasn’t mocking him.

“That’s forbidden knowledge,” he said firmly. “It can only be taught after you graduate and obtain a specialized position in a related field.”

“There is no profession like that,” Sofia countered calmly. “The only way I could gain access would be by becoming an archivist. But even then, it would still be illegal.”

“You’ve done your homework,” Borgman sighed deeply. “Even if I agreed, the foundational materials written by Moonfick are in the restricted section. No one is allowed to remove them, and copying them is a capital offense—punishable by death. The

headmaster is the only person who could grant access, and I highly doubt he'd approve."

"As it happens, I already have access to the restricted section as a third-circle mage," Sofia said with a knowing smile.

"That's impossible," Borgman replied, his tone tinged with disbelief.

Sofia reached into her satchel and produced an official badge, as though she'd anticipated this very conversation. She handed it to Borgman, who inspected it closely. There was no question—it was an authentic certificate, issued by the Tower, granting Sofia Elernes access.

"You're full of surprises, aren't you?" Borgman shook his head in resignation. "Fine, I give up. I don't like that you're starting our relationship with a bribe, but I'm looking forward to working with you."

"Not a bribe—negotiation," Sofia corrected, extending her hand.

Borgman chuckled as he shook it. "Fair enough. I'll need a few hours to reorganize my research and dig up my unpublished materials on mana frequencies. In the meantime, go read up on what you need. Let's meet back here 30 minutes after the lunch bell."

"Sounds good," Sofia said, rising from her chair and heading toward the door.

“Miss Elernes,” Borgman called after her. “If you tell me what you’re looking for, I might be able to help. I know the library like the back of my hand, and I don’t mind keeping one more secret with my student.” He raised his eyebrows suggestively.

Sofia hesitated, then decided to trust her gut. “I’m looking for research on removing the servant-master contract from one’s core. My mother is one of the foremost experts in this field, but she refuses to teach me about it.”

Borgman’s expression darkened with recognition. Isabelle. He had known Sofia’s mother in her younger days, and the resemblance was striking—not just in their appearance but in their shared defiance of societal expectations. He missed the era when students had that same rebellious drive. Back then, the university had been alive with the pursuit of knowledge, a place where curiosity flourished. Now, it felt like a cold, political institution, disconnected from its original purpose.

“The answer to that question isn’t pleasant, Miss Elernes,” Borgman said after a pause. “Aside from the consequences, you’d need someone with magic precision at the highest level.” He stopped mid-sentence as he recalled Sofia’s earlier display—how she’d decapitated a Darkclaw with the ease of slicing paper. “But maybe...”

“The highest level of precision...” Sofia murmured, her mind racing. “Would it be possible to perform this technique on oneself?”

“On oneself?” Borgman repeated, unable to hide his astonishment. “I don’t think it’s even remotely possible. And regardless, the university strictly forbids me from teaching you about it. So, stop pressing the matter. Oh, and definitely don’t look for the book *Ascension*—middle shelf, far-right corner of the library.” He leaned back in his chair, a sly smile tugging at the corners of his mouth. “Now, come back in the afternoon, and we’ll focus on that intriguing spell you demonstrated earlier. Dismissed.”

Sofia couldn’t help but flash a cheeky grin as she exited the office. It was comforting to know that, even in a place as stifling and rigid as the university, there were still individuals like Borgman—genuine people with a true passion for the pursuit of knowledge.

Keith was the only male servant of Katrina Welder. As the third son of a high-ranking noble in the Holy Kingdom, he had no inheritance to claim. To secure the family’s influence and prevent internal disputes, his father sent him to the school for the chosen ones—after all, having a servant of the gods in the family was a prestigious honor.

Keith didn’t mind. He had little interest in the life of an aristocrat. While he enjoyed hunting and falconry, lavish banquets left him drained. With his tall, well-built frame, a decent face, and noble lineage, he naturally attracted attention whenever he returned

home. Many young women sought his favor, but romance never interested him. The interactions felt shallow, artificial—until he met Carla.

She was thirteen when she won first place in the girls' fencing competition, and Keith still remembered the moment vividly. The way she removed her protective mask after the final match, revealing a radiant, genuine smile—it became one of his core memories. Some whispered against her, claiming the black marks on her face were an imperfection unfit for a servant of the gods. But to Keith, they only enhanced her beauty, complementing the aura of strength and confidence she carried.

As they grew older, mixed competitions became more common, allowing him more opportunities to see the mysterious girl. The first time he spoke to her, his chest tightened, and he spent the entire night restless, her playful smile and the scent of herbs from her apron lingering in his thoughts.

So, it came as no surprise when, two years later, Carla was chosen by the gods. Keith had expected it—he knew she was destined for something greater—but acceptance was another matter. The thought of spending the rest of his life in the Lower World without her left him hollow. He returned to his studies, preparing for future ceremonies like the rest of those who had failed to be chosen. But joy drained from his life. He lost his appetite, struggled to sleep, and found himself staring blankly at

books he once loved. Everything that once brought him happiness now felt like a chore.

For half a year, he lived like that—until, slowly, his heart began to mend. Though he still missed her, he poured himself into his training, determined to become a bishop and help those in need. He had learned Carla’s story and wanted to ensure no one else suffered as she once had.

But fate had other plans.

During a ceremony, the gods chose him. It felt unreal, like a dream. After undergoing health inspections and sterilization, his new master came to visit him. Katrina Welder was sweet—kind and welcoming—but Keith barely noticed her. Because standing beside her was Carla.

It was as if destiny had granted him another chance.

From that moment, Keith’s world regained its color. Every task, no matter how mundane, felt meaningful. He and Carla bonded with their new master, spending their days working, talking, and sharing meals together. For the first time in a long while, he felt truly alive. Sometimes, though, an anxious thought crept in—what if this was all just a fleeting dream? What if he woke up and found himself back in his old, empty life?

As time passed, a shadow began to cloud his heart. Lady Katrina had grown closer to Sofia Elernes, and whenever Sofia visited, she brought along her male servant. Keith had spoken with the

man a few times—Kristoffer was a bit peculiar, but overall, a decent guy. Even so, Keith couldn't shake his unease whenever he saw Kristoffer interacting with Carla. It was as if the two operated on the same wavelength, effortlessly understanding each other. Within weeks, Keith realized that Kristoffer's relationship with Carla was already deeper than his own.

He tried to rationalize it, telling himself that Carla's happiness mattered more than anything. But no matter how much he reasoned, he couldn't stop the bitterness welling up inside him. Every time she laughed at Kristoffer's jokes, touched his arm, or absentmindedly twirled her hair while talking to him, Keith felt an unbearable knot tightening in his chest.

Kristoffer eventually noticed something was off and asked him directly about Carla, but Keith couldn't admit his feelings. What was the point? It felt like Kristoffer was offering to step aside out of pity—and that was something Keith could never accept. He kept telling himself that resenting the man was unreasonable. Kristoffer hadn't done anything wrong. But despite his best efforts, Keith couldn't help it.

His torment reached its peak when school began, and Kristoffer left with Carla for a week-long training camp in the forest. It was pure mental torture. Sleep evaded him, his patience ran thin, and even the smallest things set him on edge. Ana and Lisa, whom he genuinely liked, were struggling with bullying, but their problems felt insignificant compared to the storm raging inside him. His

mind tormented him with visions of Carla and Kristoffer together, scenarios that made him physically ill.

That's why, when Kristoffer returned from camp and shifted all his attention to Ana, Keith felt nothing but relief. Kristoffer spent his days training and talking with her, and at night, the two of them even shared a bed, curled up together like siblings. It was enough to help Keith regain some perspective—Kristoffer really was a good person. More importantly, it meant Keith could spend more time with Carla. Their shared lessons and free time became more enjoyable, and when they weren't with the Elernes servants, it was just the two of them. Life felt like a dream once again.

That was until the sixth day after Carla returned.

"After Ana won today's spar with Daria, I think she'll be fine even when I'm with Lady Sofia," Kristoffer said with pride as they walked back to the dorm after farming class. "Though I still don't get how she ended up friends with a servant from Duke Garnez."

"It's less like friendship and more like adoption," Keith laughed. "I feel bad for her. Looks like the duke made her do some horrible things. You sure it's a good idea for Ana to stay?"

"She's finally feeling comfortable here. I get why she wants to secure her position," Kristoffer replied, waving at a few familiar faces as they passed. "She'll leave next week, so it shouldn't be a problem."

“Arnold’s going to be devastated, it will bite us in the ass. He’s been going easy on us since you two started training together,” Keith groaned. But his frustration melted away as his eyes brightened at the sight of Carla and Ana approaching from their own class. “Looks like they’re done too.”

As they got closer, Keith noticed another figure trailing behind Ana—Nina, the servant of Duke Garnez. She looked so fragile, as if a strong gust of wind could shatter her into pieces.

“I feel like a whore after those classes,” Carla grumbled. “I’m so glad I’m going back to Lady Katrina tomorrow.”

“It’s not that bad,” Ana giggled. “Now you’ll be able to seduce her with your sensual dance moves.”

“The more I hear about your lessons, the more unfair farming class feels,” Kristoffer chimed in, finally catching the girls’ attention.

“Maybe you should ask Arnold for a favor and try to switch,” Carla teased. “I’m sure you’d look fantastic dancing on a pole in a skimpy bikini.”

“Thanks,” Ana rolled her eyes in an exaggerated manner. “Now that image will haunt me for the rest of my life. Kristoffer, I’m sleeping with Nina tonight. She needs some love and cuddles.”

Nina visibly stiffened, and her cheeks turned beet red in an instant.

“Fine by me. I’ve spoiled you too much lately anyway,” Kristoffer replied, ruffling Ana’s hair.

“Don’t treat me like a child!” she pouted, but made no effort to move away.

Keith rolled his eyes. “If you’re done with your skits, can we go eat? I’m starving after all that plowing.” He rubbed his stomach for emphasis.

“Let’s go. Our big man needs a big plate of food,” Carla winked at him, and with that, they all headed toward the dormitory.

Although the food wasn’t of the highest quality, eating together made it taste delicious. Between bites of boiled potatoes and eggs, the group chatted and joked, slowly attracting other Lower Worlders to join them. At first, most had been wary of Kristoffer after his actions on the first day, but over time, that fear faded. He helped others during class, shared the food he earned as a prize for his top scores in spear training, and offered protection to those too afraid to stand up to bullies. Keith had to admit—he was impressed by how much the atmosphere had changed in just one week.

Once dinner was over, everyone headed to the showers and prepared for bed. Keith sat on his lower bunk, waiting for Carla to climb up. Having her sleep on the top bunk made it harder for troublemakers to mess with her, and knowing she was safe helped him sleep better.

"I'm going to Nina's. Goodnight, guys!" Ana called, waving as she walked off.

"Are you sure?" Kristoffer asked, his tone laced with concern. "Her bed's near Daria and Luka."

"I'll be fine," Ana assured him confidently. "We talked, and I think things are going to be okay from now on. And if not, I'll scream really loud so you can come running."

She giggled and skipped off, leaving Kristoffer shaking his head in disbelief as he sat down on his bed.

"Keith, you can go to sleep," Carla said lightly. "I need to talk to Kristoffer about our plan for tomorrow since we're both going back to the Upper Worlders." She gave him a quick nod. "Goodnight."

Keith didn't respond. He just watched her walk away, his jaw tightening as she slid effortlessly into place beside Kristoffer, close enough that their shoulders touched. After a week of peace, the familiar, ugly sting of jealousy burned through him, creeping up his throat like bile.

It was fine. They needed to plan. It was for Lady Katrina's sake.

He clenched his fists and forced himself to close his eyes, repeating those words like a prayer, but they did nothing to soothe the gnawing pit in his stomach.

Then, a muffled giggle.

Keith's eyes snapped open. His body tensed.

He told himself not to look. That it was nothing. That he was just overreacting.

But after what felt like an eternity of battling with himself, he gave in. Slowly, carefully, he lifted his head just enough to see.

And what he saw shattered him.

Carla was leaning into Kristoffer, her head resting against his shoulder, fingers brushing over his cheek with an intimacy that made Keith's stomach lurch. Her lips were slightly parted, eyes half-lidded, her entire body angled toward him like she was drawn in by gravity itself.

Kristoffer, for his part, wasn't pushing her away. If anything, he looked entirely at ease, his expression amused, maybe even a little smug, as he whispered something that made Carla stifle another giggle.

Keith's heart clenched. His chest ached, a sharp, physical pain that made it hard to breathe. He wanted to turn away, to shut his eyes and erase this moment from his memory. To storm out of the room, run until his legs gave out, and scream into the night sky.

But he couldn't look away.

Carla tilted her head, her lips brushing against Kristoffer's in a featherlight touch before pressing more firmly. Keith felt his entire body go rigid. His ears rang. His vision blurred at the edges.

Then, she pushed Kristoffer onto the bed, shifting with him, their forms disappearing from Keith's sight.

For a long moment, he just stared blankly at the space where they had been, too stunned, too wrecked to move.

The soft rustling of fabric and the faint murmur of voices sent a searing pain through his skull, like an electric needle stabbing directly into his brain.

Finally, the trance broke.

Keith lowered his head and squeezed his eyes shut. He felt like he was unraveling from the inside out, torn apart and yet unbearably empty at the same time.

Curling up on his side, he clutched his pillow like it was the only thing tethering him to reality, his body curling inward as if trying to shield himself from the agony crushing him.

But no matter how hard he tried, he couldn't escape the phantom echoes of Carla's laughter, the ghost of her lips on someone else's skin.

Night had already fallen by the time Sofia closed the book with a quiet sigh, rubbing her tired eyes. For six days, she had been combing through every document Professor Borgman had gathered on the master-servant contract. As she feared, it was nothing short of a curse—one that coiled around the subject's

core, warping their will and forcing obedience, even if it meant breaking their mind.

The last incident with Valron's servant confirmed it. The boy's curse had spiraled out of control the moment his master died by Kristoffer's hand. And now, there was an even greater risk. If Kristoffer kept developing his magic while under the contract, it could kill him. His own growth was a death sentence. That was why Sofia was here, pushing through exhaustion, trying to find a way to free him. But the deeper she searched, the less hope she found.

Much of the material came from Moonfick, a long-exiled mage whose name had been erased from respectable circles due to his grotesque and forbidden experiments. Yet, despite the horrifying nature of his work, he had been a pioneer in understanding the intricate connection between the body and the source. His research held secrets that could potentially undo Kristoffer's curse and heal his arm—but at what cost?

She clenched her fists.

Moonfick had theorized that it was possible to sever a person's source from their body and transfer it elsewhere—an act that could grant eternal life. But in practice, his methods had been deemed too monstrous to be accepted. Even so, Sofia found herself combing through his work, hoping to extract something useful, something that could help Kristoffer without condemning him to the same horrors Moonfick's victims had endured.

But the solutions were nothing short of gruesome.

The only way to remove the curse runes wrapped around Kristoffer's core was to strip away the top layer of the core itself. A partial removal might deactivate the runes, but it also carried an unpredictable risk—if the curse remained partially intact, he could become something even worse than he was now. Controlled in a different way. Twisted beyond recognition.

Her breath hitched at the thought.

Tampering with someone's core was already an unspeakable violation, but this? This was removing a part of his very essence. It could shorten his life. It could alter his personality. Kristoffer might wake up one day, free of the curse—but no longer the person she had fought so hard to protect.

Could she even justify that?

Was she doing this for him, or was it selfishness? What if without their contract, he was in fact a different person? Was she actually trying to help him or was it a desperate attempt to keep him by her side, unchanged, just as she had always known him? In theory the simplest way to go about it would be to ask him.

But could she even trust his answer? As long as the contract bound him, she had no way of knowing. Her stomach twisted with uncertainty, but she forced herself to turn the page.

The medical research was no better.

Moonfick's approach to healing was entirely unlike her mother's, rooted in cold efficiency rather than compassion. His findings suggested that magic could restore nerves, tendons, and even muscles—perhaps even repairing the irreversible damage in Kristoffer's arm.

But there was a catch.

It required a living donor.

The cells had to be fresh, harvested in real-time. Which meant that to heal Kristoffer, she would have to maim someone else.

Sofia pressed a trembling hand to her forehead, feeling the weight of it all crush her.

No matter which path she chose, she would be harming him—or someone else. There was no clean solution. No way to fix this without leaving scars behind.

She exhaled slowly, trying to steady herself. At least there had been some progress with mana frequency research, even if everything else felt like a dead end. The week hadn't been entirely fruitless.

Pushing back her chair, she glanced around the library to ensure she was alone before dimming the magic light at her table. The library was vast and eerily silent, the shelves towering over her like silent sentinels of knowledge both sacred and forbidden.

Lisa was waiting in the dorm; her servant wasn't allowed in this section of the library. But Erik Garnez was. The duke's son had

secured special permission from the headmaster and had been frequenting this area to study forbidden combat magic. Since the exam, they hadn't spoken a single word to each other. He was wary of her now—watching her from a distance, guarded.

Good.

It was better than whatever twisted dynamic they'd had before.

With one last glance at the books, Sofia slowly turned toward the exit.

The weight of her research still clung to her like a suffocating fog, but amidst the uncertainty and guilt, there was one small, selfish comfort—Kristoffer would be by her side again tomorrow.

Ana had surprised her by choosing to stay at the training grounds, and though Sofia respected her decision, she couldn't deny the flicker of guilt that came with how relieved she felt.

She had missed Kristoffer. More than she had realized.

And no matter how wrong it was, the thought of seeing him again, standing beside her, brought a quiet, desperate happiness she couldn't ignore.

Lost in thought, Sofia stepped out of the library and onto the rain-slicked path leading to the dorms. The night air was cold, heavy with the scent of wet stone and earth. Sheets of rain poured down relentlessly, drenching the academy grounds. She sighed, realizing her umbrella was back in the dorm.

Just her luck.

She wrapped her arms around herself and started walking, longing for the warmth of a hot bath.

Then—she heard it.

A muffled, pain-laced cry.

Sofia froze.

Her pulse quickened as she strained her ears, trying to pinpoint the source. Another whimper, barely audible over the rain. Without hesitation, she moved toward the sound, keeping her steps light and careful.

Rounding the corner of a small warehouse, she came to an abrupt stop.

Erik Garnez stood there, gripping a wooden cane. The polished surface gleamed under the dim light, but what caught her attention was the deep crimson gemstone embedded in its head.

At his feet knelt a small, frail girl. Her skin was ghostly pale, made even starker by the angry red welts marring her exposed back.

“Again,” Erik commanded, his voice void of emotion.

The girl shuddered. “I—I’m sorry, Master. I will never disobey you again.”

Her voice wavered, thick with pain and fear.

Erik's expression remained impassive as he lifted the cane and brought it down in a sharp arc. The sound of impact cracked through the air. The girl collapsed forward into the muddy puddle beneath her, her blood mixing with the rainwater.

Sofia's vision blurred with rage.

"What the hell are you doing?!"

She didn't think—she simply moved.

Charging forward, she slid between Erik and the girl, her breath ragged with fury.

Erik turned to her, his blue eyes flashing with disbelief. Strands of wet blonde hair clung to his sculpted face, but Sofia only focused on the cruel set of his jaw and the weapon in his grip.



“This has nothing to do with you, Elernes.” His voice was tight with irritation. “You have no right to interfere when I’m disciplining my servant.”

“This isn’t discipline!” Sofia shouted, the rain stinging her skin. “You’re going to kill her! What did she even do to deserve this?!”

Erik scoffed. “She disobeyed. I told her to wait for me in front of the library—not cowering under some other building.”

Sofia’s nails dug into her palms. “That’s it? That’s your excuse for beating her half to death?!”

His eyes darkened. “I don’t need to explain myself to you.”

The red gemstone atop Erik’s cane gleamed ominously as he raised it once more.

Sofia moved before she could think, before she could even stop herself—her body reacting purely on instinct. She threw her arm up to shield the girl.

A sharp crack split through the night.

Pain exploded up her forearm. The force of the blow sent her sprawling onto the ground beside the servant, rain-soaked mud seeping into her clothes. For a moment, she couldn’t breathe.

Above her, Erik exhaled, unimpressed. His voice, low and indifferent, barely reached through the pounding rain.

“I warned you to stay out of this.”

Sofia forced her head up, her vision swimming. The cold raindrops did nothing to numb the searing pain in her arm. Erik grabbed his servant’s sleeve and yanked her to her feet. The girl stumbled but obeyed, her posture stiff, her expression hollow.

She didn't resist.

She didn't even cry out.

She had accepted this as normal.

Sofia watched, her entire body frozen, as Erik led the girl into the darkness, their figures swallowed by the storm.

She remained where she had fallen, sitting in the blood-tinged puddle, her entire body trembling—not just from pain, but from the suffocating helplessness pressing down on her.

Slowly, she tilted her face toward the sky, allowing the icy rain to pour over her, to wash away the blood, the mud, the rage boiling just beneath her skin.

For so long, she had played by the rules. She had followed the expectations placed upon her, biting her tongue, keeping her emotions in check. She had believed—naively, perhaps—that reason and patience would be enough to change the world. That if she spoke the right words, showed the right people the right way, things would shift. That the rigid hierarchy, the divisions built on bloodlines, could be undone with time.

But this—

This was too much.

The sight of that girl, kneeling in the mud, accepting her suffering without a fight—because she had been forced by the contract attached to her very soul—was too much.

Something inside Sofia cracked, as violently and irreversibly as the cane against her arm.

She clenched her fists, ignoring the pain that flared in response. Her nails dug into her palms, grounding her in the moment, in the storm, in the truth she could no longer ignore.

This world would not change on its own.

And she was done waiting for it to do so.

The grand ballroom shimmered under the glow of enchanted chandeliers, casting a soft golden light over the gathering of nobles. The air was thick with the scent of expensive perfumes, mingling with the rich aroma of aged wine. Crystal glasses clinked as the guests exchanged pleasantries, their laughter carefully measured, their words laced with subtle meaning.

Eduard Elernes navigated the crowd with practiced ease, nodding and offering polite smiles, though his mind was elsewhere. A firm clap on his shoulder pulled him back to the present.

“Eduard Elernes! A rare sight indeed.” The voice belonged to Earl Barnos, a broad-shouldered man whose sheer muscle mass made him seem larger than his actual height. His grin was warm but laced with expectation. “I hear you finally decided to grace us with your presence. We were just discussing how pleasant it would be if you could make amends with Baron Valron.”

Eduard's smile barely faltered. "I'm glad to bring you such joy," he replied, his tone light but noncommittal. A gentle tug on his sleeve reminded him of his wife's presence at his side. Isabelle, always vigilant, subtly leaned in, her delicate fingers pressing against his wrist in silent urgency.

"I hope to have a drink with you later, should you find the time," Eduard added, smoothly shifting the conversation.

"Naturally," Barnos agreed with a hearty chuckle, raising his glass in a silent toast before turning his attention to another guest.

As soon as they were a few steps away, Eduard sighed. "Iz, you can't just pull me away every time someone irritates you."

"Garnez arrived," she whispered calmly, although her husband noticed the focus in her demeanor. "I think he's more important than indulging some sleazy two-timer."

Eduard stiffened. "Oh."

Before attending the party, they had met with Duke Ralezo in a final attempt to secure his support. It had been a fruitless endeavor. Without revealing the truth—that their daughter had killed Baron Valron's son—there was little they could do to sway him. Vincent Ralezo respected Robert Garnez's strength, and without a compelling reason, he had no interest in getting entangled in their political conflict.

Despite the setback, Eduard had insisted they attend. The pressure from the noble circles had been mounting, and with

representatives from the Tower present, this was an event they couldn't afford to miss. Even so, they had agreed to be cautious, wary of every sip of wine and every bite of food. There was no telling what Baron Valron might resort to in his grief-driven thirst for revenge.

A shift in the atmosphere signaled a new arrival.

The murmuring in the hall quieted, replaced by hushed whispers and discreet glances.

Robert Garnez had entered.

Duke Garnez was a striking figure—tall, poised, and exuding an effortless air of authority. His platinum hair, sleek and immaculate, reflected the ballroom's warm glow. Draped in a lavish crimson robe embroidered with golden accents, he carried a refined white cane adorned with red gemstones.

All eyes followed him as he moved through the hall with unhurried steps, his polite smile never wavering. A master of decorum, he acknowledged the stares with the grace of someone who was used to being watched, admired, and feared.

Many things could be said about Robert Garnez, but unlike the brash and unpredictable Vincent Ralezo, his manners were impeccable. And that, made him even more dangerous.



“Welcome, friends. I’ll be with you in just a moment.”

Robert Garnez's voice carried the warmth of a practiced statesman, his smile effortlessly charming as he nodded to the growing crowd.

"It is such a pleasure to see you again, Your Grace!"

"How is your research progressing?"

"I noticed Bayan Cosar's latest product line incorporates the magic circles you developed last year—the efficiency is simply remarkable."

The most influential figures in the room clustered around the duke like moths to a flame, eager to offer praise, to attach themselves to his name in any way possible. His reputation as both a masterful mage and a powerful noble made him the axis around which the evening revolved.

Eduard Elernes observed the scene from a careful distance, swirling the wine in his glass as he leaned toward his wife.

"Should we wait in line or attempt our greetings later?" His tone was dry, knowing full well how tedious the wait would be.

"I don't care either way," Isabelle replied, her voice laced with boredom as she subtly attempted to scratch an itch beneath her corset. Then, her gaze flickered toward a familiar figure. "What's more interesting is how your dear friend Ludwig Varsmith has been avoiding us all evening, yet he's quite eager to cozy up to the newcomer."

Eduard followed her eyes to Viscount Varsmith, who stood near the front of the queue forming around Duke Garnez. They had not spoken in weeks. Whether the distance was due to the recent... complications with Sofia, or an entirely different political shift, was uncertain. But one thing was clear—they had lost another ally.

The atmosphere of the party was suffocating, more so than usual. Hosted by one of the key members of the opposing faction, there was no expectation of friendly company, but tonight's isolation felt intentional. Duke Ralezo—one of the few figures capable of neutralizing the tension—had conveniently excused himself, opting instead for an evening in the hot springs with his attendants. Even Earl Welder, another potential buffer, had mysteriously found an excuse to decline.

From the moment they arrived, Baron Valron had greeted them with impeccable courtesy, showing no outward hostility. But the man was far too cunning for Eduard to lower his guard.

It took nearly an hour for the line around Duke Garnez to dwindle, allowing them a window to make their obligatory greetings. Eduard and Isabelle had already agreed—they would exchange pleasantries, fulfill their social obligations, and leave as soon as it was acceptable to do so. They had endured long enough for their absence not to be considered an insult.

But just as they made their way toward the duke, Eduard's steps faltered.

Robert Garnez was not alone.

He stood engaged in conversation with Baron Valron and Bayan Cosar—the worst possible combination.

Before Eduard could reconsider their approach, Garnez’s gaze flickered toward them. A slow, knowing smile spread across his lips, and he raised a hand in an inviting gesture.

Trapped.

With no choice but to comply, Eduard adjusted his posture, placed a firm yet elegant hand on his wife’s waist, and led her forward with measured grace.

“The pleasure is ours, Duke Garnez.” He offered a deep bow, while Isabelle executed a flawless curtsy.

“It’s good to see you both, Eduard, Isabelle.” The duke’s voice was smooth, yet there was something in his tone that made it impossible to tell whether his words were a pleasantry or a warning. “I do hope you weren’t avoiding me.”

Eduard kept his expression neutral, offering a polite smile. “Of course not, Your Grace. We simply did not wish to interrupt your conversation.”

“A relief to hear.” Garnez’s lips curled faintly, a glint of amusement in his eyes. “I understand your daughter is doing quite well at the academy. Given her parentage, I suppose it is no surprise she was placed in Class A.”

Eduard maintained his composure, but he felt Isabelle's fingers twitch ever so slightly against his wrist. A subtle gesture—small enough that only he would notice—but it spoke volumes.

"We have no way of contacting her until the end of the month," he replied smoothly, his tone giving nothing away. "But I appreciate the update. I'm glad to hear Sofia is doing well."

"Oh dear," Garnez chuckled, pressing a hand to his mouth in an exaggerated display of self-reproach. "I do hope I haven't been too loose-lipped with such privileged information." Then, with effortless ease, he turned his attention to the man beside him. "Baron Valron was quite concerned you wouldn't join us tonight, weren't you, Dario?"

Baron Dario Valron smiled—a carefully measured expression, polite yet unreadable.

"We've already spoken on the matter," Valron said smoothly. "I hope we can finally put past grievances behind us. In times like these, when mana beasts threaten our borders, we cannot afford internal discord."

Eduard mirrored his expression with a well-practiced smile of his own.

"A wise sentiment," he replied. "Let's arrange a private meeting to resolve our... misunderstandings. I'll reach out to you tomorrow so we can find a suitable time."

“Most wonderful.” Duke Garnez clapped his hands together approvingly. “Why not begin this peace offering with a proper toast? Waiter!”

A servant stepped forward, carrying a silver tray laden with delicate crystal glasses, each filled with golden champagne.

Eduard’s grip on Isabelle’s waist tightened ever so slightly. The entire exchange felt orchestrated—too smooth, too deliberate.

Garnez was maneuvering them into this exact moment.

Was he merely playing the role of a gracious Lord? Or was he offering Valron an opportunity to strike?

Eduard cast a glance at his wife. Their eyes met for the briefest moment, and he knew—she had reached the same conclusion.

A trap.

“My deepest apologies,” Eduard spoke up, his tone regretful but firm. “But my wife and I have recently given up alcohol. A sign of age, perhaps—we find it interferes with our sleep.” He chuckled lightly, as if laughing at himself. “Would you mind if we use water for the toast instead?”

Garnez’s expression didn’t waver. If anything, his smile grew wider.

“No problem at all,” he said jovially. “In fact, I might do the same. I am the oldest among us, after all.”

Eduard reached for a nearby pitcher, pouring two glasses of water—one for himself and one for Isabelle. He passed a third to the duke.

“To the future of the Upper World!” Garnez declared, raising his glass.

They clinked their glasses together, the sound light and crystalline.

Eduard didn’t miss the way Baron Valron took a long sip of his champagne, nor the way Bayan Cosar followed suit.

“If I ever have to choose between sleep and alcohol,” Valron laughed, swirling the last drops in his glass, “I’ll be in quite the predicament.”

Then, his sharp gaze flicked to Isabelle.

“Lady Isabelle,” he mused, tilting his head, “you haven’t aged a day in thirty years. Tell me, what’s your secret?”

She smiled coyly, playing along. “A careful regimen of creams, herbs, and green tea.” She winked. “Though I can’t say all of it tastes pleasant.”

Valron chuckled. “Ha, it’s a shame that green tea tastes like—”

His words cut off.

His body jerked violently.

A choked, strangled sound tore from his throat as his hand shot to his neck, fingers clawing desperately. His face contorted in panic.

Bayan Cosar staggered beside him, knocking his empty glass from the table. It shattered upon impact, but the sound was lost beneath the sudden, rising screams echoing through the hall.

Eduard stood frozen, heart pounding in his chest.

Dario Valron gasped, eyes wild with confusion.

“How—” He coughed violently, his knees buckling. “Why..”

His body lurched. Then, he collapsed.

Bayan Cosar fell beside him.

Glasses overturned. Chairs scraped against the marble floor as nobles stumbled back in horror. The tension in the room snapped into chaos, screams and frantic whispers filling the air.

Isabelle moved instantly, dropping to her knees beside Valron. With deft hands, she forced his mouth open, searching for obstructions.

Eduard saw her sharp intake of breath. A flicker of realization in her eyes.

She tried, desperately, to force the breath back into his lungs, her hands pressing against his chest—

But it was too late.

Valron's body had already gone still.

A hush fell over the crowd, thick with unease. Then, a whisper.

"He's dead."

More voices followed, murmurs rippling through the grand hall like a slow-building storm.

"Did the Elernes kill him?"

"What happened?"

"They always hated each other..."

"On his own estate?"

Eduard felt the weight of every gaze, the suffocating press of suspicion closing in.

Then, a single voice cut through the chaos—calm, authoritative, and deliberate.

"Eduard."

Duke Robert Garnez regarded him with a carefully measured expression, his tone gentle, almost sympathetic.

"I'm afraid this will require an official investigation," he said smoothly. "For the sake of clarity, would you and your wife accompany me to the station? It is best we act swiftly, before matters spiral further."

Eduard's breath caught.

For a moment, he could only stare—at his wife, at the duke, at the bodies cooling on the marble floor.

And then it all clicked.

The pressure of the crowd behind him. The whisper of accusations creeping like poison in the air. The weight of blame settling firmly on his shoulders.

Valron was dead. His son was already buried. And now Bayan Cosar—one of Eduard's most outspoken rivals—lay lifeless at his feet.

Three men who, in theory, stood as allies to Garnez but had grown reckless, their ambitions threatening to destabilize his position. Three men whom everyone knew opposed Eduard—and whose deaths, in the eyes of the court, would benefit him most.

It was brilliant.

In one calculated move, Robert Garnez had purged his political threats and tied the noose around Eduard's neck.

Eduard swallowed, cold fear curling in his gut. He had underestimated him. Completely.

The duke had arranged this moment flawlessly, leaving no room for escape. The Elernes family stood as the only viable suspects—cornered, outnumbered, with no defense but their own word against the rising tide of speculation.

He caught the way the other nobles watched, their expressions not of outrage, but intrigue. They were waiting—to see how he would react, to see if he would flail or fight.

Eduard forced his expression into one of reluctant agreement. There was no other choice. Not now.

Silently, he extended a hand, helping Isabelle to her feet.

“Don’t do anything reckless,” he murmured, his voice just for her. He knew her temper, knew how easily it could ignite. But they couldn’t afford that now. “I’ll protect us in court.”

She exhaled, sharp and measured, but she nodded.

Eduard turned back to Garnez and inclined his head. A sign of reluctant submission. A move of necessity, not defeat.

“Of course, Your Grace,” he said evenly. “Lead the way.”

And with that, they stepped into the lion’s den.

First classes

Kristoffer woke up to the numbing weight of his dead arm. Carla's head rested on it, her slow, steady breaths warming his skin. The early morning light filtered through the gaps in the dorm's walls. Carefully, he slid his arm out from under her, flexing his fingers to force some life back into them. The ache in his muscles was a small price to pay.

He dressed quietly and slipped outside. The sun had barely risen, and most of the dorm was still asleep. A few minutes of stretching eased the stiffness in his body, the familiar routine helping to ground him. Then, he made his way to the quiet spot Ana had shown him, where he settled into his morning meditation.

Since the spider attack, this had become as necessary as breathing. He couldn't stop the poison from running through his bloodstream, but he could manage the damage, guiding his mana carefully to repair what he could. It was a slow process, but over the years, it had become second nature—like sharpening a blade or adjusting his stance before a fight.

And today, more than ever, he needed the clarity.

His mind still hadn't fully processed what had happened last night. The warmth of Carla's skin against his, the way she fit so

easily in his arms, the taste of her lips. He had spent years overanalyzing every move, every decision, every consequence. But last night, for the first time since he could remember, he hadn't thought at all.

He had just felt.

There was something freeing about it—about surrendering to pure instinct, about letting go of logic and restraint. He knew he should probably regret it, should start thinking about what it meant, what it changed. But right now, he didn't want to.

Kristoffer let the last remnants of his thoughts fade as he finished his morning routine with a long run. By the time he returned, the dorm was fully awake, servants hurrying between morning tasks. He grabbed a towel, intent on heading for the showers, but the sight of Carla and Keith stopped him in his tracks.

They were arguing.

"What's your problem, Keith?" Carla snapped, arms crossed, her expression sharp. "No one told you to wait for me."

"I'm sorry I worry about you," Keith shot back, his voice thick with agitation. "I don't want what happened to Ana to happen to you too."

"I was with Kristoffer," Carla stated, meeting his angry eyes. "Looking at what happened to Ana, I don't think I could be any safer."

Keith's entire body tensed. His fists clenched, his breathing heavy. The moment stretched, thick with unspoken words.

Then, through gritted teeth, he muttered, "You're his second choice, Carla."

The dorm fell silent. Every whispered conversation, every movement, stopped.

Keith stared at her, anger and something else—something darker—burning in his eyes. "Everybody knows he's in love with his master. You're nothing more than a consolation prize."

The air in the room turned suffocating.

Carla didn't move at first, her face blank, unreadable. Then, slowly, she inhaled through her nose. When she spoke, her voice was quiet, but each word landed like a punch.

"You're a piece of shit, Keith."

Kristoffer had never heard her sound like that before.

"If you wanted to hurt me, you managed to," she continued, her voice breaking just slightly. "Congratulations. I hope you're happy."

Keith looked like he wanted to take the words back, but it was too late.

"Don't talk to me ever again unless it's work-related," Carla finished coldly.

Then she turned and stormed out.

Kristoffer barely hesitated before following, pushing past the stunned silence of the dorm.

“Carla, wait!” He caught her wrist without thinking.

“Don’t.” She yanked her hand free like his touch burned.

Her eyes were glassy with unshed tears, but her expression was set, determined.

“I can’t talk to you right now either,” she said, voice hoarse.

“Just... give me some space.”

Kristoffer hesitated, then nodded.

He watched her disappear down the hall, rubbing a hand over his forehead. What the hell just happened?

An hour ago, everything had been fine. Now, everything was a mess.

He turned and walked back inside. The tension still hung thick in the air, and Keith stood frozen in place, fists clenched at his sides.

Kristoffer didn’t bother holding back his frustration.

“What the fuck, Keith?”

Keith sat on his bed, face buried in his hands. At the sound of Kristoffer’s voice, he lifted his head, and the anger in his eyes reignited like a fire rekindled.

“What?”

Kristoffer's temper snapped. "What do you mean 'what'?! Why are you being a dick to Carla? And why the hell are you running your mouth about my love life in front of everyone? What do you even know? Have you ever asked me?"

Keith stood up abruptly, towering over Kristoffer. "Was I wrong?"

Kristoffer didn't back down. "You don't know shit about how I feel. And you have no right to drag me into your drama." His voice was rising, fury making his hands shake. "I asked you three times if you were in love with Carla, and every time, you said no. Now you're acting like a child. Either grow a pair and be honest, or live with the consequences of your own damn choices."

Keith didn't hesitate. He lunged, tackling Kristoffer to the floor. The impact knocked the breath out of them both, but Kristoffer recovered first. Years of training kicked in as his body moved instinctively. They wrestled for a few moments, but Kristoffer was faster, more precise. Within seconds, he had Keith's arm locked, pressing him face-down against the floor.

"I don't want to hurt you," Kristoffer said through gritted teeth. "You're acting like a loser today, but I still think of you as my friend."

Keith struggled for a second longer before finally going limp. Kristoffer released him and stood, chest rising and falling in deep, controlled breaths.

"Take a cold shower and clear your damn head."

He turned and walked away, still shaking with residual anger. The room was silent. Every pair of eyes quickly looked elsewhere, people suddenly finding something—anything—else to focus on.

Kristoffer ran a hand through his hair, exhaling sharply. “Show’s over. Sorry about that.”

The usual morning chatter didn’t quite return, replaced instead with hushed murmurs and stolen glances.

Kristoffer barely had time to process the aftermath before Ana appeared, grinning far too widely for the situation.

“Please spare me,” he groaned.

“Never took you for the love triangle type,” she teased, plopping down beside him. “So, what now?”

He sighed, rubbing his temple. “Carla wants space. Keith will probably hate me forever. No idea what now. Right now, I’m just happy to be going to Lady Sofia.”

Ana smacked the back of his head. “Not the right time to say that.”

Kristoffer winced, rubbing the sore spot. “Ow, what was that for?”

“Because you’re being an idiot.” Ana crossed her arms. “Running away from this won’t help. You need to decide what matters most to you. Father Albert always said, ‘When you’re lost, do one thing at a time.’ So what’s your priority? Do you want to be with Carla?”

Do you want to fix things with Keith? Or do you want something else entirely?"

Kristoffer blinked. "What is this sudden wisdom? Who are you, and what did you do with Ana?"

She smacked him again, lighter this time, and they both laughed.

"Thanks," Kristoffer said, finally feeling some of the tension ease. He stood and stretched. "I'll start with a shower."

Before he could take a step, the dormitory door slammed open.

"Assemble outside!" The instructor's voice rang out like a gunshot.

Kristoffer groaned, exchanging a glance with Ana. "Or not." He extended a hand to help her up before they followed the rest of the students outside.

The group slowly gathered in formation, but Kristoffer couldn't help but notice how Carla and Keith both stood noticeably far from him. He forced himself to ignore the heavy feeling in his chest. Right now, there were more important things to deal with.

Once his name was called, he left for the exchange building.

The moment he stepped inside, Lisa greeted him with a quick hug, then immediately pulled back and wrinkled her nose.

"You stink."

Kristoffer rolled his eyes. "A lot happened. I didn't have time for a shower."

Lisa crossed her arms. "Sounds like a bad excuse, but I'll let it slide. Anything on your end I should know about?"

Kristoffer opened his mouth, closed it, then opened it again like a fish gasping for air. Lisa sighed. She knew that look all too well. For someone so dependable, he was hopeless when it came to sorting through his own emotions.

"Alright, I'll go first," she said before he embarrassed himself any further. "Lady Sofia tripped on her way back from the library yesterday and broke her arm."

Kristoffer froze. "You're joking."

"I wish. Even with regeneration magic, she won't be able to use it for at least two weeks."

His face twisted into a mix of disbelief and exasperation. "Unbelievable."

Lisa shrugged. "Anyway, go clean up before you see her. Also, what about Ana? Anything I should know?"

Kristoffer hesitated for half a second. "She's fine. Somehow ended up close friends with Duke Garnez's servant." He shifted slightly before adding, "But I had a small falling-out with Keith. Not sure how that'll affect you."

Lisa's eyes narrowed instantly. "What now?"

"Nothing worth mentioning." He waved a hand like he could swat the topic out of existence. "Okay, I'm gonna shower before seeing Lady Sofia. See you later!"

Lisa watched him walk away, unimpressed. Shaking her head, she muttered, "Terrible liar," before heading off to find her best friend.

Although it wasn't easy, Sofia had managed to convince Lisa that her broken arm was the result of clumsiness. She had even prepared a detailed story about her tragic inability to climb stairs properly—enough that even someone as sharp as Lisa hadn't found much reason to dig deeper. That part of the plan had gone smoothly. But now came the difficult part.

Kristoffer.

She couldn't shake the memory of his face when he had crushed that servant's skull—how cold, how detached he had looked. If he ever found out that Erik Garnez had broken her arm... Sofia didn't know what he would do, and that terrified her. Trusting that the duke's son would keep his mouth shut to avoid trouble himself, she decided it was best to keep this secret to herself.

A familiar knock pulled her from her thoughts.

"Come in."

Kristoffer stepped inside, his hair damp from a recent shower. He greeted her politely, and just as she had expected, his eyes locked onto the cast stabilizing her arm.

“I was too focused on Professor Borgman’s teachings when going up the stairs,” she said smoothly, forcing a mischievous smile. “I hope you won’t mind taking notes for me this week.”

“Aren’t Lower Worlders forbidden from attending classes?” he asked, surprised.

“In theory, yes. But I spoke to the administration. Since I can’t write for myself and the injury happened on the academy grounds, they made an exception.”

As they talked, Kristoffer’s eyes subtly scanned the room, checking for any imperfections. It was a habit of his—a pointless one, considering Lisa had never once let the room fall below pristine standards in the three years they had worked together. Yet, despite his deep trust in her, he still checked. By now, it was more ritual than necessity.

“Which part of your arm fractured, Lady Sofia?” Kristoffer asked, swiping a finger along the nightstand as if testing for dust.

“Radius,” she answered slowly, sensing the tension hidden beneath his casual tone. “I hit the edge of the stairs trying to cover my face during the fall. Nothing serious, don’t worry.” She shifted topics quickly. “Better tell me—how was your week? Anything interesting happen? Will Ana be okay now?”

“Nothing worth mentioning.” His response was too quick, too flat. “Unlike girls, we only have classes meant to prepare us for when our masters throw us out—basics of farming, self-defense, that kind of thing. Ana will be fine. She even managed to win a duel against her bully.”

Their gazes met, both of them studying the other, looking for cracks in the carefully maintained facades.

Sofia could tell he was hiding something. But so was she. And that made it unfair to press him, didn’t it? It was only logical to let it go.

But logic was never her strong suit. And emotions were never fair.

“You piss me off sometimes,” she muttered, opening the drawer of her desk with more force than necessary.

Kristoffer blinked. “What did I do?” His confusion seemed genuinely earnest, which only irritated her more.

“Nothing.” The clipped answer didn’t invite further questions. “Let’s get to work. I’ll go over what I’ve been working on with Professor Borgman, and maybe you can make something useful out of it.”

Kristoffer looked at her like she had just spoken in an ancient, forgotten language. She could practically hear his brain overheating as he tried to figure out what he had done wrong.

Still, he let it go. For now.

Sofia took a deep breath, forcing herself to focus. “Adding smudges around the projection reduced the contrast of colors, minimizing the difference in neighboring mana frequencies,” she began, shifting into the safe, familiar territory of research. “Less color variation puts less strain on the caster and allows them to maintain the illusion longer. In other words, it’s easier to shift from yellow to orange to red than to jump directly from yellow to red. Which in practice means that changing wind spell into a fire one is almost impossible but modifying an existing wind spell into a fuel for the fire one is a plausible concept...”

Sofia’s voice was filled with quiet enthusiasm as she explained the progress she’d made with Professor Borgman, using her knowledge of mana frequencies to attempt altering the mana types consumed by runes. It had been an exhausting yet thrilling venture, and they were closer to success than she’d expected in some cases. As she spoke, Kristoffer listened with his usual attentiveness, but she could tell they both had something else on their minds. Beneath the discussion of magical theory and experimental methods, they were both waiting.

Waiting to see who would break first.

Sofia had just started to touch upon the more troubling aspects of Moonfick’s notes when a soft knock interrupted their focus.

“Sofie, are you in?” Katrina’s voice bubbled with eager anticipation, like a breath of fresh air.

Kristoffer immediately started gathering the scattered papers, while Sofia took a moment to adjust her appearance, checking herself in the mirror. There was a warmth to Katrina's presence that always felt like sunshine breaking through clouds.

When Kristoffer opened the door, Katrina practically sprang into the room, though she stopped short when she saw Sofia's arm in a cast.

"I missed you sooo mu—" she started, but then faltered, her expression filled with concern. "Are you alright? What happened to your arm?"

Sofia felt a surge of affection for Katrina, remembering how much this lively girl had come to mean to her over the past few years. Her sunny personality was infectious, and even in the chaos of their lives, Katrina remained a grounding light.

"Just an unlucky accident," Sofia reassured her with a smile. "Nothing to worry about."

Katrina instantly wrapped her arms around Sofia, pressing her side to hers with a beaming grin. "I'm so glad to see you," she exclaimed. "They made us run and cast magic until we passed out. And I had to kill insects and critters. It was disgusting. I was covered in fluids I don't even know the name of. Please, let's have a fancy tea party. I want to feel like a human being again."

Sofia laughed softly, her heart warmed by her friend's melodramatic tone. She reached up to pat Katrina's head

affectionately. As she did, she noticed Carla standing quietly in the doorway. The usual embarrassment that always followed Katrina's childishness wasn't there. Instead, Carla looked away, as if lost in her thoughts. Sofia wondered if Carla felt guilty about leaving Katrina alone with all the tough training.

"I could use a break too," Sofia said, smiling at her friend. "Let's do that."

Katrina hesitated for just a moment, a soft pink flush rising to her cheeks. "If you don't mind, I'd like to invite Jens too."

Sofia stifled a laugh, teasing, "The more the merrier."

As they gathered in Katrina's room, the atmosphere was light, full of laughter and the exchange of stories. It was clear to Sofia that something had changed between Katrina and Jens over the past week. Despite the playful distance they maintained physically, every time Jens spoke of Katrina's latest clumsy mishap, his face would light up in a way Sofia had never seen before. The connection between them was undeniable, and it made Sofia smile, even as a tinge of loneliness crept into her chest. She was happy for them, but she couldn't help but miss the simpler days when things had felt more straightforward.

The evening stretched on, with conversations flowing easily and the room filled with the warmth of shared experiences. Eventually, though, it was time to head back to their rooms. When Sofia opened the door to hers, she was met with the sight of

Kristoffer, his attention absorbed in the notes she had gathered earlier. His presence was comforting, as if he had been patiently waiting for her return.

A familiar sense of peace settled over her chest, an unexpected warmth filling the space she hadn't realized was missing. Seeing him so immersed in his research, just like the old days, felt right in a way that words couldn't capture. It was exactly what she needed.

"Welcome back, Lady Sofia," Kristoffer greeted, glancing up with a smile. "I prepared potato casserole with eggplant in case you're hungry."

Sofia couldn't resist grinning at him, the corner of her lips curling into a playful smile. "You'll make a great wife someday."

"I ate already," she added quickly, "but I can't say no to that. Just a little bit though."

As she sat down to join him, she realized just how much her life had changed in the past three years. It was rare to have moments like this—moments just for herself. But as they sat together, sharing a meal and discussing magical theories, everything else seemed to fade into the background. For the first time in a while, Sofia felt at ease, and in that moment, she remembered how much she had always cherished this simple routine. Just like in the old days, when everything felt easy and right, sitting with

Kristoffer, lost in research, and sharing a meal together was exactly what she needed.

It was a welcome respite from the endless pressure and expectations of the nobles around her, each one trying to manipulate her for their own gain.

And it was that very warmth, that fragile sense of normalcy, that loosened something in her chest—just enough to make her lower her guard.

“Kristoffer, we need to talk.”

Sofia’s mouth opened before she could stop herself, the quiet comfort of the moment pressing against her like an invisible force, urging her to break the tension that had lingered between them for far too long. And now that the words had slipped out, there was no turning back.

She took a steadying breath and met Kristoffer’s gaze, bracing herself.

“Mana frequencies aren’t the only thing I’ve been researching this past week.”

Kristoffer’s brow quirked, his eyes betrayed the shifting gears in his head. He regarded her with that familiar, unreadable intensity.

“What else have you been researching, Lady Sofia?”

Sofia rolled her eyes. “Don’t call me that. Not now.”

Kristoffer let out a small, amused exhale, but he didn’t argue.

She hesitated for just a moment before pushing forward. “Before we get to that, I need to apologize first.” Her voice was steady, but there was a weight behind it, something raw and unspoken. “I didn’t like how you acted back in the forest, but I had no right to take away your free will. That wasn’t fair to you. I’m sorry, Kristoffer.”

His expression remained unchanged, but she noticed the way his fingers curled slightly, a quiet sign of tension.

“I treated you coldly because I was scared.” She met his gaze, holding onto the moment, unwilling to let silence swallow her words. “The way you acted... it wasn’t like you. You killed them without hesitation. And I couldn’t stop asking myself—was that really *you*?”

Kristoffer remained silent, but his stare sharpened, focused entirely on her.

“I’ve had my suspicions for a while now,” she pressed on, her voice growing quieter. “Ever since we took in Ana and Lisa. And then I was given an opportunity to verify it. I’ve been researching our magical contract.” She took a slow breath, bracing herself. “And I found out what it does to you.”

Kristoffer straightened slightly.

They had never spoken like this before. Never so openly, never without the invisible weight of their roles pressing down on them. And now, for the first time they spoke as equals.

“It’s terrible,” Sofia whispered, as if saying it any louder would make it worse. “This contract—it’s a curse, Kristoffer. It doesn’t just bind you to me. It changes you, forces you to obey me, whether you realize it or not. Your love for magic, your logic-driven mind, the fact that you’ve suffered, that you’ve sacrificed yourself for me over and over again—most of it, maybe all of it, could be because of the contract.”

Her hands clenched into fists.

“If we try to remove it, I don’t know what will happen to you.” She swallowed hard. “You could become someone completely different. The moment the contract stops forcing your mind to obey—even the stupid, thoughtless things I told you to do when we were children—you might not be you anymore.”

A heavy silence fell between them.

Kristoffer had seen this look on her face before—that fierce determination barely holding back something fragile beneath.

She was terrified.

Not of him. Not even of the contract.

She was terrified of losing *him*.

And for that—for standing here and telling him the truth even when it hurt—Kristoffer respected her more than he could ever say.

He took a quiet breath, and just this once, let his own mask slip.

“Sofie.”

She jolted slightly at the way he said her name. No title. No distance. Just *Sofie*.

“The moment I saw that stone spike flying at your head,” Kristoffer said, his voice quieter now, softer, “my mind went blank. Everything else shut down. I didn’t think. I didn’t question. My body moved before any of that. Eliminate the danger. That was the only thing that mattered.”

He paused, meeting her gaze, letting her see the truth in his words.

“I don’t know if that instinct came from our contract, from my filthy blood, or from me. My own feelings.” His words felt heavier now, vulnerable in a way he never allowed himself to be. “But when I fought against your order... something broke. Along with my magic, I lost my connection to the contract. And back in that prison, for the first time, I didn’t see you just as my master. I saw *you*. A flawed, stubborn, frustrating, *human* person.” A small, almost self-deprecating smile tugged at his lips. “I should have told you sooner.”

Sofia’s heart stammered in her chest.

Feelings for me?

She shot up from her seat so fast that her chair scraped against the floor, turning on her heel toward the cupboard. “I should—I’ll make tea.” Her voice was too high, too rushed.

Kristoffer blinked, then let out a silent chuckle, understanding immediately how flustered she was.

The knowledge filled him with a kind of warmth he wasn't used to, something he didn't dare name. He could have teased her. Just a little. But he didn't.

Because in this moment, she had laid herself bare, had fought against her own fears just to reach him. And he respected her too much to make light of that.

So instead, he leaned back slightly, watching her fumble with the teacups, pretending not to notice the way her hands trembled ever so slightly. He allowed himself a small, private smile.

For the first time in years, they weren't master and servant.

They were just Sofia and Kristoffer.

She was the first to break the silence.

"So, does that mean... right now, you're not under the control of the magical contract?" Sofia kept her back turned to him, her voice carefully even, though he caught the way her shoulders curled in slightly.

Kristoffer tilted his head in thought. "I can't say for sure. But if it's still working, its influence has weakened significantly." A slow smirk tugged at his lips. "For example, I'm now fully aware of how clumsy you are—especially since you just put salt in your tea."

Sofia froze, staring down at the cup in her hands.

For a moment, she didn't move, didn't react. The air between them hung light, the atmosphere felt homey and cozy.

It was the first time they had ever spoken like this. So natural. So *warm*. It was as if the distance that had always separated them had suddenly, quietly, disappeared.

She never talked to him like this before.

Shaking off the unfamiliar feeling curling in her chest, she turned back to face him, lifting the cup to her lips with defiance.

"Maybe I like it this way," she said, arching an eyebrow before taking a sip—

—only to choke a second later, her face contorting in sheer disgust.

Kristoffer burst into laughter.

A real, genuine laugh. Not the measured amusement he reserved for others, not the quiet huffs of air she had learned to pick up on over the years.

This was unfiltered.

Sofia stared, momentarily forgetting the saltwater assaulting her tongue.

She had spent years trying to make him laugh. Ridiculous stunts, absurd jokes, dramatic gestures—none of it had ever worked.

But now?

Now, with nothing between them but an awkward conversation and a cup of ruined tea—

She had finally done it.

Her heart skipped a beat.

Kristoffer caught her staring, and their eyes met. The laughter faded slightly, but the warmth in his expression remained, lingering in the creases of his usually impassive face.

“I’m not touching the contract until we’re sure you are safe,” he said with a steady, unyielding tone. “Someone just tried to assassinate you. We can’t afford experiments. If something about me changes—if I become unreliable—” his jaw tightened, “—then who’s going to protect you?”

Sofia sighed, setting the teacup aside before passing him his own. “I don’t think we have time to wait,” she countered, not bothering to hide her frustration. “If we do nothing, this contract will kill you, Kristoffer. It’s a complex binding magic circle wrapped around your core, and it was never meant to be placed on someone with an evolving magical source. It’s one of the main reasons why Lower Worlders aren’t supposed to use magic.”

She hesitated, searching for the right words.

“It’s like forcing an overinflated balloon inside a cage. Your core keeps growing, but the contract is trying to keep it contained. Eventually...” she swallowed, “something will *burst*.”

Kristoffer took a slow sip of his tea, considering. “And by burst—”

“It could kill you.” Her voice was steady, but her fingers curled into her sleeves. “Or worse.”

For once, he didn’t have an immediate retort.

Sofia pushed forward before she lost her nerve.

“The only documented removal of the contract involved cutting away the top layer of the core itself.” Her hands clenched into fists. “It would shorten your lifespan by at least ten or twenty percent... and it could drastically change your personality. Losing a piece of your soul like that isn’t something to take lightly.”

Kristoffer let out a low chuckle. “Drastic personality change? That doesn’t sound too promising.”

Sofia’s lips pressed together. “There were a few cases where a skilled mage managed to break the curse instead. It’s incredibly risky, but from what I read—and from what you told me—it sounds like that’s exactly what you tried to do in the forest. Or something close to it.”

She moved toward her private chest, rummaging through her research notes before pulling out a stack of papers.

“I wrote down everything I found,” she said, handing them over. “Maybe if you go through them, you’ll be able to come up with something smarter.”

Kristoffer took the notes but didn't immediately look at them.

Instead, his gaze lingered on her.

She had confronted him. She had researched a way to save him.

She had done all of this, despite how difficult it must have been.

Contract or not, she shone too brightly in his cold, calculated world.

He swallowed, scratching his head, looking uncharacteristically

flustered. "Thank you." A pause. Then, quietly, "If you still want...

I can call you Sofie when we're alone."

Sofia blinked.

Then, a slow, genuine smile spread across her lips.

"I'd love that," she said, settling back into her seat.

For a moment, neither of them spoke. The silence was... different now. Not awkward, not heavy—just comfortable.

Then Kristoffer cleared his throat, flipping through the first few pages of her notes.

"So," he said, shifting into the science mode, "about your research... mind telling me more?"

Vincent Ralezo woke up to the sound of thunderous snoring. He turned his head to the left, confirming for the hundredth time this year that yes, the petite, attractive woman beside him was

responsible for a noise capable of waking the entire Upper World. Even more surprising was the fact that the beautiful redhead on his right slept peacefully through it.

With practiced ease, Vincent slipped out of bed without disturbing either of them. He moved to the bathroom, channeling mana into the faucet as he washed away the remnants of last night.

Most of the servants in his manor were women, a reflection of the duke's firm belief that people should pursue happiness through their lives. And there weren't many other things in this world that made him as happy as those alluring beauties smiling at him from the very morning.

After a brief meditation and some warm-up stretches, Vincent began his training session. For ten years, he had pursued the elusive milestone of becoming a true silent caster. He was close—painfully close. Yet every time he felt the magic take form without an incantation, it slipped away like mist through his fingers. Despite the frustration, Vincent refused to take reckless shortcuts. Diving into a mana rift might force the breakthrough, but the risk to his life—and more importantly, his sanity—was too great. He would rather master the process slowly and remain whole.

“Stone bullet.”

He spoke the spell aloud again, the familiar incantation helping him reinforce the sensation of the runes aligning. A small stone projectile shot forward, striking the target with sharp precision.

“Apologies for the interruption, My Lord,” came a voice from behind.

Vincent lowered his hand and turned slightly, recognizing Stefan’s calm, even tone.

“As you requested, I’ve gathered information about yesterday’s banquet,” the butler continued. “A great deal occurred. Would you like the report now, or after you finish?”

Vincent turned fully toward the well-dressed man. Stefan had been entrusted with the daily operations of House Ralezo so that Vincent could focus on two things: magic and women. The decision had paid off. Stefan was masterful in both politics and business. The Ralezo family flourished under his management, and Vincent made sure his butler’s efforts never went unrewarded—Stefan received a direct share of profits from all estates and ventures under his oversight.

Vincent’s had an absolute trust in him, which was exactly why he knew Stefan wouldn’t interrupt his training for a trivial reason.

“Give me the short version.”

“Dario Valron and Bayan Cosar are dead,” Stefan stated plainly.

“Murdered. The suspects are Earl Eduard and Isabelle Elernes. Poisoning. Both are in the royal prison while testimonies are still

being collected. They also stand accused of attempting to murder Duke Garnez.”

Vincent exhaled sharply and sat down on a nearby bench, running a hand through his hair.

Eduard and Isabelle had come to him for support but he’d refused. Partly because he despised the exhausting scheming of the noble courts—but mostly because of Garnez. The man was extremely dangerous. Vincent wasn’t ashamed to admit that Robert Garnez was stronger and more cunning than him.

That truth had driven Vincent to pour mountains of gold into hiring the best craftsmen. For nearly two years, they had worked tirelessly on a ring that allowed him to cast Flame thrower spell silently. Many nobles scoffed at artifacts, dismissing them as tools for the unskilled. Vincent didn’t care. He wouldn’t be outpaced. Not by Garnez, not by anyone. He’d seen firsthand the terrifying gap in their abilities, and he would not be caught unprepared. Vincent despised the thought of a fight he couldn’t win.

But Isabelle... she wasn’t just any noble. She was a long-time friend. And more than that—but Vincent pushed that thought down, locking it behind the familiar, cracking walls he’d built around feelings long buried.

“Stefan,” he said firmly, “prepare the carriage. I’m going to the royal prison.”

“At once, My Lord.” The butler bowed and departed swiftly.

By the time Vincent dressed, everything was ready—as if Stefan had anticipated his decision all along. Less than an hour passed from the moment Vincent received the news to the moment he stepped through the massive doors of the royal prison.

“I’m here to see Isabelle Elernes,” he announced to the guard at the reception desk.

The man behind it paled, stammering, “Duke Ralezo—I’m afraid visits are currently prohibited. Statements are still being—”

“I didn’t ask,” Vincent interrupted coldly, stepping past the desk.

Two guards moved to block his way, halberds crossed before him. Vincent narrowed his eyes, staring at the pair with icy precision. The men flinched, their brave expressions faltering.

“You have five seconds to reconsider your decision,” Vincent said evenly. “Make the right call, and I might forget this ever happened.”

The guards exchanged a brief glance, then silently stepped aside. Behind him, Vincent heard hushed whispers and the sound of hurried footsteps—someone had gone to fetch the warden. He didn’t have long.

Without breaking stride, the duke made his way through the corridors toward the noble cells. He knew this place well. During his years in the army, he’d walked these halls too many times, escorting prisoners or visiting comrades who had stepped out of

line. The layout hadn't changed, and with Isabelle and Eduard's status, Vincent knew exactly where to find them.

No guards barred his path. They were likely swarming the entrance now, debating whether to stop him and risk their necks, or let him pass and deal with the consequences later.

"You should've told me the party was going to be so fun, Isabelle," he said as he reached her cell.

She was sitting on the bench, as beautiful as the day he met her. Straight back, sharp gaze—and somehow still radiant, even in that dreary room. The first thing he noticed was her hair: a loose curl of hair, slightly frayed, draped over her left cheek. Isabelle always twisted her hair when she was under pressure, a small habit she'd never quite outgrown. It was almost comforting. Even with the exhaustion in her eyes, her presence seemed to cut through the gloom, lighting the shadows of the stone walls.

"If I'd known it would be that kind of fun," she said, rising to her feet and approaching the bars, "I wouldn't have gone."



“How bad is it?”

“Bad enough,” Isabelle replied with a matter-of-fact tone. “Eduard has motive, and multiple testimonies confirm it. The autopsy showed they were poisoned with Vares. You know that plant—it’s rare, restricted, lethal in the right dose. Turns out the

sanctuary log shows I brought some in last week. Now it's missing from my stores. And both Eduard and I refused the drink the victims had." She exhaled slowly. "They've got enough to call it checkmate."

Vincent stepped closer, voice low. "It's not like you to sit still and accept defeat. The Isabelle I know would tear these bars apart and set the whole place on fire."

"Eduard talked me down before they separated us." She looked away briefly, gathering herself. "Even if I break out, where do I go? They'd hunt us down, and... and our daughter would be caught in the fallout."

His brow furrowed. "So what—that's it? You're just giving up?"

"Our family name is ruined, the court's against us, and Garnez... he's already circling. The only thing I care about now is that my daughter survives this. If that means I have to strike a deal with Robert Garnez—or kill him if he won't budge—then I will." She held his gaze, her voice dropping into a near-whisper. "Taking into account our past, I know that I have no right to ask anything from you. But there is no one else I trust as much. Vicent, can you arrange a meeting with Robert Garnez? Will you protect my daughter for me?"

Vincent stared at her, the weight of her words crashing into him. How many times had she broken his heart? And yet... he'd never learned how to hate her. He'd tried. For years. But her voice, her

fire, those eyes that never backed down—they could cut through the coldest armor he wore.

“Izi...” His voice caught, uncharacteristically rough. “I don’t want to lose you. Not again. Not like this.”

“I’ll die anyway, Vincent. At least let me use the time I have left to make a world where my daughter can live in peace.”

The echo of boots rang down the corridor—the guards were closing in fast. Vincent clenched his jaw, his mind racing, weighing risks he had no time to fully calculate. Garnez wouldn’t allow him near Isabelle through proper channels again—this visit was a gamble, and time was running out.

“He won’t come, no matter what I say,” Vincent murmured, his voice low, eyes flicking toward the sound of approaching footsteps. “The only way I can think of is to offer him something he values. Maybe if I’ll tell Garnez you’re ready to trade your husband’s secrets in exchange for your safety. That might draw him out... but even if it works, you won’t win, Izi. He’s on another level—stronger, sharper. Neither of us can touch him.”

Isabelle didn’t flinch. “Then I’ll strike where it hurts, while I still can.”

Before Vincent could respond, the warden’s voice bellowed from down the hall.

“Duke Ralezo!”

Vincent recognized the warden, who appeared with three guards in tow, all armed. The man's eyes darted between Vincent and Isabelle, struggling to maintain his composure.

"What is the meaning of this? This prisoner is under investigation—no one is permitted contact, especially not without clearance. There are no exceptions."

Vincent turned slowly, his expression shifting in an instant to the familiar, carefree smile that had charmed half the Upper World.

"Relax, Georgio. We were just catching up—old friends, you know how it is." He gestured casually to Isabelle's cell. "Since you're here, let's deal with the paperwork properly. Show me where to sign to make this visit official."

The warden's stern expression faltered. "You can't simply—"

"And while we're on the subject," Vincent added, smoothly stepping between the guards and Isabelle's cell, "we should revisit that shipment of grapes you wanted from my estate. I brought some samples—perfect for the summer feasts."

Georgio sighed, irritation fading into resignation. "Duke, you should be more respectful of the rules."

Vincent grinned. "I'm all about respect. Let's talk in your office. You can remind me there."

Georgio nodded sharply. "Follow me. And next time, go through the proper channels."

As they turned down the corridor, Vincent cast one last glance at Isabelle. Their eyes met, unspoken words hanging in the air between them—too much to say, and no time to say it.

She gave a slight nod. Unyielding. Ready.

Vincent said nothing, but his hand clenched briefly at his side. Then he followed the warden into the shadows of the prison, his mind already working through the next step.

He would find a way to protect her daughter.

And Robert Garnez would listen—one way or another.

Jens had never imagined his life would spiral into such confusion in just two weeks. Meeting Katrina had been an unexpected blessing, a light he hadn't known he was searching for—but his original goal, deepening his connection with Sofia Elernes, seemed as distant as ever. His plans had unraveled one after another, yet strangely, he couldn't bring himself to feel regret. Though his father, Ludwig Varsmith, would surely see things differently.

Unlike the head of the Varsmith family, Jens had no desire to spend his life behind a desk, crunching numbers and currying favor with nobles. The role of a meticulous accountant might be secure, even lucrative, but to Jens, it felt like becoming a footnote in someone else's story. It had taken him three years to convince

his father that magic could be just as profitable for the family—and far more fulfilling.

From a young age, Jens had questioned the world's rigid social order. Nobility seemed hollow, a relic of bloodlines tracing back to the First Faculty and the original headmaster of the Tower. Many nobles had long since abandoned their duties in favor of complacency, basking in inherited titles while contributing nothing. Why should he respect people like that?

Yet Jens hadn't entirely escaped his lineage. Like his father, he thought in terms of gain, strategy, and positioning. Determined to rise above the limitations of his status, he made the decision as a young boy to become a respectable mage. It was never officially proved that talent in magic was hereditary, so Jens hoped that thanks to hard work he would be able to become someone whose abilities commanded respect even from the University of the Abyss. That would pave his way to a cozy position in the Tower, where he could finally be free of the influence of the rotten nobility-based system.

Jens was content with his steady progress until he was invited to Sofia's coming of age party. There, witnessing Duke Ralezo and Commander Berian in battle, he came to the stark realization of just how high the peak he was trying to climb truly was. From that moment on, he doubled his efforts and abandoned all his leisure hobbies. The prospect of the upcoming school kept him driven—until one day, after class, his father paid him a visit to share some

gossip he had overheard while doing bookkeeping for one of the influential figures in the Tower.

“Sofia Elernes is a third-circle mage.”

Those words still echoed in Jens’s mind, as sharp and unsettling as the moment his father first uttered them. Even under the most optimistic circumstances, Jens knew he wouldn’t reach that level until his third year of study—at the very earliest. The revelation was a blow, not just to his pride but to the careful plans he’d spent years constructing.

Still, he hadn’t walked away. Jens agreed to his father’s proposal: stay close to Sofia Elernes, build good relationship with the girl, and, through her, strengthen House Varsmith’s ties to the prestigious Elernes family. Aligning with a prodigy had its advantages. It was a bitter pill to swallow, especially for someone who longed to rise by merit, not association—but he told himself it was a necessary step. He didn’t have to be number one. Just close enough. After all, the daughter of Elernes wasn’t someone who would order him around.

Before the university term began, Jens had tried—again and again—to get closer to Sofia at various noble gatherings. But no matter how polished his words or careful his approach, he made no progress. He had a knack for reading people, and with Sofia, it was clear as day: she didn’t want to be a part of the noble world. She was distant and kept the conversations out of politeness, but

nothing more. Conversation with her felt like knocking on a door that would never open.

Worse still was the man who never left her side.

Kristoffer.

They had never exchanged a word, but Jens couldn't shake the sense of danger that seemed to emanate from the Lower Worlder. Kristoffer remained unnervingly silent most of the time, and despite Jens's talent for reading people, he couldn't decipher a thing from those sharp, cold eyes. There was something unnatural about him, something that set every instinct Jens had on high alert. Being near Kristoffer felt like sleeping next to a mana beast—never knowing when, or if, it might strike.

Jens had hoped that once at university, away from the rigid etiquette of noble parties, he could finally make progress with Sofia. Instead, everything changed. Not because of her—but because of Katrina Welder.

Falling for her hadn't been part of the plan.

Katrina offered no political advantage. Her family, while noble, held little sway in the Upper World, and she wasn't a prodigy or bearer of a feared reputation. From a strategic standpoint, there was no reason to pay her any mind. But strategy didn't matter anymore.

There was just something about her.

Her sincerity, the warmth she extended to everyone without hesitation, the soft scent of her perfume that lingered in his memory, the way her head tilted slightly when she was unsure of something—it all chipped away at the calculated walls Jens had built around himself. For the first time in his life, he didn't want to get closer to someone because of gain or ambition. He just wanted to be near her.

It was that feeling—the first real spark of something genuine—that kept him grounded when he witnessed Sofia and Erik Garnez fighting darkclaws as if it were nothing. The ease with which they wielded their power forced Jens to question everything, even the long-held belief that talent wasn't hereditary. The ability gap between them and him seemed insurmountable, the kind of thing that could crush his will to continue.

But Katrina made it bearable. With her nearby, the impossible felt less daunting.

And now, with classes finally set to begin, Jens saw another opportunity—not just to inch closer to Sofia, but to prove himself. Even if he no longer knew exactly why that goal still mattered.

As he stepped into the classroom, his gaze was immediately drawn to the back.

Sofia sat there, elegant as ever, and at her side—unsurprisingly—was Kristoffer. Jens felt that familiar, uneasy weight settle in his stomach. She had mentioned he would assist her with note-

taking, but seeing him *inside* the teaching area still seemed surreal. How had the university even allowed a Lower Worlder into such a restricted space?

The classroom was filled with an uncomfortable energy.

Twelve other students lingered in small clusters, making awkward small talk while subtly scanning the room, their eyes flicking to Sofia and then quickly away. No one approached her. Jens noted it all—the sidelong glances, the tension in their voices, the subtle hesitations in their movements. They wanted to make contact with Sofia but kept their distance.

Was it because of her public falling out with Erik Garnez, son of the Duke? Or was it because they were scared after seeing the murderous display during her exam? Likely both.

Jens approached with his usual polite smile, the kind he had honed over years of navigating noble circles. “Good morning, Lady Sofia. Do you mind if I sit next to you?”

She glanced up. “Hello, Jens. Sure, it’ll be nice to have a familiar face nearby.” Her voice was courteous, as always, but Jens saw it—the tightness in her shoulders, the way her fingers briefly clenched the edge of her desk before relaxing, the stiffness behind her smile.

She was tense. Very tense.

Jens had always been able to read people. Not just in the general sense, but *truly* read them—every shift in posture, every flicker of

emotion that crossed a face too quickly for others to notice. Tense shoulders, the angle of someone's feet, how a hand trembled just slightly before stilling, the narrowing of eyes. They were all puzzle pieces to him, threads of truth others ignored or simply couldn't see. He never understood why so many missed them.

So he watched, quietly, storing away what others overlooked.

The room fell silent as the door opened again, a hush cutting through the uneasy chatter. Erik Garnez stepped inside, surrounded by his usual entourage of adoring followers. His eyes swept the room, predatory and calculating, before settling on Sofia for a brief, unreadable moment. Beside him was a girl Jens didn't recognize. Not that it mattered.

Erik's hobby was well known. He enjoyed collecting and breaking young, innocent girls. Jens had attended one of Max Valron's infamous parties where Erik and Max hunted down Lower Worlders and tormented the girls that survived. He was disgusted with the practice, but part of surviving in the Upper World was keeping opinions like that to yourself.

He had kept it to himself, just like he kept everything else. Like the growing suspicion he had about Max Valron and Arthur Cosar's sudden disappearance. No bodies. No traces. Just *gone*, along with their servants. Officially, it was chalked up to a magical accident. Unofficially, everyone was tight-lipped.

Sofia was secretive by nature, and Jens had learned not to push her. But the feeling grew stronger with every passing minute he spent near Kristoffer, who was currently scanning the room as though evaluating each object's potential as a weapon. Jens kept the thought to himself, but he couldn't help wondering—could a Lower Worlder really have killed two Upper Worlders and their servants? Even if it had been both Sofia and Kristoffer working together, it seemed impossible, unless they had ambushed the four of them.

But she didn't seem capable of murdering a human being. Or... maybe she simply didn't *seem* like the type. That, Jens reminded himself, was exactly the kind of mistake that got people killed.

Jens's eyes locked on Erik Garnez as the Duke's son strode toward Sofia, the air around him emanating open hostility. Jens could sense it clearly—Erik wasn't here for words. His gaze had that same dangerous edge Jens often saw in Kristoffer's, a cold, calculated intensity that promised violence.

Sofia stood up, likely sensing the same threat. But Erik didn't even spare her a glance. Without warning, he pivoted and drove a fist into Kristoffer's face. The blow landed with brutal precision, and Kristoffer dropped to the floor, half a meter away, blood spilling freely from his nose.

"What the hell are you doing?" Sofia's fierce voice rang out. Jens felt a sudden shift in the atmosphere around her—the mana thickening, the air crackling. He had never seen her like this

before, not even during their battles in the exam. Anger radiated from her like heat from a forge.

Erik pointed to the girl standing beside him, her face bruised, nose visibly crooked. “Your dog broke my servant. Look at her. She’s worthless now. By the law of our forefathers, I have the right to deliver an equal injury and demand compensation. I estimate Daria’s previous worth at five hundred gold.”

Sofia stared at him, disbelief flashing in her eyes. Then her gaze shifted to Kristoffer, who stood slowly, wiping the blood from his face with a surprisingly calm expression.

“She attacked me with a knife. All I did was defend myself,” Kristoffer stated coldly.

“No one cares what happened between you two,” Erik snapped. “The result is the same—I have to replace and educate a new servant because of you. Sofia, will you pay up, or do we take this to court?”

Jens watched as the girl struggled to process what she had just been told. Her chest rose and fell, betraying the deep breaths she was taking to calm herself. Her left hand was clenched into a tight fist, her fingernails leaving marks on her pale skin. Her blue eyes darkened, taking on the hue of a stormy ocean. Seeing all these signs, and recalling their battles from the exam, Jens felt an instinctive urge to distance himself.

“I’ll write to my parents when we’re allowed to contact the outside world,” she said with a dangerously sharp tone “The Elernes family will offer fair compensation. Now step aside. I need to treat my servant so he can assist me during class.”

“I’ll inform my father as well,” Erik replied, his tone equally sharp. “If compensation isn’t delivered within the month, I’ll escalate this to the Tower.” He turned to his servant with disdain. “Join the other Lower Worlders. I can’t look at you like this.”

As the two nobles turned away from each other, Jens scanned the classroom. No one else dared speak. Twelve students, all frozen, watching the aftermath of what had begun as a noble’s petty feud and was now quickly spiraling into something far more serious.

A war, Jens thought grimly. And it’s only been two weeks.

“Sit down,” Sofia said coldly to Kristoffer. “I’ll stop the bleeding. Nothing worth mentioning, huh?”

Her tone was detached, but Jens wasn’t fooled. Beneath the surface, she was seething. She muttered softly under her breath—curses, maybe—as she cast unfamiliar spells to stem the bleeding. The blood stopped flowing, but the stains on his clothes and the floor remained, a grim reminder. She worked silently, until a sharp *crack* echoed in the quiet room as she set his nose. Kristoffer flinched, jaw tightening, but made no sound.

The door opened once more, and Rena Karlton entered the classroom with the grace of someone rehearsing every step. Jens couldn't help but smirk internally. Every time he saw her, it was like watching a play—one that never ended. The way she walked, the subtle tilt of her head, the precise angle of her hands when gesturing—it was all too perfect. Too *deliberate*. There was no spontaneity to Rena Karlton, no flicker of genuine self. She had immersed herself so completely in her performance of nobility that Jens doubted she remembered what it was like to be anything else.

She was everything Jens rejected about the Upper World: shackled by protocol, posturing for appearances, enslaved by expectation. While he worked to slip the chains of social norms, she had embraced them—worn them like armor, like art.

Rena took her place at the front of the room, chin lifted in effortless authority. “As you’ve likely heard, I will be your homeroom instructor this semester. My name is Rena Karlton, and I specialize in water magic. In addition, I will be teaching you the fundamentals of mana principles and magic.” She held her head high as she spoke with confidence. “For the next two weeks, an exception has been granted for Miss Sofia Elernes, who was injured on school grounds. Her butler will assist her by taking notes. You are not to be distracted by this.”

Her gaze briefly flicked from Erik to Sofia. Jens caught the spark of awareness in her eyes. Rena immediately understood

something had happened between the two. But, in perfect noble fashion, she ignored it entirely. Disruption wasn't her concern. Appearance was.

"We begin today. I trust you've all brought the required tools. I suggest diligent note-taking—failure in the upcoming examination, three months from now, will result in reassignment to Class B."

The room fell into focused silence as Rena turned to the board and began to draw a series of diagrams, speaking with steady cadence.

"As I explained during our field exercise, the foundation of all magic lies in our mana core—sometimes referred to as the source. You can envision it as both a container and converter. It holds our life force, which is in constant use simply to sustain us. Skilled mages draw mana from their surroundings and convert it into personal mana, forming a protective barrier around their core. This barrier slows the loss of life force, preserving strength and extending life."

She continued, lines of chalk shaping a simple core, surrounded by layers of containment. "However, our bodies still require mana to function. Thus, the barrier must be flexible—both a shield and a provider that compensates for the mana blocked from the core. Maintaining this balance is the responsibility of every mage. Keep in mind that it's impossible for the barrier to

prevent more than fifty percent of mana leakage due to core radiation.”

Rena began drawing another diagram on the blackboard. “In simple terms, our bodies continuously draw mana from the mana barrier, and as mages, it’s our responsibility to replenish it. There are four types of mana cores: fire, wind, earth, and water. Each of us has a natural predisposition, making one of these elements much stronger than the others...”

Jens listened while copying the diagram, his hand moving quickly. It was a challenge, trying to match the speed of Rena’s explanation and accurately capture the intricate figures she drew. He was focused—until something caught his attention.

Kristoffer, seated beside Sofia, wasn’t just copying. His hand moved with mechanical precision, duplicating Rena’s diagrams and adding additional lines, annotations, and symbols that weren’t on the board. He was inserting his own insights into the lecture, as though filling in the gaps of a flawed presentation.

Jens paused, eyebrows twitching slightly. That level of understanding... it wasn’t just unusual. It was unnatural for a Lower Worlder. Where had he been educated? Who had trained him?

Suddenly, it made perfect sense why Sofia had chosen him. This wasn’t just a servant; this was someone prepared, someone

useful beyond measure. Jens leaned back slightly, a thoughtful frown pulling at his mouth.

He made a mental note to watch Kristoffer even more closely from now on. There was too much that didn't add up. But Jens knew better than to voice suspicions in a room like this. In the Upper World, survival often depended on keeping your insights to yourself—and waiting for the right moment to act on them. So, he said nothing, letting the questions settle in the back of his mind like coals waiting to ignite.

With a subtle shake of his head, he cleared the thoughts and forced himself to refocus on the lecture. There would be time later to puzzle over Kristoffer. For now, Jens needed to ensure he wasn't the one moved to Class B.

"This place changed a lot in a week," Lisa remarked lightly over her half-eaten bread, her gaze drifting toward the clusters of students scattered around the room. "He might be an insensitive ass, but I guess it works sometimes."

Ana chuckled softly as she peeled a boiled egg. "People did mellow out a bit. Maybe it's just because they're getting to know each other better." She turned to the small girl sitting quietly beside her. "Nina, do you want the soft one or the hard one?"

Nina hesitantly glanced at Ana's hands. She pointed weakly at the egg in Ana's right hand and gave a barely perceptible nod in thanks, her eyes never quite meeting theirs.

Lisa watched her with a pang of concern before shifting the topic, determined to keep the mood light. "Anyway, tomorrow we've got two hours of farming basics. I think we should use that chance to patch things up with Keith. It's stupid to let some boyish spat ruin everything."

Ana frowned. "Maybe, but... I don't know. I've never seen him this down before. It might be too soon."

Her sentence trailed off, cut short as the room shifted. An instructor entered, and behind him stood Daria.

Or rather, what was left of her.

Gone was the girl who'd been all sharp wit and boundless energy just a few weeks ago. Now Daria's steps were heavy and uncertain. Her nose was crooked, swollen with bruising, and the blackness under her eyes spoke of sleepless nights and constant pain. Her face was puffy, her eyes red, as if she'd been crying for hours.

"Erik Garnez has requested Nina as his servant," the instructor announced flatly, as though he were reciting a weather report. "This girl has been dismissed."

With a firm shove, he pushed Daria forward. She stumbled but didn't react—didn't protest, didn't speak.

Nina froze, the boiled egg slipping from her fingers, softly splattering onto the table. Her heart surged into her throat. She wasn't supposed to go back yet. There were supposed to be five more days. Five days of breathing, of pretending she was safe.

Why now?

She tried to stand, but her legs refused. Her whole body trembled. Tears welled up in her eyes, blurring everything. She wanted to run, to vanish, to scream. But something inside her, something cruel and invisible, forced her upright. Her limbs felt foreign, like they belonged to someone else—a puppet being dragged by unseen strings.

Daria's broken gaze met hers, and the truth hit her. Daria hadn't been dismissed. She'd been discarded.

With hollow steps, Nina walked forward. Each movement was a betrayal of her will, her body obeying a command her heart screamed against. Unknown force held her tight, an unrelenting leash binding her to the one she feared most.

Since arriving in the Upper World, her life had been a living hell. Erik Garnez had branded her with a hot iron, sold her body to countless men, and tortured her daily. Nina had attempted to take her own life many times, but each time her body froze just before she could succeed- as if some invisible force was stopping her.



“Please,” Nina’s voice cracked as she turned to Ana, desperation bleeding from every word. “Please, Ana... kill me.”

Ana's breath caught. Her hand flew to her mouth as her eyes filled with horror. "Nina... don't. Don't say that. Please. I'm sorry... I—I could never..."

Nina gave her a soft, sad smile—an understanding smile. She didn't blame her. It was selfish to ask someone else to carry her burden. To stain their hands for her weakness.

Cowardice.

Her feet carried her forward, away from the table, away from her friends. There was nothing left but submission. No one could save her now.

All she could do was lock her heart away—tighten the seal, bury the pain, and survive.

Change in circumstances

It had only been three days since classes began, but Sofia was already at her limit. The lessons were painfully basic—concepts she had mastered with Kristoffer as a child—yet that wasn't the worst of it. Much of the material was simply incorrect. Now, it was obvious why Professor Borgman was so despised here.

The faculty she had encountered so far were rigid, unwilling to challenge outdated theories. The fact that they still clung to the belief in only four elements was laughable. But whenever she tried to point out the flaws in their teachings, she was met with condescending smiles, dismissive remarks, and the same tired excuse—"unhealthy influence from Professor Borgman". To remain in Class A, she would have to write the incorrect information they taught her on the exams. The thought infuriated her more than she expected.

"Sofie, you're distracted again," Kristoffer's sharp voice broke through her thoughts.

She looked up from the desk she had been glaring at and met his gaze. Her frustration deepened. As if the situation wasn't bad enough, Erik Garnez had taken a personal interest in tormenting Kristoffer. It had gone beyond petty resentment—this was a grudge. The moment Sofia looked away, Erik found some new way to humiliate him. She hated it. More than that, she felt guilty.

She had dragged Kristoffer into this, and now he was suffering for it.

“Kristoffer, I’m so sorry,” the soft, quiet voice left her trembling lips. “If I had known, I would never have forced you into this mess. Maybe if we told him the truth, he’d—”

“No.” Kristoffer cut her off without hesitation. “That would make things worse.” His expression darkened. “Sofie, you promised. I only agreed to come here on the condition that you never say a word. And the way they treat me is normal. I’m a Lower Worlder.”

“This is not normal.” Sofia’s frustration boiled over. She stood abruptly with clenched fists. “I hate when you act like this, like you’re just accepting it.”

Kristoffer leaned back slightly, considering her words. “It’s called social stratification,” he said, a faint smile on his lips. “You’re the kind of person who sees a beaten dog and takes it in, helps it heal. These nobles? They’re the ones who kick it.”

He paused, weighing his next words carefully. Since the curse’s influence had weakened, he had begun questioning the orders given to him before they left the mansion. Eduard Elernes had told them to stay low, but after the assassination attempt, was that even an option? Pretending Erik Garnez had no involvement would be naive. Hiding was no longer a viable strategy.

His expression turned serious. "The way they treat me is expected, but that's not the case for you, Sofie. You're a noble. And frankly, you're the one being a pushover."

She let out a sharp breath. "And what do you expect me to do? He's a future duke, and the entire school is on his side."

"It doesn't matter if he's a future duke or the headmaster himself," Kristoffer said, meeting her gaze directly. "You're shaping your own future. If you decided to take over the entire island and rule it yourself, I'd believe you and stand by your side. And then your status would be higher than his, wouldn't it? Future ruler of the island sounds far more important than future duke to me."

His firm voice cleared her head, like a bucket of cold water thrown over her. "If you let him treat you like this for the rest of your time here, that's what people will remember. That will become your reputation. You can't afford that. He doesn't have to like you, but he must respect you. And if he won't admire you, then make him fear you. Those are the only two kinds of respect people truly understand." He leaned forward slightly. "You're a far better mage than he is. Make sure he knows that messing with you isn't worth the risk."

Sofia sat down heavily, staring at the desk. As much as she hated to admit it, Kristoffer had a way of making her heart skip a beat with just his words. It was worse now that the contract's influence had weakened, and he had become more casual with

her. He made everything seem possible, and suddenly, she felt foolish for holding herself back.

But that kind of confidence was dangerous. Things were moving too fast. She couldn't act recklessly, not without considering the consequences for her family.

"What about my parents?" she murmured. "If I make an enemy of the duke, the whole family will suffer."

Kristoffer didn't hesitate. "Your parents will suffer more if their only child is treated like this. Not just personally, but politically. People will mock the Elernes name." His voice softened slightly. "I don't know what the right choice is, Sofie. But I do know you can't let things continue like this. Class A is already avoiding you. When you take over as head of the Elernes family, you'll have no allies in the Upper World."

She exhaled slowly, rubbing her temples. "We're not getting anything done today. Take the rest of the day off. I'll think about it."

Kristoffer gave her a small, confident smile before turning toward the door. "I believe in you, Sofie." Then he was gone.

She waited a moment after Kristoffer left, then let out a frustrated groan and swept everything off the desk. Papers, books, and ink scattered across the floor, but the mess did nothing to ease the tightness in her chest.

Sofia was sick of being a noble. Her ideal future had nothing to do with politics, betrayals, or assassinations. She wanted a quiet life on the outskirts of the city, far from all of this. Afternoons spent painting and researching magic with Kristoffer, away from the expectations and suffocating traditions. She didn't need luxuries—just enough to live by. Selling her paintings would be enough.

But reality wasn't so simple. She had responsibilities—to her family, to her people. Her parents were counting on her to take over the Elernes house. And more than that, she was one of the few nobles who actually cared about Lower Worlders' rights. If she turned her back on this world, nothing would change. If she didn't fight, people like Erik Garnez would grow up to shape the island, passing even harsher laws, deepening the cycle of cruelty. She couldn't stand the thought of watching from a distance as people were hunted, abused, and tortured for entertainment.

Yet, despite all of that, she wasn't moving forward. She was stuck. Her progress with magic had slowed to a crawl thanks to the school's outdated curriculum. Every class felt pointless, every lesson a step backward. The only real benefit was access to the library, which gave her research opportunities she wouldn't have had otherwise.

But it wasn't enough.

Sofia felt suffocated.

Was it really so strange to want a normal life, surrounded by normal people?

Julian Ralezo was no exception to the rule of no contact with the outside world during the semester, but it never bothered him. He and his father didn't talk much anyway. Their relationship was solid—unconventional, maybe even a little strange, but solid. There was no need for constant check-ins. They had their own lives, their own goals, and an unspoken agreement: if one of them truly needed something, the other would be there.

And apparently, that time had come.

"Master Julian, your magic circles professor said you forgot this in his class," Angie, his adorable servant, walked in with a small envelope.

Julian accepted it with a lazy smile, throwing in a charming wink for good measure. "Thanks, sweetheart."

He already knew he hadn't forgotten anything—he never brought anything to class in the first place. But he didn't let his expression slip. It wasn't about distrusting his girls; he just didn't trust the other nobles in this place. There were plenty of ways to extract information from a Lower Worlder, no matter how loyal.

He unfolded the note.

Protect Sofia Elernes. Garnez is dangerous. Don't drink the cheap stuff, and don't mix ass with peach if you don't want an infection.

Julian bit the inside of his cheek to keep from laughing out loud.

His father had the subtlety of a brick to the face. Clearly, he wanted to avoid signing his name, so he'd added the last part to make it seem like a generic message. Unfortunately, anyone even remotely familiar with Vincent Ralezo would immediately recognize his handiwork. The man had never been suited for espionage.

Julian sighed, tucking the note away. "I'm heading out for a bit. Take a bath and wait for me," he murmured, biting Angie's neck before slipping past her and out the door.

Something serious must have happened if his father was going this far. Vincent Ralezo wasn't the type to meddle in other people's business—unless it involved one particular woman.

Julian had never asked, and his father had never admitted it, but after two decades in his company, it wasn't hard to figure out that Isabelle Elernes was the only person Vincent genuinely cared about. The old man never got involved in other people's messes, but for her, he made exceptions. Importing rare herbs, pulling strings in court, quietly shielding her from trouble—always from a distance, often without her even realizing.

Julian exhaled sharply.

So, this wasn't just about Sofia. This was a favor for Isabelle Elernes.

Luckily, he was already prepared to help.

Sofia was wary of him, but Julian hated owing favors, and he'd been keeping tabs on her anyway. He had a decent grasp of her allies, her enemies, and—most importantly—where one of those allies happened to be right now.

The heavy library door creaked as he stepped inside. Heads turned, eyes narrowing, but he ignored them. His target was on the second floor.

Without hesitation, he climbed the stairs.

“Mind if I join you two?” Julian asked, watching the couple in front of him stiffen in surprise.

Jens VarSmith and Katrina Welder froze, their expressions flickering between confusion and wariness. It took them a moment to recover.

“Lord Ralezo, of course!” Katrina was the first to regain her composure. “It would be our pleasure.”

“We’d be honored,” Jens added, though his voice carried a hint of unease.

Julian stifled a laugh, dragging out a chair and settling in as if he belonged there.

“We haven’t had much chance to talk until now,” he began smoothly. “How’s the school treating you? Meeting your expectations?”

He could practically hear the gears turning in their heads, trying to decipher his intentions. The noble world was miserable like that—every conversation dissected, every word weighed for hidden meaning. Well, in this case, they weren't wrong to be suspicious. But it was still amusing to watch.

"The curriculum is demanding, but the professors are very supportive," Katrina replied carefully.

"You can see why the academy produces so many skilled mages," Jens added. "Keeping up with the classes is no easy task."

Julian gave him a knowing smile. "Well, I might have a few tricks to make things easier in Class A. But, unfortunately, they have to stay within Class A." He turned to Katrina with an apologetic look. "Nothing personal, Miss Welder. It's just how things work here. But I'm sure with Jens's help, you'll be promoted soon enough, and then you can learn all the shortcuts from him."

"I understand, no need to worry about me," she said brightly, rising from her seat. "It was nice meeting you, Lord Julian. And thank you for helping my friend."

Julian didn't miss the way Jens's mood darkened as she left. Too bad. He never liked beating around the bush.

Scanning the room to ensure no one was within earshot, he activated the enchanted necklace around his neck. A subtle

shimmer in the air signaled the formation of a sound barrier. Jens stiffened, clearly sensing the shift in mana.

“Let’s drop the politeness. No one can hear us now,” Julian said, straightening in his chair. His voice lost its casual charm, turning sharp and direct. “Tell me, Jens—if you had to pick a side today, who would you choose? Elernes or Garnez?”

Jens looked like he’d been struck. He blinked at Julian, his fingers curling into fists. The abrupt shift in atmosphere had clearly thrown him off. Julian recognized that look. He’d seen it before—people caught off guard by the way he handled things. It was in moments like this that he had to reluctantly admit he was, in fact, Vincent Ralezo’s son.

“I think both families are—”

“Spare me the bullshit, Varsmith.” Julian leaned forward, watching him carefully. “My family doesn’t support either of them, so there’s no wrong answer. I just want the truth.”

Jens hesitated, then lowered his voice. “Elernes.”

“As expected.” Julian studied him for a moment before asking, “And what about your father? If neither side had any personal stake in his business, which one do you think he’d choose?”

Jens swallowed. “Probably not the same one.”

Julian smirked. “And which matters more to you? Your choice or your father’s?”

Silence. Jens was clearly struggling with the question, like no one had ever asked him something so directly before. It wasn't surprising. Noble conversations were rarely this blunt. But Julian didn't have time for indirect games.



Finally, Jens inhaled sharply. “Mine.” His eyes held newfound resolve.

“Good.” Julian’s smirk widened. He leaned back, voice light again. “Then tell me—how do you feel about becoming Erik Garnez’s new best friend?”

Kristoffer had noticed Sofia’s growing frustration over the past few days. Some of it was certainly due to her broken arm, which made even simple tasks difficult. But he knew that wasn’t the only reason. And if he was being honest with himself, he was at least partially to blame.

Maybe he had pushed her too hard. He had deliberately called her out on her passive attitude toward Erik Garnez, hoping to spark some defiance—something that would finally make her stand up for herself. But instead of rebelling, she had withdrawn, growing even more hesitant around the duke’s son.

On top of that, she was still upset with him for refusing to tell her what had happened with the other Lower Worlders. But Kristoffer had no intention of talking about it. Especially not while Carla was still avoiding him. It felt unfair to discuss it with others when she wouldn’t even discuss it with him. And beyond that... it was embarrassing. A strange, unfamiliar emotion for him.

Something in him refused to share it. His relationship with Sofia had changed—deepened—since their contract’s influence had weakened, and he didn’t want to risk ruining that. Every day, it felt like unseen shackles around his heart were breaking, revealing

parts of himself he had never known existed. For the first time, his emotions felt volatile, his blood running hotter, his usual logic clouded by something more instinctive. But he kept it to himself. Sofia already had enough on her shoulders—he wasn't about to add to it.

Still, he wasn't the only one keeping secrets. He could tell Sofia was hiding something too. She was good at it, better than he would have expected. But the way she carefully avoided talking about her accident, the way she brushed off any mention of how she had broken her arm—it didn't sit right with him. Was she just embarrassed about her usual clumsiness? Or was there something more to it?

"What you wrote here basically means that almost everything Rena said is bullshit," Sofia grumbled, flipping through the notes from class.

Kristoffer glanced over with an amused expression. "I wouldn't put it quite like that, but... a lot of what she said was inaccurate." He pointed at the diagram from their lecture. "Based on what you learned from Professor Borgman and Moonfick's notes, we know a mana core can evolve over time. And what about someone whose mana frequency falls halfway between fire and wind? Under Rena's classification, they wouldn't fit into any of her so-called fundamental elements."

They were in a small study room beside the library, comparing class material to outside sources. Normally, Kristoffer wouldn't

be allowed here, but Sofia's broken arm granted him a temporary privilege—one he intended to enjoy for as long as it lasted.

"I know you're trying to help, but it's so frustrating having to memorize both the correct and the incorrect version," Sofia sighed. "Writing false information just to get a good grade feels dirty."

Kristoffer hesitated. Under normal circumstances, he would insist she study hard. But lately, Sofia seemed dangerously close to breaking. Her normally bright eyes were shadowed with exhaustion, and the lively energy she usually carried had dulled into something far more fragile. He wanted to protect her from the weight of everything pressing down on her, but he wasn't sure how.

"Sofie," he said carefully, "if you want, I can focus only on the information from class. We don't have to—"

"Don't go soft on me now," she cut in, shooting him a sharp look. "I think we covered this week's material well enough. Let's go back and take a long, hot bath. And I want you to cook for me before you switch with Ana."

He couldn't help but smile at her stubbornness. It was hard to believe that this was the same girl who had once been dismissed as hopeless when she was a child.

"Alright," he said with a chuckle. "I'll return the books, and then we can head back."

Kristoffer left the room, giving Sofia space to organize her notes.

The library was packed with students, many of them desperately trying to keep up with their coursework. Almost everyone from Class A was poring over their gathered notes, flipping through pages with furrowed brows. Those from the higher-ranked classes worked even harder, their dedication widening the already stark gap in skill level between students.

Despite the crowd, the library felt like home to Kristoffer. The familiar scent of paper, the neatly organized shelves, and the sheer volume of knowledge contained within its walls created the perfect refuge for someone like him. In just a few days, he had memorized the layout, navigating its maze of bookshelves with ease. It didn't take him long to return the borrowed books to their proper places before heading back to Sofia.

She was leaving the study room, still focused on her notes, when a group of students barreled into her. The impact sent her stumbling to the floor.

"Pay attention, Elnes," Erik Garnez sneered, looking down at her with an arrogant smirk. "It'd be a shame if you broke your other arm."

His friends chuckled behind him, clearly entertained. Kristoffer felt his anger spike, but he forced himself to stay calm. Instead, he swiftly moved to Sofia's side and helped her to her feet.

"I'm glad at least one gentleman is present," she said, brushing herself off. Then, with a pointed look at Erik, she added, "No need to worry about me, Lord Erik. Even with no arms, I'd still be more capable than most."

Kristoffer watched the exchange closely. The sharpness in Sofia's voice, Erik's hostility, the nagging feeling that she was keeping something from him—it all clicked into place.

After a tense moment, Erik broke eye contact and turned away, motioning for his entourage to follow. But before he could leave, Kristoffer stepped forward.

"Lord Erik," he said coolly, his voice steady despite the heat rising in his chest. "Were you the one who broke Lady Sofia's arm?"

The hallway went silent.

Sofia's eyes widened in horror as she whipped her head toward him. Erik froze mid-step but quickly recovered, turning back with a bemused expression.

"Hey, Sofia, I think your dog is barking at me," he drawled, laughing. Then his grin widened cruelly. "And what if I did? What then? Know your place, trash. You seem to forget we don't live in the same world."

"Kristof—" Sofia started, her voice barely above a whisper.

"If you did," Kristoffer cut her off, his tone cold and precise, "then according to the Forefather's Law you recently referenced,

injuring another Upper Worlder means you are entitled to both reparations and the same injury in return."

A heavy silence followed. The bystanders looked between them, caught between shock and anticipation.

For a brief moment, Erik just stared. Then he threw his head back and laughed.

"This dog is threatening me!" Erik Garnez scoffed, his laughter echoing down the hallway. "Only the Elernes trash house could produce a lunatic like this." He sneered, turning back to Kristoffer. "But you know what, you shitty Lower Worlder? Let's do exactly as you want. Let's go to my uncle. As Minister of the Justice System, I'm sure he'll judge this case very quickly."

Then, as if struck by a brilliant idea, Erik's smirk widened. "Now that I think about it, Sofia should be punished too. She attacked me when I was merely reproaching my servant. I even hurt my wrist trying to defend myself from her reckless lunge between me and my property. Since she's technically a noble, she'll get away with just a few lashes—three at most. But you?" His eyes glinted with malice as he took a step closer to Kristoffer. "You're an entirely different matter. I wonder how many lashes it'll take before you start begging for a quick death?"

Sofia's breath caught in her throat. Terror gripped her as she looked between them. How did it come to this? Where was the peaceful life they were enjoying just a few weeks ago? Why had

Kristoffer provoked him? Was his curse acting up again? She had to stop this.

Pride be damned—if it meant keeping Kristoffer safe, she would beg Erik Garnez for forgiveness. She tried to move, but the moment she shifted her weight, pain shot through her broken arm. She gasped, swaying on her feet, dizzy from the sudden agony.

Kristoffer barely noticed.

For most of his life, every decision he made had been driven by logic. It was logical to develop his skills to support Sofia. Logical to study etiquette, protect her family name, and help her build alliances. Every action had been carefully calculated to secure a comfortable, stable future for her.

That all changed the day he watched her nearly die.

That moment had been the first time Kristoffer felt something completely overpower his reason. His body had moved on its own, shielding Sofia from the venomous spit of a mana beast before his brain could even register the danger. Afterward, he had convinced himself it had been nothing but instinct. Natural, rational. Beasts attacked humans, just as humans hunted them. There was a balance to it.

But what had happened at school defied all logic.

Why would other humans attack Sofia? She was the kindest person he had ever met—gentle, selfless, never willing to harm

anyone. How could anyone want to kill someone with such potential to make the world better?

Wasn't this supposed to be an island of peace?

He had tried to suppress it, tried to bury the feeling that had ignited within him that day beneath the tree. When he had seen Sofia, bruised and cornered, desperately fending off an onslaught of attacks from fellow nobles, something inside him had shattered.

That day in the forest, he had abandoned his cold, logical self.

He acted before thinking.

His father, his mother, the Elernes family, Upper World, Lower World—none of it had mattered. Only the present moment had existed. And just like then, he felt it now.

Rage drowned out reason.

Kristoffer's hand shot forward and closed around Erik Garnez's forearm. In the moment their mana touched, something shifted. The instant their mana connected, something raw and unexpected surged through him. It felt as if a sealed gate on Kristoffer's core had been forced open, releasing a tide he didn't know existed.

Erik felt it too. His eyes widened, caught off guard by the reaction neither of them understood.

Mana rushed through Kristoffer's muscles—unfiltered and wild, stronger than anything he'd managed in training. For years, he had failed to break past the limits of his body enhancement spells. Now, with his thoughts clouded and his control slipping, it came naturally like breathing.

"What the hell are you doing?!" Erik shouted, trying to tear himself free.

It didn't matter. Kristoffer's grip didn't budge. It was like iron rooted in stone.

"There's no need to bother your uncle," he said, voice low and flat. "Threatening Lady Sofia was a mistake. You walk around like the law doesn't apply to you."

His fingers tightened.

"I'm here to remind you it still does."

The sharp crack of bone echoed in the hallway.

Erik's scream followed a second later.

He stumbled back, clutching his right arm, his expression twisted in pain and disbelief.

"You trash!" he hissed. "Call the guards! What are you all staring at?! Call the damn guards!"

His voice cracked with fury. "You're dead, Lower Worlder. You'll beg for death by the time I'm done with you."

"Kristoffer, what did you do?" Sofia's soft, shaking voice cut through the noise. Her eyes were wide, full of panic she couldn't hide.

Kristoffer turned to her, still breathing hard. "Lady Sofia, you were kind enough to spare him because you're a better person than I'll ever be." His voice was calm, but there was something dark beneath it. "But this maggot—"

He didn't get to finish.

A jolt of mana slammed into his side. His breath caught.

He staggered, the force of the hit folding him to the floor. A sharp pain bloomed across his ribs. He clutched his side, trying to keep conscious through the blinding jolt.

Heavy boots approached. The guard's armor clinked as he stepped into view, eyes locked on Kristoffer with practiced coldness.

"You are under arrest for assaulting a noble," the man announced. "Any resistance will be answered with lethal force."

Kristoffer raised his head slightly. The library had gone dead quiet. Every pair of eyes was on him—watching, waiting, afraid. No one moved. No one spoke.

All he could think about was Sofia.

She was trembling, her lips parted like she wanted to say something but didn't know what. Her fear hit him harder than the spell had.

He tried to speak. Tried to reassure her. Just one word.

But no sound came out.

Instead, he forced a weak smile. Just enough for her to see.

And then something struck the side of his head.

Everything disappeared.

Eduard Elernes had long since lost track of time in the suffocating darkness of his cell, but he knew they were keeping him here longer than necessary—trying to break his spirit. He recognized the tactic well. Prolonged isolation, deprivation of comfort, subtle psychological games—all meant to wear him down. It was almost insulting. Did they truly believe he was the kind of man to shatter just because they denied him sunlight and space?

No, their mistake was assuming he had anything left to break.

What concerned him was not his own condition, but Isabelle's. Was she holding up? Had she kept her temper in check? If Robert Garnez taunted her—and of course he would—had she resisted the urge to lash out? Isabelle was many things, but patient was not one of them. Yet, even if she let her fury slip, there was little risk. Despite everything—even the fact that Robert had poisoned

his own men without hesitation—Eduard was confident the Duke wouldn't dare harm her.

An *accidental* death in prison? That would be difficult to sweep under the rug. And Robert Garnez did not do things that way. No, he preferred spectacle, the grand performance of a just and noble ruler. He wouldn't waste this opportunity to drag the Elernes name through the mud in front of the whole Upper World. He would turn the legal process into a stage, a show trial to destroy Eduard and his family in the eyes of the nobility while securing the island under his iron grip.

A predictable move.

Sofia, on the other hand, was more vulnerable. But she was still within the safety of the school, and Robert wouldn't risk his carefully polished image by attacking a girl whose parents were awaiting trial. *Not yet, at least.* Besides, Kristoffer was with her. Ernest, his old swordmaster and most trusted friend, had spoken of the boy's skill with an unusual level of respect. Eduard had known Ernest for decades, and the man rarely vouched for anyone. If he believed in Kristoffer's abilities, that was good enough.

More importantly, the master-servant contract bound Kristoffer to Sofia. He would protect her with his life. That was an ironclad certainty. Even if Robert had eyes on her, there would be no easy opportunity to strike.

That meant Robert's plan was simple—he would wait. He would let the trial play out, orchestrate his grand performance, and crush the Elernes family in full view of the public. He would drag them into the light, make them kneel before the so-called justice of the Upper World, and then discard them like a spent torch.

But what Robert didn't know was that he had already made a fatal mistake.

A few hours ago, one of the guards—planted long ago by Eduard's allies—had delivered a message in secret. Robert had grown careless, lowering his guard now that the Elernes couple was safely locked away. That very night, the Duke had received a shipment of mana stones, and—predictably—he had stolen a portion for himself before making his official report and handing over the rest to the Tower.

And his mistake had been recorded. Eduard's allies—who had followed his orders even after his imprisonment—had captured every damning second of Robert's crime on a magic stone.

And that wasn't all.

Thanks to their new and powerful ally within the University, they had discovered Robert's hidden laboratory—the place where he conducted his illegal experiments. And within that lab was every document, every record, every scrap of evidence proving the depths of his crimes.

Stealing magic crystals from the Tower. Using forbidden spells to eternally curse human souls, binding them to magical objects. And far worse.

Finally, the truth would come to light.

Eduard had spent his entire career preparing for moments like this. He knew when to retreat, when to sacrifice a piece for the greater game, when to let his enemy believe they had the upper hand. Robert thought he had won, thought Eduard was merely a man awaiting execution. Thanks to it he was more predictable.

But the moment their trial began, everything would be exposed.

Eduard leaned back against the cold stone, his mind already crafting the speech that would grip the hearts of the Upper World. The perfect words to unravel Robert Garnez's web of lies in an instant. To shatter his influence and set the island on a new path—one where Lower Worlders were no longer treated as disposable.

And then, he felt it.

A familiar ripple of mana.

Eduard sat upright as the cell door creaked open, his sharp gaze locking onto the man stepping inside. Ludwig Varsmith.

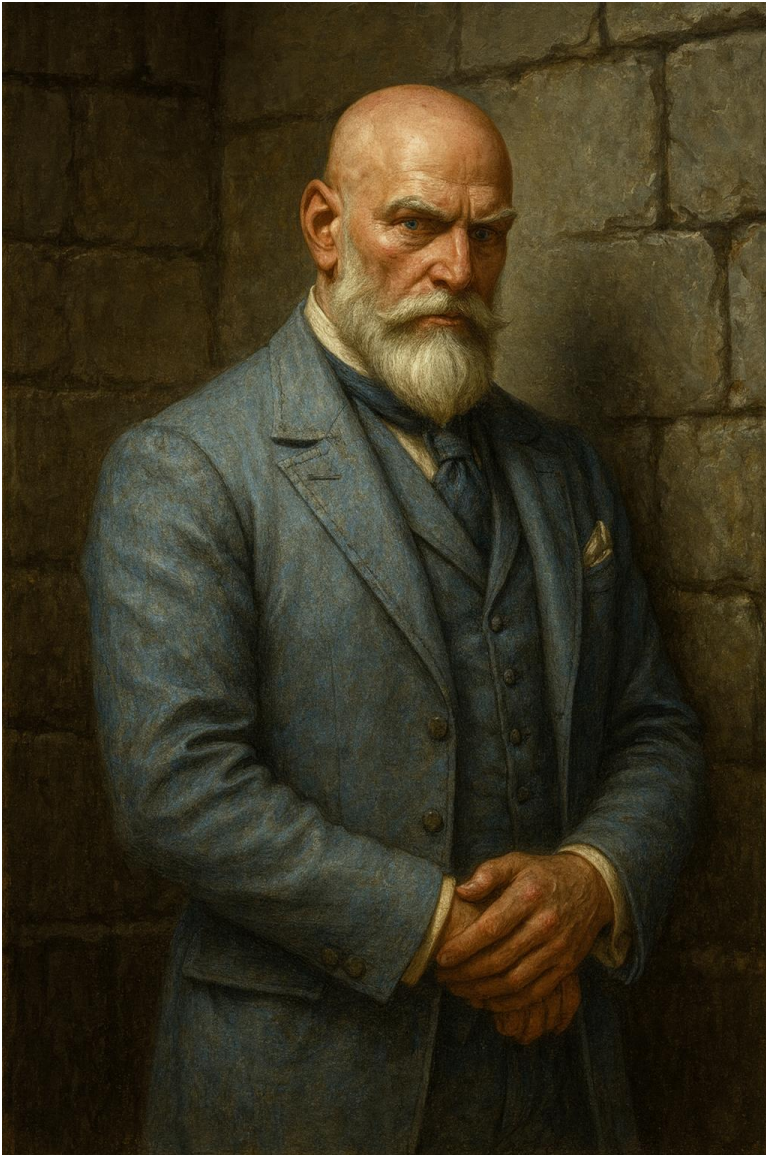
The traitor removed his hat, running a hand over his bald head as he dismissed the guard with a nod. The heavy door slammed shut behind him, sealing them in.

"It has been a long time since we last spoke, Ludwig," Eduard said with a steady, almost welcoming tone.

"I never thought we'd have to speak like this, Eduard." Ludwig sighed, stepping closer. "Let's have a heart-to-heart."

Eduard scoffed. "Your heart changes sides too easily, Ludwig. I'm not sure I want to expose mine to such bad influence."

Ludwig didn't flinch at the jab. He merely folded his hands behind his back, with a grave expression. "I won't ask for forgiveness. But you should know—I had no choice. Robert Garnez is a resourceful man. He gathered evidence about my activities in the Tower. Enough to ruin my entire family. Our faction was weakening by the week, Eduard. We never stood a chance."



Eduard raised an eyebrow, unimpressed. "A brilliant excuse. Have you considered writing fiction? You seem to have a talent for it."

Ludwig sighed again. "I'm not here to argue. I came to offer you a way out."

Eduard gave a slow, mocking clap, the chains around his wrists rattling. "How generous. Let me guess—if I roll over like a good dog, Robert will throw me a bone?"

Ludwig's lips thinned. "If you confess to Robert what evidence you have on his mana stone dealings and name your mole in the Tower, he will spare your family." He leaned in slightly, lowering his voice. "I do not like him either, Eduard. But he keeps his promises. Cooperate, and your wife and daughter will remain safe. You owe nothing to the Tower. You owe nothing to this island."

Eduard's expression remained unreadable. Then, slowly, he tilted his head back and let out an exaggerated yawn.

"Fascinating speech. Is this where I'm supposed to be overwhelmed by gratitude?" He shook his head. "Ludwig, you truly are wasted in politics. You should be performing on stage."

"This isn't a joke!" Ludwig snapped. "If you do nothing, your family will perish. You and Isabelle will be executed, and Sofia—" He paused, choosing his words carefully. "She will be nothing more than a remnant of a disgraced house. And trust me, the nobility won't let her be. They will eat her alive."

Eduard's eyes darkened.

"You should leave now," he said quietly, his voice carrying a warning edge.

Ludwig hesitated, watching him closely. "If you change your mind, tell the man who delivers your food. I'll make sure he notifies me immediately."

He turned, stepping toward the door.

Eduard waited until the cell locked shut behind him.

Then, he closed his eyes, taking slow, measured breaths. He would not let anger take root. He had work to do.

Let Robert think he had won. Let him gloat.

Soon enough, it would be his turn to watch Robert Garnez crumble.

"Fuck. This. Shit." Rey yanked the lifeless mana beast off his shoulder plate and flung it to the ground with a sickening thud. "I say we fall back, let the Tower boys deal with this mess. Call it a day, head home, and get blackout drunk for the next week. Who's with me?"

Berian didn't answer right away. His gaze swept over the battlefield—what was left of it. Blood pooled in the dirt, soaking into the earth like a grim offering. The bodies of his men, torn apart by the creatures they'd slain, lay scattered in the eerie

silence that followed the battle. Twelve had gone in. Four remained standing.

He exhaled slowly, dragging his blade across the torn fabric of his tunic to wipe away the blood. "If we disobey orders, best case? Prison. Worst case? We get labeled deserters and executed." He looked each of them in the eye. "You three don't have to go down with me. This is my mess. If you want to run, get as far away as you can, find some quiet farm to live out your days—I won't hold it against you."

Krein scoffed, his voice calm despite the carnage around them. "Berian, we knew this was a suicide mission from the start. Unless you're coming with us, we're staying."

"Yeah, what he said," Rey grumbled, rolling his shoulder with a wince. "Besides, if I ran now, I'd never hear the end of it from you. Might as well die on my own terms."

Jay shifted uncomfortably, gripping his spear tighter. "I'd prefer to fall back, actually," he admitted, voice hesitant but honest. "We killed over fifty of these things. That has to count for something, right? Maybe they'll let us walk away after we explain—"

Berian cut him off with a sharp motion of his hand, his entire body going rigid. Something was coming.

"GET READY!"

A split second later, a glob of green venom shot past his face, missing him by mere inches.

Rey was the first to react, already knocking an arrow as his sharp eyes locked onto the source—a monstrous spider, its fur bristling, its multiple eyes gleaming with malice.

Krein raised his staff, magic crackling at his fingertips—only for a 15-meter-long snake to explode from the undergrowth, hurtling toward them with terrifying speed.

Jay lunged, driving his spear forward, but the serpent twisted unnaturally, dodging the strike before snapping at him with fangs the size of daggers.

Berian didn't hesitate. "Krein, Jay—take the snake! Rey, the spider's ours!"

These creatures were deadly at a distance, but once in close combat, they lost their edge. The real problem was their speed—and the fact that Berian and his men were already running on fumes. His mana reserves were near empty, his body heavy with exhaustion. Without a burst of reinforcement magic, he wouldn't reach the damn thing in time.

With sheer willpower, he latched onto the last tattered remains of his mana barrier.

"Boost!"

Mana surged through his body, numbing the pain as he lunged forward. The biggest problem with the mage killer spiders was their intellect. The creature sensed the danger immediately.

Clicking its grotesque mandibles, it tried to escape, leaping for the safety of the trees.

But Rey's arrow whistled through the air, striking a branch just before the spider landed. The creature recoiled, bouncing off and dropping back to the ground.

Berian cursed. His exhaustion was making him sloppy. He hadn't accounted for the damn thing retaliating mid-fall. A glistening mass of green acid swelled in its maw, aimed right at him.

Shit.

"Stalagmite."

Familiar deep voice rang out behind him. It was steady and commanding, filled with confidence and power to back it up.

The earth shook—a jagged stone spear erupted from the ground, impaling the spider clean through its twitching, chitinous body.

Berian barely managed to stagger back in time, avoiding the toxic blood that dripped from the screeching creature. His heart pounded as he turned toward the voice.

"You look like shit, Berian," said Vincent Ralezo, his rune-covered scimitar still humming with energy as he cleaved the giant snake's head clean off.

The serpent's massive, scaled body slumped lifelessly onto Krein's chest before the healer gasped and shoved it aside, finally able to breathe.

“And who the fuck is that?” Rey asked, notching another arrow and sinking it into the spider’s skull for good measure.

Berian exhaled sharply. “Vincent Ralezo.” He wiped the sweat from his forehead, his gaze wary. “Duke Ralezo, thank you for the assistance. But why the hell are you here? This is a classified mission—and extremely dangerous.”

"Drop the ‘duke’ talk, Berian." Vincent’s sharp eyes scanned the battlefield, unfazed by the blood and carnage. "I’m here today as a mage and a soldier, not a noble."

Berian’s stomach tightened. Vincent Ralezo had everything a man could want—wealth, power, a legacy. Yet here he was, in the middle of a suicide mission, acting like it was just another day at the training grounds.

"I need to get to the mana rift," Vincent added.

Jay helped Krein to his feet. The young guard looked shaken but still had enough presence of mind to murmur a quiet thanks as Krein steadied himself against a tree.

Berian shook his head. “That’s impossible. We’ve been here three days and lost almost everyone. As you can see, we haven’t even crossed into the red zone.” His brow furrowed. “And since when do you take risks like this? Weren’t you the one always preaching about avoiding anything that could threaten your sanity?”

Vincent’s expression didn’t change. “Circumstances changed.”

"I know you're running on fumes," Vincent continued, pulling a small pouch from his belt. "But I came prepared. I have ten rings charged with mana stones. You'll each get two—enough to keep you on your feet. Assist me, and I'll make sure you get properly compensated."

Berian narrowed his eyes. Vincent was a hedonist, a man who trained hard but never took shortcuts. A man who avoided danger unless absolutely necessary.

So what the hell was he doing here?

There weren't many things in this world that could push Vincent Ralezo to put on actual armor and march into the mouth of death. And while Berian wouldn't say it aloud, after all the years they spend together he had a good guess.

Isabelle.

But that wasn't his business to bring up.

Rey clapped Berian on the shoulder, breaking his train of thought. "What the hell are you thinking so hard about? We're fucked either way. Might as well take whatever help we can get."

Vincent chuckled. "I like this guy." He glanced at the others, eyes sharp with unshaken confidence. "Call me Vincent. I'll take the vanguard—I'm best with earth magic and I don't mind getting my hands dirty." He twirled his scimitar, stepping forward.

"Now," he added, a smirk curling his lips, "let's get this shit over with."

“I demand a meeting with your captain. And with my servant,” Sofia said firmly, glaring at the nervous guard behind the reception desk.

“There’s nothing to demand, Elernes,” Erik Garnez cut in with a sneer before the guard could respond. “His fate belongs to my family now. As soon as the city guard picks him up, it’s over.”

Sofia didn’t even look at him. “Are you listening to me?” she pressed the flustered staff member again. “If you won’t open the door, I’ll open it myself.”

“What’s going on in my post?” a commanding voice interrupted them as a tall, broad-shouldered man in polished armor entered the room.

“Captain Assim!” the receptionist nearly jumped to his feet in relief. “A Lower Worlder attacked the son of a duke and broke his arm. We’ve locked him up and sent for the city guards. But Lady Sofia Elernes—his registered master—demands to see both you and the prisoner.”

“Lower Worlder assaulted an Upper Worlder?” Assim’s brows rose as he looked over the nobles. “Is he properly marked?”

“He lost the visible mark during some incident in the past, but he’s documented. Passed all the inspections.”

“I’m Erik Garnez,” the duke’s son snapped, stepping forward like he expected the ground to part for him. “That mangy servant

attacked me. I demand he be delivered to our estate for appropriate punishment. And Sofia Elernes assaulted me when I tried to discipline my servant.”

“We follow the law here,” Captain Assim replied bluntly, brushing past Erik like he was a coat rack. “The prisoner will be transported to the city’s holding facility. His case will be evaluated in court. Where is this Lower Worlder? I want to meet him.”

“He’s in the last cell on the right in the basement,” the receptionist added.

“Captain Assim, if I may,” Sofia spoke up, her voice calm and respectful, but her eyes still sharp.

“What is it?” Assim turned toward her with a furrowed brow.

“I’d like to invoke the Law of Our Forefathers,” Sofia said clearly, her voice echoing slightly in the room. “I’m choosing to banish my servant to the Lower World. That removes him from trial jurisdiction and permanently severs him from House Elernes.”

“You can’t do this!” Erik snapped, his voice rising with outrage. “That’s an outdated law! He assaulted a noble—he has to pay for that!”

Sofia tilted her head, expression feigning innocence. “Strange. Weren’t you the one so passionately quoting that same outdated law when you broke his nose?” Her smile didn’t reach her eyes.

Erik's fists clenched, his injured arm trembling at his side. His face turned a deeper shade of red, rage boiling beneath the surface.

"It might be outdated," Captain Assim interjected with a calm, even tone, "but the law stands. If she invokes it, the servant forfeits his status. No trial, no punishment, and no further claims. I'll see to it that he's sent directly to the transportation circle."

Erik's voice turned venomous. "If you go through with this, my father will retaliate. That piece of trash belongs to me now."

Assim met his glare without flinching. "Then tell your father we followed the law of our ancestors, as written. I've worked with Lord Garnez for years—he respects our traditions, even when they're inconvenient. You should follow his example. Now get that arm looked at—it's beginning to swell."

Turning back to Sofia, he gave her a brief nod. "By invoking this law, you relinquish all rights and responsibilities toward him. You're allowed five minutes to speak with the prisoner before transfer. Make them count. Open the cell."

"Thank you, Captain Assim," Sofia said with a courteous dip of her head. Then she turned to Erik and flashed a smile sharp enough to draw blood.

She didn't wait for a reply. The receptionist guided her down into the basement—a quiet, damp corridor with only a few occupied

cells. He handed her a heavy iron key and promptly excused himself to give her privacy.

Sofia unlocked the cell and stepped inside.

Kristoffer sat in the corner, hunched forward, arms loosely wrapped around his knees. The dim light made him look paler than usual, and the dark bruise where the mana blast had hit him was still visible under his shirt. When he lifted his head and saw her, something flickered in his eyes—relief, disbelief... maybe shame.

He stood, stiffly.

“You really messed up this time,” Sofia said, stepping inside and quietly shutting the door behind her.

Kristoffer immediately stood, his composure cracked. “I’m sorry, Sofie. I don’t know what came over me, I just—”

“We don’t have time,” she cut in, her voice low and urgent. “You won’t be staying with me anymore.”

His eyes widened. “Sofia, I’m sorry for the trouble I caused you, but if I can’t stay by your side, then... then there’s no point. Please,” he dropped to one knee, head bowed, “end it here and now.”

Sofia didn’t respond with words. She walked up to him, gently cupped his face between her hands, and tilted his head up. For a moment, she simply looked at him—seeing not her servant, not

a burden, but someone she trusted more than anyone. Then she kissed him.

It wasn't hesitant or rushed—it was soft, deep, and filled with everything she didn't have the time to say.

Kristoffer tensed at first, completely caught off guard. But then he relaxed, melting into the moment as his arms gently held onto her waist. He knew this would be his last chance to hold on to her.

When she finally pulled away, her forehead rested against his for just a second longer before she stepped back. Her smile was warm, but her eyes burned with determination.

"You're smart, Kristoffer," she said, "but you're also an idiot."

He blinked.

"You're going to the Lower World. And once you're there, you're going to live. I'll deal with the pompous duke, the nobles, the politics—everything. You don't have to worry about me."

"But—"

"No." She held up a hand. "You said you'd believe in me, remember? Even if I said I wanted to rule the island? Well, I'm saying it now. I will fix this place. So go. Be free. You've more than earned it."

Upon seeing the fire in her eyes, something in him cracked. He stood tall, and despite everything, smiled.

“If you say so, Sofie... then I believe you. I’ll do my best. I don’t know how can I live without you, but if it’s your order, I’ll try.” He paused. “If you see my mother, please... tell her I love her. And that she doesn’t have to worry—I’m stronger than I look.”

“TIME!” a voice bellowed from beyond the cell door. Sofia stepped toward it, but turned back one last time, her smirk playful through the sadness.

“Oh—and for all the chaos you caused today, you’re officially fired. Permanently. You’re no longer my servant and you never will be again.”

Kristoffer raised an eyebrow, confused.

“And I’ve been thinking... there’s no law that says someone can’t come back to the Upper World. So if life down there ends up unbearable, you can always try to climb your way back.” Her smile turned razor-sharp. “But if we meet again—it’s as equals. You call me Lady Sofia even once, and I’ll personally castrate you.”

He stared at her, dumbfounded. She winked.

The guard opened the door, stepping inside.

“We’re ready. The captain needs your signature before the transfer,” he said, addressing Sofia.

She didn’t look away from Kristoffer.

“I’m coming,” she replied, then took one last breath and gave him a smile—gentle and radiant.

“Thank you for everything,” she said. “Goodbye, Kristoffer.”

Journey into the unknown

“You need to bend over more. Right now you look like an old woman searching for mushrooms,” Ana giggled, gently pressing against Lisa’s lower back to correct her posture.

Lisa groaned, her joints cracking in protest. “I hate these classes. Why do I need to know how to bend in a sexy way when I serve a woman? Complete bullshit.”

“*LANGUAGE!*” a short, round instructor smacked Lisa’s backside with a folded fan. “No man wants a foul-mouthed girl. Keep that tongue in check or I’ll personally teach it some manners.”

Lisa clenched her jaw, barely restraining herself from snapping back. The woman muttered something about “uncivilized Lower Worlders” under her breath as she waddled off.

Ana leaned closer with a whisper, grinning. “Just two more weeks. Then we can finally focus on classes that don’t require breaking your spine.”

“I don’t get how you’re so good at this,” Lisa muttered. “Weren’t you raised by a priest? You should be worse at this than me. Where’s the justice in that?”

Ana opened her mouth to retort, but the door creaked open before she could speak. An instructor stepped inside, his presence silencing the room.

“Lower Worlder Ana,” he announced, scanning the class with sharp eyes. “You’ve been summoned by Lady Sofia Elernes.”

Heads turned. A few whispers broke out.

Ana blinked. Her gaze flicked to Lisa, who gave her a quick nod. They didn’t speak, but the shared confusion was clear.

Sofia never called on her directly—not for errands, not for meetings. If anything serious came up, it was always Kristoffer or Lisa who handled it. Whatever this was... it wasn’t ordinary.

She followed the instructor in silence, her nerves creeping in with every step. He didn’t speak, and she knew better than to ask questions he wouldn’t answer.

They reached the quiet meeting hall, strangely empty. No bustling aides, no buzz of discussion. Just stillness.

The instructor gestured to the door and turned away, leaving her alone. Ana hesitated for a heartbeat, then opened it—and froze in the doorway.

Instead of Kristoffer, Sofia stood inside, waiting.

“I came to pick you up,” the noble girl said softly, her voice carrying something tired beneath the surface. “You haven’t seen where I live yet.”

Her smile was faint. Forced. Ana had seen many expressions on her master’s face—curiosity, irritation, mischief—but never this.

The spark that usually danced in Sofia's eyes was gone, dulled into dark circles and a glassy, distant stare.

"Lady Sofia..." Ana stepped forward slowly, concern pressing into her chest. "What happened?"

"A lot of things," Sofia replied quietly. "But I'll explain it all somewhere more private. Let's go to Katrina's room."

Ana followed, her steps light but her heart heavy with suspicion. Whatever had happened, it was bad—Kristoffer not being with them said enough. And as they crossed the courtyard, Ana couldn't help but notice the stares. Every pair of eyes followed Sofia, and though the whispers were hushed, their presence pressed down on her like a storm cloud building overhead.

Once inside the dorm, they climbed to the second floor. Sofia knocked softly, then let herself into Katrina's room.

The moment Ana stepped inside, the air changed. She froze at the sight of Carla curled up on the bed, eyes red and swollen, sobbing into Katrina's shoulder. The cheerful maid who usually floated through her duties like a sunbeam now looked like a ghost of herself.

Sofia closed the door behind them. Ana followed quietly, settling near the bed with the others.

"Alright," Sofia began, her voice clear but flat, as if she'd rehearsed the whole thing on the way over. "For Ana's sake, I'll start from the beginning."

What followed was... a lot. Erik Garnez breaking her arm. Sofia hiding it. The attack in the sanctuary. The confrontation in the library, and Kristoffer breaking Erik's arm in retaliation. Every sentence layered shock over shock. Ana stared in disbelief, trying to make sense of it all while Carla had gone still, huddled in silence as if clinging to Sofia's every word.

"But the rumors aren't true," Sofia continued. "Kristoffer hasn't been sentenced to death. He's being banished to the Lower World. He's alive. That's important."

Ana's heart sank even with the reassurance. So that's what this was about. Carla's crying. Sofia's sudden resolve. The broken puzzle slowly came together.

"I'm telling you all this," Sofia pressed on, "because everything changes from now on. I'm going to challenge Erik Garnez for control of Class A. I'll build my own faction. He's had his fun—but I'm going to end it."

The silence in the room deepened.

"In three months, there's a school tournament," she said, turning to Katrina. "I want you to participate. Wipe the floor with your classmates and transfer to Class A."

Katrina blinked. "I—Jens has been helping me study, but I don't know if I can meet your expectations, Sofie. Some of them are really good..."

“There won’t be an issue,” Sofia interrupted without hesitation. “I’ll teach you myself.”

Then she turned to Ana. “And you’ll need to keep pace with Lisa for now. When we’re allowed to contact my family, I’ll request Zoey’s transfer. She’ll join us eventually and take some weight off your shoulders.”

Sofia glanced around the room, checking their faces like a commander reviewing her troops. “Any questions?”

Ana watched her master with quiet disbelief, struggling to reconcile the girl standing before her with the one she’d known for years. Sofia looked worn down, the exhaustion visible in the dark circles under her eyes—but something in her presence had changed. She stood taller. Spoke with certainty. That usual soft edge, the tendency to sidestep conflict and hide behind smiles, was gone.

It wasn’t just surprising—it was a little terrifying.

Sofia had always preferred to drift at the edges of politics, more interested in her sketches and books than noble rivalries. But this version of her? This Sofia had sharp angles. And she wasn’t drifting anymore—she was charging straight ahead.

Ana wasn’t the only one caught off guard. Katrina’s lips were parted like she still hadn’t caught her breath, and Carla looked like the air had been knocked out of her completely.

“If there are no questions, I’ll go find Jens,” Sofia said, breaking the silence. “Please don’t share what I told you. Not even with him. Ana, stay here. I’ll need you later. Katrina, if you could explain how things are structured here—who’s in which groups—I’d appreciate it.”

Then, with a small nod, she reached out and patted Ana’s head on her way out.

The room felt heavier the moment the door clicked shut behind her.

“I think...” Katrina began hesitantly, “I think Sofia’s still in shock. She’s just... pushing through it. Hard. And I don’t know how to help her when she’s like this.”

“I was going to talk to him tomorrow,” Carla whispered. She hadn’t moved from her curled-up position on the bed. “I thought we could fix things between us after coming back to our quarters.”

Ana looked between the two of them, not sure if either of them expected her to say something. Her own thoughts were a blur.

Kristoffer, attacking an Upper Worlder? She could barely wrap her mind around that.

But Lady Sofia, declaring war on a duke’s family like it was nothing? That was even harder to process. She felt proud. She felt afraid. It was too much all at once.

Without a word, Ana sat down on the bed beside Carla, still trying to make sense of it all.

“I think we should start with tea,” Katrina said softly.

Ana and Carla both nodded vigorously in agreement.

After a long, bone-jarring ride with a sack pulled tight over his head, Kristoffer was shoved into a small, windowless room and left in silence. The door locked behind him with a dull metallic clunk. There was a bed, barely more than a slab with a mattress, and a toilet tucked into the corner. Cold concrete walls boxed him in. Simple, but functional.

He didn’t move at first. Just stood there, letting the stillness settle around him.

His thoughts, however, didn’t settle. They tangled and twisted in his chest, like roots too knotted to pull apart. The last thing he remembered clearly was Sofia’s voice, her fingers on his face, the warmth of her lips still lingering faintly against his own. It had been unexpected, that kiss—soft, clumsy, a burst of emotion more than anything else. But it had sent something bright and unfamiliar pulsing through him.

Still, that wasn’t what held him in place now.

It was everything else.

He knew what the Lower World was—or at least the stories. Harsh, unstable, filled with risks he couldn't yet calculate. But not unfamiliar. He was raised by people from there and lived with them since he could remember. If survival was the goal, he could manage. Adapt. He always did.

But was survival the goal?

There were people waiting for him in the Upper World. His mother. Lisa, with her sharp mouth and soft heart. Ana, who clung to hope even when the world gave her no reason to. Carla—still difficult to define, somewhere between friend and something more. And now Sofia, who was suddenly... more complicated than ever.

He'd told her he'd believe in her. Said the words with conviction.

But belief didn't untangle the knot in his chest. Not when he couldn't trust his own mind.

The contract had twisted him again. Back in the library, everything had blurred—her pain, his fury, the unbearable need to protect her. The moment Erik Garnez sneered, Kristoffer's control snapped once again. Just like in that forest. His body had moved without permission. His mana had surged like it belonged to someone else.

And that was the real problem, wasn't it?

He couldn't be sure how much of his loyalty was his. The closer he stayed to Sofia, the tighter that contract gripped his soul. And

if they tried to remove it... there were no guarantees. The process might erase everything he was—his instincts, his memories, even the parts of him he didn't realize were borrowed.

Leaving now, going to the Lower World, might be the only way to put distance between himself and that influence. The safest option. No commands. No bond. Just space. He could start again. Build something that was truly his, free of the contract he never asked for.

But even thinking that left a bitter taste in his mouth.

Because part of him wanted to go back. Wanted it so badly it scared him. Not just for Sofia, or what they'd shared in those final moments. But for the life he was starting to build. For the people who had become more than names or roles. For the small, selfish part of him that wanted to be seen not as a servant, or a weapon—but as Kristoffer.

And right now, he didn't know who that really was.

He finally sat down on the edge of the bed, trying to calm the weight in his chest. His fingers fidgeted slightly, tapping against each other, a quiet rhythm to distract from the strain pulling at his core. The encounter with Erik had taken more out of him than he expected. Something hadn't gone back to normal—mana still stirred under his skin like a fire that wouldn't go out. He wasn't sure what it was, but either way, it left him uneasy.

That moment of contact... something had happened when their mana clashed. Some kind of resonance that didn't feel random. His instincts told him it was important, but his thoughts were too scattered to put it together. All he knew for sure was that his core felt... off.

Kristoffer exhaled slowly, making a list of more palpable theories about what had happened.

Heavy footsteps outside cut through his thoughts.

Not the usual shuffle of guards. These had purpose. Confidence. Like whoever was coming didn't expect to be stopped.

The door opened with a mechanical click, then a low groan as it swung inward. A man stepped inside—tall, composed, dressed in elegant crimson robes that made him look completely out of place against the dull concrete. His white cane, laced with embedded mana stones, tapped once against the floor before the door closed behind him with a firm thud.

“Do you know who I am?” the man asked.

“Yes,” Kristoffer said quietly, forcing himself to his feet.

“Excellent. That will simplify things.” The duke set his cane aside with casual elegance and slipped out of his crimson coat, revealing immaculate cuffs and finely tailored sleeves. “When I heard someone had snapped my son's arm with grip alone, I was intrigued. But a Lower Worlder?” He smiled like a man watching

a chessboard fall perfectly into place. “Well, that warranted a closer look.”

Kristoffer kept his face neutral, even as his heart drummed like a warning. He didn’t drop his gaze, but he didn’t speak either. There was nothing to say.

Robert continued, with an unhurried, almost warm tone. “Naturally, I looked into you. After all, bypassing the binding effects of a master-servant contract is no small feat. Imagine my surprise when I discovered your mother—Nora—alive, and hiding a son.”

He chuckled softly, shaking his head as if recalling an old joke. “That woman always tried to slip through my fingers.”

Then he moved—fluid, confident—and crossed the room in a few quiet steps. “Let’s see what she passed on, shall we?”

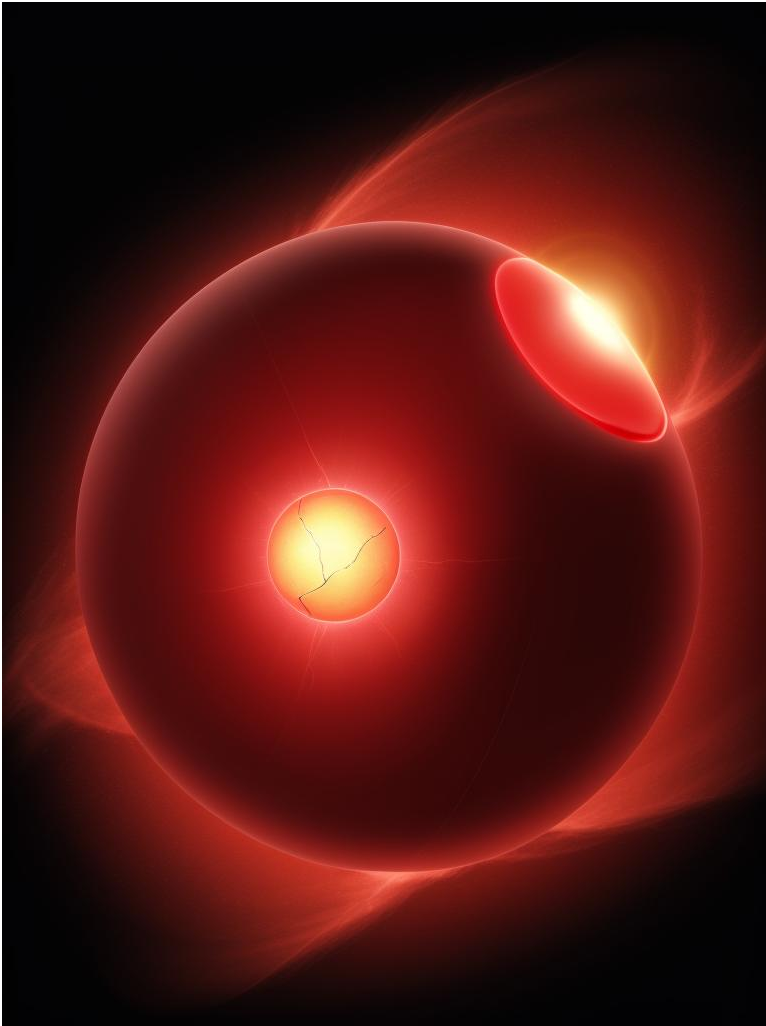
Before Kristoffer could brace himself, Robert’s hand pressed against his chest.

The pressure hit instantly. Not physical—worse. The duke’s mana tore into him with surgical precision, a violent wave that slipped through every defense Kristoffer had built over the years. His mind buckled under the weight of it. His core, already damaged, trembled as Robert’s presence wrapped around it—cold and invasive, like frost forming on cracked glass.

Kristoffer dropped to one knee, breath catching in his throat. His vision blurred at the edges.

Robert finally stepped back, brushing invisible dust from his sleeve with the same indifference one might flick off a bug.

“Just as I thought,” he said with a sigh, almost bored. “Diluted, yes. But there it is—faint traces of my mana.” He tilted his head, voice cooling. “And that fissure... quite the fracture. With a core like this, I’m afraid you’re of no use to me.”



Kristoffer pushed himself back to his feet, jaw clenched, every breath scraping through his lungs like gravel. His body trembled—not just from the earlier intrusion into his core, but from the weight of what this man represented. Still, he stayed quiet.

“Show me what you can do. Attack me,” Robert said, almost pleasantly.

Kristoffer leaned against the wall, refusing to move. “No.”

The duke’s smile curled into something crueler. “How much did Nora tell you about me?”

Kristoffer said nothing.

Robert’s voice dipped lower, vicious smile crept up on his face. “She was a delight at first — squirming, crying, so full of life. But after two years, your mother broke. No more screams, no more fight. Just a corpse with a heartbeat, lying there, taking it like the whore she is-”

“Boost!”

The spell exploded through Kristoffer’s veins and he lunged, fury overriding every ounce of control. He aimed a punch at the duke’s face, raw instinct guiding the strike.

Robert caught his arm mid-swing, unfazed. With the ease of tossing a child, he pivoted and hurled Kristoffer across the room. The boy’s body slammed into the concrete wall with a wet crack. The pain spread instantly, radiating from his ribs into his back.

“Enhancement spells?” Robert said, turning slowly. He raised a hand and summoned a flame that hovered just above his palm, burning white at the center. “You need to try harder than that. Use the element that flows in our blood. Or do you really think you can touch me without trying your very best?”

Kristoffer forced himself upright, coughing through gritted teeth. “Piercing bullet” he muttered, barely managing the chant.

The mana bolt whistled through the air, sharp and swift. Robert barely glanced at it — a lazy motion of his hand, and the spell unraveled into nothing, as though reality itself refused to acknowledge it.

“I truly don’t know what I expected from a Lower Worlder,” Robert sighed, brushing an invisible speck of dust from his sleeve. “The matter of fact is...” He gave a soft, amused chuckle. “That little Elernes bitch went and saved you. Banished you, thinking she’d given you a way out. How sweet.”

He stepped back to his coat, reaching into the inner lining. When he turned again, there was a small syringe in his hand, filled with a faintly glowing green liquid.

“But luckily,” he said, walking toward Kristoffer, “I came prepared.”

Kristoffer tensed, but the blow still knocked the wind out of him. A boot drove into his stomach, pinning him to the floor while Robert lifted his arm and jammed the needle under his armpit. The burn was instant. Sharp. Cold and hot all at once, as if fire and ice were colliding in his veins.

“You’ve heard of mage-killer spiders, haven’t you?” Robert asked as he pulled the empty syringe free and slipped it neatly back into his coat. “This one’s based on their venom. Refined. Deliberately

unstable.” He smiled as if sharing an inside joke. “You’ve got two days. Three, if you’re lucky. Not that it’ll matter.”

Kristoffer curled on his side, gasping, the first waves of nausea already twisting through him like a knife.

The duke squatted beside him, his tone dropping lower.

“It would be ridiculous to let you just live after what you did to my son. You thought you could go down to the Lower World and rebuild your little life? Please. You’ll rot there. Alone. And the best part?” His voice dropped to a whisper, thick with venom. “Your mother’s still mine. Contract’s intact. I could have her jump off a cliff tomorrow and no one could stop it.”

He straightened his coat, dusted his lapel, and turned for the door.

“And the Elernes?” he added over his shoulder. “Caged. Forgotten. Waiting to die. You have no one left, boy.”

He paused, smiled faintly.

“Goodbye... my ‘son’.”

The door slammed shut, hard enough to rattle the frame.

Kristoffer stayed motionless on the floor, his back to the wall, the cold from the concrete creeping into his bones. The poison was already working through him, eating away at his core, seeping into places mana used to flow cleanly.

He didn't know if it was rage, grief, or just helplessness that pulled the scream from his chest — raw and loud, echoing off the stone like something primal. He slammed his fist into the wall, then again, until the pain overtook the anger and left him gasping.

Tears came. Quiet at first, then heavier, until he couldn't stop them. His hand was shaking as he reached for the edge of the enchantment still flickering across his skin. He deactivated it. The weight of exhaustion hit him like a wave.

"I will kill him," he whispered hoarsely, breath catching in his throat.

"I will not die until I kill him."

"We need a damn break," Berian muttered, planting his sword into the dirt and leaning against it, his breath ragged. "We keep pushing like this, we'll be corpses before the rift gets a chance to kill us."

They'd made it farther than they had any right to. Vincent's mana rings had given them an edge, but that edge had dulled fast. Bodies didn't run on mana alone — not when sleep, food, and the will to stand had been left behind hours ago.

"You feel that pull?" Vincent said, voice low as he wiped the blood off his brow with the back of a scorched sleeve. "We're close. Too close to stop. The rift's not just mana — it's madness. It gets in your head. If we rest now, it'll start whispering."

“I don’t care if it starts singing lullabies,” Rey groaned, sliding down next to a moss-covered log. “I’m sitting. My spine is two shots away from quitting the job entirely. And what the hell was that last thing? A butterfly with a cat’s face and fangs? I think I stabbed it in the pancreas, if it even had one.”

“I-Is that normal?” Jay’s voice cracked. The younger soldier looked like he’d aged five years since they entered the red zone. “Do people really go crazy this close?”

“Jay, you sweet summer idiot,” Rey snorted. “People go crazy near their in-laws. This is a tear in reality itself. You’re holding up well.”

“It’s not a joke,” Krein said gently. “Rifts warp more than mana. They bend who you are. You think the world’s shifting around you — until you realize you’re the one unraveling.”

“Charming,” Rey muttered, chewing on the end of a broken arrow. “What do they even want us to kill? I signed up to stab bandits and chase mana beasts, not march into hell and fight nightmares from a bad acid trip.”

“You should’ve stayed behind, Rey,” Berian said with a tired smile. “But I admit, your whining keeps the silence away.”

“Flattered,” Rey deadpanned. “Tell my future corpse I was entertaining.”

“I just wanted a simple life,” Jay spoke up quietly. “Become a town guard somewhere quiet. Maybe buy a horse. I never asked to get pulled into this.”

Berian gave a quiet nod. “Neither did I.”

There was a pause. Then he added, more to himself than to the others, “I wanted a cottage in the hills. A wife who didn’t mind how quiet I was. A garden we could tend to while playing with our dog. But the sense of responsibility chained me to this job and here I am.”

“And what about you, Ralezo?” Krein asked, resting beside Rey. “You’ve got land, power, money, women. Why the hell are *you* out here bleeding next to a bunch of misfits?”

Vincent didn’t answer right away.

He leaned back against the tree, head tilted toward the canopy above. When he spoke, his voice wasn’t as smooth as usual — it was quieter. Older.

“Because none of that fills the hole.”

The others went still.

“You chase what they say matters,” Vincent went on, gaze far away. “Power, respect, pleasure. I had all of it. I still do. But it’s all just noise. A distraction. Because there was one thing I really wanted, and I let it slip through my fingers like an idiot. Thought I could live without it. Thought I’d find something better.”

He closed his eyes, exhaling slowly.

“Turns out there’s no substitute for the real thing. And by the time you realize it, it’s too late. So now... I chase whatever lets me pretend it doesn’t hurt. But when she’s in trouble, I can’t stand by. No matter how much it costs.”

Rey blinked. “Damn. That was... unexpectedly poetic. Thought you were gonna say you lost a bet or something.”

“Don’t get used to it,” Vincent said with a crooked smile. “Sentimentality is a symptom. Probably means I’ve been near the rift too long.”

Berian glanced at him, voice low. “It’s about her, isn’t it?”

Vincent didn’t reply.

He didn’t need to.

Krein gave a long sigh and rested his head against the bark behind him. “I never cared for riches. Went into healing to help people. Got dragged into this because Berian asked, and I trust him. That’s all there is to it.”

“I didn’t ask,” Berian murmured, eyes soft.

“You didn’t have to,” Krein replied with a small, tired smile.

Before the mood could settle into anything too sentimental, Rey rolled his eyes and leaned back against a tree. “Alright, before you girls start holding hands and braid hair...”

He didn’t get to finish.

A scream — raw, high-pitched, and inhuman — cut through the air.

They all turned toward the sound.

Jay was convulsing on the forest floor, his right arm drenched in a viscous, pinkish slime that oozed from the branches above. The stuff clung like leeches, bubbling as it ate into his skin. The young soldier thrashed, trying to tear it off, but the more he struggled, the deeper it seemed to fuse.

“Hold still—!” Krein dashed toward him, dagger already drawn, trying to slice the substance free.

But before his blade made contact, Jay’s eyes rolled back — and in one swift, impossible motion, he drove his spear straight into Krein’s gut.

Krein let out a wet gasp, stumbling back as the spear was ripped free.

“What the hell—Jay?!” Rey barked, but the young soldier wasn’t there anymore.

Whatever was left of him was laughing. Wild, guttural laughter that didn’t belong in a human throat.

Jay lunged again, and Rey barely managed to sidestep. A split-second later, Vincent’s sword flashed. A clean arc — and the corrupted arm hit the ground with a splatter.

Jay collapsed, twitching, frothing at the mouth. Krein crumpled beside him, unmoving, blood pooling fast beneath his robes.

Vincent exhaled hard, wiping his blade clean with a grimace. “Break’s over,” he muttered. “Let’s move before the trees start vomiting more horrors.”

Rey dropped to one knee beside Krein, fingers pressing gently to the older man’s throat. His usual sarcasm was gone.

Just a quiet nod.

Then he stood, shouldered his bow, and followed the others without a word.

For a while, they walked in silence — a silence that weighed heavier than any monster they’d fought.

It was Berian who finally broke it. “What happened to Isabelle?”

Vincent didn’t look at him. “Framed by Garnez. She’s in prison, waiting for execution.”

The words were clipped. Controlled. But there was a tremor beneath them, like a crack beneath glass.

“Can you feel it?” the duke added, nodding forward. “We’re almost there.”

The forest thinned suddenly, giving way to a massive clearing. At the center, the rift pulsed — a yawning, circular wound in the world, its swirling center bending light like heat off scorched

metal. The earth surrounding it was charred and dry, covered in strange dark veins that pulsed like veins under skin.

Mana rolled from it in waves — now pulling, now pushing — like the rift was breathing.

“It looks nothing like it used to,” Berian murmured. “This place was once... peaceful. Still green. Now it stinks of death.”

“See those rocks near the edge?” Vincent asked. “They’re watching us. I can feel them.”

As if on cue, several large boulders twitched.

“Do or die now,” the duke said, rolling his shoulders. “Get ready.”

Rey narrowed his eyes. “How the hell do you fight rocks?”

“Preferably fast,” Vincent replied, crouching to press his palm to the ground. “Before we draw a crowd.”

He began chanting — low and steady — as glowing sigils flickered to life beneath his feet. The moment his hand connected with the soil, the earth groaned, and a chunk of it rose into a boulder-sized bullet, humming with compressed mana.

The stones surrounding the rift responded immediately. They stirred and began piecing themselves together — limbs forming, a torso pulling from the dirt, jagged slabs of earth falling into place to shape a hulking golem.

But Vincent didn’t wait.

With a sharp exhale, he released the spell.

The rock missile blasted forward like a cannon shot. It struck the forming creature dead center, shattering it mid-assembly. Chunks of stone exploded outward in a shower of debris.

Berian was already moving. He rushed into the chaos, kicking and tossing away the fragments that still twitched, scattering them across the clearing.

“See anything?” Rey shouted, sliding into position, arrow already notched. “Core? Crystal? Glowing ‘stab me here’ sign?”

“I don’t see shit!” Berian growled, eyes scanning for any hint of weakness. The shattered pieces he’d scattered were already rolling back, reassembling like they were pulled by a silent command.

Vincent didn’t wait for instructions. He dropped into a stance and murmured another incantation. Mana surged through his veins, and stone formed around his scimitar, reshaping the blade into a brutal sledgehammer. With a burst of speed, he charged, slamming the weapon into the golem’s chest. A thunderous crack echoed through the trees — stone splintered, fractures ran up its side — but the creature didn’t crumble.

“Cut it with water, Berian!” Vincent barked. “Don’t let it swing!”

Berian planted his feet, tried to focus — but the rift twisted the air, bending the flow of mana. His willpower buckled under the weight of exhaustion and magical interference. The runes refused to stabilize. His fingers trembled.

“Move away! Plan C!” Rey’s voice cut through the chaos like a blade.

They didn’t need to be told twice.

Berian dove to the side. Vincent veered left. In perfect synchrony, they cleared the path.

Rey stood alone, breathing hard. He pulled a single arrow from his quiver — short shaft, crystal-red head, humming with dormant power. The thing had cost him a year’s salary. Custom-forged, alchemically treated. Supposed to punch through a drake’s hide, if you believed the shady merchant who sold it.

Maybe it would even buy them a second more of life.

He lined up the shot with the crack Vincent had made in the golem’s chest. A heartbeat passed. His aim steadied.

“Please work, you overpriced bastard,” Rey muttered — and let it fly.

But the golem moved, faster than any of them expected.

Its massive arm wrenched loose from its body mid-swing and hurled itself like a boulder straight toward him.

Rey’s eyes widened. He saw the projectile pass the arrow midair.

He tried to move — but his legs gave out beneath him. Too battered. Too slow.

The stone struck him square in the head. A wet, heavy sound — then silence.

Berian stared, frozen, as Rey's body hit the ground.

There was no scream. No farewell.

Just a twisted, broken mess where his friend had been standing a moment ago.

Then the arrow struck.

A flash of red light — then a concussive blast. The golem's chest exploded, shrapnel flying in every direction. Both surviving men were knocked back, deep cuts instantly opening across arms, cheeks, legs.

As the dust settled, one stone — larger than the others — glowed faintly. Blue, rhythmic, like a dying heartbeat.

Vincent staggered to it. Without a word, he raised his makeshift hammer and brought it down.

Once. Twice. A third time.

The light dimmed.

He kept swinging.

Even after the glow was gone, even after the golem was nothing but rubble, he didn't stop until the weapon slipped from his bloodied hands.

"Fuck," Vincent muttered, collapsing beside the shattered stone. Dust clung to his blood-slicked skin, his hands trembling with the aftermath of spent magic and too many dead men.

Berian limped over, boots dragging through crushed stone and dried blood. He dropped beside him with a groan, his body nearly as battered as his soul. For a long moment, he didn't speak. Neither of them did.

"We probably woke up the whole damn island." Berian whispered first, breaking the silence.

Vincent let out a long breath. It sounded more like surrender than relief. "Yeah. But nothing's coming," he said, eyes scanning the treeline. "Maybe even the beasts know better than to stick around now."

He leaned back against a half-buried root, hands slack in his lap, voice quiet. "I'm sorry, Berian. Your companions... they were good men. I didn't know them long, but they were the kind of people I wouldn't mind dying beside."

Berian nodded slowly, not quite able to meet his gaze. His eyes drifted back to the clearing—if it could even be called that anymore. Shattered stones lay scattered like discarded bones, the aftermath of their battle strewn in grim silence. Where Rey had fallen, there was hardly a shape left to mourn. The crushed remains of his body, head obliterated by the flying boulder, were barely human now—just torn flesh among the debris. Berian looked away, jaw tight, the image already burned too deep into his mind.

“They weren’t even supposed to be here,” he said, the bitterness cutting into every word. “The Tower handed me the order— assemble a squad, push through the red zone, cull the beasts. ‘Make it safe for the Lower Worlder farms on the fringe,’ they said. As if we weren’t all just feeding ourselves into the grinder.”

His jaw tensed. “None of them volunteered. We didn’t talk about that, but it’s true. Orders came down, and they got swept along. Even Krein. Even Jay.”

His voice cracked as he spoke the name.

“I told myself we could manage. That we’d make it out. But I think... maybe I just wanted to believe it wouldn’t all be for nothing.”

There was a long pause. Vincent didn’t speak. Just rested a hand on Berian’s shoulder for a moment—quiet, steady.

“We’ll drink to them,” he said finally. “All of them.”

He stood with a groan, wiping dust from his coat with a hand that shook more than he wanted to admit.

“But first,” he added, eyes narrowing on the warped shimmer ahead, “I need you to cover me for just a little longer. I’m going to take a look inside.”

Berian snorted, the sound half a laugh, half a wheeze. “Optimistic of you to think you’ll be sane enough afterward to enjoy that drink.”

He pushed himself to his feet with a grunt and dusted off his knees. “Let’s face it, Vincent. We’re dead men limping. We barely made it through that jungle with five good fighters. Now it’s just the two of us—half-dead, half-broken, full of bad decisions.”

“Don’t worry about the odds,” Vincent said with a crooked grin, giving him a wink. “I’ve got a date with destiny. Or at least with Isabelle. She’d kill me if I died without a proper goodbye.”

Berian muttered, “Knowing her, she’d kill you either way.”

Vincent chuckled. “Yeah, but at least that one’s familiar.”

The two men stood in silence for a moment longer, the humor fading into something heavier. Berian shook his head.

“This plan is absolute garbage, by the way.”

“I know,” Vincent replied. “But it’s still better than whatever the Tower thought they were doing.”

Berian gave a dry chuckle. “I’ll raise a glass to that.”

Vincent grinned. “Let’s just make sure we’ve got hands left to hold it.”

Then he stepped forward into the clearing.

The moment he crossed the threshold, the air changed. Mana pressed down on him—not with the chaos of a storm, but the slow, crushing weight of something vast and ancient. The ground beneath his boots thrummed with a pulse that didn’t match any

heartbeat he'd ever felt. Not human. Not beast. Something else entirely.

He let out a breath, and it left his mouth in a white fog. A strange contrast to the sweat still clinging to his back. Like two climates fighting for control over his body.

"Here goes nothing," Vincent muttered under his breath.

He steadied himself, fingers weaving tightly in a sheath of his own mana. The flow was unsteady—frayed from fatigue and overuse—but it was still his, stubborn and alive. That would have to be enough.

He reached out.

The moment his fingertips brushed the rift, sound ceased to exist.

The cold wasn't just cold. It was invasive. It bypassed his skin entirely and sank into the marrow of his bones, into the spaces behind thought. A hollow, biting void that gnawed at the very edges of who he was. His mana buckled. His core twisted violently, as though every thread of it were being pulled from opposite ends, unraveling one strand at a time.

He staggered, breath hitching, and dropped to one knee. His body screamed to recoil, but his hand stayed locked in place. His teeth clenched so hard his jaw throbbed, and still—he held.

Then the rift reached deeper.

It wasn't just draining his magic now. It clawed at his identity—dragging up memories he hadn't touched in years. The echo of Isabelle's laughter. The warmth of her hand in his. The first spell he ever mastered. The nights he drank too much just to forget the mornings that came after. Everything he was—pulled toward that yawning dark like it was trying to decide what to keep and what to throw away.

He fought it. But it was too much.

Something inside him gave way.

And as his vision blurred and consciousness slipped free of his grasp, all Vincent could do was whisper the most important thing in his life—

“...Isabelle...”

Then everything went black.

Robert Garnez was growing increasingly tired of being surrounded by fools.

Bayan Cosar's loose accounting had turned from creative to idiotic, Dario Valron couldn't keep his mouth shut for five seconds without naming names, and Erik—his own son, his legacy—had been publicly humiliated by a girl. A girl from the Elernes house, no less.

The irony wasn't lost on him. It was poetic, in the way tragedies often are.

Worse than the embarrassment was the fallout. Eduard Elernes had gathered evidence—real, damning evidence—on the misuse of state-distributed mana stones. Sloppy. Unforgivable. If it were only Eduard, that would be manageable. But the nature of the information suggested something deeper. Someone had helped him. Someone dangerous. And if there was a second player at the table, Robert had no intention of letting them remain in the shadows.

That was why, against better judgment, he'd agreed to this meeting.

When the guard opened the reinforced door and nodded, Robert straightened his coat, adjusted the white glove over his left hand, and stepped inside the narrow room. Cold. Grey. Two chairs, one table, no charm to speak of. Functional. Controlled. His kind of place.

Isabelle Elernes was already seated, dressed in a worn grey tunic that clung too tightly to bruised skin and too loosely to her dignity. But there was no shame in her posture. No fear in her eyes.

Robert met her gaze. Still sharp. Still proud. And behind those eyes—the mind of a woman who had once reshaped the very fabric of their society. The architect of the first binding spells. And now, a ghost of her former self. But this ghost had teeth.

He took his seat with the grace expected of a duke and rested both hands atop his cane.

“I can see only two reasons why you'd request this meeting,” he began smoothly “Either you're smart enough to recognize how much we could gain by cooperating... or you're foolish enough to think you still stand a chance at beating me.” He offered a polite, almost warm smile. “And I do dislike wasting time on the latter.”

Isabelle tilted her head slightly, the corners of her lips curling— not quite a smirk, not quite amusement.

“The fact you came here not knowing which one it is,” she said, “tells me exactly how valuable the information I hold is to you.”

Her beauty hadn't faded with age. It had sharpened, matured— like a blade forged through fire and buried in frost. Her eyes were tired, but only in the way of someone who had stayed awake too long because the world refused to change.

“I asked you here for one reason,” she continued. “I want assurances. Real ones. Not theater. How do I know you won't turn on my family the moment this conversation ends?”

Robert studied her for a long moment before speaking, calculating the angle of every word.

“I'll offer an official confession—blaming Valron's death on a power struggle within his own family,” he said, tone calm and precise. “You and your husband will walk out of this prison today,

with clean names and intact reputations. If Eduard agrees to stop digging through graves, we can take it further.”

Robert leaned back and took a serious tone.

“Your daughter is beautiful. And more importantly, powerful. A direct descendant of the First Counselors. If she were to marry my son, our families would create a union the Upper World hasn't seen since the founding days. Together, they could become the cornerstone of a new age.”

He observed her face, trying to read her reaction.

“And you want me to believe you'd let us live in peace,” Isabelle said, her voice flat, “while we carry enough knowledge to tear down your carefully built house of cards? After you killed your own men right in front of us?”

“Those are empty accusations,” Robert replied, his brow tightening. “What's your counteroffer, then?”

“Can you make sure no one's listening in?” she asked, reclining slightly in her chair. “Otherwise, we'll just keep spinning in circles.”

Robert studied her, looking for any signs of a trap. Her expression was calm. Unreadable. There was something unsettling about her—equal parts conviction and calculation. For someone known more for her compassion than politics, she wore that mask of steel rather well.

Still, he trusted in his own wards and the safeguards he had brought. Without hesitation, he channeled mana into the necklace beneath his collar, activating the soundproofing spell around the room.

The moment she felt the shift in the air, Isabelle spoke.

“We make a contract. Etched directly onto our cores. Just like we do with Lower Worlders.”

A smart play. Binding both sides equally, ensuring her family’s safety in the only truly enforceable way. It would be difficult to back out of, and dangerous to fake. She was no fool.

But neither was he.

Robert leaned back, thoughtful. The contract would bind him just as tightly as her. And for someone with her expertise—who had helped shape the servant system alongside Warren—it would be reckless to allow her any access to his core.

“No,” he said finally. “It’s too risky. Even with supervision, I don’t trust you not to slip something into the spellwork. You know too much about how these runes function.”

“Then what’s your counteroffer?” she asked, eyes narrowing—sharp enough to cut glass.

“I already gave it,” he answered, voice cooling with every word. “Don’t confuse my presence here with weakness. I’m still the one in control. There are plenty of ways to get the answers I want, and you know that.”

He tapped a gloved finger on the head of his cane.

“I’m even willing to overlook the fact that you kept my son hidden from me. But this is it, Isabelle. Take it or leave it—unless you’ve got something else worth saying.”

She didn’t blink. “You don’t trust me because you know exactly what you’ve become.”

Robert’s eyes narrowed slightly, but she continued without hesitation.

“I know what you’re working on. Binding a human soul to a magical object isn’t just imprisonment—it cuts them off from the reincarnation cycle. From the natural order. From the void.”

Her voice didn’t tremble. It was clear and full of quiet anger.

“You’re not just a murderer, Robert. You’re a monster.”

He exhaled slowly, as if tired of hearing the accusation.

“Cats kill for sport and people still post paintings of them in their parlors,” he said, waving a hand. “I work in the margins of society — the forgotten, the condemned — and suddenly I’m the villain.”

He leaned forward, resting his elbows on the table, fingers laced.

“You’re an idealist, Isabelle. Always have been. But ideals don’t build walls. They don’t stop what’s coming.”

His voice didn’t rise. If anything, it dropped into something more intimate, almost confessional.

“You know how many of our greatest medical discoveries came from torture? From watching the human body fail, again and again, so that others could survive? People like you cling to the results but pretend the process never happened. That the hands delivering healing were never bloodied first.”

He paused, eyes narrowing slightly.

“Progress demands a price. Always has. We stand on the bones of those who came before us. If I have to choose between sacrificing a few already-damned lives and watching this entire island burn, then yes — I will bear the weight. Not because I enjoy it. But because someone has to.”

Isabelle didn't flinch. Her gaze was level. Cold.

“Spare me the justifications,” she said. “You're not bearing the weight for anyone but yourself. You're not a martyr. You're not a savior. You're just a man who wants control. And you've wrapped your greed in philosophy so tightly you can't tell the difference anymore.”

Robert's smile faded. His voice, when it returned, was calm, but firm.

“It's like you've closed yourself off from reality,” he said. “I doubt you haven't heard the reports. The mana anomalies in the rifts are growing worse. The beasts are evolving. The wilderness in the Lower World is already a living hell. And that dragon circling the

northern cliffs? It hasn't attacked — yet. But if it does? The Tower doubts the barrier will hold.”

He shifted in his seat, folding his hands over the head of his cane.

“But if we reinforce that barrier — fuel it with mana from those who offer nothing back to this world — we might stand a chance. What you call cruelty, I call necessary arithmetic.”

He met her gaze directly.

“And what have you done, Isabelle? You heal wounds. Stitch flesh. Patch up the aftermath, but never the cause. You treat symptoms while ignoring the disease eating away at the world. And somehow, you still claim the moral high ground.”

“I see,” she said quietly. “So this is your version of compassion.”

“You think I’m doing this for power?” Robert’s voice dipped. Not angry — disappointed. “I hate powerlessness. That’s all. I hate standing idle while the world spins into chaos.”

He looked at her now not with contempt, but with something that almost resembled pity.

“The weak always serve the strong. It’s not cruelty. It’s nature. Evolution didn’t hesitate to cast aside entire species — why should we pretend magic hasn’t made a new one? We are not equals, Isabelle. Not anymore. The strong decide the fate of the weak. Always have. And pretending that humans are above that truth is the most naïve lie of all. Especially now — when we’re about to find out what it means to be prey again.”

Silence settled between them — deep, suffocating.

Isabelle didn't flinch. Her hand rose slowly to rest over her heart.

"I'm glad," she said, voice calm but razor-sharp. "Glad I finally got to see your real face. The mask never suited you."

She tilted her head slightly, eyes narrowing.

"Out of all the nobles I've ever worked with, you always gave me the worst feeling. Something in your presence that made my skin crawl."

Then, her voice dropped — low, steady, like the silence before a storm.

"Tell me, Robert. Was it you who ordered the attack on my daughter?"

The duke's intuition screamed. His skin prickled with invisible warning, instincts sharpened by decades of survival telling him to move. But his pride — that ever-looming shadow — kept him seated. He would not flinch. Not before her.

"It was Valron's idea," he said evenly. "If I'd planned it myself, I wouldn't have sent a bunch of amateurs who couldn't finish the job."

"But you knew?" she pressed, leaning in just slightly. Her eyes never left his.

Robert felt his throat tighten. The question hung in the air like a knife. He could lie, but something told him it wouldn't matter. Not to her. And certainly not now.

"I did," he admitted.

The moment the words left his mouth, everything changed.

The air vanished.

It wasn't gradual. One breath he could feel. The next — nothing.

His lungs seized, gasping uselessly. Panic flared behind his eyes as he turned toward Isabelle. She was already moving — one hand raised, the other darting away from the table. He felt it then, the wind blade slicing toward him.

He channeled mana into the defensive rune embedded in his cane just in time. A crackle of force shimmered in front of him, absorbing the blow — barely. Without the artifact, he'd be on the floor with his throat opened wide.

He staggered to his feet, leaning heavily on the table, vision spinning. His body screamed for air. His hands trembled. He pointed the cane at her, pouring mana into the casting rune, but the fire spell fizzled out the moment it formed — starved of oxygen, like a spark in a vacuum.

She didn't hesitate. Another attack followed.

His thoughts were unraveling — strands of focus snapping one by one. No air. No fire. No way to anchor a silent spell with his mind

in chaos and his lungs screaming for breath. He blocked the next attack with a clumsy surge of mana from his cane, then forced another burst inward, flooding his brain, clawing back what clarity he could.

How was she doing this? Silently casting. Sustaining the suffocation field while launching offensive spells. This wasn't the medic he'd seen in reports. This was something else. Something far more dangerous.

If he couldn't cast fire at range, he'd have to get close. Force the magic through his body, bypass the need for air by pouring raw mana straight into the flame. Risky. Crude. But possible.

He grit his teeth and forced a simple rune into place in his mind. His heel slammed against the stone floor.

Spikes erupted from the walls behind her — not to kill, just to draw her reaction.

She moved instantly. Reflexive. Fast.

Right into his reach.

He caught her by the throat with his right hand, stumbling forward with what little strength he had left. Her skin was slick with sweat and blood, but he held her.

And still — her magic didn't break. No gasp. No hesitation. The suffocation held. Her eyes, bloodshot and burning with pain, didn't waver.

His grip was weak. His body failing. She clawed and kicked, striking his ribs, but he didn't let go.

He raised his left hand.

Burning hands.

Mana surged. Heat burst from his palm. Flames crawled over her throat, blistering red and raw.

She screamed inside the sound barrier. Her legs buckled.

The stench of burning flesh filled the air — thick, acrid, choking.

But no air followed it.

He staggered. His legs gave out. The world tilted.

Robert Garnez — the most powerful man in the Upper World — collapsed to his knees.

And beside him, Isabelle fell too.

Blood poured from the charred mess of her throat. Her breath came in ragged, invisible spasms — what was left of it. She twitched, barely conscious, but her eyes were still open.

Still smiling.

It was a ruined smile — bloody, hateful, defiant. And even now, even while dying, she hadn't released the spell.

Robert stared at her through a haze of black at the edges of his vision.

She was really going to die just to kill me.

He hated her for it.

And respected her more than he'd ever admit.

But he wouldn't let it end here. He refused.

With the last thread of will he could muster, Robert forced mana into his body, giving it strength to crawl to his battered opponent.

Isabelle tried to pull away, her fingers scraping the floor, but her body had given out. She collapsed—too broken, too drained to resist.

He reached her.

Clamped his right hand around the ruined remains of her throat.

Burning hands.

She gurgled, a wet rasp of defiance still clinging to her as she weakly reached for his arm. But he intercepted the movement with his left—and that's when it happened.

His arm went numb.

No feeling. No strength. It dropped to his side like dead weight, unresponsive and foreign.

A flicker of panic slipped through the cracks in his control.

Snarling, Robert forced a brutal surge of mana into his other hand. The spell ignited white-hot — raw, unfiltered power — and fire tore through flesh and sinew. Artery. Windpipe. Gone.

Isabelle went still.

But the air... didn't return.

His lungs convulsed against the vacuum. Vision flickering, he staggered, half-conscious, his thoughts unraveling.

Not like this. Not now.

He forced his body forward, rolling her over, searching her chest with what little focus he had left. That's when he saw them — bandages, soaked in blood, partially torn loose during the fight.

With his only working hand, he summoned a final flicker of flame. It sputtered, strained — but it was enough. He burned through the fabric.

The smell hit first. Burnt cloth, blood, skin.

Then he saw it — a magic circle carved directly into her body, each rune etched with agonizing precision. Deep. Deliberate. The spell wasn't sustained by concentration.

It was bound to her core.

She'd tied her soul to the spell, willing to die just to drag him down with her.

Robert stared at it, rage and awe battling in his chest. Then, with the last spark of strength, he burned through the circle.

The runes shattered.

And with them — finally — the air returned.

It hit like a punch to the gut. He gasped, coughing violently, every breath laced with blood and ash.

He collapsed backward, choking on the heat, the room thick with the stench of scorched flesh.

His gaze drifted to his right arm — limp, mottled with a purple stain where her fingers had touched him in her final moment. The cursed imprint was already spreading like rot beneath the skin.

Robert lay there, chest heaving, breath catching on every inhale.

And then he laughed. Dry. Bitter. Too tired to be cruel.

“What a crazy woman,” he muttered hoarsely.

Eduard Elernes had learned long ago that nothing good ever followed hurried footsteps in a prison.

He rose from the creaking bed and approached the cell door, the dull sound of boots slapping against stone echoing through the hallway. Voices. Clanging metal. Tension.

A horrible feeling got hold of his stomach.

He leaned in, placing his ear lightly against the cold iron—just in time for the lock to snap and the door to burst open, catching him off balance. Eduard hit the floor with all the grace of a man who’d once taught ballroom etiquette and now found himself face-down in a dusty cell.

“Well, that’s hardly gentlemanly,” he muttered, brushing himself off and standing as five armored men poured into the room.

The one in the center, clearly the leader, removed his helmet and gave him the kind of look Eduard had seen too many times — calm, professional, and deeply unconcerned with the lives of others.

“Lord Elernes,” the man said. “We’re here to extract some information. Cooperate, and this will be painless.”

Eduard offered him a smooth, courteous smile, as if the five men had wandered in by mistake looking for directions.

“Five unexpected visitors in such a cozy place. How charming. You seem to know me, but I’m afraid I haven’t had the pleasure. Names, perhaps? And while we’re at it, would you care to explain what all the noise outside is about?”

The leader’s jaw tightened. “Names won’t matter. The commotion isn’t your concern. What matters is this—who are you working with inside the Tower?”

“Hmm,” Eduard mused, keeping the smile. “That does sound important. But I have to ask first: my wife... Isabelle. She’s not one for staying quiet. And it occurs to me that something very loud is happening out there. You wouldn’t happen to know if those two things are connected?”

Behind his back, Eduard dragged a fingernail across his wrist — a small, precise cut. The pain didn’t even register.

“You’re not in a position to be asking questions,” the mercenary growled, stepping forward. “There’s no water in this cell. You’re powerless. We’re the ones in control here.”

Eduard raised an eyebrow. “You’re sure?”

The leader opened his mouth, but whatever brilliant declaration he had planned never made it out. His head separated cleanly from his shoulders, thudding to the floor with a wet splat. The man’s body followed a heartbeat later.

The other mercenaries didn’t even have time to react before Eduard’s blood whip sliced across the room in a clean, gliding arc. The one to his left was bisected at the chest, while the next caught the tail end of the strike through the pelvis. His mana shield bloomed too late — a moment’s hesitation, a lifetime’s cost.

“Fireball!”

“Stone bullet!”

The remaining two cast on instinct, but the blood whip was already shifting.

Drawing in the spilled blood of their fallen comrades, the weapon grew—thicker, faster, alive with violent grace. It coiled around Eduard like a crimson serpent, rotating in a spiraling blur. The first spell slammed into it and dissolved like mist; the second scattered against the whirling shield of blood as if it had hit a wall of blades.

Then the whip hissed—twisted—and lashed out with surgical precision.

It sliced through both men's knees in a clean, fluid motion. They dropped screaming, their legs folding beneath them in a spray of red that slicked the stones underfoot.

Eduard advanced with a calm step, as if he were strolling across a ballroom floor. His posture was relaxed, his tone mild.

“Now then,” he said, eyes cool. “The commotion outside. I’ll ask once more. Is it related to my wife?”

One of the men groaned, blood pouring freely from the stumps where his legs had been. He raised a trembling hand, trying to speak—his eyes filled with defiance.

“You won’t get awa—”

He never finished.

The whip flicked once more, and the man’s skull split cleanly in half. His body sagged to the floor in silence.

That left one.

Eduard crouched beside him, still composed. The mercenary’s breath hitched, his hands soaked in his own blood as he stared up, paralyzed by pain and fear.

“You’re quite unlucky,” Eduard said gently. “You’re the last. But it means you get the rare privilege of my undivided attention. If you’d like to avoid unnecessary pain, I suggest you speak plainly.”

“We don’t know anything!” the man choked out. “We were just told to extract information! I swear! We were just told it was urgent!”

Eduard watched him closely, reading every tremor, every twitch of the man’s face. Then, with a faint nod that was almost sorrowful, he replied.

“I believe you.”



The whip struck one final time, piercing his heart in a single, merciful thrust.

Silence settled over the cell once more.

Eduard stood. His eyes swept the floor—wet with blood, streaked with the aftermath of a fight that should never have happened. His mind moved fast, each thought clicking into place with practiced precision. Robert Garnez was many things—arrogant, cruel, calculating—but never reckless. Assassins, sent into a prison cell with no subtlety, no cover, no plausible deniability?

That wasn't control.

That was panic.

Something had gone wrong.

He let the blood whip dissolve at his feet. The thick red liquid hissed once, then stilled, seeping back into silence. With a surgeon's steadiness, he tore a strip from his tunic and bound his wrist, suppressing the slow, pulsing leak of blood. His movements were measured and efficient, but his thoughts were the complete opposite.

A cold fury stirred in his chest—sharp and rising. He forced it down. Rage wouldn't help now. Nor would fear, no matter how tight it coiled when he thought of Isabelle. Their future rested on discipline. On restraint. So he locked it all away, sealed beneath a layer of will so dense it might crack his ribs.

One by one, he stripped the captain's body. Breastplate. Cloak. Gloves. Buckles clicked and leather cinched with mechanical efficiency, as if he were dressing for a duel instead of stepping deeper into the eye of a storm.

When he was done, Eduard stood still for a long moment in the middle of the blood-soaked cell, breathing in silence.

The path was clear. Sofia would be the next target—if she wasn't already. She was vulnerable, and more importantly, young enough not to see the knife coming until it was too late. Protecting her had always been the goal. The plan. The reason behind every calculated step of the past year.

And Isabelle...

His jaw tightened. If they sent assassins for him, then something had gone wrong. Very wrong. She might already be dead. He told himself that. Let the thought repeat in his head like a command: Assume the worst. Do what must be done.

But it didn't stop the images that followed. Isabelle, proud and wounded. Still breathing. Still waiting.

He exhaled slowly, the weight of decision pressing down like a mountain on his back.

His wife. His daughter.

His heart. His mind.

Isabelle would demand he protect Sofia. He could already hear her voice. And yet—if there was still time—if she had endured...

Would he ever forgive himself for not trying?

Eduard reached for the metal door, his gloved hand hovering just above the handle.

“Damn it,” he whispered, voice low and raw. “We were so close.”

Then he opened the door, and vanished into the corridor beyond.

The world was doing its best impression of a drunk spinning top.

Kristoffer's vision swirled like watercolors in a storm, every edge blurry, every light too bright. His chest burned like it had swallowed a furnace, and the more he tried to draw breath, the more it felt like breathing sand. Regeneration was out of the question — mana slipped through his fingers like soap. So he did the only thing he could.

He focused on not dying. Mostly by breathing. In. Out. In again.

Somewhere in the soup of sound, a door opened. Or maybe a wall fell over. Footsteps clanked, someone said something — maybe a question? Or a threat? Hard to tell, really. The voices buzzed in his ears like bees auditioning for a choir.

Then hands grabbed him, pulled him up. Or tried to.

Kristoffer's legs gave the performance of their lives — collapsing spectacularly under him. After a few grunts and what sounded like very creative swearing, the voice behind the hands gave up and tossed him over a shoulder like a sack of uncooperative potatoes.

The trip through the stone corridors felt like a pilgrimage across a continent. At some point, Kristoffer swore they passed a mountain range. Or maybe that was just the prison stairs.

They finally entered a wide, echoing chamber lit by torches and pulsing crystals. He was barely conscious, but even in his current state, he could tell it was important. The air buzzed with tension and mana. A group of robed figures argued nearby, waving their arms and pointing — mostly at him.

But Kristoffer wasn't paying attention.

Because the floor was beautiful.

They'd dropped him onto a platform covered in runes — precise, glowing, elegant. His cheek pressed against the cold stone, and he smiled, fingers twitching slightly to trace the nearest pattern.

"Pretty..." he murmured dreamily, petting the floor like it was a beloved pet.

The arguing men stopped, gave up whatever bureaucratic war they were waging, and began unloading boxes and bags onto the platform around him. Magical items. Lots of them. Kristoffer blinked at one — it blinked back. Or maybe that was the poison.

He tried to lift his head to get a better look, but his stomach voted no with violent conviction. After a few failed attempts, he wisely gave up and resumed bonding with the floor.

The runes flared beneath him—lines of ancient geometry syncing with the pale glow of the stone obelisks encircling the platform.

A low hum rippled through the stone, then the ground began to move. No—descend.

Kristoffer barely registered the motion at first. His brain was lagging behind the rest of reality, like a man chasing a train long departed. It wasn't until the chamber ceiling began to disappear above him that he realized what was happening.

Air hit his face. Cold, dry, sharp. Then the view unfolded below—hills, scattered villages, winding rivers—and far in the distance, mountain ranges crawling across the horizon.

And all of it was terrifyingly far away.

His stomach clenched.

Then revolted.

A wet splatter followed, accompanied by a sharp gasp and the unmistakable hiss of outrage. Kristoffer blinked, eyes swimming, and saw a man in ceremonial white robes standing just a few steps away. The man was now... slightly less white.

"You disgusting insect!" the priest spat, recoiling as vomit dripped down the hem of his garment.

Kristoffer groaned and wiped his mouth with the back of his hand. The nausea faded slightly, enough for his thoughts to form sluggish shapes again. Around him, magical items had been carefully placed on the platform—staves, amulets, scrolls, rings—each one humming with quiet power. Dozens of them. High-level enchantments.

He turned his head. Bad idea.

The landscape below yawned wide, as if the world had forgotten where the ground was supposed to be. Heights. He really, really didn't like heights.

His stomach heaved again, but had nothing left to offer. He curled sideways, breathing through his nose, and tried not to die or humiliate himself further.

Behind him, the priest backed away cautiously—then stepped on one of the glowing staves.

Crack.

The delicate shaft split in two. A spark flickered. Something sizzled.

“You idiot!” the man shouted, his voice bordering on feral panic. “Do you have any idea how much that was worth?!”

Kristoffer blinked up at him—or at the three overlapping versions of him. It was hard to tell which one was real. His vision swam like he was underwater. The poison had already reached his temples, and holding on to consciousness was becoming its own full-time job.

The priest raised a foot, clearly considering kicking him, but one look at Kristoffer's unfocused eyes—and maybe the lingering threat of more vomit—made him reconsider. He stepped back with a grimace, mumbling curses under his breath.

Kristoffer turned slowly onto his back, gazing up at the shrinking circle of sky. The Upper World was getting smaller with every passing second. Somewhere up there—his mother. Sofia. Everybody in Elernes estate. And Robert Garnez.

He clenched his jaw. Even in his poisoned haze, he knew one thing: he had to get back. Somehow.

He rolled onto his side and reached weakly toward the runes beneath him. His fingers hovered just above the intricate spellwork, brushing the edge of brilliance—beautiful, ancient, maddening. There were too many layers. Even if he were sober and rested, analyzing a formation this large would take days. Weeks, maybe. Now, with a scrambled brain and an upset stomach? Impossible. Especially with half the platform buried beneath arcane gear.

His hand dropped limply.

Then the platform began to slow. A deep vibration shuddered through the stone, followed by the sharp hiss of dust being kicked up around the perimeter. Voices rose from below.

Cheers. Shouts. Dozens—no, hundreds—of people. All chanting, clapping, bowing.

The stone slab touched the earth with a dull thud that shook Kristoffer's bones. He grimaced as his body bounced slightly from the impact, limbs too uncooperative to even flinch properly.

A man in purple ceremonial robes climbed the steps toward the platform. He was beaming, eyes wide with awe and reverence.

“Welcome, oh Great Being!” the man proclaimed, dropping into a low bow.

The Upper Worlder priest puffed up like a well-fed rooster and motioned toward the goods spread across the platform. “I bring gifts,” he announced grandly, then gestured vaguely toward Kristoffer. “And return one of yours.”

Kristoffer tried to raise a hand. Protest, wave, maybe just twitch a finger. Even a groan would’ve done. Nothing. His body had clearly filed a resignation letter while he wasn’t paying attention.

“I expect one thousand high-quality mana stones,” the priest continued, voice smooth with practiced entitlement, “and twenty young women. Attractive ones. Five virgins. And if you’ve got any strong boys, I’ll take five of those as well.”

The man in purple didn’t blink. “Of course, Great Being. Your generosity honors us. Might we receive your blessing while the offerings are arranged?”

The Upper Worlder raised his arms, reciting with dramatic solemnity: “Oh you of strong faith, may enlightenment reach you and fortune fall upon your kin. The gods grant their favor... in gratitude for your generous donations.”

The absurdity of it all poked a faint spark of consciousness into Kristoffer’s dazed mind. He managed a groan—soft and

undignified—still sprawled flat on the stone platform. A shadow slid across his vision.

A tall figure in black robes stepped onto the platform and, without a word, scooped Kristoffer up in both arms. The movement was surprisingly gentle, though it made Kristoffer realize how soaked his back was with sweat. Cold air hit his skin as they stepped through towering double doors, and everything started blurring again. Colors smeared. Sounds faded. His body sagged in the man's grip like an overripe fruit.

He didn't know how long they walked. Minutes? Hours? Time was an abstract painting he couldn't decipher anymore.

Eventually, he was lowered onto something soft. It cradled him, warm and comforting. A bed. Probably.

A woman's voice cut through the haze. Her tone was very matter-of-factly and brisk. "What's wrong with him?"

"I have no idea," came the response—deeper, male, slightly strained. "The Great Being didn't say anything. But his temperature's off. Almost burnt my hands carrying him."

"Fever and full-body tremors..." she muttered, leaning in close. Her eyes inspected his glassy ones. "Bring me the Tukif's spit. We need to counteract whatever's in his system before it cooks his organs."

Kristoffer wanted to ask what that was. Tukif's what?

But the bed was too soft. The voices too distant. And the weight dragging down his eyelids too heavy to fight anymore.

He let go, slipping into unconsciousness with one last fragmented thought.

“Did she just say spit?”

Epilogue

The scent of drying herbs filled the corridor — mint, rosemary, and some bitter Lower World flowers she still couldn't name in the Upper World tongue. They hung in neat bundles from the wooden beams above the stone passage, gently swaying in the breeze drifting through the open window.

Nora stood barefoot on the warm tile floor, sleeves rolled up, her hands dusty with soil from the planter box she'd been tending. Across from her, Yaren — a Lower Worlder boy barely out of adolescence — was trying to hang a string of lavender sprigs with more enthusiasm than coordination.

"Not like that," Nora said gently, smiling. "They'll rot if you clump them together. Give them space to breathe."

Yaren gave her a sheepish nod and turned back to his work. Nora liked him — polite, quiet, always willing to help without asking. He reminded her of Kristoffer, once upon a time.

Then his fingers twitched.

It was subtle — a little spasm. Then came a grunt, low and sharp, as he stumbled back a step and clutched his head like someone had struck him with an axe.

Nora's smile vanished. "Yaren?"

He growled. A low, animal sound. His breath hitched, eyes wide — but they weren't really looking at her anymore. His irises were trembling, darting in every direction, and his expression twisted into something grotesquely unfamiliar.

"Yaren. Stop. You're scaring me."

He stepped forward. Fast.

Nora backed up instinctively, nearly knocking over the herb rack.

"I... I never had a woman, you know that?" His voice cracked, slurred like he was drunk. "Years. They keep us clean. Empty. But now... now she's gone... gone... I can *want* again."

Panic surged through her. Isabelle.

Oh no.

She turned to run — but he was faster. He slammed her into the wall, one hand tangling in her hair, the other groping blindly. She fought back immediately — slamming her elbow into his ribs, stomping on his foot, driving her knee upward. It staggered him, but not enough. He was stronger. Driven by something broken and sick.

Her instincts screamed.

He pinned her again.

Nora bit down hard on his shoulder — he howled — but he didn't let go.

Then came a *crack*.

Yaren flew sideways like a broken puppet, crashing into the herb rack in a cascade of wood and brittle leaves.

Ernest stood in the hallway's entrance, eyes wide, chest heaving, the handle of a fireplace poker still trembling in his grip.

"You alright?" he barked, moving to her side. "Nora?"

She nodded, dazed, blood on her lip. "I'm... I'm fine. I'm fine."

He crouched beside the boy — unconscious but alive — and cursed under his breath. "It's happening all over the house," he said. "Anyone bound to Lady Isabelle — they're losing control. The contract's ruptured. There's panic, violence, screaming downstairs. I think..." His voice dropped. "I think she's gone."

Nora didn't speak. She just stood, one hand braced against the wall, her eyes far away.

"Take this." Ernest shoved a sturdy old broom into her hands. "I know you were trained. I need your help. We're not going to stop them — just protect the rest. Especially the younger ones."

"What about you?" she asked hoarsely.

"I'll handle the upstairs," he said, grabbing a letter opener from the shelf like it was a sword. "But there's more. We can't stay. Not now. Not with this chaos."

He leaned close, voice dropping to a whisper. "The safehouse Eduard arranged — it's time. You'll go tonight. You'll be protected there."

Nora hesitated. "I'm not leaving Kristoffer. Or the Elernes family."

"They may be sent there too," Ernest said quietly. "That's why you *must* go. You'll be waiting when they arrive."

She gripped the broom tighter. Her pulse thundered in her ears.

"I'll fight until you say it's time," she said.

Before either of them could move, a bell rang out through the estate — clear and loud, each chime evenly spaced, echoing across the walls like the ticking of a grand, unseen clock.

Not an alarm.

Not a call to arms.

A summons.

Then, a voice followed. Cold. Refined. Precise. Amplified by spell or projection.

"By order of Duke Robert Garnez, I request audience with the House of Elernes. I have come to retrieve his property."

Ernest froze.

The color drained from his face like someone had pulled a plug. His eyes snapped to Nora, and his voice came out low and urgent.

"Hide. Now."

She didn't argue. Her bare feet were already moving.

He turned on his heel, straightening his back, brushing soot from his coat as if presentation might matter to what was coming. From deeper within the estate, the voice rang out again — closer this time.

“My master is willing to overlook the offense of harboring his servant... should you surrender her willingly.”

Footsteps followed — not rushed, but perfectly measured. Each one placed with intention. The sound of expensive boots on stone. A silhouette emerged in the main hall: tall, lean, dressed in a sharply tailored black coat, its hem free of even the smallest wrinkle.

A silver-tipped cane tapped once against the floor.

“Time to meet Adrel,” Ernest muttered grimly.

He stepped forward, the weight of the house behind him, and the burden of generations on his shoulders. Behind him, unseen, Nora slipped into the servant stairwell, broom clutched tightly in hand.

Adrel stood still in the grand entry, framed by glass-filtered morning light. His black uniform bore no insignia, but every detail—from the polished cane to the ironed folds—declared him as something more than a messenger.

A predator in valet’s clothing.

“I would speak with the steward of this house,” he said, voice even as ever. “Not a servant. Not a child. A man who understands the meaning of property.”

Ernest stepped forward, matching the man’s stillness with calm that didn’t quite reach his hands.

“You’re speaking to him.”

Adrel tilted his head. He didn’t smile. “Good. Then you understand what I’m here for.”

“I understand that you’ve come uninvited to a noble house,” Ernest replied. “And that your tone walks the edge of disrespect.”

The butler’s eyes didn’t move from his face. “Your masters are absent. You speak on their behalf. But I was told this house held what belongs to mine.”

“If your master believes a woman is his property, then perhaps he ought to revisit the law. This is the Elernes estate. Not his kennel.”

Adrel exhaled—just once. “I was told to extend courtesy. Offer peace. That offer is short-lived, I assure you.”

A weight settled in the air. Not from a spell, but something older—a practiced stillness that only men who had seen blood spilled behind silk curtains could conjure. Both butlers stood motionless, trained hands idle but ready, their eyes locked in silent calculation.

Magic. Blade. Politics. They were veterans of all three.

And both knew: if it came to violence, the cost would be steep.

Ernest's voice remained level, his hands calmly at his sides. "No one here belongs to your master. Whatever fantasy he's spinning, you'll find no evidence of it in this house."

A measured pause.

"I see," Adrel said, the words crisp, almost formal. "Then I'll deliver your answer. If my master takes offense... I trust you're prepared to justify this choice. To your lords. Or to the Tower."

Then, with the same poise he'd arrived with, he turned. No anger. No haste.

Just the soft click of his cane trailing behind him as he walked the polished corridor.

Nora regained consciousness to the piercing scream from the room next door. Her heart seized in immediate recognition—it was the voice of the gentle woman who had shared the secret passage Robert used for smuggling mana stones into the laboratory. Nora tried instinctively to rush to her aid, but cold iron bit sharply into her wrists, stopping her after just one desperate step. Chains bound her arms tightly to the stone wall, dried blood beneath them a brutal reminder of how she had struggled and twisted herself raw before losing consciousness earlier.

“Silence,” Robert’s voice commanded, echoing icily through the damp chambers. “Or I will rip out your tongue.” He paused, muttering almost to himself, “I can’t afford the barrier now—it would interrupt the flow of magic.”

Deep cuts across Nora’s stomach and chest burned relentlessly. The intricate runes Robert had carved into her flesh seared not only her skin but her soul, their twisted magic worming coldly into her very being. She wanted to scream for help, but her throat was dry, stripped of strength. Waves of despair rolled through her, pulling her consciousness deeper into the creeping darkness with every heartbeat.

Then, abruptly, reality returned.

Nora leaned heavily against the cool stone wall, fighting for breath. Her body trembled, slick with cold sweat as the vision receded. The mere whisper of Robert Garnez’s name had been enough to tear open old wounds, unleashing memories she had buried for years. She forced herself upright, emerging slowly from the shadowed side passage into the servants’ hall. Her breathing shook as she steadied herself, fingers trembling as they tightened around the sturdy handle of the broom.

The rear corridor was deserted now, ravaged by chaos—shattered furniture scattered across the floor, tapestries torn, vases reduced to jagged shards. Distant screams still echoed faintly through the walls, a haunting chorus marking the collapse of Isabelle’s magic-servant contracts. The minds bound by her

magic frayed and unraveled in unpredictable directions, plunging those unfortunate souls into madness.

Nora's jaw set in grim determination. The broom in her grip was simple and worn. But in the hands of someone trained to fight for survival, it could be enough.

When she finally reached the garden, Ernest was waiting. His sleeves were stained with dirt and blood, sweat gleaming on his brow.

"He's gone," Ernest said flatly.

Nora didn't need to ask who.

He stepped closer, voice low and urgent. "Take the eastern trail, past the river shrine. There's a warded marker there; behind it lies a hidden path. Follow it to the refuge Lord Eduard established, should..." He hesitated, his voice breaking slightly, "...something like this ever occur."

Nora stared at him, anxiety clear in her eyes. Her gaze flickered toward the darkening horizon, then back to Ernest, concern etched deep into her features.

"And you?"

"I'll remain," Ernest replied quietly. "Someone has to contain this chaos before blood floods these halls. Someone needs to answer when the Tower inevitably comes."

Nora nodded slowly, though a quiet ache rose in her chest. An invisible, restless pull nagged at her heart—a ghostly demand from the old bond to Robert Garnez, calling her to abandon everything and run back to the nightmare she had barely survived. But her love for Kristoffer anchored her, firm and unyielding, giving her strength enough to defy even the magic etched into her soul.

“And Kristoffer? Sofia?” she asked, her voice tight with anxiety.

“If there’s even a sliver of hope, they’ll return either here or to the shelter,” Ernest assured gently.

A heavy silence filled the space between them.

Nora knew precisely how the magic-servant contract worked. Isabelle had explained it clearly and repeatedly after the Elernes family took her in—pregnant, terrified, and fleeing from horrors she still couldn’t fully speak about. A single command from Robert Garnez, just a whisper of his voice, would shatter the fragile resolve she clung to now, forcing her heart and mind back to him, despite every cruelty he had inflicted.

Nightmares still haunted her sleep, relentless memories from her captivity in Robert’s dark laboratories. She vividly remembered the other Lower World women hanging limply from chains, their bodies gaunt, skin etched with bloody runes. Their eyes—hollow, lifeless—could no longer even summon tears when they recounted the unspeakable atrocities Robert had

committed. He had stripped them of more than dignity or freedom; he had hollowed out their souls, leaving only empty husks.

Nora's heart twisted painfully as the memory surfaced again: Robert's cold, clinical voice as he calmly explained his findings, how the human soul—particularly a fresh, unborn soul—could be more effectively bound to magical objects. He had forcibly impregnated them, sometimes with his own seed, other times with strangers', treating their bodies like mere tools in his relentless experimentation.

She could never forget the torment of losing her first child. The physical agony paled in comparison to the soul-rending pain of feeling her child torn from her, its tiny essence shackled in cruel magic, ripping away a piece of her own being with it.

That agony had sparked her desperate resolve to escape when she discovered she carried Kristoffer. A woman from the Lower World had sacrificed herself to create the chance, buying Nora precious seconds to flee the cursed laboratory. But Robert was meticulous; as soon as he noticed her absence, every trace of his experiments had vanished, leaving no proof of his monstrous deeds.

Yet despite the horror, despite all the suffering, the accursed bond still pulled at her heart, insisting she return to him as though he were the center of her existence. Nora hated that part

of herself—wanted desperately to despise Robert—but the invisible chains wrapped around her soul wouldn't allow it.

She looked around the Elernes estate one last time. Her gaze fell upon Ernest, then wandered over the beautiful gardens, the warm sanctuary that had sheltered her soul for nineteen years. This had been her haven, the only place she'd found peace, and it was all because of Isabelle. Isabelle, who had stubbornly ignored Eduard's justified warnings, insisting they save a woman who was precious property of one of the world's most dangerous men.

A single, silent tear slid down Nora's cheek as the realization washed over her: she would never be able to thank Isabelle properly. Words couldn't possibly express the depth of gratitude she felt—for saving her life, for protecting Kristoffer, for giving them both a chance at happiness.

But now Isabelle was gone, and remaining here would only put everyone she cared about in greater danger. One whispered word from Robert would destroy her resolve and make her a liability to those she loved.

She turned back to Ernest, who was watching her silently, his eyes softening as he caught the glistening trail down her cheek. She nodded once, a gesture that held all the gratitude and sorrow words could never fully convey. Then, with a quiet, shaky breath to steel herself, Nora turned away from the second true home

she'd ever known and disappeared silently into the trees, refusing to look back.

The enormous mana stones flashed to life, illuminating the platform as it ascended, carrying a small group of chosen ones and their precious cargo of mana crystals. Cheers erupted from the gathered crowd, faces alight with awe and reverence. Bishop Albert stood silent, hands clasped gently behind his back, his heart swelling with anticipation. It had been more than twenty years since a prophet last descended from the Heavenly Island. Today, history had once again chosen his kingdom.

“Bishop Albert,” a temple guard approached cautiously, lowering his voice respectfully, “should we disperse the crowd now?”

“Yes, please,” Albert nodded absently, his gaze fixed on one of the ornate magical staves left behind by the Greater Being. Carefully, almost reverently, he lifted it from the platform. “And take these artifacts to the vault. Leave them near the entrance—I’ll examine and catalog them personally later.”

The guard bowed deeply and hurried to execute the orders, but Albert wasted no time watching him go. He moved quickly from the ascension hall, navigating familiar corridors until he reached the office of their most brilliant doctor.

“He’s sleeping,” came the sharp voice of a woman who didn’t bother turning around from her cluttered desk. “If you’re here for an interrogation, you’ll have to wait.”

“Have some respect, Claire! This is the bishop you’re speaking to,” snapped Dan, the guard who had carried the boy earlier.

Albert lifted a calming hand. “It’s alright, Dan. Go and help the others with the artifacts.”

The guard hesitated briefly, glancing warily between Claire and Albert, before nodding and excusing himself with a polite bow. Albert quietly locked the door behind him and approached the sleeping figure on the bed.

The young man appeared barely twenty, his breathing labored and uneven, as though each breath cost him great effort. Ugly, faded scars marred his chest and left arm, a testament to past pain Albert could hardly imagine.

“You could at least pretend to respect me in front of the others, Claire,” Albert sighed gently. “Tell me—what’s wrong with him? How soon will he wake?”

Claire finally set down her pen and turned around, brushing unruly strands of brown hair away from tired eyes. Her gaze held irritation tempered by deep concern.

“It’s complicated,” she said, frustration edging her voice. “Honestly, I’m not even sure what we’re dealing with. His body seems... mutated. His blood is practically toxic, his bones and

muscles show strange, irregular properties, and his left arm shouldn't even function—but he moved it just fine. If these symptoms were new, I'd say he wouldn't survive the night, but clearly, he's lived with this condition for some time. I gave him strengthening herbs for now and sent for the court mage."

Albert leaned in closer, inspecting the boy with a thoughtful frown. "My memory isn't what it once was, but I'm certain we never sent anyone quite like him to the Upper World. And he bears no prophet's mark..."

A knock at the door interrupted his musings. Albert turned toward Claire, who merely shrugged and went back to scribbling notes. He shook his head mildly, a wry smile playing at the corner of his lips, and opened the door to a familiar face.

"Ah, Albert!" boomed Anthony, stepping in flamboyantly, his blue robes shimmering with golden embroidery. He spread his arms theatrically, smiling warmly. "I hear we have quite the special guest today."

Albert stepped aside to let him in, shaking his head with mild affection. "Hello, Anthony. Good to see you, as always."

Anthony's gaze shifted, landing on the woman hunched over her notes. "Claire," he greeted cheerfully. "Still charmingly disheveled, I see."

"Anthony," Claire replied without glancing up. "Still compensating for your insecurities with fancy robes, I see."

Albert stifled a sigh as Anthony chuckled, moving closer to the sleeping figure. “Careful, Claire—I outrank you now. Technically, I could have you executed for such insolence.”

“And technically,” she shot back dryly, scribbling without pause, “I could ensure you remain impotent until your dying breath. Now stop wasting time and get to work.”

Anthony’s smile faded slightly as he approached the bed, placing a hand on the patient’s forehead, his tone growing serious. “What have you tried so far? Did you already cast cleansing or regeneration spells?”

“Oh, absolutely nothing,” Claire deadpanned. “I just stood here waiting for you to grace me with your infinite wisdom. Of course I tried everything, you buffoon. Nothing worked. It might be a curse or something equally obscure. Take a look.”

Albert wisely stayed silent, observing their familiar exchange with resigned patience. He watched carefully as Anthony’s hand shifted down to rest gently on the boy’s chest. The mage’s face shifted from focused determination to shock, then contorted with sudden pain. Anthony staggered back, cursing loudly as he fell heavily onto the floor, gripping his temples.

“That’s new,” Claire commented, mild amusement flickering in her eyes as she stood and approached Anthony. “Care to explain?”

“What happened?” Albert asked urgently, his voice edged with concern.

Anthony hissed through clenched teeth. “There’s something terribly wrong with his core. It feels like molten iron, boiling violently. The moment I tried to probe it, my astral form felt like it was impaled by a searing spike.” He rubbed his forehead, wincing. “He shouldn’t be able to repel mental contact while unconscious. I’ve never encountered anything like it.”

Claire’s eyes brightened with curiosity. “Do it again. I’ll track the mana activity while he attacks you.”

Anthony shot her a venomous glare. “Why don’t you try, if you’re so eager for pain? My mind feels like it’s split open. I’m not going near his core again. Wait until Sara returns from her expedition—she might have a trick or two to bypass his defenses.”

Albert’s expression darkened with worry. “He might not survive that long. Is there truly nothing else we can try? And does this mean the boy is a mage?”

Anthony shook his head grimly, brushing dirt from his robes as he rose unsteadily to his feet. “There’s nothing more I can safely do right now. He caught me off guard and my willpower is badly strained. It’ll take days before I dare approach him again—and frankly, even that seems risky. He’s either a trained mage or one of those wild naturals, similar to the Empress. Either way,

proceed with extreme caution. Now, if you'll excuse me, I need painkillers and solitude."

They watched him leave in an uncharacteristically hurried shuffle, silence settling between them for a moment.

"We must save this boy," Albert finally murmured, determination coloring his voice. "He may carry knowledge from the Heavenly Island far beyond what even Suzie brought us. With a prophet like him, we can solidify our kingdom's strength—perhaps even sway some rebellious kingdoms back to our side and put an end to the Empress once and for all."

Claire's lips curled into a faint smile. "Well, he knocked Anthony flat on his pompous ass, so I suppose I owe him at least a decent effort." She sighed dramatically. "Fine, Albert, go and report. I'll fill him with every concoction I have and take the night watch. But send someone early tomorrow—if he makes it that long, I'd like to finally get some sleep."

"Thank you, Claire," Albert said sincerely, meeting her tired eyes. "I trust you'll keep what happened here between us. I must report carefully to the church and court..."

Erik entered his room and locked the door behind him before sitting heavily at his desk.

He had just spent another two hours with the healers—like he had every day since the incident. His arm wasn't simply broken;

the bone had been *crushed*. Even with the best healers in the city, recovery would take weeks of pain and constant treatment.

With a sudden snarl, Erik swept his uninjured arm across the desk. Papers, ink, and quills scattered across the floor.

“Damn it!” he shouted, his voice breaking with rage.

How could the Elernes just *let that Lower Worlder go* after what he’d done?

Why hadn’t Father contacted him yet?

And what in the Abyss was that strange mana reaction when his energy clashed with Sofia’s servant’s?

Truth be told, Erik was terrified.

When he’d first been sent to the academy, he thought it was freedom—a reprieve from the endless regime his father had imposed since childhood. Years of brutal training, experiments, and the merciless “tests” he’d endured alongside his siblings had left him half numb, half desperate for air. For the first time, he wondered if life could be more than the endless cycle of blood and obedience.

But even in this supposed sanctuary, Father’s voice echoed in his mind:

“Show them the superiority of the Garnez bloodline. Make them worship you—or fear you.”

At first, things had gone well. The intimidation, the manipulation, the charisma drilled into him since birth—all of it had worked. He'd built influence quickly, surrounded himself with followers. Pushing others around, commanding their fear—it was better than enduring Father's hand.

But then came Sofia Elernes.

She refused to bow, refused to play his game. Worse—her skill in magic eclipsed his own. Her defiance had been a public slap to the image of control he'd built. And now, humiliated by her *servant*, the illusion had shattered completely.

The academy whispered his disgrace. Every whisper sounded like his father's footsteps drawing nearer.

Erik rubbed his chest unconsciously, tracing the faint ridges of old scars—runes his father had carved into his skin when he was a child. They ached now, a phantom pain that reminded him of what true punishment looked like. The academy had once felt like escape from hell. Now it was just a different kind of cage.

"Lord Erik," his servant tiny, weak voice was audible through the locked doors of his room "You have a visitor... Jens Varsmith."

Erik froze. *Jens Varsmith?*

Why would one of Sofia's allies come to see him now? Was this her way of mocking him further? Or was Jens—like his father Ludwig—simply hedging his bets, playing both sides to ensure he never lost?

Either way, Erik couldn't show weakness.

He knelt to gather the scattered papers and ink, straightened the desk, and adjusted his robe until not a wrinkle remained. When he spoke, he was the picture of control—measured voice, rigid stance, the smile of a man who'd already won.

“Let him in,” he said evenly.

Nina opened the door, and Jens Varsmith stepped inside. He paused just past the threshold, his sharp eyes quietly sweeping the room. Erik noticed how his gaze lingered on the dark stain on the floor where the ink had spilled earlier. Typical. It wasn't the first time Erik had caught Jens observing things others would have missed — small gestures, fleeting glances, cracks in tone. The kind of details only a man used to watching, not speaking, would catch.

Jens's eyes finally met his. He offered a polite, well-rehearsed smile — too careful to be genuine.

“Lord Garnez,” he greeted, bowing his head slightly. “I appreciate you seeing me on such short notice.”

Erik didn't return the smile. Instead, he waved Nina away with a flick of his hand. The girl froze for a heartbeat, unsure whether to serve refreshments or vanish entirely. Erik waited until the door clicked shut before leaning back in his chair, settling into the familiar role of a predator assessing prey.

“Let’s skip the pleasantries,” he said coldly. “I’m busy. What does Elernes’s lapdog want from me?”

The insult landed cleanly. Jens’s composure wavered for just a moment. He tried to hide his emotion, but he slipped up—his lips pressing into a thin, tense line. That single instant told Erik everything: the boy wasn’t used to verbal duels.

“I’m here on my own behalf,” Jens replied after a beat, voice steadier than his face. “I think we could both benefit from an amicable relationship. And for the record, I’m no one’s lapdog. Sofia isn’t interested in politics — and even if she were, she’s too soft for it.”

Erik tilted his head, studying him. The sudden shift of loyalty was hard to believe—especially from someone so tightly tied to Sofia’s circle. The timing was awfully convenient too, coming right after Erik’s public humiliation.

“And why,” he asked eventually, his tone flat and measured, “would I want an *amicable* relationship with you? What’s in it for me?”

Jens straightened slightly, as though bracing for impact. “Information,” he said simply. “Something that would be valuable to you. And in exchange, I don’t want much — just a promise that when you start climbing the political ladder, you’ll help me secure a comfortable position in the Tower. Nothing prestigious. Just something safe. Quiet.”

Erik's eyes narrowed. "And how do I know you're not lying? That this isn't some cheap trick to crawl back to your mistress with stories about me?"

"You'll know it's true once you hear it," Jens replied. His tone was calm, but the way he shifted his weight from one leg to the other betrayed the tension under his mask. "My concern is whether *you* will keep your word once you get what you want."

Erik's lips curved slightly — a faint, mocking smile. The boy was either bold or stupid. He gestured toward the chair opposite him. "Sit. Let's see what kind of information makes you think you can bargain with me."

Jens obeyed. He moved carefully, his every action overthought and overcalculated — the kind of behavior Erik had seen in men who were used to surviving rooms full of people stronger than themselves.

"You say Sofia isn't interested in politics," Erik began after a moment of silence, "but I find it hard to believe you wouldn't run to her if it suited you. And you..." his voice sharpened, "you're close with Katrina Welder, aren't you? Sofia's best friend — which makes her my enemy."

That earned a flicker of emotion. Jens's jaw clenched. When he spoke, his voice carried real heat.

“I want Katrina kept out of this,” Jens said firmly. “Play your political games, build your alliances, I don’t care. But if she’s harmed because of you, this conversation ends here.”

Erik studied him with renewed interest. That tone — that unguarded edge — was more telling than anything Jens had said so far. A weakness. A lever. His father would’ve called it a blessing.

“Fair enough,” Erik said, relaxing slightly. “If your information is worth my time, we can talk about an arrangement. But I don’t make promises in advance.”

Jens nodded once, as though he’d expected that. “Then let me prove I’m serious,” he said, his composure returning with effort. “I’ll offer you one piece of information for free—about you. If it convinces you I’m worth keeping around, we’ll discuss a deal.”

Erik arched an eyebrow. Curiosity stirred despite himself. The boy had come more prepared than he’d expected.

“Go on then,” he said, leaning back in his chair.

Jens hesitated just a heartbeat too long before speaking. “I know,” he began carefully, “that you—and several others you might call siblings—were *conceived* by your father in a... special way.”

The words hung in the air like a dropped blade.

For a moment, Erik said nothing. His mind spun, fragments of old memories flashing through the haze: dark corridors, the smell of

blood and alchemical resin, the merciless coldness in his father's voice. He blinked, forcing himself to focus on Jens's face.

How could this nobody know *that*?

Had Father leaked something? Impossible. Robert Garnez would burn the entire continent before allowing such a stain to touch his name.

"Where did you hear about something like that?" Erik asked at last, his voice low, dangerous—too steady for how violently his pulse was hammering.

Jens held his gaze, though Erik saw the flicker of fear beneath the calm. "I can't reveal my source," he said carefully. "But as an act of good will, I can assure you it wasn't from Sofia Elernes."

He hesitated, then added, "I've never shared this information with her, or anyone else. I thought it might serve as proof of my sincerity... and as the foundation for a more amicable relationship."

Erik leaned forward slightly, studying him in silence. Jens's hands were clasped too tightly in his lap. His breathing, just a bit too controlled. Every part of him screamed tension—but not deceit.

"How much do you know?" Erik asked curtly.

"Pretty much everything an 'incubator' would know," Jens replied carefully.

Heavy silence filled the room. A storm of wild thoughts and feelings crashed through Erik. The echo of children screaming during “testing” ringed in his head, just like it did most of the nights.

He exhaled slowly, trying to contain the rising panic. “I can’t get rid of you,” he said quietly at last. “You’ve got an informant who could act against me, so I have no choice but to keep you close.”

He pulled open a drawer and retrieved a small golden pin embossed with the Garnez crest. With a flick of his wrist, he tossed it toward Jens. “I respect the cunning. Fine—I’ll bite. You’ve got your alliance. Now talk. What’s this information that’s supposed to make me lose sleep?”

Jens caught the pin and held it carefully, as though it might burn him. “Your father, Robert Garnez,” he began quietly, “is remarkably good at covering his tracks. But even he slips sometimes. One of the ‘incubators’ escaped. And survived.”

Erik froze.

“More than that,” Jens continued softly. “The experiment your father was preparing... survived as well. You had a clash with him recently. If you accuse Sofia Elernes of teaching her servant magic, your father’s secret could come out. It would be mutual destruction.”

Erik’s pulse thundered in his ears. The pieces began slotting together, too fast, too violently. The way his mana had reacted

when he touched Kristoffer—different from any resonance he'd felt before. Familiar, raw, almost like recognition.

Could it be...?

He couldn't believe it. But he also couldn't *not* believe it. If Jens was right, then that Lower Worlde—

He didn't even finish the thought.

Did Father know? He *had* to. Robert Garnez didn't overlook anything. Then why hadn't he acted? Was this another test? A silent trial to measure Erik's loyalty or competence? Or had Father truly lost control of his creation?

When Erik's focus snapped back to the present, Jens was still watching him—eyes calm but wary, like a man standing too close to a caged predator.

"You're protecting both me and Sofia," Erik said finally, his voice low, unreadable. "That's quite the balancing act."

He stood, his shadow falling across Jens. "Fine. I'll hold you to your word. You're responsible for yourself—and your informant. If I ever hear a whisper of this from anyone else, I'll assume it came from you. And when that happens, I'll erase you. Understood?"

Jens didn't flinch. "Understood. And yes—I can make sure this information never leaves this room."

“Good.” Erik nodded curtly, regaining his composure. “Then welcome to the Garnez faction. Come see me tomorrow before classes. We’re done here.”

Jens inclined his head in acknowledgment and left the room, closing the door quietly behind him.

The silence that followed was suffocating.

Erik turned toward the window, staring out into the pale night. His hands trembled slightly as he drew a breath.

Was this why Father still hadn’t contacted him? Another one of his twisted lessons?

Had he already failed?

Would he be *discarded*—or worse, taken apart and rebuilt like the others?

His reflection in the glass looked pale, almost foreign. For the first time in years, Erik Garnez realized he had no idea which pieces of his life were still his—and which belonged to his father’s design.

Kristoffer opened his eyes slowly, greeted by the gentle, hazy glow of early morning filtering through an unfamiliar window. He blinked lazily, taking in the strange room. His mind felt oddly disconnected—floaty and relaxed, a pleasant haze replacing his usual sharp edge of anxiety.

Slowly, his gaze settled on a woman slumped over a cluttered desk in the corner. Her brown hair was a chaotic mess, drool pooling gently on the scattered notes beneath her cheek. He briefly considered his situation, vague images flickering through his mind: the poison, the platform, the strange people who had greeted him. He must be in the Lower World—the exact place he didn't want to be. Strangely though, instead of the usual concern, he felt only a gentle, drifting curiosity.

He pushed himself up with a grunt of effort. His body felt surprisingly light, as if he'd shed some invisible weight. Glancing down, he realized—with mild, detached surprise—that he was completely naked.

“Hmm,” he murmured, unfazed. Nearby, draped neatly over a chair, were simple linen clothes. He pulled them on slowly, enjoying the soft feel of fabric against his skin. Then he turned to the sleeping woman, taking a cautious step forward.

"Excuse me..." he ventured softly.

She mumbled something incoherent, shifted slightly, then began snoring softly. Kristoffer smiled faintly, finding her familiar somehow. Like Ana—impossible to wake without a fight. Better to let her rest.

With that decided, he turned quietly and slipped through the door, stepping out into a long stone corridor lined with closed doors. Kristoffer walked slowly, trailing his fingers against the

cool stone walls, his head blissfully empty. He felt strangely carefree, as if he'd shed not just clothes but also years of tension.

At the corridor's end was an enormous, intricately carved door, distinctly different from the others. Curious, he pressed his palm to the handle and nudged it open gently.

His breath caught.

On the other side was a massive library—row upon row of bookshelves stretched toward vaulted ceilings, filled to overflowing. Kristoffer's heart leapt like a child discovering sweets, all rational thought slipping from his mind.

He stepped inside, eyes wide with wonder. At the library's center, plush chairs surrounded reading tables, and in the largest, most comfortable-looking chair sat an enormous man. His massive frame filled the seat, muscular arms crossed casually over his broad chest. His hair was thick, dark, and wild, his beard braided with intricate ornaments that spoke of battles fought and victories won.

Before Kristoffer could quietly retreat, their eyes met. The large man raised an eyebrow, gesturing calmly.

"I'm usually the only one here this early," the man rumbled, his voice like distant thunder—deep yet oddly welcoming. "Come closer, boy."

Kristoffer hesitated, suddenly aware he might be stepping into trouble. Instinctively, he felt the urge to hide his identity. He

immediately recalled his old friend's name and used it without hesitation. "My name's Greg. Sorry for interrupting—I'm just passing through."

The huge man chuckled softly, a deep sound echoing from his chest. He stood smoothly, moving with surprising grace to block Kristoffer's quiet retreat. A heavy hand rested gently on Kristoffer's shoulder.

"The way you looked around like a child in a candy shop makes me doubt your words, Greg," he said, voice gentle despite his imposing presence. "Who are you really? One of the Candidates, perhaps?"

"Sorry," Kristoffer replied airily, his brain sending nonsense to his tongue. "I'm not allowed to talk to strangers. I have responsibilities to get back to."

"Strangers?" The huge man's face broke into an incredulous smile, eyes twinkling with amusement. "You don't recognize me?"

Kristoffer shook his head lightly, feeling mildly embarrassed but mostly amused at his own recklessness. "I'm afraid I'm quite terrible at remembering faces."

The man's booming laughter filled the room, surprisingly warm and genuine. "There aren't many who'd say that, boy. I am Balthazar the Great, first and last of his name, King of Aldzan,

Champion of the Church, Conqueror of the Wild Tribes, Wielder of Deathbringer, General of—”

The library door creaked open softly, interrupting the long list of grandiose titles. A petite woman with a gentle, motherly face peered in quietly, her warm gaze instantly dissolving the mighty warrior’s imposing aura.

“Pooky Boo!” She tried her best to appear stern, but in Kristoffer’s foggy mind, she resembled nothing so much as an angry kitten. “You forgot your knee warmer. You don’t want your joints hurting again, do you?”

“Martha, not now...” The giant’s voice turned soft, almost pleading.

“Yes, now!” She marched toward him and handed him a knitted woolen cloth, clearly unbothered by his intimidating presence. “I won’t hear otherwise. And remember your stretches before training!”

“Fine...” Balthazar mumbled sheepishly, eyes dropping to the floor.

“Good.” She nodded with satisfaction. Then, turning to Kristoffer, she offered a bright smile. “Sorry for interrupting. I’ll let you get back to your business. I’m making your favorite apple pie today, Pooky. Bye!”

As swiftly as she'd appeared, Martha vanished through the library doors, leaving behind an awkward silence. Kristoffer bit his lip, his drugged mind struggling mightily to suppress a laugh.

"What are you smirking about?" Balthazar's voice rumbled with a renewed edge, eyes narrowing slightly. "You should know I'm a close friend of Bishop Albert. If I don't deem you worthy, you can forget about being chosen."

"Sorry, I didn't mean anything by it," Kristoffer tried to apologize, but his fuzzy brain rebelled and made him speak further. "I'm just glad to see you happily married, Pooky Boo. Gives me hope for my own future."

Balthazar's eyes widened in shock, freezing him momentarily before he lunged forward in a swipe. Kristoffer reacted purely on instinct, his body dodging back just in time. The blow was fast, powerful, and clearly intended to teach him a stern lesson.

"Only my wife can call me that," Balthazar growled dangerously. "You'd best start begging for mercy."

"I really am sorry!" Kristoffer shouted back, his legs already carrying him swiftly toward the door at the far end of the library. "I must attend to my responsibilities!"

"I've remembered your face, Greg!" The king's voice echoed loudly behind him. "You won't get away with this!"

Kristoffer sped through unfamiliar corridors, heart racing with panic and drug-induced confusion. His limbs felt strangely

energetic, yet his brain floated in a blissful haze, barely comprehending how he'd gotten himself into this bizarre predicament.

His legs moved faster than his thoughts, and before he knew it, he found himself bursting through another tall door, desperately seeking refuge.

The sight that met him stopped him dead in his tracks.

Inside, a strikingly beautiful woman in her forties lay amidst a tangle of sheets, passionately entwined with four young, well-built men. Five pairs of startled eyes locked onto Kristoffer, frozen awkwardly in the doorway.

“Are you joining, or are you just going to stand there?” the woman purred seductively, gracefully rising from the bed and approaching him without an ounce of shame.

“Sorry, wrong door...” Kristoffer mumbled, reaching hastily for the knob behind him.

“No, no, no,” she cooed softly, grabbing his wrist and pulling him back gently but firmly. “You found exactly the right door.”

He felt the soft caress of her fingers against his cheek. The next moment, a strange warmth spread rapidly through him, originating from the ring she wore. His vision blurred, and his pulse quickened uncontrollably. An overpowering hunger filled his mind, banishing rational thought.

Before he realized it, Kristoffer wrapped an arm around her slender waist, pulling her forcefully against the wall with sudden aggression, heart racing with a feverish desire that wasn't entirely his own.

"Somebody is hungry" she whispered seductively. "Lucky for you, I'm a generous host. Welcome in my all you can eat buffet."

The door burst open suddenly, interrupting her seductive words.

"Suzie, stop!" barked a plump older man with an alarmed expression. "You can't have him!"

"But Albert," she pouted, her hand still pressed possessively against Kristoffer's chest. "He came to me..."

"No, Suzie!" The older man yanked Kristoffer away firmly, inserting himself between them. "You've already been given plenty of companions this month. He comes with me."

Before Kristoffer could protest—or process anything at all—the older man tugged him hastily out into the hallway. His head spun even more chaotically than before, the effects of the woman's magic still lingering painfully in his blood.

"Apologies for that," the older man said softly as he guided Kristoffer briskly down the hall. "Suzanne's appetite has been... heightened since her return from the Upper World. She can be rather overwhelming."

They soon entered a warm, inviting room furnished with polished wooden chairs and an intricately carved table. The older man gestured Kristoffer to sit, quickly preparing a cup of steaming tea.

“My name is Albert,” he explained gently, handing him the cup. “I’m a bishop here, responsible for taking care of our... special guests. The tea should help clear your head. You’ve had quite the cocktail of medications from Claire, and it might leave you feeling a bit disoriented for a while longer.”

Kristoffer sipped the tea carefully, wincing slightly at the heat, yet appreciating the immediate clarity it brought. His mind sharpened just enough to piece together fragments of recent events. Albert was the man Balthazar had mentioned. Kristoffer briefly apologized internally to his deceased friend for misusing his name yet again. It was too late now—he’d committed to this lie.

Besides, anonymity felt safer for the moment. No one here needed to know who he truly was.

“Thank you for helping me earlier, Bishop Albert,” he spoke carefully, measuring each word to prevent another slip. “My name is Greg. It’s a pleasure to meet you.”

“The pleasure is mine, Greg,” Albert replied warmly, his gentle smile reassuring. “You’re safe here. Finish your tea, and then I’ll show you to your room so you can rest properly.”

With his mental barriers still weakened, Kristoffer's true feelings slipped out before he could catch himself. "Do you think you could help me return to the Upper World?"

Albert's eyes widened in surprise. "Return? I'm afraid that's impossible, Greg. You've been exiled—the Greater Beings no longer deem you fit for their realm. But don't worry; we'll ensure you have a comfortable life here. In return, we only ask you to share the wisdom you gained on the Heavenly Island. Thousands are praying for your health and eager to learn from you. Forgive my poor memory, but could you remind me when exactly you were chosen to ascend?"

Alarm bells began ringing loudly in Kristoffer's mind. He took another careful sip of tea, buying precious seconds to think. If these people couldn't or wouldn't help him return, remaining here would only waste valuable time—time he desperately needed to protect his mother and Sofia. And based on Albert's reaction, it was clear the church had every intention of keeping him close as their prized possession.

Kristoffer knew how rare he was: a Lower Worlder born in the Upper World. It had been decades since anyone had been exiled, and even then, none had his unique origins. Such rarity was bound to attract unwanted attention, and the moment these people learned the truth, they'd never let him leave willingly.

Fortunately, the tea seemed to possess some detoxifying effect, gradually clearing his mind enough to organize his scattered

thoughts. Kristoffer steadied himself, ready to feign exhaustion and request sleep—but just then, a memory flashed in his mind. Without thinking, he spoke.

“Bishop Albert... Do you know Ana?”

Albert rose abruptly from his seat, eyes wide with surprise and hope. “You know Ana? How is she? Is she well? Has she been eating properly? When did you last—”

But Kristoffer never heard the rest of the bishop’s eager inquiries. Agony tore through his chest without warning, a wildfire of mana erupting violently beneath his ribs. He gasped sharply, gripping his chest as dizziness overtook him, sending him collapsing to the unforgiving stone floor.

Albert knelt beside him in alarm, his panicked shouts fading into indistinct murmurs. Kristoffer’s consciousness slipped away, clinging desperately to one final memory—warm, peaceful, bathed in sunlight:

The rustling leaves in the gardens of Elernes mansion, Sofia’s bright laughter ringing freely, Ana tugging gently on his sleeve with playful impatience, Lisa’s normally stern expression softening under the influence of wine, revealing the vulnerable sweetness beneath. All of them together, being sent off on their journey to the University of the Abyss.

Then the memory slipped away like sand through his fingers, and Kristoffer surrendered to the dark embrace of unconsciousness.

End of Book One

Afterword

Hello, dear reader.

I hope you enjoyed reading this book at least half as much as I enjoyed writing it.

Creating the universe of the Upper and Lower World has been incredibly fun, and I'm really looking forward to showing you more of it in the next book. So stay tuned if you enjoyed this one.

There are many people I would like to thank for helping me out during the creation process. But there are two without whom I would never have been able to finish the book properly.

First, I have to thank my girlfriend Ursula, who kept bringing me my favorite whiskey to keep my creative batteries charged.

Thank you for your patience, motivation, and honest review of the first draft.

I hope that by the time you read this thank-you note, my stupid ass has already taken you out for a nice dinner as proper thanks. If not—you get five free slap tickets on top of the nice dinner.

Second, I have to thank my basement-dweller friend, Pacierz.

He survived reading through my first few books—which were average at best—and kept giving me honest feedback so I could improve as a writer.

All of this for the cheap price of vodka and moonshine. And he even managed to move out of the basement in the meantime! Congratulations on finally living in an almost normal apartment. However, you will always be a basement dweller in my heart.

And a big thank you to all the people I've met in my life so far.

It was thanks to you that I have been able to bring so many characters to life—the good ones and the bad ones.

And naturally, a big thank you to you, dear reader.

Writing this book helped make everyday life more bearable for me.

I hope reading it did the same for you.

See you in the next one!

Extra – Social hierarchy in the Upper World

